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Ezra 1:1–11

Ezra

Ezra 1:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 1:1–11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 1:1–11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Many years before this story, the Babylonians destroyed the city of Jerusalem and the temple of Yahweh, and took the people of Judah to Babylon. Now, Cyrus is the new ruler over Babylon. King Cyrus says the exiles from Judah can return from Babylon to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple in Jerusalem. Many of the people of Judah prepare to go back to Jerusalem. This is the first story in the books of Ezra and Nehemiah.

The first part of this story is very similar to the end of the book of 2 Chronicles.

Stop here and listen to your translation of 2 Chronicles 36:22–23, if you have already translated the book of 2 Chronicles. Pause this audio here.

Before this story begins, Cyrus, who was the king of Media, defeats not only the Babylonians but also other kings and kingdoms. Together, all of these lands become part of the very large kingdom of Persia, with Cyrus as the king over all of these kingdoms.

Stop here and look at a map of the kingdom of Persia as a group. Pause this audio here.

In the first year of the rule of King Cyrus, Yahweh causes Cyrus to let the exiled Israelites go back to Jerusalem. Remember that the prophet Jeremiah said Yahweh would return the exiles to Jerusalem after 70 years. Yahweh has not yet completely finished doing what he said he would in Jeremiah's prophecy. Surprisingly, Yahweh uses a foreign king to bring the people back to Judah. In the same way that Yahweh used the Babylonians to discipline the Israelites, Yahweh now uses a foreign ruler to bring the Israelites back to the land of Judah.

Although Yahweh is the one in control, it is possible that Cyrus also lets the people of Judah leave in order to gain their support and possibly to have a way to get to the land of Egypt easily, because Egypt is close to the land of Judah. It was common during the time of King Cyrus for a new ruler to give something to the people he ruled over so the people would become his loyal supporters. The Persians sent other people back to their lands, too.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do new leaders do in your culture to make the people loyal to the new leaders? Pause this audio here.

King Cyrus makes a proclamation that the Israelites can go home to the land of Judah. During the time of King Cyrus, the king told an important message to heralds, who traveled throughout the kingdom of Persia to tell the people the message. The heralds probably said the message in different languages so that all of the people

could understand the message. In this story, the heralds probably speak the message in Hebrew, the language of the people of Judah. The Persians also write down the message so that no one forgets what the message is.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when your leaders or rulers had an important message to give to your community. Who spoke the message to you? Pause this audio here.

In Cyrus' message, Cyrus says that Yahweh is the God of heaven, and that Yahweh gave Cyrus all of the kingdoms of the earth. Some people think this means that Cyrus worships Yahweh, but we know that Cyrus says similar things about other people groups' gods. Maybe Cyrus calls Yahweh the "God of heaven" because the Persians also have a god of heaven. We also know that in the book of Isaiah, the prophet Isaiah says that Yahweh chooses Cyrus to bring the people back to the land of Judah, but that Cyrus does not personally know Yahweh. It is likely that Cyrus heard about Yahweh from Daniel and other Israelite exiles who lived in the land of Babylon.

Cyrus also says that Yahweh told Cyrus to build a temple for Yahweh at Jerusalem in the land of Judah. Remember, the temple of Yahweh is where God's people worship God. Cyrus gives permission to any of the people of Judah who want to go build this temple for Yahweh in Jerusalem. Cyrus also says, "may their God be with them," which most people think is a blessing on the people who will return to the land of Judah. Other people think "may their God be with them" means that the Israelites will physically bring their God with them back to the land of Judah. At this time, many people believed that a god only had control over the land of the god's people. If the people brought their gods, in the form of idols, to the land of Babylon, then the people also needed to take their idols with them when they left Babylon.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes Jerusalem, the land of Judah, Babylon, and the kingdom of Persia. Pause this audio here.

Finally, Cyrus says that the neighbors of the exiles in Babylon should help the exiles who go back to the land of Judah. These neighbors should give the exiles silver, gold, goods, livestock, and freewill offerings to help the exiles rebuild the temple in Jerusalem. Goods are things for work, like equipment or utensils, and freewill offerings are gifts that the people choose to give freely in the temple of Yahweh. Some people think these neighbors are other Israelites who survived the exile but decided not to return to the land of Judah. Other people think these neighbors also include non-Israelites who live in Babylon. However, it would be strange if non-Israelites gave gifts for Yahweh, who is not their god.

The Israelites hear the proclamation from King Cyrus, and Yahweh moves the spirits of many Israelites to prepare to go back to the land of Judah in order to rebuild the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem. These Israelites include many leaders of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin, priests, Levites, and probably also some other Israelites. You will remember that it was the tribes of Judah and Benjamin who made up the kingdom of Judah, so it was people from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin who were in exile in Babylon. Priests normally served in the temple, and the Levites took care of other tasks in the temple. Remember, there was no temple for the priests and Levites to serve in while the people were in exile in Babylon.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you and your family moved to a new place, or when someone you know moved to a new place. Why did you move? What did you bring with you? Pause this audio here.

The Israelites who prepare to return to the land of Judah collect the resources from their neighbors, whom King Cyrus instructed to give gifts to the exiles. The neighbors give silver and gold articles, goods and livestock, valuable gifts, and animals for freewill offerings that the people can give to Yahweh.

King Cyrus takes out the articles that belong to the temple of Yahweh. Remember that at the end of the book of 2 Chronicles, King Nebuchadnezzar took these articles from the temple of Yahweh and Nebuchadnezzar put these articles in his own temple of his gods in Babylon. During the time of King Nebuchadnezzar, when a king conquered another nation or people, the king took the conquered nation's gods and put their idols, or images, in his own temple. This showed that the conquering king won over the other people and that the conquering king had power over their gods. Unlike the other people groups, there were no images of Yahweh in Yahweh's temple, so King Nebuchadnezzar took the gold and silver articles from the temple of Yahweh instead and put these articles in his temple to show his victory over the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community or country, when one group conquers a different group, what does the winning group do to show their victory? For example, does the winning group take anything from the losing group? What does the winning group do with the things they take from the losing group? Pause this audio here.

It is surprising that Cyrus gives these valuable temple articles back to the Israelites. King Cyrus tells Mithredath, the treasurer, to bring out these articles, and Mithredath carefully counts the temple articles. Mithredath gives the articles to Sheshbazzar, the prince of Judah. Sheshbazzar is probably the leader of the people of Judah, and not the son of a king. Sheshbazzar brings these temple articles with the group of exiles who travel back to Jerusalem.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh causes or moves the spirit of Cyrus, the king of Persia, to fulfill the word of Yahweh that Jeremiah spoke.

In the second scene: Cyrus sends a message to the Jewish exiles in Babylon. Cyrus gives the exiles permission to return home to Jerusalem in Judah in order to rebuild the temple. The neighbors of the exiles should give the exiles gifts as the Jews leave Babylon.

In the third scene: Some exiles prepare to return to Jerusalem in Judah. The neighbors of these people give gifts to the people who prepare to return to Jerusalem.

In the fourth scene: Cyrus gives the gold and silver articles from the temple of Yahweh back to the Jewish exiles so that the exiles can bring these articles back to Jerusalem. There are 5,400 articles.

The characters in this passage are:

- Cyrus, the king of Persia
- Yahweh
- Jeremiah
- The Jewish exiles in Babylon
- Neighbors who remain in the land of Babylon
- Leaders of the families of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin
- Priests and Levites
- King Nebuchadnezzar
- Mithredath, the treasurer
- And Sheshbazzar, the prince of Judah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that this story happens a long time after the Babylonians took the people of Judah into exile in Babylon. Remember also that the first part of the story is very similar to 2 Chronicles 36:22–23. It is possible that the storyteller of 2 Chronicles is the same storyteller here in the book of Ezra. Or maybe the storyteller in Ezra wants to connect the two stories together so that people remember what happened in the book of 2 Chronicles.

In the first scene, we learn that it is the first year of the rule of King Cyrus of the kingdom of Persia. Remember that Cyrus is the new ruler over the entire region, including the lands of Babylon and Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a few different stories that are about the same person or character. Pay attention to how you start the second or third story about this person or character. How do you introduce the person? How do you help people remember what happened in the last story so they are ready for

a new story? How will you start this story about King Cyrus and the exiles who return to Judah from Babylon? Pause this audio here.

We also learn that the events in this story happen in order to make the prophecy of the prophet Jeremiah happen. Remember that the prophet Jeremiah said the Israelites would be in exile for 70 years. It has probably not yet been 70 years since the exiles went to Babylon from the land of Judah. But it is possible that the prophecy of Jeremiah means it is 70 years from the time the Babylonians destroy the temple of Yahweh to the time that the people rebuild the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem.

The storyteller says the prophecy of Jeremiah is the word of Yahweh, that Jeremiah speaks with his mouth. "Jeremiah speaks with his mouth" is special language that means Jeremiah was the prophet who spoke the words about the return of the Israelites to their homeland. Yahweh told Jeremiah what to say to the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the idea that Yahweh gave the prophet Jeremiah words to say, and that this current story makes those things happen as Jeremiah said they would? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh is the one who moves the spirit of King Cyrus to make a proclamation for all the people in the kingdom of Persia. Other ways to translate this are: "Yahweh puts a thought in the mind of Cyrus," or "Yahweh gives Cyrus this desire." Yahweh causes Cyrus to act, but Yahweh does not push Cyrus to act. We learn what the proclamation is in the next scene.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story that includes a part about the spirit, which is the thoughts or desires of one of the characters. Pay attention to how you talk about this invisible part of that character. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says the proclamation of King Cyrus. First, the storyteller says this is the proclamation of King Cyrus. This is a formal introduction to the message, and it was common for kings or rulers to make proclamations like this during the time of King Cyrus. Remember that this is an oral message that heralds told to the people all throughout the kingdom of Persia. Cyrus also put this proclamation in writing, maybe on a paper that the heralds carried with them as they shared the proclamation with people throughout the kingdom.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you introduce the message from King Cyrus? Here are some translation examples:

- I, Cyrus, ruler of Persia, say...; or
- This is what Cyrus, the king of Persia, says....

Pause this audio here.

There are three parts of the message of King Cyrus. First, Cyrus says that Yahweh told Cyrus to build Yahweh a temple in Jerusalem in Judah. Then, Cyrus says Yahweh's people from Judah have permission to go to Jerusalem to build the temple for Yahweh. Finally, Cyrus says the neighbors of the exiles should give gifts to the exiles for the temple for Yahweh. There is no specific information in this message about how Yahweh's people should rebuild the temple of Yahweh. Later in the book of Ezra, the storyteller repeats the message of Cyrus, and the storyteller includes specific instructions for how the people should rebuild the temple of Yahweh.

In the first part of his message, Cyrus says that Yahweh, the God of heaven, gave Cyrus all the kingdoms on the earth. Remember, although this could mean that Cyrus follows Yahweh, it probably just means that Cyrus respects other people and their gods. Yahweh told Cyrus to build a house for Yahweh in Jerusalem in the land of Judah. In this story, the "house" means the temple of God. Remember that the temple represented God's presence among his people, and it was very important for the Israelites to worship God in the temple.

Also, remember that there already was a temple in Jerusalem before the exile to Babylon. It may be helpful to say that Yahweh told Cyrus to rebuild the house for Yahweh in Jerusalem. We know that the books of Ezra and Nehemiah tell the story of how the people rebuild the house of God.

In the second part of the message, King Cyrus says that any of God's people who want to return to Jerusalem are free to go back. It seems that Cyrus himself will not go to Jerusalem to build the temple of Yahweh, but that Cyrus will permit the Jews, or Yahweh's people from the southern Israelite Kingdom of Judah, to go to Jerusalem to

build the temple of Yahweh. In this story, “God’s people” means the Jews and their descendants who worshiped Yahweh at the temple in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show that any of the people of God may return to Jerusalem? For example, it may be best to translate this as a question, “Who is there among you of all God’s people?” Pause this audio here.

Cyrus also says, “may their God be with them.” Cyrus is talking about all of the Jewish exiles who are going back to the land of Judah. Most people think that this means King Cyrus wants to bless, or speak good words about, the people who will return to the land of Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some common blessings in your language that you say to someone before that person goes on a long journey? Where will you include this blessing in your translation? For example, you could choose to include the blessing at the beginning of this part of the message or at the end of this part of the message. Pause this audio here.

Cyrus gives the people permission to leave the land of Babylon, but Cyrus does not order the people to leave Babylon. We know that some exiles choose to stay in Babylon, possibly because they are doing well economically and do not want to leave a good place. Remember that the exiles are not slaves or captives in Babylon at this time.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show that Cyrus gives the people permission to leave Babylon? Pause this audio here.

Cyrus gives the exiles permission to go up to the city of Jerusalem in the land of Judah. The city of Jerusalem is on a hill, which is a raised area of land, so people often said, “Go up to Jerusalem.” Also, people often traveled “up” to a sacred or important place, or people said “go up” to mean travel north. In this story, “go up to Jerusalem” means travel from Babylon along the Euphrates River to the city of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map that includes Jerusalem, the land of Judah, Babylon, the city of Babylon, and the kingdom of Persia again as a group if needed. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time you or someone you know traveled from one place to a more important or larger place or city. Pay attention to how you talk about going to that more important place or city. How will you translate “go up to Jerusalem” in this story? Pause this audio here.

Cyrus also gives the exiles permission to rebuild the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem. In the original language, the storyteller says that Yahweh is the God of Israel, who is the God in Jerusalem. Remember that the Persians believed that gods only ruled over the land of their own people, but we know that God rules over all the world.

In the third part of the message, King Cyrus says the exiles’ neighbors should help the exiles who choose to go back to Jerusalem in the land of Judah. In the original language, the storyteller says that “the men of the place should support each one who remains, in whatever place he may travel to.” The “men of the place” means the neighbors, or people who live near the Jewish exiles. These neighbors could be other Jewish exiles who do not travel back to the land of Judah, or they could also include non-Jewish neighbors in Babylon. “Each one who remains” probably means the other Jews who had also come to live in exile in Babylon. The main idea is that wherever the Jewish exiles are in the land of Babylon, their neighbors should give these exiles support as the exiles prepare to return to the land of Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this part of the message of King Cyrus about the gifts the neighbors should give to the exiles? Pause this audio here.

Cyrus says that the neighbors should give gifts to the exiles. The exiles will likely use these gifts for their journey and to help rebuild the temple in Jerusalem. Remember that the gifts include silver, gold, goods, livestock, and freewill offerings. Silver and gold are valuable metals that people use to make things like jewelry. Goods are things for work and can mean equipment, materials, or utensils. Livestock are animals that people raise, like sheep, goats, and cattle. Freewill offerings are gifts that Israelites give in the temple of Yahweh because they want to, not because Yahweh requires them to.

Stop here and look at pictures of silver and gold. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe a ritual that you do because you want to do the ritual, instead of because someone requires you to do the ritual. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the Jewish exiles hear the message from King Cyrus, and some of the exiles prepare to do exactly what King Cyrus says to do. These exiles prepare to return to Jerusalem to build the temple of Yahweh. Remember that the most important part about the exiles going back to Jerusalem is to rebuild the temple of Yahweh so that the Jewish exiles could worship Yahweh again.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about your discussion from the previous step about a time when your leaders or rulers had an important message to give to your community. How did people respond to the message? What would be the best way to translate the beginning of this scene about how the Jewish exiles respond to the message of King Cyrus? Pause this audio here.

It is important to remember that Yahweh moves the spirits of some of the Jewish exiles so that these exiles want to return to Jerusalem. Not all of the exiles want to return to the land of Judah, but only some of the exiles. The storyteller uses the same words in the original language here for "moves the spirit" of the exiles as the storyteller used earlier in the story when Yahweh moved the spirit of Cyrus. Make sure to translate "move the spirit" in the same way that you did earlier in this story.

The Jews who prepare to travel back to the land of Judah include many leaders of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin. You may remember from 1 Chronicles that it was the tribes of Judah and Benjamin that the Babylonians took into exile. The storyteller says these people are the "heads of the father's houses," which probably means they are leaders over extended family groups. Some priests and Levites also prepare to make the journey back to Jerusalem. Yahweh may also move the spirits of other Jews from the land of Judah who are not leaders of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin or religious leaders. It is possible that other non-leaders from Judah and Benjamin also came. Cyrus has not given the Jews a limit on how many people can go back. Cyrus has also not said when the people should go back.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "heads of father's houses" in this story? How will you show that Yahweh moves the spirits of these Jewish exiles? Pause this audio here.

Before the exiles leave on their journey, it is likely that the exiles needed time to sell their property and time to prepare for the long journey. We know from another part of the book of Ezra that the journey from Babylon to Jerusalem would take the exiles about four to five months.

In the second part of the third scene, neighbors of the exiles who will return to Jerusalem give generous gifts to the returning exiles. Remember that it is possible these neighbors are other Jews, or they might also include non-Jews. Some people think these gifts are similar to the gifts the Egyptians gave to the Israelites when the Israelites left Egypt many years before.

In the fourth scene, Cyrus brings out the articles that belong to the temple of Yahweh. These articles are valuable objects that people made of silver and gold that priests and Levites used in the temple of Yahweh to hold and deal with animals' blood, incense, or other offerings.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "articles" in this story? Look at a picture of various temple articles like gold and silver bowls, censers for incense, and utensils. Pause this audio here.

Remember that before this story, King Nebuchadnezzar took these articles out of the temple of Yahweh and put the articles in Nebuchadnezzar's own temple in Babylon. The storyteller actually uses the same word in the original language that Nebuchadnezzar took these articles out of the temple of Yahweh, and that now Cyrus brings these things out of the temple of Nebuchadnezzar's god. King Nebuchadnezzar took these articles by force, but Cyrus sets these things free. It may be helpful to say first what King Nebuchadnezzar did in the past, and then say what King Cyrus does in this current story. For example, "In the past, King Nebuchadnezzar had taken the articles out of the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem and brought these articles to the temple of his god in Babylon. Now, King Cyrus takes these same articles out of that temple in Babylon."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best order to translate the actions of King Nebuchadnezzar in the past and King Cyrus in this story? How will you show the contrast between what King Nebuchadnezzar did in the past and what Cyrus does in this story? Pause this audio here.

We also learn that Cyrus does not bring out the articles himself, but Cyrus gives Mithredath, the treasurer, the responsibility to bring the articles out of the temple of the gods of Nebuchadnezzar. The Persians had a god named Mithra, and "Mithredath" means "gift of Mithra." Mithredath was an important official, and he was responsible for the treasures in the temples in Babylon. Mithredath counts out the temple articles, and then Mithredath gives these articles to Sheshbazzar, the prince of Judah. Sheshbazzar is the leader of the first groups of exiles who return to the land of Judah, but Sheshbazzar is not the son of a king.

Mithredath carefully counts the articles, and the articles include 30 gold dishes, 1,000 silver dishes, 29 knives, 30 gold bowls, 410 other silver bowls, and 1,000 other articles. It is difficult to know exactly how to translate each of these articles. "Dishes" might also be "basins," rounded dishes in which you can hold liquid, like a bowl. "Knives" could be "pans." The knives are possibly for people to use when they sacrifice animals in the temple. The "other silver bowls" could be bowls of a different kind.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the names of each of the temple articles that Mithredath counts? Look at the photos of the temple articles again if needed. Pause this audio here.

It is also difficult to know why the total number of articles is 5,400. The number of articles listed before the total is only 2,499. Some people think that the list only includes the most important or valuable articles, or that someone made an error when they wrote the numbers of the articles. Remember, do not change any of the numbers, even though the numbers do not seem to add up. It is also possible that the list does not include the bronze articles, which are not as valuable. Or maybe Cyrus does not give back the total number of articles at the same time.

Sheshbazzar brings these articles with him when he returns to the land of Judah from the land of Babylon. Remember that other exiles also travel with Sheshbazzar, and these Jews are the descendants of people whom Nebuchadnezzar took into exile in Babylon. It is important for the history of the Jews that the Jews who return to the land of Judah will use the same articles in the temple of Yahweh that their ancestors used in the past before their exile to Babylon. Also, it is important that the Jews travel with these articles from the temple because these articles represent the presence of Yahweh for the exiles, since there is no longer any temple.

The storyteller does not describe the journey of the exiles from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah. We know from later in the book of Ezra that Ezra traveled for about four months to make the journey from Babylon to the city of Jerusalem, so it probably also took the exiles about four months to return from Babylon to Judah.

Stop here and look again at a map of Babylon, Jerusalem, and Judah. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the story and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Cyrus, the king of Persia
- Yahweh
- Jeremiah
- The Jewish exiles in Babylon
- Neighbors who remain in the land of Babylon
- Leaders of the families of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin
- Priests and Levites
- King Nebuchadnezzar
- Mithredath, the treasurer
- And Sheshbazzar, the prince of Judah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

A long time before the start of this story, the prophet Jeremiah made a prophecy that one day the Jews would return from Babylon to the land of Judah. In this story, Cyrus became the king of Persia. In the first year of the rule of King Cyrus, Yahweh gave Cyrus the desire to make a proclamation for the people throughout the entire kingdom of Persia. The people also wrote down the proclamation. Yahweh did this in order to fulfill the prophecy of the prophet Jeremiah that the Jews would return to the land of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Cyrus, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy to be the new ruler of this large kingdom of Persia. I rule over many kings and kingdoms; or
- I think it is a good idea to make a proclamation for all of Persia to hear. I want the people to be happy in my kingdom, and this proclamation will help the people; or
- It is important to write down this proclamation so that no one forgets what I say in my message to all the people in the kingdom of Persia.

Also, ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am willing to use another foreign ruler to fulfill my plans for my people, the Jews; or
- I spoke through my prophet, Jeremiah, that I would bring the exiles home from Babylon to the land of Judah, and I will keep my promise; or
- The Jews have been in exile long enough, and it is time for the exiles to come back home to the land of Judah.

Continue the drama.

This is what Cyrus, the king of Persia, said: "Yahweh, the God of heaven, gave me all of the kingdoms of the earth. Yahweh chose me to build a temple for Yahweh at Jerusalem in the land of Judah. Any of the people who belong to Yahweh have my permission to go up to Jerusalem. You may go to Jerusalem to build a temple for Yahweh, the God of Israel, who is in Jerusalem. May your God help you! The neighbors of every place in Babylon should give gifts to the Jews who choose to return to the land of Judah. These neighbors should give silver, gold, equipment, animals, and other freewill offerings for the temple of God in Jerusalem."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Cyrus, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I recognize that Yahweh, the God of the Jews, is powerful. I do not want to build a temple for Yahweh myself, but I want the Jews to know that I honor and respect their God. So I am glad to let some of the Jews return to their homes so they can build a temple for Yahweh. I have also let other people go back to their lands, too; or
- I am happy to let some Jews go back to their land of Judah. The people will be happier in their own land, where the people will worship their own God. And the people will like me since I let them go home. It is better for me if some people leave so that all of the people are happier; or
- It is good for me if some of the Jews go back to the land of Judah. I hope to take the land of Egypt someday, and if there are some Jews in the land of Judah, they will help keep the land of Judah under my control.

Also, ask the people playing the Jews, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are shocked that King Cyrus gave us permission to leave Babylon and return to the land of Judah! King Nebuchadnezzar forced us to come here in exile, and now a different foreign ruler is telling us we can finally go home to the land of Judah; or
- We are so happy to think about rebuilding the temple of Yahweh so that we can worship Yahweh in the temple in Jerusalem again. We want to return to the land of Judah as soon as we can; or
- We are not sure if we want to go back to the land of Judah. Judah is very far away, and we are content in our lives here in Babylon now. Maybe we will just stay here.

Continue the drama.

Yahweh stirs the spirits of many Jews so that these Jews want to return to Jerusalem to build the temple for Yahweh. These Jews include many leaders of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin, and many priests and Levites. The neighbors of these Jews give the Jews generous gifts of silver articles, gold, goods, livestock, expensive gifts, and also freewill offerings.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the heads of the families of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin and the priests and Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are very happy that we have permission to leave Babylon and finally go back to the land of Judah! We have heard about the land of Judah from our fathers and grandfathers, and we want to return to our land; or
- We are ready to sell our property and pack our things so we can make the long journey back to the land of Judah; or
- We are looking forward to being back in the land of Judah. We will finally be able to rebuild the temple of Yahweh and worship Yahweh in his temple; or
- We are glad that Yahweh is fulfilling the prophecy of the prophet Jeremiah. We can finally go home to the land of Judah; or
- We are surprised that our neighbors gave us gifts! This will help us make the journey back to the land of Judah, and the gifts will also help us build the temple of Yahweh and start new lives in the land of Judah.

Also, ask the people playing the neighbors who remain in the land of Babylonia, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are Jews, but we definitely do not want to return to the land of Judah. That was the land of our ancestors, but we have new lives here in Babylon. We will be happy to give gifts to the Jews who choose to leave so that they have support for their journey; or
- We are happy for our neighbors, even if we do not worship the same god as they do. We will give these neighbors gifts so that they can have a good journey back to their land; or
- We wish we did not have to give our neighbors these gifts. Yahweh is not our god, and we do not want to give gifts for the temple of a different god. But King Cyrus told us to give these gifts, so we will give them.

Continue the drama.

In the past, King Nebuchadnezzar had taken the articles out of the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem and brought these articles to the temple of his god in Babylon. In this story, King Cyrus took these same articles out of that temple in Babylon. King Cyrus gave Mithredath, the treasurer, the task of bringing out the articles. Mithredath counted out the articles to Sheshbazzar, the prince of Judah. This is the inventory of the articles of the temple of Yahweh that Cyrus gave back to the Jews: 30 gold dishes, 1,000 silver dishes, 29 knives, 30 gold bowls, 410 other silver bowls, and 1,000 other articles. There were 5,400 gold and silver articles. Sheshbazzar brings all of these articles with him when the exiles leave Babylon to return to the land of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Cyrus, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- These Jews do not have any idols, so I want them to take these articles home to their land and their god instead of keeping these articles here in Babylon; or
- Even though these articles are valuable, it is important to me that the people in my kingdom are happy. I have sent other people home with their gods, and I think that every people should be able to worship their own god in their own land; or

- King Nebuchadnezzar lived a long time ago, and I do things differently from Nebuchadnezzar. Nebuchadnezzar chose to destroy the temple of these people and bring the people here to Babylon. I choose to let the people go back to their land and their god. I think the Jews will be loyal to me because I am being kind to them.

Also, ask the people playing the heads of the families of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin and the priests and Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are shocked that King Cyrus is returning these temple articles! Now we can return to the land of Judah and rebuild the temple of Yahweh to worship in the same way that our ancestors worshipped Yahweh; or
- It is very special to us that we will bring these temple articles back to the new temple in Jerusalem; or
- We are very thankful to King Cyrus because he is returning these important articles to us; or
- We know that Yahweh has power over all the kings of the earth because Yahweh told King Cyrus to let us go back to Jerusalem, and Cyrus is even returning the temple articles; or
- We hope that we can worship and follow Yahweh better than our ancestors did. We know that Yahweh punished our ancestors when the Babylonians took them into exile, and we hope that we can follow Yahweh faithfully.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Cyrus becomes the king of Persia. A king rules over a city or a territory called a kingdom. King Cyrus rules over a very large kingdom that includes many smaller kingdoms.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **king** and **kingdom** in this passage? For more information on king and kingdom, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh moves the spirit of King Cyrus so that King Cyrus would make a proclamation. Yahweh does this in order to fulfill the word of Yahweh that Jeremiah spoke in the past. Yahweh is God's personal name. The spirit of a person is the thoughts, feelings, and emotions of a person. A proclamation is an official message that a ruler sends throughout his kingdom. People speak the proclamation out loud for the people to hear the message from the ruler. The word of Yahweh is the message that Yahweh told to the prophet Jeremiah in the past.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate **Yahweh** and "**word of Yahweh**." For more information, refer to Yahweh and Word in the Master Glossary. Translate Yahweh and "word of Yahweh" the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the idea that Yahweh moves the **spirit** of King Cyrus? For more information on spirit, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "**proclamation**" in this story? Translate "proclamation" the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament. Pause this audio here.

Cyrus says that Yahweh, the God of heaven, gave Cyrus all the kingdoms of the earth. Heaven is where God lives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **God** and **heaven** in this passage? For more information on God and heaven, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Cyrus also says that Yahweh told Cyrus to build a new temple for Yahweh at Jerusalem in Judah. A temple is a place where people worship God, and other people have different temples to worship their gods. Another name for this temple for Yahweh is the "house of God," or the "house of Yahweh." Jerusalem was the capital city of the land of Judah, and the first temple was also in Jerusalem before King Nebuchadnezzar destroyed the temple. Judah was the name of the southern kingdom before King Nebuchadnezzar took the people of Judah into exile in Babylon.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **temple**, **Jerusalem**, and **Judah** in this passage? For more information on temple or "house of God," Jerusalem, and Judah, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Ezra 1:1–11

Cyrus says that the people in his kingdom have permission to go up to Jerusalem in Judah to build the temple of Yahweh, the God of Israel. In this story, Israel means the people of Israel, or the descendants of Jacob.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **Israel** in this passage? For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Cyrus says that the neighbors of the Jews should give gifts to the Jews who are returning, including freewill offerings. A freewill offering is a gift that the Jews gave to Yahweh in the temple because they wanted to give it, not because Yahweh required it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **freewill offerings** in this passage? For more information, refer to freewill offerings in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

After the people hear the message from Cyrus, Yahweh moves the spirits of many Jewish exiles to return to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. These Israelites include the leaders of the fathers' houses of Judah and Benjamin, the priests, the Levites, and maybe some other Israelites. "Heads of father's houses" means the leaders of the groups of households of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin. A household is all of the people who live together in one house. Priests are descendants of Aaron from the Israelite tribe of Levi, and priests worked in the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem. Levites are also from the tribe of Levi, but they are not descendants of Aaron. The Levites also helped in the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "**heads of fathers' houses**," **priests**, and **Levites** in this story? For more information on heads of fathers' houses, refer to **household** in the Master Glossary. For more information on priests and Levites, refer to the Master Glossary. Translate "heads of fathers' households," priests and Levites in the same way as you have in previous books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

In the past, King Nebuchadnezzar took the articles from the temple of Yahweh and put these articles in the house of King Nebuchadnezzar's false gods. Nebuchadnezzar worshipped many gods, including Marduk, the king of the Babylonian gods. Babylon had many temples where the Babylonian people kept idols, or statues, of their gods.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **gods** in this passage? For more information on gods, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Sheshbazzar brings all of the gold and silver articles with him when the exiles all go back to Jerusalem. Exile means that a person must live outside of their own country, and that person is not able to return home. The Babylonians forced the people of Judah to leave Judah and to move to Babylon as exiles, but now the exiles are going home.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **exile** in this passage?

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 1:1–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (860 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (17.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (9.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Ezra 2:1–20

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 2:1–20 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:1–20 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:1–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Yahweh moved the spirit of King Cyrus to say that the Jewish exiles could go back to Jerusalem in Judah to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. Yahweh also moved the spirits of many Jewish leaders, priests, and other Jews so that they would prepare to return to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. Cyrus returned the temple articles to the Israelites, and Sheshbazzar brought these temple articles with the people when they returned to Jerusalem. Now, the storyteller lists the people who return from Babylon to Jerusalem in Judah. This is the first part of a six-part list of the exiles who return to Jerusalem in the land of Judah.

It is not clear how much time has passed between the previous story and this current story. It is also not clear if this list only includes the people who are in the first group to return to Jerusalem in Judah, or if this list also includes people who return later. You will remember that later, people called these Israelites from the province of Judah “Jews.” The storyteller in Ezra sometimes calls these people Israelites, and sometimes he calls them Jews. Remember that many Jews also choose to stay in Babylon, and these people do not return to the land of Judah.

As the passage begins, the storyteller says these are “the people of the province” who return from exile in Babylon. “The people of the province” probably means the people who used to live in the province, or land, of Judah. Remember that in the past, King Nebuchadnezzar took the people by force from Judah to Babylon into exile, and now King Cyrus of Persia has said that the Jews in Babylon can return home to Judah. It is possible that some Jews in Babylon were still alive from the time when King Nebuchadnezzar took the Israelites into

exile. But many of the people in this list were born in exile in the land of Babylon. Remember that the exiles have been living in the land of Babylon for at least 50 years. When the exiles first came to the land of Babylon, they were all prisoners. But now the new generation of exiles is no longer prisoners.

Stop here and look at a map that includes the land of Babylon, the city of Babylon, the land of Judah, and the city of Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

The people all returned to the cities or villages of their ancestors in the land of Judah. We know that all of the cities and villages in this list are very close to the city of Jerusalem in the land of Judah. Remember that many of the Israelites who make the journey to Judah have never been to Judah before. These people's ancestors told them about their cities and villages back in the land of Judah. Also, remember that the cities and villages in the land of Judah were probably mostly in ruins because King Nebuchadnezzar's soldiers had destroyed the cities and villages during the battle.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when someone forced your ancestors, or the ancestors of someone you know, from their home. Where did your ancestors live? Did your ancestors return home? How did your ancestors know where to return? What did your ancestors do when they finally returned home? Pause this audio here.

There are 11 leaders who return with the people of Israel, and some people think that we should also include Sheshbazzar from the previous story. This would mean there are 12 leaders, which is similar to the 12 tribes of Israel. A similar passage in Nehemiah 7 says that 12 leaders return with the people of Israel, but the names of the leaders are a little different. Nehemiah 7 also includes lists of all the people returning to the land of Judah.

Stop here and listen to your recording of Nehemiah 7:4–73 if you have already translated this passage into your own language. Pause this audio here.

The leaders in this list include Zerubbabel, a descendant of King David, and Jeshua, a descendant of the last high priest before the exile. Other leaders are Nehemiah, Seraiah, Reelaiah, Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispar, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah. It is interesting that several of these leaders have Persian or Babylonian names, which shows that at least some of the Israelites in exile gave their children Persian or Babylonian names.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you decide what to name your children? Talk about someone you know who has an unusual name in your culture. Where did this unusual name come from? Pause this audio here.

In the rest of this list, and in the following five lists, we hear the number of men from each family of the people of Israel who return to the land of Judah. This list does not include women and children, and it probably only includes men over the age of 12. For this passage, the storyteller lists the names of 18 families and the number of people in each family who return from Babylon to the land of Judah. It is interesting that the people in this current passage are not religious leaders, but ordinary Israelites. It is also likely that many of these people were wealthy or from the upper class because we learn in a later part of the list that many of the people in the list had servants or slaves.

For the first family, the storyteller says that 1,272 "sons" or descendants of Parosh come back to the land of Judah. Parosh is the name of these men's common ancestor, and not the name of their family or clan leader. It is possible that Parosh was the head of a family when King Nebuchadnezzar took the people from Judah to Babylon in exile, and now all of the descendants of Parosh share this common ancestor.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Give a list of your ancestors. Pay attention to how you identify the families of your ancestors. Pause this audio here.

For each family, the storyteller gives the name of the common ancestor and the number of the men who return to the land of Judah. In this passage, there is a total of 15,604 Israelite men who return to the land of Judah, plus the women and children in each of these men's families.

Many people have different ideas about why this list of returning exiles is so important. Some people think that it is a list to show who owns the land after the exile, or to know how many people owe taxes. Other people think this list shows who the true Jews from Judah are, the people who obey the commands of Yahweh and have not

married other people outside of Israel. Or maybe people used this list in later generations to show that their ancestors were faithful to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the list of ancestors you listed earlier. Why is your list of your ancestors important to you? Pause this audio here.

This list is also important because it shows that the true Israelites are the same people from before the exile. The Israelites need to be pure so that they can worship Yahweh correctly in the temple of Yahweh, and this list shows that the people who return to Judah have ancestors from Judah. Yahweh is not starting over with a new people, but Yahweh is continuing the story with the same people, the people of Israel.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:1–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: Many exiles return from Babylon to Jerusalem in Judah. There are 11 leaders of these Israelites.

In the second scene: The storyteller lists the names of 18 families and the number of people in each family who return to Jerusalem in Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelites who return to the land of Judah
- King Nebuchadnezzar
- 11 Israelite leaders, including Zerubbabel and Jeshua
- 18 Israelite families
- And the Israelites in each of the 18 Israelite families

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that in the previous story, King Cyrus gave the Jewish exiles permission to return to Jerusalem in Judah to build the temple of Yahweh. Many of the exiles prepared to make the journey from Babylon to Jerusalem in Judah. At the end of the previous story, King Cyrus also gave the temple articles back to the exiles to bring to Jerusalem in Judah. Remember that the exiles returned to the land of Judah to rebuild the temple of Yahweh.

Now, the storyteller pauses the story's action to give the list of the people who return from Babylon to Jerusalem in Judah. These exiles show great faith in Yahweh by listening to Yahweh and by returning to the land of Judah, even though Yahweh did not promise that he would restore the kingdom of Judah. This list begins a new section in the book of Ezra. This is the first part of the six-part list of the exiles who return from Babylon to Jerusalem in Judah. The storyteller lists a different group of people in each of the six parts of the list.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story that includes a list of the ancestors of some of the characters in the story. Pay attention to how you begin the list of ancestors in the story. How will you start this new section of the book of Ezra? Pause this audio here.

In the first scene, the "people of the province" return from Babylon to the land of Judah. These Israelites are mostly from the Israelite tribes of Judah and Benjamin, and they used to live in the province of Judah. A province is a part of a land or a part of a kingdom. In the original language, the storyteller says the "sons of the province," which means the people who belong to a specific land. Remember that "people of the province" probably means the people from the land of Judah, who are Israelites, or more specifically, "Jewish" people. However, some people think it could mean people from the province of Babylon or people from the province of the Persian Empire. Remember that the land of Judah is not an independent nation at this time, so "people of the province" might mean the people who used to live in Judah but now are part of a province of the Persian Empire.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "people of the province" in this passage? Pause this audio here.

In the original language, the storyteller says that the exiles go up to Jerusalem in Judah. The Jews always said that a person goes "up" to Jerusalem because the city of Jerusalem was on a hill and was an important holy place.

Stop here and look at a map that includes the land of Babylon, the city of Babylon, the land of Judah, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate this part of the passage? Some ideas include: "The exiles came up to Jerusalem," "The exiles went up to Jerusalem," and "The exiles returned to Jerusalem." Pause this audio here.

Remember that King Nebuchadnezzar and the Babylonians took these people, and the ancestors of these people, into exile in Babylon in the past. Other ways to describe the idea of exile are that the Babylonians captured the Israelites, the Babylonians took the Israelites away from their country, or the Babylonians made the Israelites captives. The Babylonians forced the Israelites to live in Babylon for a long time, probably about 50 years. Now, these Israelites from Judah who went into exile, and the descendants of these Israelites, are returning to Jerusalem in Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this part of the passage to show what King Nebuchadnezzar did in the past when he captured the exiles and took them to Babylon? How will you translate what the Israelites are doing now in this passage? Would it be best to say first what King Nebuchadnezzar did in the past? Pause this audio here.

The exiles went back to the towns of their ancestors. A town is a place where people live together in an organized community. Remember that many of the people going to Jerusalem have never been there before, but the people all go to the towns of their ancestors. In the original language, a town could be a very small settlement like a village, or a large settlement with walls around it like a city.

This story gives the names of 11 leaders who return to Jerusalem with the Israelites. Remember that some people think that Sheshbazzar also returns with the exiles. If that is true, then there would be 12 leaders altogether. However, in Nehemiah 7, the list of 12 leaders is different from the list in this current passage. It is possible that the Ezra 2 list and the Nehemiah 7 lists are different because of copying errors. However, you should not change the list in Ezra 2 to match Nehemiah 7. There is no additional information about these 11 leaders in this list, but we know about the leaders from other parts of the Old Testament.

Zerubbabel and Jeshua are two important leaders who return with the exiles. Remember that Zerubbabel is a descendant of King David. Zerubbabel later becomes the governor of the land of Judah. Zerubbabel's grandfather was Jehoiachin, the king of Judah who was exiled to Babylon, and Zerubbabel was a descendant of King David. Some people think that Sheshbazzar came at the same time as Zerubbabel with this first group of exiles. Maybe Sheshbazzar was the representative from the Persian government, and Zerubbabel was the leader of the Israelites. Other people think that Sheshbazzar came first, and then Zerubbabel came back to Judah with a second group of exiles to rebuild the temple.

Jeshua is the descendant of Jehozadak, the last high priest before the exile. In other parts of the Old Testament, the storytellers call Jeshua "Joshua" instead, but it is the same person. This is not the same Joshua who led the Israelites into the promised land. Nehemiah in this list is not the same Nehemiah who rebuilt the Jerusalem wall years later that we hear about in the book of Nehemiah. Seraiah is the father of Ezra, the storyteller in this book. Mordecai is not the same Mordecai as in the book of Esther.

In the second scene, the storyteller lists the families of men who return to Jerusalem in Judah. Remember, this is only the first part of the six-part list of exiles who return. It is interesting that the first part of the list only includes common people, and not the religious leaders of the Israelites. The storyteller calls these men the "men of the Israelites." In later passages, the storyteller lists people by the places they come from or the jobs they do, including priests, Levites, singers, temple servants, and other workers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you introduce this list of the Israelites who return to Jerusalem in Judah? Here are some translation ideas:

- The list of the men of the people of Israel; or
- This is the list of the clans of Israel with the number of men who returned; or

- Here is a list of how many men returned from each family.

Pause this audio here.

Remember that these are the people who respond when Yahweh moves their spirits. Remember that other ways to translate this are: “Yahweh puts a thought in the minds of the people,” or “Yahweh gives the people this desire,” or “Yahweh causes the people to act, but Yahweh does not push the people to act.” These people leave Babylon to restore the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem in Judah. This could be a list of the people who are a true part of Israel, and not only the first people to return. Also, remember that the names in this list are not the names of the “heads” or leaders of the households. These names are all the names of ancestors before the exile, and these people probably used to live in Jerusalem before the exile to Babylon.

For each of the 18 families in the list in this passage, the storyteller first says, “the sons of,” followed by the ancestor’s name, and the number of men in the family of that ancestor. Remember that “sons” means descendants in this passage. Here are some translation ideas:

- There were 1,272 men related to the ancestor Parosh.
- There were 1,272 men from the clan of Parosh.
- Sons of Parosh, 1,272.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember your discussion in the first step about giving a list of your ancestors in your language. How will you translate the list of family groups in this passage? Be consistent in how you translate each family clan in the list. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller includes additional information for two of the families in this passage. The storyteller says that there are 2,812 men from the family of Pahath-Moab. In the original language, “Pahath-Moab” means the governor of Moab. It is possible that the name is two names, Pahath Moab. The storyteller says that these men are also descendants of Jeshua and Joab, who are probably in the same family as Pahath-Moab.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the information about the family of Pahath-Moab? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller also includes more information about the sons of Ater and about Hezekiah. Some people think that Ater and Hezekiah are two different people, and that Ater is Hezekiah’s distant relative. These people say that Hezekiah is a descendant of Ater in the same family group. Other people think that Ater and Hezekiah are the same person.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the information about the family of Ater? Pause this audio here.

Remember that people have different ideas about why this list of returning exiles is important. The storyteller may include this list for practical reasons. Maybe the Israelite leaders used this list to help them organize the people on the journey back to Judah, or maybe the list was a record of who came back, even after people could no longer remember who came back. Some people think that the list shows who owns the land, and that future generations would look back at this list to prove their rights to the land in Judah.

This list could also be important for the Babylonian authorities to know who left Babylon, and for the people of the places where the Israelites traveled to know who and how many people passed through their land. Officials in Judah also may have needed to know who lived in Judah in order to help the people pay taxes to the Persian Empire.

The storyteller may include this list for spiritual reasons. The list might show who is a true Israelite, someone who obeys Yahweh. In future generations, it will be important to show that someone is a true Israelite, someone who has not intermarried with others and who still follows Yahweh. This list also shows that these Israelites are from the same people who had followed Yahweh before their exile to Babylon.

After this six-part list, the storyteller will return to the main action of the story when the people begin to rebuild the temple of Yahweh.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:1–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelites who return to the land of Judah
- King Nebuchadnezzar
- 11 Israelite leaders, including Zerubbabel and Jeshua
- 18 Israelite families
- And the Israelites in each of the 18 Israelite families

Remember that many people probably heard this list at the time that the storyteller wrote the list. Also, remember that in future generations, people probably heard this list of the Israelites who returned to the land of Judah. So, here are some additional characters that might help you understand some of the emotions of the characters in this passage:

- Israelites who might hear this list in future generations
- And Babylonian or Persian officials who hear this list

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the past, King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon captured many people in the land of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar took these people to live in exile in the land of Babylon. Now, the descendants of these Israelite exiles return from the land of Babylon to the city of Jerusalem and to the land of Judah. These Israelites live in the towns where their ancestors used to live before the exile. The leaders of the Israelites are Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Nehemiah, Seraiah, Reelaiah, Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispar, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Israelites who return to the land of Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are happy to finally return to the land of our ancestors; or
- We have heard a lot about the land of Judah from our ancestors, and we are glad to finally get to see this land for ourselves; or
- That was a long journey from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah. We need time to rest and rebuild our towns.

Also, ask the people playing the leaders of the Israelites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are honored to lead the Israelites back to the land of Judah; or
- We are glad that King Cyrus of Persia let us leave the land of Babylon to return to the land of Judah; or
- We need to get ourselves organized before we start to rebuild the temple of Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

And here is a list of how many men returned from each family. From the family of Parosh, there were 2,172 men. From the family of Shephatiah, there were 372 men. From the family of Arah, there were 775 men. From the family of Pahath-Moab, through the sons of Jeshua and Joab, there were 2,812 men. From the family of Elam, there were 1,254 men. From the family of Zattu, there were 945 men. From the family of Zaccai, there were 760 men. From the family of Bani, there were 642 men. From the family of Bebai, there were 623 men.

Pause the drama. Ask the people who are playing Israelites who might hear this list in later generations, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are proud that our ancestors are in this list of the people who returned from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah because our ancestors are true Israelites; or
- We know that our ancestors were a part of the people of Israel before the exile, and now we see that more of our ancestors also came back to the land of Judah after the exile; or
- Even though the number of men is small from each of these families, we know that each of these men, and their families, obeyed Yahweh when they came back to the land of Judah.

Continue the drama.

From the family of Azgad, there were 1,222 men. From the family of Adonikam, there were 666 men. From the family of Bigvai, there were 2,056 men. From the family of Adin, there were 454 men. From the family of Ater, whose son was Hezekiah, there were 98 men. From the family of Bezai, there were 323 men. From the family of Jorah, there were 112 men. From the family of Hashum, there were 223 men. From the family of Gibbar, there were 95 men.

Pause the drama. Ask the people who are playing the Babylonian or Persian officials who might hear this list, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- This list is important because all of these people left the land of Babylon; or
- We need to keep track of these people so that we make sure these people pay all of the taxes that they need to pay to the Persian Empire; or
- We do not care if these people live in the land of Babylon or in the land of Judah. We only want these people to pay the taxes that they must pay.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:1–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

"The people of the province," who are the people of the land of Judah, return to the land of Judah. These are the people who lived in Babylon in **exile** for many years. In the past, **King** Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon took these people into exile in the land of Babylon. A king is someone who rules over a city or a territory. Translate exile and king the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Israelites return to the city of **Jerusalem** and to the land of **Judah**. Jerusalem was the capital city of the kingdom of Judah in the past. The temple of Yahweh used to be in the city of Jerusalem. The kingdom of Judah was the southern kingdom after the nation of Israel split into the northern kingdom of Israel and the southern kingdom of Judah. Translate Jerusalem and Judah the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on Jerusalem and Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Israelites also return to their own towns or cities. These are the towns where the ancestors of the Israelites lived before the exile to the land of Babylon. These towns are all within the land of Judah and are also close to the city of Jerusalem. In this case, towns could refer to a very small settlement like a village, or a large settlement with walls around it like a city.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **town** in this passage? Pause this audio here.

The **Israelites** return to the land of Judah with 11 leaders. The storyteller gives a list of the men of the people of Israel who return to the land of Judah. The people of Israel are the "Israelites," or the descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. We know that the Israelites who return to the land of Judah are mostly from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin, which used to be part of the southern kingdom of Judah. Remember that people used to call the northern kingdom "Israel," and these people intermarried and mostly no longer followed Yahweh. The storyteller probably says "Israelites" in this list to show that the people who return are true Israelites who still follow Yahweh and did not intermarry with other people groups who are not Israelites. Translate "people of Israel" the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on "the people of Israel," refer to **Israel** and Israelite in the Master Glossary.

The storyteller lists the number of sons of each family who return to the land of Israel. Sons means descendants in this list.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **sons** in this passage? For more information on sons, refer to **descendants** in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 2:1–20

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (840 KB)
- Setting the Stage (7.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (11.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.4 MB)

Ezra 2:21–35

Ezra 2:21–35

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 2:21–35 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:21–35 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:21–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, the storyteller began the list of the exiles who returned to Jerusalem in the land of Judah. Remember that Yahweh had moved the spirit of King Cyrus to let the Israelites go back to Jerusalem in Judah to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. In the first part of the list of the exiles who returned to Judah, we heard the names of the 11 leaders and the names of 18 families who also returned with the leaders. The storyteller said the number of people in each family who returned. Remember, these first 18 families are ordinary Israelites, and not religious leaders. Now, in this current passage, the storyteller says the names of 15 more groups of people. This is the second part of a six-part list of the exiles who return to Jerusalem in the land of Judah.

In this passage, the storyteller lists the people according to the names of places in the land of Judah instead of according to the names of the people. It is not clear why the storyteller says the place names in this passage instead of the names of the people. Some people think that these people might be the poorer people who did not own land in their own names in the land of Judah. Other people think the place names in this list show how the people of Israel continue to have a place in the land of Israel, even after the exile. This shows that Yahweh continues to provide for the people of Israel. It is also possible that the storyteller chooses to describe the people in this passage according to place names because this was common during that time to list people in different ways in official documents.

Also, it is most likely that these are the names of places where the ancestors of the returning Israelites are from. Perhaps the Israelites who returned from Babylon also returned to live in these towns of their ancestors, but we are not sure. The people in this part of the list have not lived in any of these towns in the land of Judah before, but the ancestors of these people used to live in these towns before the exile to Babylon. Remember that this entire six-part list includes only the men who choose to return to the land of Judah. However, we know that women and children also come back with the men.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about where you are from. Where are your ancestors from? Why is it important to be from a certain place, or in our culture, why would you want to know where someone is from? Pause this audio here.

The list of family groups in this passage who return to the land of Judah is also in the book of Nehemiah. The list in the book of Nehemiah is very similar to the list in this current passage.

Stop here and listen to your recording of Nehemiah 7:26–38 if you have already translated this passage into your own language. Pause this audio here.

For each of the 15 groups of people in this passage, the storyteller says the place or places where their ancestors are from, and the number of people in the group who return to the land of Judah. For example, the storyteller says that there are 123 sons of Bethlehem, and there are 56 men of Netophah. “Men of” and “sons of” have the

same meaning, and they both show that these men had ancestors who used to live in the towns of Bethlehem or Netophah before the exile to Babylon. Throughout this passage, the storyteller sometimes says “men” of a place or “sons” of a place to describe each group of people who return to the land of Judah.

The storyteller lists the places in this passage in a specific order. The list starts with places in the south of the land of Judah. Then the list moves north, then northwest, then far north, then southwest, then northwest, and finally northeast. Maybe the storyteller lists the places this way in order to keep the list organized.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: List the important towns and cities in your region or country. Pay attention to how you listed them. Where did you start? What did you list next? Why do you think you listed these important towns and cities in this order? Pause this audio here.

The first two places are Bethlehem and Netophah. Both of these towns are south of Jerusalem in an area that used to be in the land of the tribe of Judah. Netophah was a city for the Levites.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage and the city of Jerusalem. Find Bethlehem and Netophah on the map. Pause this audio here.

All of the other places in this passage are in an area that used to be the land of the tribe of Benjamin. Anathoth and Azmaveth are both towns north of Jerusalem. Anathoth was the home of the prophet Jeremiah.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage and the city of Jerusalem. Find Anathoth and Azmaveth on the map. Pause this audio here.

Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth are three towns northwest of Jerusalem. The storyteller groups these three towns together to give a total number of people for all three towns. This may be because these three towns are close together. We know from the book of 1 Samuel that the Israelites put the ark of Yahweh in the town of Kiriath Jearim after the Philistines gave the ark of Yahweh back to the Israelites. Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth were three of the cities of the Gibeonites who tricked Joshua and made a treaty with the Israelites.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage and the city of Jerusalem. Find Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth on the map. Pause this audio here.

Ramah, Geba, Micmash, Bethel, and Ai are all towns to the far north of Jerusalem. The storyteller groups Ramah and Geba together, and Bethel and Ai together. Again, this is probably because these towns are close together. Remember that Micmash is the place where Jonathan, the son of King Saul, fought against the Philistines. Most people believe that the Babylonians did not destroy Bethel, but that people destroyed Bethel later when the Persians became the rulers of the land.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage and the city of Jerusalem. Find Ramah, Geba, Micmash, Bethel, and Ai on the map. Pause this audio here.

Nebo, Magbish, the other Elam, and Harim are all towns southwest of Jerusalem. Remember, there was a person named Elam in the previous passage. It is possible that in this current passage, “the other Elam” means a person, and not the name of a town called “Elam.” It is possible that Elam took the name of the place where he lived as his family name or as his personal name. This group of people is not the same group of people as in the previous passage.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage and the city of Jerusalem. Find Nebo, Magbish, the other Elam, and Harim on the map. Pause this audio here.

Lod, Hadid, and Ono are towns northwest of Jerusalem. Jericho and Senaah are both towns northeast of Jerusalem. The largest number of Israelites return to Senaah. Some people think that Senaah is not a place, but a group of all the poor people who return to the land of Judah.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage and the city of Jerusalem. Find Lod, Hadid, Ono, Jericho, and Senaah on the map. Pause this audio here.

We know that later in the book of Jeremiah, many of the people whose ancestors are from these places help to rebuild the walls of Jerusalem.

Ezra 2:21–35

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:21–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

In the first scene: The Israelites return whose ancestors lived in the towns of Bethlehem and Netophah. These towns are south of Jerusalem.

In the second scene: The Israelites return whose ancestors lived in Anathoth and Azmaveth. These towns are north of Jerusalem.

In the third scene: The Israelites return whose ancestors lived in Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth. These three towns are northwest of Jerusalem.

In the fourth scene: The Israelites return whose ancestors lived in Ramah, Geba, Micmash, Bethel, and Ai. These towns are all to the far north of Jerusalem.

In the fifth scene: The Israelites return whose ancestors lived in Nebo, Magbish, the other Elam, and Harim. These towns are southwest of Jerusalem.

In the sixth scene: The Israelites return whose ancestors lived in Lod, Hadid, and Ono. These towns are northwest of Jerusalem.

In the seventh scene: The Israelites return whose ancestors lived in Jericho and Senaah. These towns are northeast of Jerusalem.

The characters in this passage are:

- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Bethlehem and Netophah
- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth
- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Ramah, Geba, Micmash, Bethel, and Ai
- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Nebo, Magbish, the other Elam, and Harim
- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Lod, Hadid, and Ono
- And Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Jericho and Senaah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

It might be helpful to start this passage by reminding people that this is a continuation of the list of exiles who return from Babylon to Jerusalem in Judah. Also, this is a part of the list with the numbers of the men whose ancestors had lived in these towns before the exile to Babylon.

In the first scene, the Israelites return whose ancestors came from the towns of Bethlehem and Netophah, which are both towns south of Jerusalem. The storyteller says there are 123 men whose ancestors had lived in Bethlehem and 56 men whose ancestors had lived in Netophah. Bethlehem is about 10 kilometers south of the city of Jerusalem, and Netophah is near Bethlehem. Other ways to say this could be, "these men were from the town of Bethlehem," or "these are men whose families originally came from Bethlehem." Remember that "men of" and "sons of" have the same meaning.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the number of men whose ancestors lived in the towns of Bethlehem and Netophah? Pause this audio here.

Remember that the towns in the first scene are in the land that used to be the land of the tribe of Judah. Also, remember that the storyteller tells the towns in a specific order based on the location of the towns, and that the storyteller groups certain towns together, probably because these towns are close to each other.

Stop here and look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Find Bethlehem and Netophah on the map. Pause this audio here.

Ezra 2:21–35

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: Would it be helpful to include the general location of the groups of towns in this scene as they relate to the city of Jerusalem? For example, maybe you would translate the first scene as, “The towns of Bethlehem and Netophah are south of Jerusalem in land that used to be in the land of the tribe of Judah. There are 123 men whose families originally came from Bethlehem, and there are 56 men whose families originally came from Netophah.”

Or you can choose not to include the additional information about the locations of the towns, and that the land used to be in the land of the tribe of Judah. If so, you might translate this scene as, “There are 123 men whose families originally came from Bethlehem, and there are 56 men whose families originally came from Netophah.” Pause this audio here.

The remaining scenes in this passage all have towns that are in the land that used to belong to the tribe of Benjamin.

In the second scene, the Israelites return whose ancestors came from the towns of Anathoth and Azmaveth. Remember, these towns are both north of Jerusalem, in the land that used to belong to the tribe of Benjamin. Anathoth is about 5 kilometers north of Jerusalem, and Azmaveth is about 8 kilometers north of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Find Anathoth and Azmaveth on the map. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the Israelites return whose ancestors came from the towns of Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth. These three towns are northwest of Jerusalem. In the original language, the storyteller says the name “Kiriath Arim,” but most scholars believe this is the same town that people call Kiriath Jearim in other passages. Kiriath Jearim is about 13 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem. Kephirah is north of Kiriath Jearim, and Beeroth is about 19 kilometers north of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Find Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth on the map. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the Israelites return whose ancestors came from the towns of Ramah, Geba, Micmash, Bethel, and Ai. These towns are all north of Jerusalem. In the original language, Bethel means “house of God.” Bethel is a town on the border. Ramah is about 8 kilometers north of Jerusalem, and Geba is east of Ramah. Micmash is about 13 kilometers northeast of Jerusalem, and Bethel is 10 kilometers north of Jerusalem. Ai is 2 kilometers east of Bethel.

Stop here and look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Find Ramah, Geba, Micmash, Bethel, and Ai on the map. Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the Israelites return whose ancestors were from the towns of Nebo, Magbish, the other Elam, and Harim. These towns are southwest of Jerusalem. Nebo of Judah is not the same as the town of Nebo of Moab, which is to the east of Jerusalem in the land that used to belong to the tribes of Reuben and Gad. People do not know exactly where Nebo of Judah is. Magbish is probably southwest of a town called Adullam. Elam was a well-known town in the place that is modern-day Iran, but this Elam is a different Elam, near Jerusalem. People are not certain where Harim is, but it is near the other towns in this scene.

Stop here and look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Find Nebo, Magbish, the other Elam, and Harim on the map. Pause this audio here.

In the sixth scene, the Israelites return whose ancestors were from the towns of Lod, Hadid, and Ono. These towns are northwest of Jerusalem near the coast of the Mediterranean Sea. In the New Testament, the storytellers call Lod “Lydda.” Lod is about 18 kilometers southeast of Joppa. Hadid is a town in the valley of Aijalon. Ono is about 8 kilometers north of Lod, and nearly 48 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Find Lod, Hadid, and Ono on the map. Pause this audio here.

In the seventh scene, the Israelites return whose ancestors were from the towns of Jericho and Senaah. Jericho and Senaah are northeast of Jerusalem. Jericho is a town about 16 kilometers northwest of the Dead Sea. People do not know where the town of Senaah is, but some people think that Senaah might be about 8 kilometers north of Jericho.

Ezra 2:21–35

Stop here and look at a map that includes all 21 towns in this passage, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Find Jericho and Senaah on the map. Pause this audio here.

Some people think that Senaah sounds like "the sons of the person people hated" in the original language. These people think that the large group of people whose ancestors were from the town of Senaah might actually be a group of poor people, because they are "the sons of the person people hated." It would be best to translate this scene with Senaah as the name of a town because we are not sure that it means a group of poor people returning to the land of Judah from exile in Babylon.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:21–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has seven scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Bethlehem and Netophah
- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth
- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Ramah, Geba, Micmash, Bethel, and Ai
- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Nebo, Magbish, the other Elam, and Harim
- Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Lod, Hadid, and Ono
- And Israelites who return whose ancestors lived in Jericho and Senaah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

This is a continuation of the list of exiles who return from Babylon to Jerusalem in Judah. This is a part of the list with the numbers of the men whose ancestors had lived in these towns before the exile to Babylon.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing all of the Israelites who return to the land of Judah, whose ancestors lived in each of the towns in this passage, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are honored to see the names of the towns of our ancestors in this list of exiles who return from Babylon to the land of Judah; or
- We are very happy that we can finally return to the land of our ancestors. We have never been here before, but we have heard a lot about the land of Judah, and we are happy to be here; or
- We are a little nervous about how we will live in the land of Judah now. In the land of Babylon, we had homes and work, and now we have to start over completely here in the land of our ancestors.

Continue the drama.

Ezra 2:21–35

The towns of Bethlehem and Netophah are south of Jerusalem in land that used to belong to the land of the tribe of Judah. There are 123 men whose families originally came from Bethlehem, and there are 56 men whose families originally came from Netophah.

The towns of Anathoth and Azmaveth are north of Jerusalem, in land that used to belong to the tribe of Benjamin. There are 128 men whose families originally came from Anathoth, and 42 men whose families originally came from Azmaveth.

The towns of Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth are northwest of Jerusalem, in land that used to belong to the tribe of Benjamin. There are 743 men whose families originally came from the towns of Kiriath Jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth.

The towns of Ramah, Geba, Micmash, Bethel, and Ai are all north of Jerusalem, in land that used to be the land of the tribe of Benjamin. There are 621 men whose families originally came from the towns of Ramah and Geba. There are 122 men whose families originally came from the town of Micmash. And there are 223 men whose families originally came from the towns of Bethel and Ai.

The towns of Nebo, Magbish, the other Elam, and Harim are southwest of Jerusalem, in land that used to belong to the tribe of Benjamin. There are 52 men whose families originally came from the town of Nebo, and there are 156 men whose families originally came from the town of Magbish. There are 1,254 men whose families originally came from the town of Elam, and there are 320 men whose families originally came from the town of Harim.

The towns of Lod, Hadid, and Ono are northwest of Jerusalem, in land that used to belong to the tribe of Benjamin. There are 725 men whose families originally came from the towns of Lod, Hadid, and Ono.

The towns of Jericho and Senaah are northeast of Jerusalem, in land that used to be in the land of the tribe of Benjamin. There are 3,630 men whose families originally came from the town of Senaah.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:21–35 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The storyteller gives the names of 21 **towns** in this passage, and many of these towns are well-known from other parts of the Old Testament. In your translation, it may be good to say that these are towns so that people know what these names refer to. If you include town in your translation, remember that a town can be any size of a settlement. You should use the same general word for town that you used in the previous list.

There are 123 men whose ancestors are from the town of **Bethlehem**. These 123 men return to the land of Judah from the exile in Babylon. The name Bethlehem means “house of bread.” King David was born in Bethlehem, and Jesus would also be born in Bethlehem. Translate Bethlehem the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament. For more information on Bethlehem, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 2:21–35

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (573 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (629 KB)
- Speaking the Word (807 KB)

Ezra 2:36–42

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 2:36–42 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:36–42 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:36–42 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passages, the storyteller began to list the exiles who return to the land of Judah. Remember that Yahweh had moved the spirit of King Cyrus to let the Jewish exiles go back to Jerusalem in Judah to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. Yahweh also moves the spirits of many Israelites to return to Judah to rebuild the temple. First, the storyteller listed the names of 11 leaders and 18 families of ordinary people who returned with the leaders. Then, we heard 15 more groups of people and the towns where those people's ancestors lived. Now, in this passage, the storyteller lists the priests and Levites who also return to Jerusalem in the land of Judah. This is the third part of a six-part list of the exiles who return to the land of Judah.

It is surprising that the storyteller lists the regular Israelites before the religious leaders. This might show that the storyteller wants to emphasize the ordinary people who listen to Yahweh and return to the land of Judah. We also know that the priests and Levites are very important to help lead the exiles who return to the land of Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who are the religious leaders in your community? What do these leaders do to serve your community? Pause this audio here.

The list of priests and Levites who return to the land of Judah is also in the book of Nehemiah. The list of priests is identical in both passages, and the list of Levites is also very similar.

Stop here and listen to your recording of Nehemiah 7:39–45 if you have already translated that passage into your own language. Pause this audio here.

In the first section of this passage, the storyteller lists the families of the priests who return to the land of Judah. The total number of priests who return is 4,289, which is 1 in every 10 people who return to the land of Judah. In the past, King David organized the priests into 24 family groups. Now, only 4 of these 24 family groups of priests return to the land of Judah. Remember that the storyteller only lists the men in each of these family groups, and not the women and children. The number in the list probably only includes men over the age of 12.

The first family group of priests that the storyteller lists is the descendants of Jedaiah. Jedaiah had been the leader of this family group a long time before this, and the “house” or family of Jeshua is a part of the larger clan of the descendants of Jedaiah. It is important that sons of Jeshua, from the family clan of Jedaiah, are among the priests who return to the land of Judah. In the past, Jedaiah was the leader of one of the 24 groups of priests before the exile. This shows that the returning exiles have a strong connection to the Israelites from before the exile.

The other three families of priests who return to the land of Judah are descendants of Immer, Pashhur, and Harim. This family of Harim is probably not the same group of people that the storyteller already listed in a previous passage. We learn later in the book of Ezra that sons of Jeshua, Immer, Harim, and Pashhur are among the priests who married foreign wives.

In the second section of the passage, the storyteller lists the Levites who return to the land of Judah. The total number of Levites who return to the land of Judah is 341, which is a much smaller number than the number of priests who return to the land of Judah. It is possible that fewer Levites choose to return because the Levites have no land of their own in the land of Judah. Instead, the inheritance of the Levites is a special relationship with Yahweh himself. Other people think that fewer Levites return because maybe the Levites were not happy about the low-status jobs that they had as assistants to the priests in the temple. It is possible that the Levites who returned after the exile also had extra pressure to complete their work because there were not many Levites who returned to the land of Judah.

The storyteller lists three groups of Levites. The first group is the descendants or “sons” of Jeshua and Kadmiel, who are the ancestors of Hodaviah. These sons of Jeshua and Kadmiel help the priests in the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who helps your religious leaders in your community? How do these people help the religious leaders? Pause this audio here.

The second group of Levites is the singers. The storyteller lists only one family of singers who return to the land of Judah, the sons of Asaph. The singers were responsible to write music, sing, and play musical instruments in the temple as a part of the worship of Yahweh. During the time of priests and Levites, other people around the Israelites, like the Canaanites, also had singing and music at their religious festivals. The singers in this current list were only religious singers. Later, the storyteller lists exile singers who did not make religious music.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of music or singing do you have at your religious festivals, services, or ceremonies? Who sings or performs the music? If possible, sing one of these songs together with your group, or play some musical instruments together. Pause this audio here.

Most people think that temple singers and musicians in this passage are only men because in the past, King David only chose men as the singers in the temple. Also, people needed to be ritually clean before going into the temple, and the law of Moses did not allow people to enter the temple if they were unclean. We know that women sometimes led worship in other parts of the Old Testament, but never in the temple.

The third group of Levites is the gatekeepers. The descendants of six different gatekeepers return to the land of Judah. In the past, the gatekeepers had two main jobs to do in the temple of Yahweh. The gatekeepers guarded the entrances to the temple to make sure only ritually clean people came into the temple. The gatekeepers also

guarded the storerooms in the temple where the priests kept the articles and food that the priests used for the worship of Yahweh.

Stop here and listen to your recording of 1 Chronicles 9:17–29 as a group, if you have already translated it. This passage describes the duties of the gatekeepers. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: What does a guard, janitor, or gatekeeper do in your community? What do these people guard? What do other people think about this job?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:36–42 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller lists the priests who return to the land of Judah.

In the second scene: The storyteller lists the other Levites who return to the land of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- The four groups of priests
- The Levites who are descendants of Jeshua and Kadmiel
- The Levites who are singers
- And the Levites who are gatekeepers

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

It might be helpful to start this passage by reminding people that this is a continuation of the list of exiles who return from Babylon to the land of Judah. Also, remember that this is a list of the priests and Levites who return to the land of Judah.

In the first scene, the storyteller lists four family groups of priests who return to the land of Judah. Remember that 24 groups of priests served in the temple of Yahweh during the time of King David. The first group of priests is the descendants, or "sons," of Jedaiah.

These descendants of Jedaiah are a part of the smaller family group of Jeshua. Jeshua is also called Joshua in other parts of the Old Testament. Remember that Jeshua was already in this list in a previous passage as one of the leaders who returns to the land of Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Would it be helpful to include a summary about this scene to show that this part of the list is about the priests who return? Here are some translation ideas:

- This is a list of the number of priests who returned, according to their families; or
- These are the priests who return.

Pause this audio here.

Also, how will you translate this part of the first scene to show that the 973 priests who return are a part of both Jeshua's family and the larger clan of Jedaiah? Here are some translation ideas:

- 973 priests returned who were descendants of Jeshua. Jeshua's ancestor was Jedaiah; or
- From the family of Jedaiah, through Jedaiah's descendant Jeshua, 973 priests returned.

Pause this audio here.

The other three families of priests who return to the land of Judah are sons or descendants of Immer, Pashhur, and Harim. We know that in the past, Pashhur was opposed to the prophet Jeremiah. Remember that the sons of Harim who return in this current passage are not the same people from the previous passage whose ancestors were from a town called Harim.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show that these three groups of people in scene one are also priests? Here are some translation examples:

- From the family of Immer, 1,052 priests returned. From the family of Pashhur, 1,247 priests returned. From the family of Harim, 1,017 priests returned; or
- Other priests who returned are 1,052 from the family of Immer, 1,247 from the family of Pashhur, and 1,017 from the family of Harim; or
- Priests who were descendants of Immer, 1052. Priests who were descendants of Pashhur, 1,247. Priests who were descendants of Harim, 1,017.

Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller lists three groups of Levites who return to the land of Judah. Remember that in the past, the Levites helped the priests in the temple of Yahweh. Not many Levites return to the land of Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Would it be helpful to include a summary about this scene to show that this part of the list is about the Levites who return? Here are some translation ideas:

- This is a list of the number of Levites who returned, according to their families; or
- These are the Levites who return; or
- These are the men who are descendants of the tribe of Levi, according to their families.

Pause this audio here.

The first group of Levites includes both the descendants of Jeshua and the descendants of Kadmiel. The descendants of Kadmiel are also sons of Hodaviah. Some people think that "sons

of Hodaviah" means two names, "Binnui and Hodaviah," instead. Also, some people think that the sons of Jeshua and the sons of Kadmiel are both ancestors of Hodaviah, but it is not clear.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this part of the list of Levites who return? Some translation examples include:

- From the families of Jeshua and Kadmiel, 74 Levites returned. All of those Levites were descendants of Hodaviah, who was the descendant of Jeshua and Kadmiel; or
- 74 Levites were descendants of Hodaviah. Their ancestors included Jeshua and Kadmiel; or
- 74 Levites returned. These Levites were descendants of Jeshua or descendants of Kadmiel, who was one of the sons of Hodaviah.

Pause this audio here.

The second group of the Levites is the temple singers or musicians. In the original language, the word usually means singers, but we know that these singers also wrote music and played musical instruments when people worshipped Yahweh in the temple. Also, remember that temple singers and musicians are usually men in the Old Testament. In the original language, the storyteller uses the male form of the word for singers, and later in the list, the storyteller uses the male and female forms of the word for singers when the storyteller is listing the non-religious singers who return.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "singers" in this scene to show that it is men, and not women singers? Also, choose a word in your language that could mean both singer and musician, if possible. If your language does not have a word like that, choose a word that means "singers." Pause this audio here.

Some people think it is not clear what the relationship between the Levites and the singers is. However, it is most likely that the storyteller lists the singers separately from the other Levites because the singers have different work to do than the work of the other Levites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you introduce the singers in this list? Will you say that the singers are also Levites? Here are some translation ideas:

- 128 singers returned. These singers were from the family of Asaph, from the tribe of Levi; or
- From the family of Asaph, 128 singers returned; or

- The singers from the family of Asaph, 128.

Pause this audio here.

The number of singers of the family of Asaph is 128 in this current passage, but in the similar passage in Nehemiah 7, the storyteller lists 148 singers. Also, we see later in Nehemiah 10 that people from the other two families of singers also return to the land of Judah, but it is likely that they return later than the family of Asaph.

In the last part of the second scene, the storyteller lists the gatekeepers. Remember that gatekeepers were responsible to guard the temple and the temple storerooms. In the original language, the storyteller says, "the sons of the gatekeepers." Other ways to translate "gatekeepers" are "guards" or "people who guard the temple and its gates."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Listen to your translation of 1 Chronicles 9:17–27 to hear how you translated "gatekeepers" of the temple of Yahweh. How will you translate gatekeepers in this passage? Translate "gatekeeper" the same way that you did in 1 Chronicles 9:17–27. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller lists six different families of gatekeepers in this passage. We know that Shallum, Talmon, and Akkub used to live in Jerusalem before the exile, but we do not know anything else about Ater, Hatita, and Shobai or their families.

The storyteller in Nehemiah 7 lists 138 gatekeepers instead of the 139 gatekeepers in this current passage.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:36–42 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The four groups of priests
- The Levites who are descendants of Jeshua and Kadmiel
- The Levites who are singers
- And the Levites who are gatekeepers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

This is a list of the number of priests who returned, according to their families. 973 priests returned who were descendants of Jeshua. Jeshua's ancestor was Jedaiah. From the family of Immer, 1,052 priests returned. From the family of Pashhur, 1,247 priests returned. From the family of Harim, 1,017 priests returned.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the four groups of priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are happy to return to the land of Judah so that we can rebuild the temple of Yahweh; or

- We have faith that Yahweh will be able to help us rebuild Yahweh's temple; or
- We are glad that so many priests chose to come back to the land of Judah. This will help us be able to do the important work in the temple that Yahweh told us to do.

Continue the drama.

This is a list of the number of Levites who returned, according to their families. From the families of Jeshua and Kadmiel, 74 Levites returned. All of those Levites were descendants of Hodaviah, who was the descendant of Jeshua and Kadmiel.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Levites who are the descendants of Jeshua and Kadmiel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We want to serve Yahweh and help the priests in the temple of Yahweh; or
- We are worried that we will have a lot of extra work to do because we do not see a lot of other Levites coming back with us to serve in the temple of Yahweh; or
- We do not mind that some people do not think our work is of very high status. We are ready to serve Yahweh in the temple.

Continue the drama.

128 singers returned. These singers were from the family of Asaph, from the tribe of Levi.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Levites who are singers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are ready to sing and make music for Yahweh in the temple; or
- We wish that singers from the other two families of singers also returned with us to the land of Judah; or
- We hope that the people can rebuild the temple quickly so we can start singing and worshipping Yahweh in the temple.

Continue the drama.

139 gatekeepers returned, who were the descendants of Shallum, Ater, Talmon, Akkub, Hatita, and Shobai.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Levites who are gatekeepers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are ready to serve Yahweh as gatekeepers in the temple; or
- We are nervous that more gatekeepers did not come back with us. We will have a lot of work to do to organize all of the temple articles that King Cyrus returned to us; or
- We know that many people do not think our work is very important as gatekeepers, but we know that it is important to Yahweh.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:36–42 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The storyteller lists the **priests** who return to the land of Judah. Only certain people could become priests. The tribe of Levi was one of the 12 tribes of Israel, and Aaron was from the tribe of Levi. Only descendants of Aaron could become priests. Translate priest the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

Priests returned who were "sons" or **descendants** of Jeshua, and Jeshua's ancestor was Jedaiah. We know from other parts of the Old Testament that Jeshua is the son of Jehozadak, and that Jeshua becomes the new high

priest after the people return from exile. Translate descendants the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on descendants, refer to the Master Glossary.

We see this same list of priests who return to the land of Judah in Ezra 10. Some of the priests take foreign wives. Also, we know that when Ezra returns to the land of Judah a few generations later, only these same four family groups of priests also return to the land of Judah.

The storyteller also lists the **Levites** who return to the land of Judah. In this passage, the Levites are from the tribe Levi, but they are not descendants of Aaron and are not priests. Before the exile, the Levites helped the priests with work in the temple. According to the law of Moses, the Levites could not offer sacrifices on the altar of the temple of Yahweh. In the law of Moses, Yahweh provided 48 cities for the Levites to live in, and the people supported the Levites. Translate Levite the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament. For more information on Levite, refer to the Master Glossary.

Singers also return to the land of Judah. We know from other parts of the Old Testament that King David organized temple singers into 24 groups so that each group worked with one of the 24 groups of priests. The singers who return are from the family of Asaph. Asaph was the chief musician during the time of King David. Asaph wrote many Psalms.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Listen to your translation of 2 Chronicles 15:16. How will you translate **singers** in this passage? Translate singers the same in this passage as you did in the 2 Chronicles passage. Pause this audio here.

Gatekeepers also return to the land of Judah. Gatekeepers guard the **temple**, but they are not military guards. We know that during the time of King David, there were as many as 4,000 gatekeepers and 4,000 musicians serving in the temple. Now, we see there are only 341 total who return to serve as Levites in the temple of Yahweh, which is a much smaller number of Levites. In the original language, the storyteller says only that the gatekeepers came, but some translations also add that the gatekeepers guarded the temple gates and doors. If you choose to add the information that they are temple gatekeepers, translate “temple” the same as you have in previous passages of the Old Testament. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate gatekeepers in this passage? If needed, listen to your translation of 1 Chronicles 9:17 again to hear what you called gatekeepers. Pause this audio here.

We know from Psalm 84 that the Psalmist said he would rather be a gatekeeper for the house of God than live with wicked people.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 2:36–42

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (829 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Ezra 2:43–58

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 2:43–58 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:43–58 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:43–58 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passages, the storyteller listed the exiles who returned to the land of Judah. Remember that Yahweh had moved the spirit of King Cyrus to let the Jewish exiles go back to Jerusalem in Judah to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. Yahweh also moved the spirits of many exiles to return to Judah to rebuild the temple. The storyteller listed the names of Jewish leaders, ordinary Jews, and the priests and Levites who returned to the land of Judah. Now, the storyteller lists the descendants of the temple servants and the descendants of the servants of Solomon who return to the land of Judah. This is the fourth part of a six-part list of the exiles who return to the land of Judah.

The storyteller lists the descendants of the temple servants who return to the land of Judah. Temple servants are the men who help the Levites in the temple. Later in the book of Ezra, we learn more about the work of the temple servants. Temple servants probably did work like cutting wood, carrying water, cleaning floors, and other tasks in the temple. Temple servants were the lowest group of temple workers. It is possible these temple servants did other work outside the temple as well.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the place where you worship or do your religious practices. Who are the people who do the basic tasks to take care of this place, such as cleaning? Pause this audio here.

Many people think the temple servants are the descendants of the Gibeonites, who are not Israelites. You will remember from the book of Joshua that Joshua forced the Gibeonites to be woodcutters and water carriers for the Israelite community after the Gibeonites tricked the Israelites. It is possible that these temple servants also

included other foreigners, and maybe even descendants of people whom King David had fought and captured in the past. It is clear that many of the names in the list of temple servants are foreign names, and not Israelite names. This shows that it is likely that the temple servants were not Israelites. This is surprising because in the book of Ezekiel, the prophet Ezekiel warns against foreigners serving in the temple of Yahweh. And other parts of the Old Testament say that to bring a foreigner into the temple of Yahweh makes the temple unclean. However, in the book of Isaiah, the prophet Isaiah says that certain foreigners can serve in the temple. We know that both Ezra and Nehemiah warn the Israelites not to marry foreigners, so Ezra may list the temple servants separately to remind the full Israelites not to intermarry with these foreigners.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about different groups of people in your village, community, region, or country. Are there certain groups of people that you should not marry or be around? Why? Pause this audio here.

Although there are different ideas about Israelites having contact with foreigners, we know that the temple servants did have a place in Israel when they returned from exile. King David himself said that the first temple servants should serve in the first temple in Jerusalem. Now, the descendants of these first temple servants are returning to serve again in the second temple in Jerusalem. Temple servants for both the first and second temples did not need to pay taxes, similar to the way priests and Levites did not need to pay taxes. We know that the temple servants also helped to rebuild the wall in the book of Nehemiah, and the temple servants committed to the covenant to follow Yahweh. The temple servants probably had higher status than slaves or other non-Israelites. We know from the book of Nehemiah that the temple servants also lived in a special part of Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about foreigners in your community who may have lower status, but who do have rights as servants or workers. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller also lists the descendants of the servants of Solomon. Although it is not clear who exactly the servants of Solomon were, we do know that these servants of Solomon had a lower status than the temple servants earlier in this passage. These servants of Solomon also had a higher status than people who did not know their ancestry at all. However, the servants of Solomon could not intermarry with Israelites, similar to the temple servants. If an Israelite woman married someone who was a servant of Solomon or a temple servant, their children would not be true Israelites.

Also, we know that the temple servants and the servants of Solomon are similar because the storyteller gives a total number for both groups together in this list. Both groups were a part of the history of Israel before the exile, and it is likely that the servants of Solomon also helped the Levites in the daily work in the temple of Yahweh, similar to the work of the temple servants.

Some people think the servants of Solomon are foreigners whom Solomon forced to work in the temple that Solomon built. It is possible these people were foreigners who remained in the land of Canaan when Joshua conquered the land. These servants of Solomon might have been Amorites, Hittites, Perizzites, Hivites, or Jebusites.

Other people think the servants of Solomon are not Canaanites who remained in the land, but prisoners of war. We know that other non-Israelites took other people captive when they fought against those people. These non-Israelites often made these captives work in the service of their own gods. It is possible that Solomon took captives from wars and made these captives work in the temple that Solomon built for Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, if one group captures some people from another group of people, what happens to the people they capture? Do the people they capture become servants, slaves, workers, or something else? Pause this audio here.

This list of the descendants of temple servants and the descendants of the servants of Solomon is also in the book of Nehemiah. The list in Nehemiah is almost the same as the list in this current passage.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Listen to your recording of Nehemiah 7:46–60, if you have already translated this passage into your own language.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:43–58 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The descendants of the temple servants return to the land of Judah.

In the second scene: The descendants of the servants of Solomon return to the land of Judah.

In the third scene: The storyteller says how many descendants of temple servants and descendants of the servants of Solomon return to the land of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Descendants of the 35 family groups of the temple servants
- And descendants of the 10 family groups of the servants of Solomon

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

It might be helpful to start this passage by reminding people that this is a continuation of the list of exiles who return from Babylon to the land of Judah. Also, remember that this is a list of the descendants of the temple servants and the descendants of the servants of Solomon who return to the land of Judah.

In the first scene, the storyteller lists 35 families of temple servants. The descendants of these 35 temple servants are people who return to the land of Judah. Remember, there is a very similar passage in Nehemiah 7:46–60. The storyteller in this current passage includes three more names than the storyteller in the book of Nehemiah—Akkub, Hagab, and Asnah.

Remember that temple servants are people who do the lowest kind of work in the temple. In the original language, "temple servants" means "the given ones" or "the dedicated ones." People gave the temple servants to serve the Levites in the temple, and the Levites set apart the temple servants to serve Yahweh. Other ways to translate temple servants are "workmen," "temple slaves," or "temple workers."

In the original language, the storyteller uses the same word in 1 Chronicles 9:2 as the storyteller uses in this current passage for temple servants. Translate temple servants the same way that you did in 1 Chronicles 9:2.

Stop here and listen to your translation of 1 Chronicles 9:2, if you have already translated this passage into your own language. How will you translate temple servants in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: Would it be helpful to include information here about the role of the temple servants? For example, you could say, "This is a list of the descendants of the temple servants who return to the land of Judah. Temple servants help the Levites in the temple." Pause this audio here.

In the original language, the storyteller says, "the descendants of Ziha, the descendants of Hasupha, the descendants of Tabbaoth." In some translations, people do not repeat "sons" or "descendants" for each name. For example, a translation might say, "the descendants of Ziha, Hasupha, and Tabbaoth."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the 35 families of temple servants in this scene? Would it be better to include "sons of" or "descendants of" for each family name, or is it better to simply say "the descendants of" one time at the start of the list? Pause this audio here.

Some names are Israelite names, although this does not necessarily mean these temple servants were Israelites.

In the second scene, the storyteller lists 10 families of the descendants of the servants of Solomon. It might be helpful to begin this scene by introducing the list, saying, "This is a list of the descendants of the servants of Solomon who return to the land of Judah." Some of the names in the list describe certain tasks. People may have those names to show what tasks they did to serve Solomon.

The name Hassophereth means “the scribe,” and some people think this means that these servants of Solomon also helped write down the amounts of money that the Israelites gave to the temple. Also, in the original language, the name Hassophereth is feminine, and so some people think that Hassophereth was a woman. It would be unusual for a woman to work as a servant for Solomon in the temple, but it is possible. Some people think the name is feminine because the name shows that a whole group of people worked as scribes for the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about names in your community that describe a group of people, and the work that those people do. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the storyteller lists the total number of people in this current passage. This includes both the descendants of the temple servants who return to the land of Judah and the descendants of the servants of Solomon who return to the land of Judah. Remember that in previous passages of this list of the people who return to the land of Judah, the storyteller lists the number of people from each family. But here the storyteller gives only a total for all of the families in this category of temple servants and servants of Solomon. Remember that this probably shows these servants had similar work and that the servants were of a lower status than other people who returned to the land of Judah.

The total number of people in this passage is 392. This means there were fewer than 9 people for each family in this list. This is a much smaller number of people for each family than in the other parts of the list of people who return to the land of Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the third scene to show that the total number includes the descendants of the temple servants and the descendants of the servants of Solomon? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:43–58 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Descendants of the 35 family groups of the temple servants
- And descendants of the 10 family groups of the servants of Solomon

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

This is a list of the descendants of the temple servants who return to the land of Judah. Temple servants help the Levites in the temple. The descendants of each of the following families of temple servants return to the land of Judah: Ziha, Hasupha, Tabbaoth, Keros, Siaha, Padon, Lebanah, Hagabah, Akkub, Hagab, Shalmai, Hanan, Giddel, Gahar, Reaiah, Rezin, Nekoda, Gazzam, Uzza, Paseah, Besai, Asnah, Meunim, Nephussim, Bakbuk, Hakupha, Harhur, Bazluth, Mehida, Harsha, Barkos, Sisera, Temah, Neziah, and Hatipha.

Pause the drama. Ask the descendants of the 35 family groups of the temple servants, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are honored to see the names of our ancestors in this list of returning exiles from Babylon to the land of Judah; or
- We are very happy that we can finally return to the land of our ancestors. We have never been here before, but we have heard a lot about the land of Judah; or
- We are glad to return to serve in the temple of Yahweh. Our ancestors served in the temple of Yahweh, even though our ancestors were not Israelites. We also are not Israelites, but we want to serve Yahweh in the temple.

Continue the drama.

This is a list of the descendants of the servants of Solomon who return to the land of Judah. The descendants of all of the following servants of Solomon return to the land of Judah: Sotai, Hassophereth, Peruda, Jaala, Darkon, Giddel, Shephatiah, Hattil, Pokereth-Hazzebaim, and Ami.

Pause the drama. Ask the descendants of the 10 family groups of the servants of Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are honored to see the names of our ancestors in this list of returning exiles from Babylon to the land of Judah. We know that our status is lower than the priests, Levites, and the temple servants, but we are still happy that our ancestors are included in this list; or
- We know that our ancestors served King Solomon. It is possible that King Solomon took our ancestors captive a long time ago after a war, but our ancestors were faithful to serve in the temple for a long time. We will continue to serve in the temple the same way that our ancestors did; or
- We are a little nervous about moving to the land of Judah. We hope that the Israelites will treat us well because we are not Israelites.

Continue the drama.

There were a total of 392 descendants of the temple servants and descendants of the servants of Solomon who returned to the land of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the descendants of the 35 family groups of the temple servants and the descendants of the 10 family groups of the servants of Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are surprised that only 392 of us are returning to the land of Judah; or
- It might be difficult for us to complete all the necessary work in the temple because there are not a lot of us returning to the land of Judah; or
- We may not be a large number of servants returning to work in the temple of Yahweh, but we are proud to return to the land of Judah to serve in the temple.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:43–58 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The storyteller includes a list of the **descendants** of the temple servants who return to the land of Judah. Descendants are a person’s children, grandchildren, and all future generations from the same family line. Another way to translate descendants is “sons.” Translate descendants the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on descendants, refer to the Master Glossary.

Temple servants help the Levites in the temple. Remember that in the original language, the storyteller says “the **dedicated** ones.” Dedicate means to set someone or something aside for a special use for Yahweh. The words “servant” and “temple” are not in the passage. Other ways to translate temple servants are “temple slaves,” “workmen,” or “temple workers.” For more information, refer to temple and servant in the Master Glossary. Remember that in this passage, the temple servants are not able to serve Yahweh in the same way that the priests and Levites serve Yahweh. But the temple servants do have a special purpose in the temple of Yahweh.

The storyteller also includes a list of the descendants of the **servants** of Solomon who return to the land of Judah. Remember that Solomon was the third king of Israel. Solomon was the son of King David, and Solomon built the first temple of Yahweh. The first temple servants probably helped build the first temple of Yahweh. Now, the descendants of the servants of Solomon come back to the land of Judah and help rebuild the temple of Yahweh. The storyteller uses the common word for servants to describe the servants of Solomon. For more information about servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 2:43–58

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (528 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Ezra 2:59–63

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 2:59–63 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:59–63 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Ezra 2:59–63

3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:59–63 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passages, the storyteller listed the exiles who returned to the land of Judah. Remember that Yahweh had moved the spirit of King Cyrus to let the Jewish exiles go back to Jerusalem in Judah to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. Yahweh also moved the spirits of many Israelites to return to Judah to rebuild the temple. The storyteller listed the names of Jewish leaders, ordinary Jews, priests, Levites, the descendants of the temple servants, and the descendants of the servants of Solomon who returned to the land of Judah. Now, the storyteller lists the people who could not prove they were Jews. This is the fifth part of a six-part list of the exiles who return to the land of Judah.

Remember that one of the purposes of this list is to show that the people who return to the land of Judah are descendants of the same people who left Judah before the exile to Babylon. Before the exile, a family passed down their land to their descendants, and this showed everyone the identity of that family. After the exile, the Israelite people did not have land anymore. Instead, the Israelites needed to prove that they were descended from Israel with a genealogy of their ancestors, which was probably an official family record. This record was a list of the names of the people's ancestors.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you keep records of your ancestors? If possible, ask several people in your group to list their ancestors. Pause this audio here.

In this passage, the storyteller lists both ordinary people and priests who cannot prove that they are true Israelites. It is possible that these people lost their family records. If someone cannot prove their ancestry, this means they are not full members of the community.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about someone in your community who does not have proof of their ancestors. What happens in your community if you do not have proof of your identity or your family? Pause this audio here.

This list of the people who cannot prove that they are Israelites is also in the book of Nehemiah. The list in Nehemiah is very similar to the list in this current passage.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Listen to your recording of Nehemiah 7:61–65, if you have already translated this passage into your own language. Pause this audio here.

In the first part of this passage, the storyteller lists people from five towns in Babylon who cannot prove they are Israelites. Remember that in the previous parts of this list, the storyteller listed the people according to the towns of their ancestors in the land of Judah. The people in this current passage might not know which town in the land of Judah their ancestors are from, and that may be why the storyteller lists these people according to their Babylonian towns.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that shows the land of Babylon, the city of Jerusalem, and the land of Judah. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says there are only 652 ordinary people who cannot show that their families are descended from the Israelites. This is a very small number compared to the total number of Israelites who can prove that their families were descendants of the Israelites. Some people think that the storyteller lists the descendants of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda here so that the other Israelites know not to marry anyone in these three families. Other people think the people in this passage might be foreigners who decided to become people of Israel, and that is why they cannot prove their ancestry as Israelites.

In the second part of the passage, the storyteller lists the priests who cannot prove they are priests of Israel. Remember that in the law of Moses, Yahweh said only the descendants of Aaron can serve as priests. Priests

serve Yahweh in the temple of Yahweh. In order to be a priest, a person needed to show they were a descendant of Aaron.

The storyteller lists the descendants of three priests who come back to the land of Judah, but the storyteller does not give the number of the priests who return. The first of these three priests had married the daughter of a man from Gilead named Barzillai, and then that priest had taken his father-in-law's same name, "Barzillai." We do not know the original name of this priest. This is the only time in the Old Testament that a storyteller calls a man by the name of the man's wife's family, and not the name of the man's family.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, is it more common to take the name of the husband's family or the wife's family? Give examples of the names of the people in your group. Pause this audio here.

Some people think that Barzillai took the name of his wife's father because his wife's father only had daughters. Other people think that Barzillai was not able to be a priest because Barzillai took the name of his wife's father in order to inherit the land from his wife's father, and priests were not permitted to inherit land. The inheritance Yahweh gave the priests was not land, but their relationship with Yahweh himself. Other people think Barzillai did not have a list of his ancestors, and that is why the storyteller lists Barzillai with his wife's family.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about what happens if someone does not have a name in the normal way for your community to name people. Pause this audio here.

These descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai searched for their names in the records of their families, but they could not find any proof that they were priests of Yahweh. The other Israelites allowed these descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai to stay in the community, but they did not allow the men to serve as priests or offer sacrifices to Yahweh.

Priests served Yahweh in the temple of Yahweh, and priests needed to be ritually clean. If a person is ritually unclean, it means there is something about the person on the outside that makes the person unclean. If priests were not ritually clean, the priests could make anything they touched unclean. A ritually unclean priest could even make the entire community of Israel unclean.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about ritual cleanness and uncleanness in your community. What kinds of things make a person ritually clean? What kinds of things make a person ritually unclean? Pause this audio here.

Also, the governor, or ruler, of the land of Judah ordered the descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai not to eat the most holy, or sacred food. This governor is the Persian governor of the land of Judah. Most people think that the governor in this passage is Zerubbabel, but some people think it might be Sheshbazzar. It is interesting that the Persian governor of the land of Judah prohibits these men from eating the food for the priests. This shows how important religious laws are in the land of Judah. Normally, only priests can eat food that priests have offered to Yahweh.

The governor says these men cannot eat the food for the priests until there is a priest who can consult the Urim and Thummim. It is possible that a priest could use the Urim and the Thummim to find out whether Yahweh would let these descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai eat the holy food. Most likely, there was no high priest yet in Jerusalem, or maybe there was no Urim and Thummim available.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who is the governor, or ruler, of your community or region? What kinds of rules does this ruler make for the people? Pause this audio here.

We know from the law of Moses that the Urim and Thummim are the holy lots that the high priest wore over his heart. We do not know exactly what the Urim and Thummim looked like, or how the high priest used them. But we know the high priest used the Urim and Thummim to hear answers from Yahweh. During this time, the Assyrians used a white stone and a black stone to tell the future. It is possible that the Urim and Thummim were similar to the stones the Assyrians used. Some people think the Bible does not include a lot of information about how the high priest used the Urim and Thummim so that no one would recreate these objects to hear from God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What rituals do you use in your culture to help you make important decisions? What do you do in order to hear from God or from your deity?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:59–63 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller lists the ordinary Israelites who cannot prove that their families are from the people of Israel.

In the second scene: The storyteller lists the priests who cannot prove that they are from the people of Israel and true descendants of Aaron. The descendants of these three families of priests cannot serve as priests.

The characters in this passage are:

- Descendants of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda
- Descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai
- The father of Barzillai's wife, who is also named Barzillai
- The governor
- And a priest who can consult the Urim and Thummim

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

It might be helpful to start this passage by reminding people that this is the fifth part in a six-part list of the exiles who return from Babylon to the land of Judah. In the following passage, the storyteller gives a summary of the total number of people who return to the land of Judah.

In this passage, the storyteller lists people who cannot prove their ancestry as Israelites. In the original language, the storyteller uses words that show it is a new section of the list. All of the people in the previous parts of this list had proof of their ancestry as Israelites. But in this section, the storyteller lists people who do not have proof of their ancestry as Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story that includes several similar parts, and one part near the end that is different from the other parts. Pay attention to how you begin the part of the story that is different from the other parts. How will you translate the beginning of this passage to show it is a new part of the list? Pause this audio here.

Remember that in the previous passage, the storyteller listed the descendants of the temple servants and the descendants of the servants of Solomon who returned to the land of Judah. It is likely that the people in the previous passage had a higher status than the people in this current passage, who could not prove their ancestry. The people in this current passage are still able to live in the community of the Israelites, but these people are considered lower status than even the servants.

In the first scene, the storyteller gives information about the ordinary people who could not prove their ancestry as Israelites. First, the storyteller says these people go to Jerusalem in the land of Judah. In the original language, the storyteller says that the Israelites "go up," which means that the Israelites go up to Jerusalem in Judah. You will remember from previous passages that the Israelites always say that a person goes "up" to Jerusalem because the city of Jerusalem was on a hill and was an important sacred place.

Stop here and look at a map that includes the land of Babylon, the city of Babylon, the land of Judah, and the city of Jerusalem again as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller says where these people came from in the land of Babylon. Remember that in all of the other parts of the list, the storyteller listed people according to the towns of their ancestors in the land of Judah. Now, the storyteller lists people according to five towns where they had lived in the land of Babylon during their exile.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: Would it be helpful to include the information in your translation that these five towns are in Babylon, and not in the land of Judah? Pause this audio here.

In the original language, a “tel” is the hill that forms when people build newer cities on top of older, ruined cities. Tel Melah and Tel Harsha are both towns that people built on top of other ruined cities. Tel Melah means “hill of salt,” and Tel Harsha means “hill of wood.” Some people think that Kerub, Addon, and Immer are the names of one town instead of three separate towns. If Kerub-Addon-Immer were one town, then each of the three family groups in the next part of the scene might be from one of these three towns. Other people think that Kerub, Addon, and Immer are towns close together in the land of Babylon.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the five names of the towns that the people came from in the land of Babylon? Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller says these people cannot show they are descendants of the Israelites. In the original language, the storyteller says, “These people were not able to show the house, or family, of their fathers and if their seed were from Israel.” Fathers are their ancestors, and seed means descendants.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this part of the scene where these people cannot show they are descendants of the Israelites? Here are some translation options:

- These people could not show that their families were descended from Israel; or
- These people could not prove with their family records that they were true people of Israel; or
- These people could not prove they were Israelites by the name of their father’s family, and they also could not prove they were Israelites by their blood.

Pause this audio here.

In the final part of this scene, the storyteller lists the names of three families of people who are ancestors of these people who are coming back to the land of Judah: Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda. Remember, there is a similar passage in Nehemiah 7. The storyteller in the book of Nehemiah lists 642 people who cannot prove they belong to the people of Israel, instead of 652 in this current passage.

In the second scene, the storyteller lists the priests who cannot prove that they belong to Israel and that they are priests. In the original language, the storyteller shows that this scene is closely related to the first scene. This scene includes more people who cannot prove their ancestry, but it is different from the first scene because it is even more important that priests are able to prove who their ancestors are. Priests served in the temple of Yahweh, and priests must be descendants of Aaron, who was in the tribe of Levi.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the beginning of this scene to show that it is also about people who cannot prove their ancestry, and that the people in this section are priests? Some translation options include:

- And now the list of the priests who cannot prove their families are descended from Israel; or
- There are other people who returned who also cannot prove their ancestry as Israelites. These people are priests.

Pause this audio here.

The storyteller lists the descendants of three priests who return to the land of Judah. In the original language, the storyteller says, “sons of the priests,” but this has the same meaning as “priests.” Hobaiah’s name is not in any other part of the Old Testament. Hakkoz was a priest during the time of King David. Most people think that later in the book of Ezra, the people made Meremoth a priest, who was a descendant of Hakkoz. Hakkoz in this current passage is probably the same Hakkoz as later in the book of Ezra.

Remember that Barzillai took the name of his wife’s father. The wife’s father, Barzillai, lived during the time of King David. This Barzillai helped David when David was fleeing from David’s son Absalom.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate the information about Barzillai, his wife’s father from Gilead, and the unusual way that Barzillai took the name of his wife’s father? Here are some translation options:

- Barzillai was a man who had married a daughter of Barzillai from Gilead; or
- The family of Barzillai descended from a man who married the daughter of Barzillai the Gileadite; or

- Barzillai had married the daughter of a man named Barzillai, and then he took the same name as his wife's father. His wife's father was from Gilead.

Pause this audio here.

The wife's father, Barzillai, was from Gilead. Gilead is east of the Jordan River, where the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh lived in the past.

In the next part of the second scene, the storyteller gives more information about why these priests are not able to serve as priests of Yahweh. Some translations say that the priests searched for their names in the official family records, and other translations say the priests searched for their family records, or genealogical records. Either way, the priests could not find proof that their ancestors were Israelites. You will remember that a genealogy is a list of a person's ancestors.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this part of the scene? Will you say that the priests looked for their names in the records, or that the priests looked for their records? Pause this audio here.

Because these men could not find proof in the family records that their ancestors were Israelites, the Israelites did not let these men serve as priests. If these men served as priests even though they had no proof that they came from priestly families, the men would not be ritually clean and able to serve Yahweh in the temple. If these men served in the temple even though they could not prove they were really priests, the men could make everything they touched unclean, too.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember your discussion from the previous step about ritual cleanness and uncleanness. How will you talk about the idea that these men were unclean because they had no proof that they were priests, and that these men would make everything in the temple unclean, too? Pause this audio here.

In the original language, it is not clear who says these men cannot serve as priests. It may be the governor from the next part of this scene, or it might be the leaders of the people, or it might be all of the Israelites. Translate this part of the scene without saying who prevents the men from serving as priests, if your language allows you to do this. If you must choose someone to be the person who prevents the men from serving as priests, it may be best to say the governor says these men cannot serve as priests.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this part of the scene, which shows that because these men cannot find their family records, the governor or someone else does not allow these men to serve as priests? Pause this audio here.

It may be helpful to change the order of this part of the second scene. For example, it might be better to include more information about why these men cannot serve as priests earlier in the scene, and then list the names of these families. For example, you might say something like: "There are other people who returned who also could not prove their ancestry as Israelites. These people were priests. These people searched for their family records, but they could not find their family records. As a result, the leaders did not let these people serve as priests because these people were unclean because they had no family records. The names of these families of priests are Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai. Barzillai had married the daughter of a man named Barzillai, and then he took the same name as his wife's father. His wife's father was from Gilead."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best order to translate the ideas in this scene about the names of the families of priests, and the reasons that these men could not serve as priests? Pause this audio here.

In the final part of this scene, the governor says the descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai are not allowed to eat the sacred food that normally only priests of Yahweh can eat. The reason the governor says this is that these three families of people cannot prove they are Israelites and descendants of Aaron. Therefore, these men cannot serve as priests.

In the original language, the "governor" means someone that other people fear and respect, or "excellency." This is a Persian title for governor, probably because the Persians chose the governor. Remember that although most people think this governor is Zerubbabel, it is not necessary to say the name of the governor in this passage. If

Zerubbabel is the governor, that may be why the governor tells the men not to eat the food for the priests. A Jewish governor would know the Israelite laws about priests.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the word “governor” in this passage? Pause this audio here.

The governor says these men cannot eat the holy food until a priest can use the Urim and Thummim to find out Yahweh’s opinion about this. Remember that the high priest wore the Urim and Thummim over his heart. It is possible that the Urim and Thummim were small objects that people made from precious stones, wood, or bone. It is possible that the Urim and Thummim were two different colors, or that the Urim and Thummim had different writing on them. Most likely, people in this part of the world were already familiar with the idea of the Urim and Thummim, and probably already used something like this before Yahweh gave the law to Moses.

Because the governor says that they need to wait until a priest can use the Urim and Thummim to see what Yahweh thinks, this probably means that Jeshua the high priest is not yet back in Jerusalem to consult the Urim and Thummim. It also might mean that the priests must wait until the people build the new temple. We never hear about any priests using the Urim and Thummim again, which means a priest probably did not consult the Urim and Thummim to learn God’s will during the time of the second temple in Jerusalem. Some people think that a priest will never actually consult the Urim and Thummim again. Therefore, the descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai would need to wait until the time when Yahweh himself decides if they and their descendants are able to be priests.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:59–63 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Descendants of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda
- Descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai
- The father of Barzillai’s wife, who is also named Barzillai
- The governor
- And a priest who can consult the Urim and Thummim

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The descendants of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda came up to Jerusalem in the land of Judah. These people came from the towns of Tel Melah, Tel Harsha, Kerub, Addon, and Immer in the land of Babylon. These people could not show that their families were descended from Israel. There were 652 descendants of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda who came to the land of Judah from the land of Babylon.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the descendants of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda in this passage, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are embarrassed that we are not able to prove that we are true Israelites; or
- We feel bad that we cannot find our family records to show that we are also descended from the people of Israel; or
- We feel shame that the people consider us lower status than even the descendants of the temple servants; or
- Even though we do not have proof of our ancestry as descendants of the Israelites, we are glad that we are in the list of people returning to the land of Judah. We are still in the community of the Israelites.

Continue the drama.

There were other people who returned who also could not prove their ancestry as Israelites. These people were priests. These priests were the descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai. Barzillai had married the daughter of a man named Barzillai, and then he took the same name as his wife's father. His wife's father was from Gilead. The governor did not allow these people to serve as priests because these people could not find their family records that proved they were descendants of Aaron. The governor also said these people could not eat the priests' food until there was a priest who could consult Yahweh with the Urim and the Thummim about this question.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the descendants of Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai in this passage, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel bad that we cannot prove that we are descendants of the priests of Yahweh; or
- We know that it is better for the Israelites if we do not serve as priests, because we might make the entire community of Israelites unclean if we cannot prove that our ancestors were descendants of Aaron; or
- We hope that a priest will come soon who can consult Yahweh using the Urim and Thummim. Then maybe we will be restored as priests, or maybe our descendants will be restored as priests.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:59–63 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The storyteller lists the people from five **towns** in the land of Babylon. The word town is not in the original language, but if you include town in your translation, you should use the same general word for town that you used in previous passages.

The storyteller lists the people who cannot prove the **house** of their fathers. The house of their fathers means the family of their ancestors. Sometimes the storytellers in the Old Testament say the word house to mean a group of people who have something in common, such as people from the same family. Translate "house" the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament. For more information on house, refer to **household** in the Master Glossary.

The storyteller also says these people cannot prove if their **seed** were from **Israel**. Seed means **descendants**. Israel is the people of Israel, meaning the people who are descendants of Jacob. Translate Israel the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on "seed," or descendants, and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember your discussion from step three about how you will translate this part of the passage. If you choose to translate the idea of "seed" or descendants, how will you translate seed in this passage? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says there are 652 **descendants** of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda who return to the land of Judah. Descendants are a person's children, grandchildren, and all future generations from the same family line. Another way to translate descendants is "sons." Translate descendants the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on descendants, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra 2:59–63

The storyteller also lists the descendants of the **priests** who return to the land of Judah. Only certain people could become priests. The tribe of Levi was one of the 12 tribes of Israel, and Aaron was from the tribe of Levi. Only descendants of Aaron could become priests. Translate priest the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

The descendants of the priests searched their family records, or their **genealogy**, for proof that they were descendants of Aaron. A genealogy is a list of the names of people who belong to the same ancestor. For more information on genealogy, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate genealogy in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Because these descendants of the priests could not find proof that they were descendants of Aaron and fit to be priests of Yahweh, the governor considered these men as unclean and unfit to be priests of Yahweh. A clean person is someone who is fit for service to God, and an unclean person is not fit for service to God. Nothing that was unclean could enter the temple of Yahweh, and priests needed to be very careful to remain clean. If someone could not prove he was a descendant of Aaron, then it was important for this person not to serve as a priest of Yahweh. This person might make the temple of Yahweh unclean and the people of Israel unclean.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **unclean** in this passage? Translate unclean the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament. For more information on unclean, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The governor orders these men not to eat the most holy food until a priest can consult the Urim and the Thummim. A governor is a ruler of the land. The storyteller in the book of Nehemiah uses this same word in the original language to describe Zerubbabel. Remember that normally, only priests can eat the food that the priests sacrifice to God. People had dedicated this food to God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **governor** and **holy** in this passage? Translate governor and holy the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament. For more information on holy, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Remember that we do not know a lot about the **Urim** and the **Thummim**. We know from the book of 1 Samuel that the high priest during the time of King Saul consulted the Urim and the Thummim in order to hear God's decision about who ate food. Remember that Saul had made an oath that no one could eat anything until Saul defeated his enemies, the Philistines. Jonathan ate some honey because Jonathan did not know about Saul's oath. The Urim and the Thummim showed that Jonathan was the one who had eaten the food.

Some people think that each object had one side with Urim on it and one side with Thummim on it, and if both objects landed with Urim facing up, the answer from God was "no." If both objects landed with Thummim facing up, then the answer from God was "yes." If one object was Urim and one was Thummim, there was no reply from God.

Stop here and listen to your recording of Exodus 28:30, if you have already translated this in your language. Some translations call these "holy lots" instead of Urim and Thummim. How will you translate Urim and Thummim in this passage? Translate Urim and Thummim the same as you have in the Exodus 28:30 passage.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 2:59–63

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (821 KB)
- Setting the Stage (7.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (12.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (950 KB)

Ezra 2:64–70

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 2:64–70 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:64–70 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:64–70 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passages, the storyteller listed the exiles who returned to the land of Judah. The storyteller listed the names of Jewish leaders, ordinary Israelites, priests, Levites, the descendants of the temple servants, the descendants of the servants of Solomon, and the people who could not prove they were Israelites. Now, in this passage, the storyteller gives a summary of all the people who come back to the land of Judah and tells what the people do when they arrive in the land of Judah. This is the final part of a six-part list of the exiles who return to the land of Judah.

This passage is very similar to a passage in the book of Nehemiah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Listen to your recording of Nehemiah 7:66–73, if you have already translated this passage into your own language. Pause this audio here.

In the first part of this passage, the storyteller lists the total number of Israelites who return to the land of Judah, which is 42,360. The number 42,360 is more than 29,818, which was the total for all of the previous lists of people. Some people think that maybe the storyteller made a mistake when he copied the lists of the numbers of people, or that maybe the storyteller did not include all of the families who returned. [Most people think that the numbers of people before this only included the men, so this number is probably bigger because it also includes the women and children who returned.]{.mark}

The storyteller also includes the number of men and women servants, singers, and animals that return with the Israelites. The servants, or slaves, belonged to the Israelite families. We know that only a wealthy family could own servants, pay singers, or ride on horses or mules. This shows that many Israelites who returned were wealthy. The men and women singers who returned are different from the temple singers. The singers in this passage sing for social events like weddings and funerals, and not for religious events. It is likely that wealthy Israelites paid these singers to sing at their social events.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of events in your community have singers? What kinds of songs do the singers sing? Who pays the singers? Pause this audio here.

About one animal for every five people return to the land of Judah, which is a lot of animals. During this time, people often rode horses, mules, camels, and donkeys, or the animals carried heavy burdens for the people. Some people think it is possible that Cyrus, the King of Persia, donated some horses to the leaders of the Israelites. Remember that King Cyrus let the Jews return from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah. Mules are the children of a female horse and a male donkey. Camels are large animals with one or two humps on their backs. The kind of camels in this story had one hump.

Stop here and look at pictures of a horse, a mule, a camel, and a donkey. Pause this audio here.

There are many more donkeys in the list than horses, mules, or camels, maybe because poorer people used donkeys. People also put loads on donkeys, or women and children rode on donkeys. The storyteller does not say that any sheep, goats, or cattle return to the land of Judah. It is likely that the travelers did not bring any sheep, goats, or cattle because these animals would have slowed down the travelers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What animals do you ride in your community? What animals do you use to carry heavy burdens? Pause this audio here.

In the next part of the passage, the storyteller says what the people do when they arrive at the house of Yahweh in the city of Jerusalem. Some of the “heads” of the families, or leaders of the families, give freewill offerings to help rebuild the temple of Yahweh. Some people think that only some of the leaders of the families give gifts, and that the storyteller wants to emphasize that other leaders of families did not give any gifts. However, it is more likely that people gave what they could give, and that wealthier people gave more gifts than poorer people because wealthier people had more money to give.

Remember that in the law of Moses, Yahweh does not require freewill offerings. People give this kind of offering to Yahweh only if they want to, not because they have to. The Israelites gave freewill offerings when the Israelites built the tabernacle in the book of Exodus, and when the Israelites built the first temple of Yahweh in the book of 1 Chronicles. In this passage, the people want to rebuild the new temple at the same location where the first temple used to be. It was common in other parts of the Old Testament to rebuild an altar or a holy place in the same location as another holy place from the past.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about some important religious temples, churches, altars, or sites in your community. Where did people build these important religious sites? Did anyone build a religious site on the same location as a previous holy site? Pause this audio here.

The leaders of families give what they can to the treasury for the work to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. The treasury is the funds that the people store up for this work. The leaders of families give very generous gifts of gold, silver, and priestly robes. People used gold and silver for money. These robes are for the priests of Yahweh to use in the new temple.

Stop here and look at pictures of gold coins, silver, and priestly robes as a group. Pause this audio here.

In the final part of the passage, the storyteller finishes the list of the people who return from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah. People understand this conclusion in different ways. Many people think there are two groups of people. One group is the priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, temple servants, and some of the common Israelites who all settle in their towns, probably very close to Jerusalem. The second group is the rest of the common Israelites, who settle in the towns where their ancestors were from. Other people think there were three groups of people: the people who settled in Jerusalem, the people who settled in towns near Jerusalem, and the people who settled in towns where their ancestors used to live, which were probably farther from Jerusalem.

Remember that this six-part list is important because it shows the true Israelites who are descendants of the same people of Israel from before the exile to the land of Babylon. Understanding where each person came from was very important in Israelite culture, especially in order to rebuild the temple, their place of worship. In the following passages, the Israelites will start to rebuild the temple of Yahweh.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:64–70 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller lists the total number of Israelites who return, and the number of servants, singers, and animals that also return with the Israelites.

In the second scene: The leaders of families of the Israelites give gifts to support the work that people will do to build the temple.

In the third scene: All of the Israelites settle in their towns in the land of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- The whole assembly of Israelites
- 7,337 male and female servants
- 200 male and female singers
- 736 horses
- 245 mules
- 435 camels
- 6,720 donkeys
- Leaders of families
- Priests
- Levites
- Temple singers
- Gatekeepers
- Temple servants
- And the rest of the Israelites

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

To start this passage, it might be helpful to remind people that in the previous five passages, the storyteller listed all of the Israelites who returned to the land of Judah. The storyteller calls these people Israelites in this passage. The storyteller probably wants to emphasize that these are true Israelites who continue to follow Yahweh and are qualified to rebuild their temple, which is the center of Israelite culture and community. Now, this is the final part of the six-part list. In this part, the storyteller gives a summary of the people who return to the land of Judah.

In the first scene, the storyteller says the total number of Israelites who return to the land of Judah. In the original language, the storyteller calls this "the whole assembly," which probably includes all of the men, women, and children of the Israelite community who return. An assembly of people was usually a group of people who

met for a purpose. These Israelites gathered and traveled together for a common purpose. Remember that it is difficult to know why the number 42,360 is more than the total number of people from the previous five lists of people. The total number of people who returned is the same as in the similar passage in the book of Nehemiah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about one group of people? How do you talk about several groups of people together as one larger group? How will you translate the whole “assembly” or group of people in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Remember that some people think the number in this passage, 42,360, includes the women who also returned. However, this would be a very small number of women, only 12,500 women for 29,818 men. Other people think it could be possible that only a small number of women came because it was a long and difficult journey from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah, and it was easier for a single man to travel alone without a wife and children. This may also explain why Israelite men wanted to marry foreign wives later in the book of Ezra. Maybe there were not enough Israelite women for all of the men to marry.

In addition to all of the Israelites, 7,337 male and female servants and 200 male and female singers also returned to the land of Judah with the Israelites. Another word for servants is slaves. Servants did not have a choice about serving, and usually their masters did not pay the servants anything. Remember that wealthy families owned servants. The number of servants who return is high compared to the number of Israelites who return. Remember that the law of Moses said the Israelites must act fairly toward their servants. The high number of servants who return might show that the Israelites treated their servants well because the servants were willing to come back to the land of Judah with the Israelites.

Wealthy families also paid singers to sing at social events. Remember that these singers are different from the temple singers. The storyteller in the book of Nehemiah says that 245 singers returned to the land of Judah, and some people think the storyteller in Nehemiah made a mistake.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate servants and singers in this passage? Remember the word you used to translate singers in the previous passage about temple singers, and that singers also played musical instruments. Translate singers in a similar way in this passage, but remember that singers here do not sing in the temple. Pause this audio here.

Many animals also return with the Israelites. The Israelites bring 736 horses, 245 mules, 435 camels, and 6,720 donkeys. It is important to notice that there are many more donkeys than other animals because poorer people rode donkeys, and people often put heavy loads on donkeys. Wealthier people rode on horses or mules. Camels also carried very heavy loads.

Stop here and look again at pictures of a horse, a mule, a camel, and a donkey, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the names of the animals in this passage? Some languages do not have different words for mules and donkeys, so these languages add the number of mules and donkeys together. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller starts a new section about what the people do when they arrive at the house of Yahweh in Jerusalem in the land of Judah. Remember that the storyteller does not say anything about the journey from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah. We know it was a long journey, and it probably took the people several months to travel from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah.

Stop here and look at a map of the land of Babylon, the land of Judah, and the city of Jerusalem as a group. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story that first includes a long list of the genealogy or descendants of someone, and then tells a story about those people. Pay attention to how you change from talking about the list of the people to the story about the people. How will you translate the beginning of this section to show it is a new section in the passage? Pause this audio here.

When the Israelites come to the house of Yahweh in Jerusalem, the leaders of the families give gifts to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. In the original language, the heads of families are the “heads of the fathers.” These men are probably the chiefs or leaders of extended families.

Remember that in a previous passage, King Cyrus gave gifts from his royal treasury, and that people who stayed in Babylon also gave gifts. Also, Cyrus gave back the gold and silver articles that the Babylonians had taken from the temple in Jerusalem, and the people brought these articles back with them to the land of Judah. The Israelites did not rebuild the temple with money from taxes or from the government, but from gifts that people gave freely.

Remember that it might be important that the storyteller says "some" of the leaders of families give gifts. In the similar passage in the book of Nehemiah, the storyteller says that some leaders of families give gifts, and some of the common people also give gifts. It is likely that the storyteller in this current passage simply says that "some" of the leaders give gifts, probably according to how much money they were able to give. People with more money could give more than people without a lot of money.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time in your community when people gave gifts based on how much they could give. How did you describe this? Pause this audio here.

Remember also from previous passages that the reason the people return to the land of Judah is to rebuild the house of Yahweh in Jerusalem. God moved the spirit of Cyrus to let the people return to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. God also moved the spirits of the Israelites to come back to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. It is important that the storyteller repeats the idea of the temple, or house, of Yahweh in this passage because this keeps the focus on the temple in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Go back and listen to your translation of the previous passage, at the beginning of the book of Ezra, where God moves the spirit of Cyrus to let the people leave the land of Babylon. Pause this audio here.

The people give generous freewill offerings. First, the storyteller says the purpose of the freewill offerings. The leaders of families give gifts in order to rebuild the temple of Yahweh on the original site of the first temple. Next, the storyteller says how much the leaders of families give, and the types of gifts the leaders of families give. In the original language, the storyteller says that each leader gives "according to his strength," which means according to his ability or how much he owns and can give. The gifts go into the treasury for the work to rebuild the temple in the same place as it was before. Later in the book of Ezra and also in the book of Nehemiah, the storytellers call the rebuilding of the temple of Yahweh "the work."

The leaders of families give a very large amount of gold and silver, as well as 100 priestly robes. Some people think the leaders of families give 61,000 darics of gold, while other people think the leaders of families give 61,000 drachmas of gold. Darics were gold coins, and people named darics after the Persian King Darius. One daric was equal to one month's pay for a soldier. However, many people think Persian gold darics are from a later time period.

Drachmas were Greek coins, but drachmas were usually silver, and not gold. Gold is more valuable than silver. It is possible that there was a Persian gold drachma that people used before the Persian gold daric. It may be easier for your team to say the amount of gold in kilos than in darics or drachmas. The leaders of families give 500 kilograms of gold.

Stop here and look at a picture of gold coins again as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate how much gold the leaders of families give to rebuild the temple of Yahweh? Some translation ideas are:

- The leaders give 61,000 darics of gold; or
- The leaders give 500 kilograms of gold; or
- The leaders give 61,000 gold coins.

Pause this audio here.

The leaders of families also give 5,000 minas of silver. Minas are not silver coins, but weights of silver. One mina weighs 570 grams. The Babylonians used minas to measure their silver. Again, it might be best to say the amount of silver in kilos instead of minas. The leaders of families give about 2,800 kilograms of silver to help rebuild the temple of Yahweh.

Stop here and look at a picture of silver again as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate how much silver the leaders of families give to help rebuild the temple of Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

Finally, the leaders of families give 100 priestly robes. Priestly robes are tunics that priests wore in the temple of Yahweh. People made priestly robes from fine white linen cloth.

Stop here and look at a picture of priestly robes again as a group, if needed. Pause this audio here.

In the similar passage in the book of Nehemiah, the storyteller says that the common people also give gifts, and not only the leaders of families. Also, in the book of Nehemiah, the amount of gold, silver, and priestly robes is different than in the book of Ezra. In the similar passage in Nehemiah, the storyteller says that the people give 41,000 gold darics, 4,200 silver minas, and 67 priestly robes. It is possible that the storyteller did not copy the number correctly for the book of Nehemiah.

In the third scene, the storyteller says that all of the Israelites settled in their towns in the land of Judah. It is important to remember that in the first passage where this long list started, the storyteller said that the Israelites each went to their own towns. Now, the storyteller repeats this same idea at the end of the list that the Israelites all went to the towns of their ancestors.

Also, remember that people understand this conclusion in different ways. There might be two or three different groups of people who settle in different places, and there are some difficult words to understand.

Part of the problem is that the words “lived in Jerusalem” and “nearby” are not in the original language. However, we know that the religious workers all needed to be near Jerusalem in order to work in the temple, so it would be likely that the priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, and temple servants would all live in or near Jerusalem. Some people think it is best not to include “in Jerusalem and nearby,” and instead simply say, “they lived in their towns.”

It is also difficult to know what “along with some of the other people” means in this passage. Most people think it means the regular Israelite people who were not religious workers like priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, and temple servants. It is possible that some of the regular Israelites also lived in the same towns where mostly religious people lived.

Finally, “all Israel” probably means all of the remaining Israelites. After the people returned to the land of Judah after the exile, it was common to describe the religious workers separately from all of the rest of the Israelites. The priests and Levites had a higher status than regular Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this conclusion to the passage, and to the entire list of the people who returned to the land of Judah? Here are some translation ideas:

- The priests, the Levites, some of the people, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants lived in their towns. All of the rest of the Israelites lived in their towns; or
- The priests, the Levites, and some of the people lived in Jerusalem and nearby. The singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants lived in their towns. All of the other Israelites lived in their towns; or
- The priests, the Levites, and some of the people settled in or near Jerusalem. The singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants settled in nearby towns. The rest of the Israelites settled in the towns where their ancestors had lived.

Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:64–70 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The whole company of Israelites
- 7,337 male and female servants
- 200 men and women singers
- 736 horses
- 245 mules
- 435 camels
- 6,720 donkeys
- Leaders of families
- Priests
- Levites
- Temple singers
- Gatekeepers
- Temple servants
- And the rest of the Israelites

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The total number of the people who returned from exile was 42,360 people. In addition, 7,337 male and female servants and 200 singers returned with the Israelites. The people had 736 horses, 245 mules, 435 camels, and 6,720 donkeys.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the whole assembly of Israelites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are very happy to finally return to the land of our ancestors; or
- Many of us are returning to the land of Judah with a lot of money, animals, and servants. We are ready to be generous to the work to rebuild the temple of Yahweh; or
- We had a very long journey to the land of Judah. We are glad that we finally arrived in the land of Judah.

Continue the drama.

When the Israelites arrive at the house of Yahweh in Jerusalem, the leaders of the families give gifts to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. The gifts are freewill offerings so that the people can rebuild the house of God at the same location where the first temple used to be. The leaders of families each give what they can for the work to rebuild the temple. The leaders give 500 kilograms of gold, 2,800 kilograms of silver, and 100 priestly robes.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the leaders of families, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are glad to give gifts freely so that we can rebuild the temple of Yahweh. This is why we came back from the land of Babylon to the land of Judah, and we are ready to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. We are ready to serve and worship Yahweh; or
- We want to be very generous in our gifts because we are committed to rebuilding the temple of Yahweh; or
- We are very thankful that Yahweh kept his promises to our ancestors that he would bring the people of Israel back here to the land of Judah; or

- We cannot believe that we are finally here in the land of Judah, at the exact site where the first temple of Yahweh once stood! We have heard of the temple; or
- We are very sad that the first temple is not here any longer. We heard it was a beautiful temple for Yahweh. We hope we can build another good temple for Yahweh so we can serve and worship Yahweh in the right way that Yahweh said in the law of Moses.

Continue the drama.

The priests, the Levites, some of the people, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants lived in their towns. All of the rest of the Israelites lived in their towns.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests, the Levites, some of the people, the singers, the gatekeepers, the temple servants, and the rest of the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are glad to be back in the towns of our ancestors. We are connected to the Israelites from the past, and we want to raise our children to also follow Yahweh, back here in the land of Judah; or
- We are happy to have our land back again. This is the land of our ancestors; or
- We feel peace because Yahweh moved in our spirits to bring us back here to the land of Judah, and now here we are. Yahweh kept his promises.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 2:64–70 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Many servants, singers, and animals come back to the land of Judah with the assembly of the Israelites. You may remember from other books of the Old Testament that an assembly of people was a group of people that gathered together for a common purpose. In this case, these Israelites gathered to travel together to Jerusalem and help rebuild the temple of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **assembly** in this passage? Pause this audio here.

A **servant** does work for someone else and has a low position in the community. **Singers** can also play musical instruments, and these singers are not temple singers. Translate servant and singers the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Israelites brought **horses**, **mules**, **camels**, and **donkeys** back to the land of Judah with them. Wealthier people or royal people rode on horses. Mules are big and strong like horses. Mules are also patient and dependable, like donkeys. Camels are large animals that can carry very heavy loads. Camels can travel long distances without drinking any water. Donkeys are smaller than horses and mules. People often used donkeys to help them work in their fields or to carry burdens. Translate horses, mules, camels, and donkeys the same as you have in previous passages of the Old Testament. For more information on camels and donkeys, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and look again at pictures of a horse, a mule, a camel, and a donkey, if needed. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites arrive at the **house of Yahweh** in **Jerusalem**. Jerusalem was the capital city of the kingdom of Judah in the past. The house of Yahweh, or the temple of Yahweh, is where the Israelites used to worship Yahweh. The house of **God** is the same place as the house of Yahweh. Remember that the Babylonians destroyed the first temple in Jerusalem, and the Babylonians took the people into exile in the land of Babylon. Yahweh is God's personal name. Translate the house of Yahweh, Jerusalem, and God the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on the house of Yahweh, see "temple" in the Master Glossary. For more information on Jerusalem and God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Some of the heads of the fathers' **households** give **freewill offerings** for the house of God. The "heads of fathers' houses" means the leaders of the groups of households of the Israelites who return to the land of Judah. A household is all of the people who live together in one house. In the past, Israelites gave freewill offerings to thank Yahweh for something. Freewill offerings are offerings that Yahweh did not require the people to make.

Translate “heads of fathers’ households” and “freewill offerings” the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on household and freewill offerings, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Israelites give 61,000 **drachmas** of gold. Remember that drachmas were usually silver, so many people think the Israelites give 61,000 **darics** of gold. This was about 500 kilograms of gold.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember your discussion in step three about darics of gold and drachmas of gold. How will you translate how much gold the Israelites give to the work to rebuild the temple of Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

The Israelites also give 5,000 silver minas, or about 2,800 kilograms of silver, and 100 **priestly** robes. Priests serve Yahweh in the temple of Yahweh, and priests must wear robes that people made from fine white linen. Another word for a robe is a **tunic**. A tunic is a long piece of clothing that people wear under their other clothing. Remember that Yahweh told the Israelites in the law of Moses how the Israelites should make all of the clothing for the priests.

Stop here and listen to your recording of Exodus 28 about the priestly garments as a group, if you have already translated it. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate “priestly robes” in this passage? Remember that the priests also wore other special pieces of clothing, in addition to their white tunics. For more information on priests, refer to the Master Glossary. For more information on the word for robes in this passage, refer to tunic in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The priests, the **Levites**, some of the people, the singers, the **gatekeepers**, and the **temple servants** lived in their towns. Levites are from the tribe of Levi, but they are not descendants of Aaron, and are not priests. Before the exile, the Levites helped the priests with work in the temple. Temple servants help the Levites in the temple. Other ways to translate temple servants are “temple slaves,” “workmen,” or “temple workers.” Translate Levite, gatekeepers, and temple servants the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on Levite and servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

All of the rest of the **Israelites** lived in their **towns**. The Israelites are the people of Israel, who are the descendants of Jacob. These towns are where the ancestors of the Israelites lived before the exile to the land of Babylon. These towns are all within the land of Judah, and most of these towns are also close to the city of Jerusalem. Translate “town” the same as you have in previous passages, and remember that these towns could be very small villages or very large cities. Translate “Israelites” the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on Israelites, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 2:64–70

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (877 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (13.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (971 KB)

Ezra 3:1–7

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 3:1–7 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

King Cyrus was king of Persia at the time of this story, and Cyrus gave the Israelites permission to travel back to the land of Israel. In the previous passage, the storyteller provided a list of families who traveled back to Israel. This story is about how the Israelites obey Yahweh's laws again. The story shows us how the Israelites have returned to Israel and to praising Yahweh the way Yahweh commanded.

The Israelites finished moving into their towns in the seventh month of the year. The Israelites often prepared to gather their crops during the seventh month of the year, which is September or October in our calendar. The seventh month is important to the Israelites because Yahweh commanded the Israelites to celebrate many special events in this month. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to celebrate many of these special events because each one reminded the Israelites of all the ways Yahweh had taken care of them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your culture keep track of the days and months? What are some important times of year in your culture? Pause this audio here.

After the Israelites finished moving, the entire group of Israelites met in Jerusalem because they all wanted to start rebuilding Yahweh's temple. At that time, a man named Jeshua was the leader of the priests, and a man named Zerubbabel was a leader of the Israelites. Jeshua and Zerubbabel were the leaders of the construction project, and they started by building Yahweh's altar. Israelites used the altar to give important gifts to Yahweh. Because Yahweh's gifts were very important, Jeshua and Zerubbabel started building the altar first so they could

Ezra 3:1–7

give Yahweh gifts before the Israelites finished the temple. The Israelites probably built the altar using stones and made a flat surface on top that they would use to burn animals as a gift to Yahweh. The Israelites would give these gifts to Yahweh every morning and every night. On special days, the Israelites would give more gifts to Yahweh in the way Yahweh commanded the people.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel and find Jerusalem as a group. Notice where the Israelites would have needed to travel to build the temple. Look at a picture of an altar as a group and talk about similar objects that people in your culture may use in religious or cultural ceremonies. Pause this audio here.

Several groups of local people were living in the area when the Israelites moved back into Israel. Some of these groups of people were the Ammonites, Samaritans, Moabites, and Edomites, and they had fought and disagreed with the Israelites for hundreds of years. You will remember that the Samaritans were the Israelites who were from the Northern Kingdom of Israel. The Samaritans had not followed Yahweh, and Yahweh had allowed foreign countries to conquer them. These people did not follow Yahweh the way Yahweh instructed and were unfriendly to the Israelites when they tried to build the altar. The storyteller does not explain why these local people were not friendly to the Israelites, but it could be because they disagreed with the Israelites on how and where the Israelites built the altar. The most important thing to know is that the Israelites were afraid because of the local people, but the Israelites chose to build the altar anyway.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When was a time you were afraid of something but chose to act anyway? What happened as a result? Pause this audio here.

After the Israelites finished building the altar, the Israelites started celebrating the special religious events Yahweh commanded the Israelites to celebrate during the seventh month of the year. One of these events is called the Festival of Tabernacles. This celebration reminded the Israelites about how Yahweh had saved them when they were slaves in Egypt many centuries before this story. During the Festival of Booths, Israelite families would make tents out of tree branches and live in the tents for eight days. While the Israelites lived in tents for eight days, the priests would make a special burnt offering to Yahweh on each day of the celebration.

Stop here and look at a picture of a tent that the Israelites would make for the Festival of Booths celebration. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites also started celebrating the Festival of the New Moon again. The Israelites celebrated this festival at the beginning of every month when they saw the new moon rise in the sky. The Israelites would celebrate by blowing trumpets and making burnt offerings to thank Yahweh for the new month.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story of a time when you celebrated a new beginning. Pause this audio here.

When the Israelites started celebrating the festivals again, the Israelites also started making the usual burnt sacrifices to Yahweh as Yahweh had commanded in the law. The Israelites also made sacrifices to Yahweh that Yahweh did not require. The Israelites made these “freewill” sacrifices just because they were very thankful to Yahweh for taking care of the Israelites. It is important to understand why the Israelites were giving Yahweh sacrifices because it shows that the Israelites were focusing on worshipping Yahweh even though they had not built the temple yet.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of events does your culture view as important to remember? What does your culture do to remember these events? Pause this audio here.

The Israelites now have an altar, but the Israelites still do not have a temple. To build the temple, the Israelites gave money to the “masons,” or people who cut stones, and to the “carpenters,” or people who made things from wood for building. The Israelites also gave oil, wine, and food to the Sidonians and Tyrians. The Sidonians and Tyrians were people from a region next to Israel. In exchange for the supplies and money, the Sidonians and Tyrians gave the Israelites cedar trees. You will remember that the Israelites used the cedar trees from the Sidonians and Tyrians to build Yahweh’s first temple many centuries before this story. To send the cedar trees to the Israelites, the Sidonians and Tyrians tied the logs together and floated the logs on the sea to Joppa. It is important to know that Joppa is a city in Israel that is close to the sea. Then the Israelites would bring the logs a long distance over the land to Jerusalem. The Israelites could do all this work to rebuild the temple because King Cyrus gave them special permission.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cedar tree. Note the size and shape of the logs. Also, look at a map of the trading route the Israelites used to get what they needed to build the temple.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The Israelites finish moving into their towns and decide to meet in Jerusalem. Then Jeshua and Zerubbabel help the Israelites start building the altar. The Israelites are afraid of the local people but continue to work on the altar anyway.

In the second scene: The Israelites finish building the altar, and the Israelites start making sacrifices to Yahweh. The Israelites also start celebrating festivals like the Festival of Booths and the Festival of the New Moon again.

In the third scene: The Israelites want to start building the temple. The Israelites give money to stone and wood workers to build the temple. The Israelites also give supplies to the Sidonians and Tyrians in exchange for special cedar trees.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelites
- The local people
- Jeshua, the lead priest
- Zerubbabel, a leader of the Israelites
- Yahweh
- Wood workers
- Stone workers
- Sidonians
- And Tyrians

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the Israelites finish moving into their towns and decide to meet in Jerusalem. The storyteller says that the Israelites all gathered as one. This means that because all the Israelites agreed that it was important to meet together to build the temple, it was like one person had made the decision. The storyteller uses this phrase to explain that the Israelites felt very unified in their decision. This is important because it shows that all of the Israelites thought it was important to start worshipping Yahweh again.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about people gathering in your language? Pause the audio here.

The Israelites meet in Jerusalem in the seventh month of the year. The storyteller uses these words to give background to the story and to explain that something new is starting.

Stop here and tell a story to the group that includes a time of year when an event begins. Pause the audio here.

The Israelite's decision to meet in Jerusalem is the first thing the Israelites do when they have settled in Israel. When the Israelites arrive in Jerusalem, Jeshua the priest and Zerubbabel the leader take charge of the construction of the altar.

The Israelites were scared of the people around them when they built the altar. Some people say that the reason the Israelites built the altar to Yahweh is that the Israelites were scared of the local people. Some other people say that the Israelites were already scared of the local people and built the altar despite their fear. We do not know which opinion is correct, but we know for sure that the Israelites were scared of the local people when the Israelites built the altar.

Stop here and discuss your choice as a group. Why do you think the Israelites were afraid? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, after the Israelites build the altar, the Israelites start to make sacrifices and worship Yahweh. The order of this scene can be hard to follow. The Israelites build the altar first and then start to offer daily morning and evening sacrifices to Yahweh on the first day of the seventh month. Although the storyteller first talks about the most important festival in the seventh month, the Festival of Tabernacles, this festival does not happen until later in the month. Instead, the Israelites probably celebrate the Festival of the New Moon first at the beginning of the month and begin offering all the regular, daily burnt offerings that Yahweh required in his law. The Israelites celebrate the Festival of Tabernacles later in the month after the Festival of the New Moon.

Stop here and tell a story to the group. Pay attention to how you tell the story. How do you explain to the audience what order the events happened in? Pause this audio here.

Throughout the seventh month, the Israelites also celebrate other festivals the way Yahweh had commanded. Some of the Israelites even choose to bring some optional sacrifices for Yahweh simply because they are thankful. The storyteller is very clear that the Israelites begin to celebrate all the festivals and special events the same way Yahweh said to do in the law he gave to Moses, and that Moses wrote down. In other words, the Israelites do all these things to obey what "was written" in Scripture. This means that the Israelites obey Yahweh and follow Yahweh's commands well.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you explain that something was done the right way in your culture? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the Israelites have been making sacrifices to Yahweh, but still have not built the base of the temple. When the Israelites built a building, the Israelites had to put down a strong base before they built the walls and roof. The Israelites may have built this base from large, strong stones. This kept the building strong and helped it to last longer.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words do you use to describe the base of a building? What words do you use to describe the parts of a building that make it stand strong? Pause this audio here.

So, the Israelites decide to build the temple. The Israelites need people to make the temple, so they give money to stonecutters and woodworkers. Masons, or stonecutters, are people who work with stone to make buildings. Carpenters, or woodworkers, are people who work with wood for buildings or furnishings. At the same time, the Israelites give food, wine, and oil to the Sidonians and Tyrians in exchange for the cedar trees that the Israelites use to make the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call people who work with stone and wood in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelites
- The local people
- Jeshua, the lead priest
- Zerubbabel, a leader of the Israelites
- Yahweh
- Wood workers
- Stone workers
- Sidonians

- And Tyrians

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In scene one, the people playing the Israelites finish moving into their homes and travel to Jerusalem because they want to build the temple. The people playing Jeshua and Zerubbabel lead the Israelites as they build the altar, even though the Israelites are scared of the local people.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am excited to be worshiping Yahweh again! or
- I am scared that the local people around us will kill us.

Ask the person playing the local people, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The Israelites told us we could not help them build the temple, and now we are angry that the Israelites are building the altar without us; or
- The Israelites took away our land. Now, the Israelites are building an altar, which must mean the Israelites will stay here. That makes us angry!

Ask the people playing Jeshua and Zerubbabel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We must worship Yahweh again, as Yahweh commanded us. We must help the Israelites follow Yahweh!

Continue the drama.

In scene two, the people playing the Israelites start making daily sacrifices to Yahweh and celebrating the Festival of Tabernacles and the Festival of the New Moon. Some of the people playing the Israelites can also choose to bring their own sacrifice to the altar to show their thankfulness to Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love my people so much, and it makes me so happy that they are obeying me again.

Ask the person playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so thankful that Yahweh has brought us back into Israel! or
- Following Yahweh is a lot of work! or
- I am so happy that I can worship Yahweh again the way he commanded us to; or
- I hope that Yahweh saves us from the anger of the people around us.

Continue the drama.

In scene three, the people playing the Israelites give money and supplies to the woodworkers, stonecutters, and the Sidonians and Tyrians to build the temple. The people playing the Sidonians and Tyrians then float cedar trees on the sea so that the Israelites can use the trees for the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, “What are you feeling and thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- The first temple to Yahweh was much more beautiful. I am so sad that we cannot give Yahweh more; or
- I am so happy that we can finally give Yahweh a temple again!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The storyteller mentions that in the seventh month of the year, the people of **Israel** lived in their towns. Israel is the name of the territory where the Israelites lived. Israel also refers to one of Abraham’s sons, who was named Israel. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages.

The Israelites moved into **towns** in Israel after King Cyrus of Persia gave them permission to leave. Use the same word or phrase for towns as you used in previous passages.

The Israelites decided to meet in **Jerusalem** to rebuild Yahweh’s temple. Jerusalem is one of the most important cities in Israel. For more information on Jerusalem, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Jerusalem as you used in previous passages.

Jeshua and Zerubbabel built the altar to Yahweh with the help of their relatives, associates, fellow priests, or brothers. The people were other priests and maybe some regular Israelites who worked with Jeshua and Zerubbabel to build the altar. Some of these people were probably relatives, or part of Jeshua and Zerubbabel’s brothers and close family, and some may have just been other Israelites who wanted to help.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **priests**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites built an altar to Yahweh in Jerusalem. An altar is a place where people make many kinds of offerings to Yahweh. The Israelites would often make altars with stones and with a flat surface on top.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **altar**. Look up altar in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites built an altar to the **God** of Israel. In the Bible, God refers to God who is powerful and created the whole world. It is the same God who made promises to Abraham. God is also the same God that the Israelites have worshipped for many centuries. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

A burnt offering is a specific form of sacrifice. A priest burned the plants or animals that people meant to give to Yahweh. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to give burnt offerings in special ways in the Old Testament.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **burnt offering**. Look up burnt offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites built the altar and made sacrifices on it according to the Law of Moses. The Law of Moses is the law that Yahweh gave to Moses that explains how the Israelites should live. The law tells the Israelites how to worship Yahweh and how to treat the people around them. “According to the Law of Moses” in this story means that the Israelites gave Yahweh sacrifices in the way Yahweh commanded.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **law**. Look up law in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra 3:1–7

The Israelites made offerings and sacrifices to **Yahweh**. Yahweh is a name for God that God gave Moses many centuries before this story. The name Yahweh reminds the Israelites of God's promises to the Israelites. This name reminds everyone that God never changes and always keeps his promises. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages.

The Israelites celebrated the "Festival of Tabernacles" or "Festival of Booths." It was a special event that the Israelites celebrated to remember when Yahweh saved them from slavery in Egypt many centuries before this story. During the Festival of Tabernacles, the Israelites set up tents and lived in them for eight days. The Israelites celebrated this event to remember when their ancestors had walked in the desert for many years before moving into Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the F**estival of Tabernacles**. Look up "Festival of Tabernacles" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites also celebrated the "New Moon festival." In Old Testament times, the people of Israel celebrated this festival at the beginning of each month, when the people could see the new moon rise in the sky. During this festival, the Israelites stopped their work, offered special sacrifices, and blew trumpets to celebrate.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the **New Moon Festival**. Refer to "Festival of New Moon" in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites made sacrifices to Yahweh and celebrated all the **appointed festivals of Yahweh**. The appointed festivals of Yahweh are the festivals that Yahweh commanded the Israelites to celebrate.

The Israelites chose to give Yahweh "freewill offerings" when they started celebrating Yahweh's festivals again. A freewill offering is another specific form of sacrifice. A freewill offering is a sacrifice that the Israelites would bring to Yahweh when they were thankful for Yahweh. It is important to know that Yahweh does not require the Israelites to make freewill offerings.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **freewill offering**. Look up freewill offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites gave sacrifices to Yahweh even though they had not built the foundation of the temple yet. A foundation is the base of a building. People build a foundation first to make a building stable and strong for a long time.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **foundation**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites met in Jerusalem because they wanted to build Yahweh's **temple**. The temple is a place in Jerusalem that the Israelites built so that they could worship Yahweh as he commanded. The "house of God" is another name for the temple. King Solomon first built the temple many centuries before this story. After King Cyrus gave the Israelites permission to move into Israel again, the Israelites wanted to rebuild the temple so that they could start worshiping Yahweh again. For more information on the temple, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for temple as you used in previous passages.

After the Israelites built the altar, they gave money to masons and carpenters to build Yahweh's temple. Masons and carpenters are people who have special skills to work with different kinds of supplies. Masons cut and shape stones and rocks, and carpenters cut and shape wood. Masons and carpenters both use their skills to make buildings and objects.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **masons** and **carpenters**. Discuss what you call people who build with stone and wood in your culture. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites gave wine, oil, and food to the Sidonians and Tyrians in exchange for cedar trees to build the temple. Wine is a drink that people make from fermented grape juice. Grapes are small, soft, and juicy berries that grow in several different colors.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wine**. Look up wine in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller mentions that **King** Cyrus of Persia gave special permission for the Israelites to get cedar trees from the Sidonians and Tyrians. A king is a special person who rules over a city or area. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 3:1–7

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (663 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (6.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Ezra 3:8–13

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 3:8–13 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:8–13 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Ezra 3:8–13

3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, Jeshua and Zerubbabel helped the Israelites build Yahweh's altar. It is important to remember that the Israelites wanted to start worshipping Yahweh again in the way that Yahweh had asked them to. The Israelites started following Yahweh's commandments in the law of Moses and making sacrifices to Yahweh on the altar. It is also important to remember that the Israelites gave money and supplies to many workers to gather cedar trees and to start to build the temple. This story is about how the Israelites continue to obey Yahweh and begin to build Yahweh's temple.

This story takes place about eight months after the Israelites built the altar, so this is during the second year that the Israelites were again in Jerusalem. This story happens in the second month of the second year. It is important to know that this means that the Israelites did not start to work on the temple right after they finished building the altar. This story also takes place in the second month of the year. This is also important because it is the best time of the year for the Israelites to start building. For the Israelites, the second month of the year happened after the spring rains made the ground wet, so the Israelites would be able to build the temple on dry ground. The Israelites also built Yahweh's first temple during the second month of the year.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your culture decide when to start a building project? Pause this audio here.

In the second month of the year, Jeshua and Zerubbabel helped the Israelites start to build the temple, just as they had helped the Israelites build the altar. Jeshua and Zerubbabel used the help of Jeshua and his family, Kadmiel and his family, and the sons of Henadad and their families. All these people were from the Israelite tribe of Levi.

Stop here and tell a story to the group of a time when your family or a group of people in your community worked together on a project or activity. Pause this audio here.

Jeshua and Zerubbabel gathered all the Levites who were 20 years old or older to oversee the workers building the temple. It is important to know that in the Israelites' culture, an Israelite could work as a Levite or soldier when he was 20 years old. These Levites watched the workers so that they could make sure that the workers were building the temple the way Yahweh commanded.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture decide when the community considers someone to be an adult with all the same rights as other adults? When can people in your community start working important jobs? Pause this audio here.

When the workers started or were working on the base or foundation of the temple, the priests celebrated! The priests put on the special clothes they wore when they served Yahweh and blew into trumpets to worship Yahweh with music.

Stop here and look at a picture of the special clothes the priests wore. Discuss this question as a group: What special clothes do people wear for important events in your culture? Why? Pause this audio here.

For the celebration, the priests played trumpets and a special group of Levites played cymbals to praise Yahweh. A trumpet was a short metal tube that a priest would blow into to make a high sound. Cymbals were flat metal circles that the Levites would hit together to make a loud sound. The priests and the Levites played music and sang songs to Yahweh to lead the people to praise and thank Yahweh for all he had done.

Stop here and look at a picture of a trumpet and cymbals. Also, discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture celebrate when something good happens? What kinds of instruments do people in your culture play at big events? Pause this audio here.

Ezra 3:8–13

The storyteller explains that a special family of priests played the instruments at the Israelites' celebration. A priest named Asaph lived when King David ruled over the Israelites, many centuries before this story. During his rule, King David made Asaph and Asaph's family in charge of playing the music and leading the songs that people used to worship Yahweh at the temple. In this story, the special Levites who sang at the temple were all part of Asaph's family. This is important to know because it shows that the Israelites are trying to worship Yahweh the same way they used to many years ago.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The Israelites had special people to lead them when they worshipped Yahweh with music. How do people in your culture lead music at important events? Pause this audio here.

The Israelites sang a song to worship Yahweh because Yahweh did good things for the Israelites and promised to love Israel forever with a steadfast love. When the Israelites finished singing, the Israelites shouted loudly. The Israelites yelled because they were very thankful to Yahweh for all he had done, and because the Israelites were so happy that they could worship Yahweh in a temple again.

Stop here and tell a story of a time in your life when you were so happy you could shout or do something to show your happiness. What did that moment feel like to you? Pause this audio here.

Many of the Israelites were very happy to have the temple again. But some of the older priests and Israelites were very sad. The older Israelites were sad when they remembered Yahweh's first temple, which the Israelites had built many centuries before this story. The older Israelites were so sad that no one could tell who was shouting because they were happy and who was yelling because they were sad. The storyteller even explains that when the Israelites yelled, the noise was so loud that people could hear it from a long distance away.

Stop here and tell a story to the group about a time when you were sad during a celebration.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Jeshua and Zerubbabel help the Israelites build the temple's base. Many of the priests and their families lead the workers to help make sure everything is done correctly.

In the second scene: The Israelites finish construction on the temple's base, and the priests and Levites lead the Israelites to set up a party to worship and celebrate all that Yahweh did for them. The priests and Levites use instruments and sing songs.

In the third scene: Some Israelites see the new temple and are very sad. Some Israelites see the temple and are very happy! All the Israelites let out a loud yell that people can hear from a great distance away.

The characters in this passage are:

- Zerubbabel
- Jeshua
- Jeshua's brothers and family
- Kadmiel
- Kadmiel's family
- Henadad's family
- All the other Levites
- Yahweh
- Asaph's family of Levites
- The Israelites
- The head of the Israelite families
- The builders who laid the temple's foundation

- And the older Israelites who were sad

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the storyteller mentions that the story happens in the second year after the Israelites arrived in Jerusalem, during the second month. This is several months after the Israelites had built the altar. Remember that the second month of the year is important because it is after the spring rains. It is the best time of year for building.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how would you describe the second month of the year, during the second year that the Israelites are there in Jerusalem? Pause this audio here.

In the second month of the year, Zerubbel and Jeshua gathered their brothers, families, and all of the priests and prepared to help the Israelites finally build Yahweh's temple. The storyteller mentions that Jeshua and Zerubbabel only gathered the priests, Levites, and other Israelites who had moved back into Israel. You will remember that some Israelites did not go to Babylon with the rest of the Israelites and were still living in Israel before this story. There is tension between the two groups of Israelites in this story—those who stayed and those who came back.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will include the extra information that the Israelites who returned only gathered the people who had returned. Pause the audio here.

Jeshua and Zerubbabel only gathered people from their families and from the other Levite families who were 20 years old or older. Jeshua and Zerubbabel gathered these Levites so that the Levites could supervise the workers as the workers built the temple. This way, the Levites could make sure that the workers were building the temple the way Yahweh commanded.

Stop here and remember the story you told the group about a time you and your family or a group of people from your community worked together on a project. Discuss this question as a group: How did the person who told the story describe what happened? What kinds of words did he or she use to talk about working as a family? Pause this audio here.

Jeshua and Zerubbabel led the Israelites to build the temple's foundation first. A building's foundation is the base of the building. The Israelites often used rocks or stones to build the foundations of their important buildings. This foundation helps keep the building strong and keeps it from shifting or sinking over time. The foundation is a very important part of the building process, especially at the time of this story.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture make sure that buildings are stable and strong? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, the priests and Levites led the Israelites in a celebration to thank Yahweh. The storyteller does not clearly explain when in the story this celebration happens. Some people think the Israelites celebrated after they finished the base or foundation of the temple. Other people think the Israelites celebrated while the workers were building the temple's base. We do not know which of these opinions is correct. It is important to know that the celebration happened close to the time that the workers built the temple's base. It is also important to know that the celebration was because the people wanted to worship Yahweh and thank Yahweh for helping them.

Stop here and discuss your choice as a group. When do you think the celebration took place? Pause this audio here.

For the celebration, the priests played trumpets, and the special group of Levites who were part of Asaph's family played cymbals. Both the priests and Levites sang songs that worshiped and thanked Yahweh. The songs praised Yahweh because the things Yahweh does are good and Yahweh promised to always love Israel. The priests and Levites led this celebration the same way King David told them to many centuries before this story.

Stop here and look at the pictures of trumpets and cymbals again. How would you describe instruments like this in your culture? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the Israelites then let out a loud shout of praise to Yahweh. Some people say the Israelites' loud shout was like a shout of victory in battle. The Israelites shouted because they were worshipping Yahweh with all their hearts.

Many of the Israelites were very happy and thankful for the new temple. Some of the older Israelites were very sad when they saw the new temple's base. The storyteller does not explain why these people were sad. Most

people say that the older Israelites were sad because they remembered what Yahweh's first temple looked like. Yahweh's first temple was really big and fancy, and this new temple was probably not that fancy. The older Israelites might be sad that they were not able to give Yahweh as nice a temple this time. Some other people say that the older Israelites were sad because they were sorry that Israel's enemies destroyed the first temple because of Israel's sin. We do not know for sure why the older Israelites are sad, but it is important to know that the older Israelites who had seen Yahweh's first temple were sad.

The Israelites' shout of sadness and thankfulness was really loud. The shout was so loud that people in the crowd could not tell who was shouting because they were sad and who was shouting because they were happy. The shout was also so loud that people could hear it from a long distance away.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Zerubbabel
- Jeshua
- Jeshua's brothers and family
- Kadmiel
- Kadmiel's family
- Henadad's family
- All the other Levites
- Yahweh
- Asaph's family of Levites
- The Israelites
- The head of the Israelite families
- The builders who laid the temple's foundations
- And the older Israelites who were sad

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The Israelites finished building the altar a few months before this story. The Israelites are preparing to start building the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jeshua and Zerubbabel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh's temple is so important. I am so nervous about doing it correctly! or

Ezra 3:8–13

- We have not been able to worship Yahweh correctly for so long. I am so excited to be able to worship Yahweh in the temple again!

Continue the drama.

Next, Jeshua and Zerubbabel gather all the other priests, Levites, and all the other people of Israel who had returned to Israel. Jeshua and Zerubbabel prepared to start the work. Jeshua and Zerubbabel appointed the Levites who were 20 years old or older to help lead the workers.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing all the Levite families, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I feel so important since I am able to help make sure Yahweh's temple is built correctly; or
- I am scared I am going to make a mistake and make Yahweh upset with me; or
- I am very excited to help build the temple so we can worship Yahweh in it sooner!

Continue the drama.

The workers work on the base of the temple, and the priests and Levites have a celebration. The priests and Levites play trumpets and cymbals and sing songs of praise to Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests and Levites who lead the celebration, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I am so thankful that Yahweh led us back to Israel, protected us from our enemies, and has helped us to start building the temple; or
- I finally get to praise Yahweh the correct way again! or
- I hope Yahweh is happy with his new temple.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It makes me so happy to see my people wanting to follow me correctly again; or
- I love my people so much. It makes me excited to see my people wanting to praise me.

Continue the drama.

Then, all the Israelites shouted very loudly because they wanted to praise Yahweh so much. Some of the older Israelites who remembered Yahweh's first temple were very sad.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the older Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I remember Yahweh's first temple, which was so big, beautiful, and fancy. I am so sad that we cannot give Yahweh something better than this temple; or
- Our enemies destroyed Yahweh's first beautiful temple because of our sins. I am so sad that our people were the reason our enemies destroyed Yahweh's first temple.

Continue the drama.

The Israelites shouted happy and sad shouts so loudly that people far away could hear the Israelites!

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I am so happy! We can finally worship and praise Yahweh in our own land again, the way our family did for many centuries before us. This event is so special! or
- I want to be as loud as I can because I am so thankful to Yahweh for helping us to start building the temple again! I want everyone around us to know how happy I am.

Ezra 3:8–13

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 3:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this story, the Israelites met at the **house of God**. The house of God is the same thing as the "house of Yahweh" that the storyteller mentions later in the story. Remember that the house of God is a way to talk about the place on earth where Yahweh lived among his people. It is important to remember that the house of God can mean the temple, but can also mean other places. Use the same word or phrase for the house of God as you used in previous passages. For more information on the house of God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jeshua and Zerubbabel started working on the temple with all their "**brothers**" or relatives. Remember that these people are close family, like Jeshua and Zerubbabel's brothers and sisters or children. Brothers can also sometimes mean cousins and other relatives. Use the same word or phrase for brothers or relatives as you used in previous passages.

Jeshua and Zerubbabel also worked on the temple with the Israelite **priests** and Levites. The priests were a special group of Levites whom Yahweh chose to serve Yahweh in the temple. The priests made all of the sacrifices to Yahweh and performed many other special duties that served Yahweh. Use the same word or phrase for priests as you used in previous passages. For more information on priests, refer to the Master Glossary.

When Jeshua and Zerubbabel started working on the temple, they chose **Levites** who were 20 years old or older to help them. Remember, Levites are the group of Israelites whom Yahweh chose to serve Yahweh in the temple. Use the same word or phrase for Levites as you used in previous passages. For more information on Levites, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jeshua and Zerubbabel chose Levites to help supervise the workers who were building the house of **Yahweh**. Remember, Yahweh is a name God gives himself. The name Yahweh reminds people of God's promises to the Israelites. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

The storyteller lists some of the important Levite families that helped work on the temple. The storyteller mentions Kadmiel and the **sons of Judah**, which can also be translated as the "sons of Hodaviah." No matter which way people translate the phrase, the storyteller uses this phrase to remind us of the names of the important Levite families he already described in the book of Ezra. Use the same word or phrase for the "sons of Judah" or "sons of Hodaviah" as you used in previous passages.

The people working on the temple laid the foundation of the **temple**. We do not know exactly what this means, but it probably means that the workers started rebuilding the base of the temple building on which it could stand strong. It could also mean that the workers fixed the part of Yahweh's first temple that was still standing. Use the same word or phrase for temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the Israelites **laying a foundation** or **building a foundation** or base for the temple. Pause this audio here.

When the workers build the base of the temple, a special group of priests holds a celebration. These priests wear special clothes during the celebration. These special clothes were clothes that the priests often wore for important events. Yahweh commanded the priests to wear these clothes in the law of Moses.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **special clothes**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller describes the celebration the priests had when the workers built the base of the temple. In this celebration, the priests play trumpets to praise Yahweh. This means that the Israelites play trumpets to show Yahweh how grateful and thankful they are for all Yahweh has done for the people. Trumpets are long metal tubes. People blow into one side of a trumpet, and it makes music.

Ezra 3:8–13

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **trumpets**. If you have already translated trumpet in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Levites also played cymbals at the celebration. Cymbals are flat metal discs. People hit cymbals together to make a loud, crashing sound. People use cymbals to make music.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **cymbals**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The priests and Levites used trumpets and cymbals to praise Yahweh. Praise is when you speak out loud and say all the good things Yahweh has done. Praise is a way to give thanks and honor to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **praise**. Look up praise in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The priests played music and sang songs to Yahweh as **King** David had told them to do many years before this story. Remember, a king is someone who rules over a group of people. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in other passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

The storyteller describes King David as the king of **Israel**. Remember, Israel is the land where the Israelites lived. When the storyteller says that King David was king of Israel, the storyteller means that King David ruled over the land of Israel and the Israelites. Use the same word for Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

During the priests' celebration event, the Israelites sang songs that praised Yahweh and thanked Yahweh for all he had done. One of those songs praised Yahweh for his steadfast love. Some people also translate steadfast love as "faithful love," "kindness," or "lovingkindness." Yahweh is a faithful God. Yahweh always keeps his promises! Steadfast love is a way to describe Yahweh's faithfulness. It reminds the Israelites of Yahweh's loyalty and that Yahweh will always keep the promises Yahweh made to the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **steadfast love**. Look up steadfast love in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When the Israelites sing about Yahweh's steadfast love, they sing that Yahweh's love endures forever. This means that Yahweh's steadfast love will never end. Yahweh will always be faithful, loyal, and merciful to his people forever!

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **endures forever**.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 3:8–13

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (624 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

Ezra 4:1–6

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 4:1–6 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:1–6 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Cyrus, the king who ruled the kingdom of Persia, had allowed the exiles from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin to return to their hometown, called Jerusalem, to build the temple of Yahweh, the God of Israel. In the previous passage, Jeshua, son of Jozadak, and Zerubbabel, son of Shealtiel, and their helpers had rebuilt the altar of Yahweh and the foundation of the temple.

The storyteller continues the previous story and explains how the neighboring people, whom he calls the enemies of Judah and Benjamin, responded to the efforts of the exiles to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. The people of the land, or enemies of Judah and Benjamin, may be people whom the Assyrian king defeated and sent to live in the neighboring land of Samaria.

By this time, these enemies of Judah and Benjamin had lived in Samaria for several decades. Many of these people were likely born in this land. To these people, the exiles are “foreigners” who have come to take away these people’s land and influence.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How well do people in your culture get along with foreigners? Talk about a time when someone came back to your area to claim something that they believed was theirs. Pause this audio here.

It is entirely possible that the enemies of Judah and Benjamin heard the great shouts of joy and the trumpets that the priests blew when they celebrated that they had finished the foundation of the temple. Or it is possible that the enemies heard a report from someone about how the exiles came back to the land to rebuild.

Stop here and talk about a time when people in your community reacted when they heard loud celebrations or heard news that something big had happened. How did people respond? Pause this audio here.

The enemies came to Zerubbabel and the leaders of the families of Israel and asked to help build the temple. The enemies claimed to worship Israel's God as well and to have made sacrifices to Yahweh since King Esarhaddon of Assyria brought them to that land. We know that King Esarhaddon ruled from 681 to 669 B.C. King Esarhaddon forced these foreign communities to settle in Samaria after Esarhaddon conquered Samaria, which was the former northern Kingdom of Israel. An Israelite priest probably went to teach the people who settled there the law of the god of the land. However, the people ended up mixing religions when they worshiped Yahweh but also served their carved images or idols. Thus, the enemy people's statement that they worship Israel's God as Israel does may have been partially true.

Stop here and discuss together as a group how people in your community mix worship of God with other gods or ancestral practices. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when someone offered to help you but really had other motives. Pause this audio here.

The exiled leaders tell their enemies that the enemies cannot help the exiles rebuild the temple. The exiles refer to the political decree or order that King Cyrus gave, that the exiles were the only ones the king permitted to build the temple. The exiles clearly called Yahweh the exiles' God and so seem to indicate that the exiles want to keep the temple building pure. The people of the land were upset by this response from the exiles and decided to try to keep the exiles from building the temple by making the exiles afraid. The exiles could do very little to protect themselves. Enemies surrounded the small group of exiled people in Jerusalem. The exiled people could not defend themselves.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when someone tried to make you afraid. How did you feel about this? Pause this audio here

The people of the land hired or bribed "counselors" or officers to make it difficult for the exiles to continue to build the temple. To bribe someone is to pay that person to do something they should not do. This continues from the reign of King Cyrus of Persia into the reign of King Darius of Persia. This is a period of about 20 years. During the reign of King Darius, the Jews began rebuilding the temple again.

Stop here and discuss together as a group: Share a story about a time when you or someone else gave a bribe, or when someone tried to bribe you or another person. What do people in your culture think about people who try to bribe others? Pause this audio here.

After King Darius of Persia ruled his kingdom, King Xerxes ruled his kingdom. The enemies of Judah wrote a letter to King Xerxes of Persia to accuse the people of Jerusalem and Judah. It is not clear what the enemies of Judah accused the people of Judah and Jerusalem of doing. King Xerxes' first year of reign started in 485 B.C. King Xerxes was the son of King Darius. At the time of King Xerxes' first year of rule, there was a rebellion in Egypt, so it is likely that King Xerxes did nothing about the letter of accusation that King Xerxes received.

Stop here and discuss this together as a group: Talk about a time when you or someone else accused another person of doing something wrong, but the leader or person in charge did nothing about it. How did you or someone else feel about what happened?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

Ezra 4:1–6

In the first scene: The enemies of Judah heard that the exiles were rebuilding the temple of Yahweh. The enemies of Judah came to where the exiles from Judah were building and asked Zerubbabel and the leaders of the families if the enemies of Judah could help build the temple alongside the people of Judah. The enemies of Judah said that they wanted to help because they also worship the Israelites' God. The enemies of Judah said that they have sacrificed to the God of Israel since King Esarhaddon brought them into the land.

In the second scene: Zerubbabel, Jeshua, and the leaders of the families of Judah, or Israel, refused the help of the enemies of Judah. The leaders of Israel told the enemies of Judah that the enemies of Judah had no place helping the Israelites. The Israelites told the enemies of Judah that King Cyrus' decree said that the Israelites would be the ones to rebuild the temple of their God.

In the third scene: The enemies of Judah try to make the people of Judah afraid and stop the plans to rebuild the temple. The enemies of Judah bribe the Persian officers to make it difficult for Judah to rebuild the temple. This happens through the rest of King Cyrus' reign into the reign of King Darius.

In the fourth scene: Many years later, during the reign of King Xerxes, the enemies of Judah wrote a letter to the king to complain. The enemies accused the people of Judah of doing something wrong.

The characters in this passage are:

- The enemies of Judah and Benjamin
- The exiled Israelites from the Israelite tribes of Judah and Benjamin
- Zerubbabel
- Jeshua
- Leaders of the Israelite families
- Yahweh
- King Esarhaddon
- Officers or counselors
- King Cyrus
- King Darius
- And King Xerxes

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story takes place in Jerusalem after the exiled Israelites, or the "children of the exiles," return to rebuild the temple of Yahweh. The exiles had already built the foundation of the temple. The exiles are continuing the work on the temple. This story starts when a neighboring people group, who are enemies of the people of Judah and Benjamin, hears that the exiles are working to rebuild the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say "children of the exiles." Think about how you would talk about people who were taken away in the past and their children who returned.

Pause this audio here.

When the enemies of the people of Judah and Benjamin hear that the exiles are rebuilding the temple, they approach Zerubbabel and the leaders of Israel. The storyteller directly quotes the enemies to show clearly and strongly what they said. The enemies of Judah and Benjamin say, "We will build with you because like you we try to follow your God. We have sacrificed to your God ever since King Esarhaddon of Assyria brought us here."

Then Zerubbabel and Jeshua and the leaders of the Israelite families respond strongly and directly: "You have no part with us in building a temple to our God. We alone will build it for Yahweh, the God of Israel, as King Cyrus, the king of Persia, commanded us." You will notice that here the storyteller calls the leaders of the exiles the leaders of the Israelite families. The people from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin were also Israelites. By this time, they were the only tribes of Israel who still followed Yahweh. Because of this, storytellers often call the people of Judah and Benjamin the true Israelites. You will also notice that the storyteller uses the title "king" twice for Cyrus. The exiles want to be clear to their enemies that the Israelites are following the command of the King of Persia, who is King Cyrus.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the title of Cyrus. The title “King” shows someone with great authority. This strong title means that the Israelites were obeying the most powerful ruler of their time. How can you translate this title in your language? Pause this audio here.

After the Israelite rulers reject the request of their enemies, the enemies try to discourage the exiles or cause the exiles to lose their courage so that the exiles will not continue to build the temple. The word discourage means “to weaken the hands.” So the enemies are trying to weaken the exiles’ hands from working.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate to “discourage” or “weaken the hands.” Pause this audio here.

The enemies of Judah also try to frighten the exiles, though the passage does not say how they try to frighten the people. The enemies also “bribed” or paid officers to do things they were not supposed to do to keep the exiles from building the temple. The enemies of Judah discouraged and frightened the Israelites all the days of King Cyrus until the days of King Darius.

Then, many years later, when King Xerxes started to rule his kingdom, the enemies of Judah sent King Xerxes a letter to accuse the exiles who were living in Judah and Jerusalem. Some translations use the Hebrew name for King Xerxes, which is Ahasuerus.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The enemies of Judah and Benjamin
- The exiled Israelites from Judah and Benjamin
- Zerubbabel
- Jeshua
- Leaders of the Israelite families
- Yahweh
- King Esarhaddon
- Officers or counselors
- King Cyrus
- King Darius
- And King Xerxes

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The enemies of Judah heard that exiles were rebuilding the temple of Yahweh.

Ezra 4:1–6

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the enemies of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Who do these people think they are? Why do these people get to rebuild a temple in our land? or
- I wonder what these people are doing here? I feel like these people should not build without talking to us.

Continue the drama.

The enemies of Judah came to where the exiles were building and asked Zerubbabel and the leaders of the families if the enemies of Judah could help build the temple alongside the exiles. The enemies of Judah said that they wanted to help because they also worshiped the exiles' God. The enemies of Judah said that they had sacrificed to the God of Israel since King Esarhaddon brought them into the land.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the enemies of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Since this is where we live, these people should at least let us help them out; or
- We learned about these people's God. We should be able to worship this God as well; or
- I hope these people let us help. Then we can keep an eye on these people and maybe overthrow them.

Continue the drama.

Zerubbabel, Jeshua, and the leaders of the families of Israel refused the help of the enemies of Judah. The leaders of Israel told the enemies of Judah that the enemies of Judah had no place helping the Israelites. The Israelites told the enemies of Judah that King Cyrus' decree said that the Israelites would be the ones to rebuild the temple of their God.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the exiles, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Do they really think we will let them help? We are here to build a house for the one true God! or
- I am suspicious about what these people really want from us. I do not think they actually want to help.

Continue the drama.

The enemies of Judah try to make the people of Judah afraid and disrupt the plans to rebuild the temple. The enemies of Judah bribe the Persian officers to make it difficult for Judah to rebuild the temple. This happens through the rest of King Cyrus' rule into the rule of King Darius.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the exiles, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is so frustrating. I do not understand why God does not help us out; or
- This is really going slowly now since we have so much opposition. But we will get it done; or
- How long, God, will we have to endure these enemies?

Continue the drama.

Many years later, during the reign of King Xerxes, the enemies of Judah wrote a letter to the king to make accusations against the people of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the enemies of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry. I do not want these people to grow strong again; or
- I want the king to stop these people. I feel worried that the people of Judah will rise and become powerful.

Ask the person playing the exiles, "When you learned that your enemies sent a letter against you, what were you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

Ezra 4:1–6

- I feel confused. Why do these people hate us so much? or
- I feel afraid. What will the king do to us? or
- I feel sad. We only want to rebuild God's house.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The enemies of **Judah** and **Benjamin** heard that the people of Judah and Benjamin who returned from **exile** were building the **temple** for **Yahweh**, the **God** of **Israel**. Judah and Benjamin were two of the tribes in the southern kingdom. Israelites are the people of God who were descendants of Abraham and, more specifically, descendants of Jacob. Exile is when a conquering nation does not allow the people to live in their home country. The temple for Yahweh was the place where the Israelites worshipped and made sacrifices to Yahweh. The God of Israel is the God who created everything, whom Israel worships. See the Master Glossary for more information on Israel, Judah, temple, God, and Yahweh. Translate exile and the children or people of the exile in the same way you have in previous passages.

The enemies of the exiles came to where Judah was building and asked **Zerubbabel**, one of the leaders of Judah, and the leaders of the families if the enemies of Judah could help build the temple alongside the Israelites. The enemies of Judah said that they wanted to help because they also "**seek**," or try to ask for help from, the exiles' God. These enemies said that they also give honor to Yahweh, the God of Israel. The enemies of Judah said that they had **sacrificed** to the God of Israel since **King** Esarhaddon brought them into the land. To sacrifice is to give to God something of great importance or value. People usually slaughtered an animal when they made a sacrifice. A king is the ruler of an area. See the Master Glossary for more information on sacrifice and king.

Zerubbabel, Jeshua, and the **leaders of the families** of Israel refused to allow the enemies of Judah to help build the temple. The leaders of Israel told the enemies of Judah that the enemies of Judah had no place helping the Israelites. The Israelites told the enemies of Judah that King Cyrus commanded that the Israelites would be the ones to build the temple for Yahweh, the God of the Israelites. Translate "leaders" or "heads" of families the same way you have in previous passages.

The enemies of Judah try to make the people of Judah afraid and stop the plans to rebuild the temple. The enemies of Judah **bribe** the **officers** to make it difficult for Judah to rebuild the temple. This happens through the rest of King Cyrus' **kingdom**, or reign, and into the kingdom, or reign, of King Darius. An officer is an advisor to the King of Persia. Use the same words for government officer and for kingdom as you have previously, and refer to kingdom in the Master Glossary for more information. To bribe someone means to pay that person money so that the person will do something you want, even though that action is illegal.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bribe**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Many years later, at the beginning of the reign of King Xerxes, the enemies of Judah wrote a letter to the king to make accusations against the people of Judah.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 4:1–6

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (463 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (693 KB)

Ezra 4:7–16

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 4:7–16 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:7–16 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:7–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The people of Judah and Benjamin returned from exile to Jerusalem to rebuild the city. The people who were living in the land did not want the exiles to rebuild Jerusalem. We know that the people began working on the temple again during the reign of King Darius. The people finished the temple during Darius' reign. It is likely that the people continued to rebuild Jerusalem during the reign of King Xerxes, who reigned after King Darius. But now King Artaxerxes reigns, and we will see that the enemies of the exiles will again oppose the exiles. Artaxerxes ruled in Persia from 465 to 424 B.C. At that time, Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, and their fellow workers wrote a letter to Artaxerxes to complain about the Israelites. The storyteller does not say anything else about these men and their helpers. These men wrote the letter in Aramaic. Aramaic was the official language of the Persian Empire. Some translations mention that the people translated the letter, but it is unclear into what language people translated the letter.

Ezra 4:7–16

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture talk to or get the attention of the leaders or government officials to complain? Share a story of when you had to make a complaint to an official. Pause this audio here.

Rehum, the commander, and Shimshai, the scribe, also wrote a letter to Artaxerxes against Jerusalem. A commander is a high-ranking official who reports to the king. The scribe was also a high official who wrote official letters or translated official documents. The rest of this passage is a copy of this letter.

The writers of the letter identify themselves as Rehum and Shimshai, along with the rest of their fellow workers. Rehum and Shimshai are writing the letter on behalf of all of the people that they mention as their fellow workers. Rehum and Shimshai list these people by their positions and the cities they come from.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What effect does it have in your community when a message comes from many groups instead of just one? Why do people do this? Pause this audio here.

The people whom Rehum and Shimshai listed by origin were the people whom Osnappar, also called Ashurbanipal, king of Assyria, deported and settled in Samaria and in the area beyond the river. Some translations call this area the “Trans-Euphrates.” This area includes everything west of the Euphrates River to the Mediterranean Sea.

Stop here and, if needed, look at a map of the Trans-Euphrates region. Pause this audio here.

These people would have objected to the Persian leaders giving special treatment to the exiles.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Have you seen some people become jealous or upset when leaders give one group special treatment? What happened? Pause this audio here.

Rehum and Shimshai were attempting to pressure King Artaxerxes when they said that they were speaking for the whole area of people and that they feared for the safety of Persia.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would someone in your culture try to pressure a ruler to do what they wanted the ruler to do? Do you have examples of a time when someone tried to pressure a leader to do something? What actions or words did that person use? Pause this audio here.

Then the letter identifies who the letter is to and who sent the letter. The writers of the letter show respect to the king when they call themselves the king’s servants. The writers also identify themselves by their location in a province they call “beyond the River.”

The writers of the letter warn the king of the issues that will come if the king allows the Jews who came from Babylon to finish building Jerusalem. You may remember that people called the exiles from the Israelite tribes of Judah and Benjamin “Jews.” The writers refer to Jerusalem as an evil and rebellious city. The writers of the letter insist that if the Jews build Jerusalem, then the Jews will no longer pay their taxes to the Persian king, and the king will have less income. The Persian Empire thought taxation was very important. The Persian Empire believed that if people stopped paying taxes, those people were rebelling.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what happens when people do not pay their taxes or dues to the leaders? Pause this audio here.

The writers of the letter say that they share or eat the salt of the palace in order to show that the writers are loyal to the king and that the king pays the writers to work for the king. The writers state that they do not want the king to be put to shame, and so the writers suggest a solution. When the Persians replaced the Assyrian and Babylonian empires, they got their records. These records were in the form of clay tablets, or leather or papyrus scrolls, in the royal archives. These records would report that the rulers in Jerusalem rebelled against the Assyrians and Babylonians, especially when the rulers fought against the Babylonian rulers who destroyed Jerusalem in 586 B.C.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How have people in your culture kept records of the past? Tell a story that your tribe, culture, or people group has passed down. Pause this audio here.

The writers of the letter state their final conclusion: that if the Jews rebuild the city of Jerusalem, then the king of Persia will no longer have control over the land beyond the River because the Jews will take over this province.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why do people become afraid when they think they will lose control, power, or land? How have you seen this in your community?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:7–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, and the enemies of Judah complain to King Artaxerxes about the Jews rebuilding Jerusalem. Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, and those with him wrote the letter in Aramaic, the language people used for official letters in the Persian Empire. The king's servant translated the letter into another language.

In the second scene: Rehum, a commanding officer, and Shimshai, the secretary, also wrote a letter to King Artaxerxes against Jerusalem. The beginning of this letter gives the names of the people who are sending the letter. This gives the idea of who the letter is from and who the letter represents.

In the third scene: Rehum's and Shimshai's letter to King Artaxerxes warns the king about the Jews rebuilding Jerusalem and the damage it will do to King Artaxerxes' kingdom.

The characters in this passage are:

- Artaxerxes, king of Persia
- Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, and their fellow workers
- Rehum, the commanding officer
- Shimshai, the secretary
- Judges
- Officials
- Administrators
- Ashurbanipal, or Osnappar, king of Assyria
- And the Jews who are rebuilding Jerusalem

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story takes place in the days of King Artaxerxes, the king of Persia. People complained against the exiles who worked to rebuild Jerusalem in the time of King Darius, and people continued to complain in the days of King Artaxerxes.

In the first scene, we do not know what Bishlam, Mithredath, and Tabeel wrote to King Artaxerxes. Because the first scene is within the context of several complaints people sent to the kings of Persia, we assume that this letter was also a complaint about the exiles. Bishlam, Mithredath, and Tabeel wrote this letter in Aramaic, which was the official language of the Persian Empire.

In the second scene, Rehum, the commander, and Shimshai, the secretary or scribe, wrote a letter against the Jews to King Artaxerxes as well. This is a separate letter, and here we have the text of the letter. The storyteller tells us that he is beginning to directly quote the letter.

The letter starts with who wrote the letter and who the letter is for. Some translations include this as the beginning of the letter. Someone would write the names of the people who sent the letter on the outside of the paper, along with a brief explanation of what the letter was about. Some translations show that the list of names of the people who wrote the letter is not an actual part of the letter.

Rehum's title is commanding officer. This is a high-ranking non-military official who could give orders and reports to the king. Shimshai was a scribe, or a person who wrote official documents. The rest of Rehum and Shimshai's associates, or people who were connected to them, were all people of high importance in the government. This was the government over the people who "Osnappar," or Ashurbanipal, settled in Samaria, or "beyond the

River" in the Trans-Euphrates. These people kept their ethnic identity even when Osnappar deported or forcefully moved them out of their own land and settled in the area. Osnappar, or Ashurbanipal, was the Assyrian king who deported these groups of people. Here, the letter writer refers to Osnappar as "great and honorable" or noble. These words describe a very powerful ruler.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you refer to a person who writes important letters for leaders? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you say "the people connected to them" in your language? How would you refer to people who work together as a group? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe this list of people that the letter represents. Will this be a part of the letter or just a separate list? Do people in your culture write the sender's information on a letter? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you say that a ruler is very powerful and respected? How does your language show honor without adding too much praise? Pause this audio here.

The third scene is the text of the letter to King Artaxerxes. The letter tells the king that the Jews who came from Babylon are rebuilding Jerusalem. Jerusalem is a wicked and rebellious city. The writers tell the king that if the Jews rebuild the city, the Jews will no longer pay taxes, tributes, and duties to the king. Taxes are payments to the ruler. Tributes are gifts or payments to show respect to a powerful king. Duties are fees that people pay at the city gates or trading places. These are three separate kinds of payments to the king's treasury, but you could group them all together as "taxes." The letter states that if the Jews do not pay their taxes, then the kingdom itself will suffer from the financial loss.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What are the different types of taxes or payments that people in your culture pay to the leaders or government? How will you talk about these taxes in your translation? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about the way a kingdom or a kingdom's wealth "suffers"? How do people in your language talk about a leader who loses land or authority? Pause this audio here.

The writers use words to try to get favor from the king and to get the king to listen to the writers. The writers describe themselves as loyal to the king. The phrase "we eat the salt of the palace" shows that the writers receive from the palace and therefore owe a debt to the king. The writers tell the king they are writing so that no one will dishonor or shame the king. This language makes the letter sound as if the writers have the king's best interest in mind and have no other motive to write the letter.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people say they are loyal to a leader because they depend on the leader for food, support, or life? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss together as a group: How would you send information to a leader in your culture? Discuss what you would say to a leader in your community that you want to do something for you. Make your message sound like you are more concerned about that leader than you really are. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use to show that. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:7–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Artaxerxes, king of Persia
- Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, and their fellow workers
- Rehum, the commanding officer

Ezra 4:7–16

- Shimshai, the secretary
- Judges
- Officials
- Administrators
- Ashurbanipal, or Osnappar, king of Assyria
- And the Jews who are rebuilding Jerusalem

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, and the enemies of Judah complain to King Artaxerxes about the Jews rebuilding Jerusalem. The enemies of Judah wrote this letter and translated it into Aramaic.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Bishlam, Mithredeth, and Tabeel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hope King Artaxerxes pays attention to our complaints; or
- I cannot believe these Jews are taking back our territory and rebuilding their city! I am so mad that the Jews are taking our land!

Continue the drama.

Rehum, a commanding officer, and Shimshai, the secretary, wrote a strong letter to King Artaxerxes against Jerusalem. The men write on behalf of many leaders in the region, including judges, officials, and administrators.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehum or Shimshai, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We must make this letter sound very serious. I feel pressure to get the king's attention; or
- I feel proud because many leaders trust me to write this letter for them; or
- I feel worried that the Jews will become powerful again. I want to stop the Jews before it is too late.

Ask the person playing King Artaxerxes, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- There seem to be a lot of complaints about the Jews! Maybe I should pay attention to this; or
- What now? Why are people sending me so many letters about the Jews in the area beyond the River? or
- I really wish someone else could deal with these letters.

Continue the drama.

This passage includes a copy of the letter that Rehum and Shimshai and their associates wrote. Rehum and Shimshai wrote this letter to King Artaxerxes to warn the king about the Jews rebuilding Jerusalem and the damage it would do to King Artaxerxes' kingdom.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Artaxerxes, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I definitely do not want to lose the taxes that I get now. I had better do something about this; or

- Rehum and Shimshai are clearly good men to look out for me like this. I will see how I can help these men out! or
- I do not like it when people try to get favors from me

Ask the person playing Rehum and Shimshai, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hope this works. We wrote the letter from everyone of importance in this area, so I am sure the king will listen! or
- I am so angry because those Jews are trying to take our territory! or
- I am sure if we keep at it, we will stop the Jews from rebuilding, and the king will listen to what we ask of him!

Ask the person playing the exiles rebuilding Jerusalem, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Why are these people against us? It makes me feel sad and confused; or
- I feel afraid. If the king listens to those letters, we may have to stop building; or
- I feel tired. Trouble keeps coming again and again, but I still want to trust God.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:7–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

During the reign of Artaxerxes, **king** of Persia, Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabeel, and their associates wrote a letter to the king. These men wrote the letter and translated it into Aramaic. The king is a person who rules over a territory or region. Be sure to translate king in the same way you have previously. King is in the Master Glossary.

Aramaic was the official language of the Persian Empire.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Aramaic**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Rehum, the commanding officer, and Shimshai, the scribe or secretary, wrote a letter against Jerusalem to Artaxerxes.

Stop here and remember how you discussed what you call a person who writes important letters for leaders. What will you call the **scribe** in this passage? For more information, refer to scribe in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Rehum, Shimshai, and their associates were judges, officials, and administrators over the people from Persia, Uruk and Babylon, the Elamites and Susa, and the other people who were settled in the city of Samaria and the Trans-Euphrates. "Trans-Euphrates" means the land "beyond the River," on the west side of the Euphrates River. Judges decide whether what people do is right or wrong and whether or not those people are guilty or innocent. Officials help run the land. Administrators give orders for daily work in the kingdom.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **judges**, **officials**, and **administrators**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. For more information on "judge," refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Persia**, **Uruk**, **Babylon**, **Elamites**, and **Susa**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and repeat the words you decided upon in the proper order. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Trans Euphrates** or "beyond the River." If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra 4:7–16

The writers of the letter sent the letter to King Artaxerxes. The writers call themselves **servants** of the king, who live in the Trans-Euphrates. In this story, "servant" refers to people who are under the authority of the king. Use the same word or phrase for servant when it means someone who works for a king as you have previously. Servant is in the Master Glossary.

The writers tell the king that the **Jews**, or people who came from Persia back to Jerusalem, are rebuilding the wicked and rebellious city. "Wicked" is very harmful or evil. When someone is rebellious, that person refuses to obey the rules. These Jews are restoring the walls and the foundations of this city. The Jews are descendants of Jacob. The Jews are the Israelites from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin who were exiles in Babylon. You will remember that in previous passages in Ezra, King Cyrus sent the Jews back to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Jews**. Look up Jews in the Master Glossary. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **wicked** and **rebellion**. Look up wickedness in the Master Glossary. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The writers also tell the king that if the Jews build and restore Jerusalem, they will no longer pay taxes, tributes, or duties to the king, and the king's income will suffer losses. Taxes are payments to the ruler. Tributes are gifts or payments to show respect to a powerful king. Duties are fees that people pay at the city gates or trading places.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **taxes**, **tributes**, and **duties**. Remember that you can simply use a general word for "taxes" if you do not have different words for different kinds of taxes in your language. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The writers serve the king in his palace and are obligated to serve the king well. A king's palace is the house where the king lives and often rules from.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **palace**, or **king's house**. Pause this audio here.

Since the writers are in service to the kingdom, the writers do not want people to dishonor the king. That is why the writers sent the warning to the king. The king should then search the old records, or **scrolls**, from the previous kings and learn that Jerusalem was rebellious. The kings who controlled the land destroyed Jerusalem because of its history of revolt. To revolt is to rebel against someone or something.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **revolt**. If you have already translated this word in another book in the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **records** or **scrolls**. Most kings' officials wrote their records for the kingdom on long pieces of paper or animal skins, which they then wrapped around long sticks on both sides. You may use your word for scrolls, or a more general word for "documents of a king." For more information about scrolls, refer to scroll in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The writers then tell King Artaxerxes that if people rebuild the city, then all of the province west of the Euphrates River will no longer belong to King Artaxerxes.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 4:7–16

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (493 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (694 KB)

Ezra 4:17–24

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 4:17–24 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:17–24 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:17–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The enemies of the exiles in Jerusalem, Rehum and Shimshai, wrote a letter to King Artaxerxes of Persia to complain about the exiles that returned to rebuild Jerusalem. In this passage, the king writes a reply to the enemies of the Jewish exiles in Jerusalem.

King Artaxerxes answers the letter of the Jewish enemies. The enemies of the exiles wrote the letter in Aramaic. Someone translated and read the letter to the King of Persia. Because of the letter, King Artaxerxes ordered someone to search the records for information about the kings of Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what kinds of orders do rulers give? What happens if a person ignores or tries to change an order? Pause this audio here.

The records showed that the people in the city of Jerusalem had rebelled against other kings.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of records or stories do people keep about your culture, or the cultures in the surrounding areas? How do people in your culture keep these records? Who is able to access these records? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Have you heard of a place or group that people know as troublemakers in your community? How does that reputation affect that place or group, even years later? Pause this audio here.

Many mighty kings had ruled Jerusalem and the Trans-Euphrates, or the province "beyond the River." We do not know if these records are specifically about the great Israelite kings like David and Solomon or about other kings like the Assyrian and Babylonian kings. These Assyrian and Babylonian kings collected taxes from the people in the province. Those kings of Jerusalem, however, received tributes, customs, and tolls. These are all types of taxes that the people paid to kings.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why do leaders in your culture care so much about taxes or contributions? What happens when people stop paying taxes or contributions? Have one or two people act as leaders who are reacting to people who have stopped paying taxes. Pause this audio here.

Therefore, the enemies of Israel are to issue an order to stop people from rebuilding the city until King Artaxerxes makes an order that people can rebuild again. This order is important because no one could change a Persian King's order once he ordered it. King Artaxerxes tells the enemies of Israel not to waste any time but to make the Israelites stop immediately.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do leaders show that what they command is urgent and that people must do it quickly? Pause this audio here.

King Artaxerxes asks a question that the king does not want anyone to answer. King Artaxerxes asks why the king should let things get worse and damage the king's interests. The king does not tell the enemies to destroy the progress the Jews have already made on rebuilding Jerusalem. However, it is possible that this is the time when the enemies destroyed the walls of Jerusalem and set the gates on fire.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How have your community leaders reacted when people made complaints? What must people do when the leaders give orders to fix those problems? Pause this audio here.

When someone read the letter from King Artaxerxes to Rehum the commander, and Shimshai the scribe, and their fellow workers, the ones who heard the letter went to the Jews who returned from exile and forced the people to stop rebuilding the city of Jerusalem. It is most likely that the officials took many Samaritan soldiers with them to force the Israelites to stop building.

Most likely, the storyteller tells us about this opposition during the reign of King Artaxerxes to remind us that the enemies of the Jews opposed the Jews a lot! The Jews had to persevere through many hard times! But now the storyteller goes back in time to his main story about when the enemies of the Jews stopped the work on the "house of God," or temple, in Jerusalem during the reign of King Cyrus many years before King Artaxerxes. You will remember that during the reign of King Cyrus, enemies of the Jews stopped the work on the temple. But King Darius allowed the Jews to start the work again, and the Jews completed the temple during Darius' reign. In the next passage, the storyteller will return to the story when the Jews started to rebuild the temple for the second time during King Darius' reign.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Share experiences where you, someone else, or your community were forced to wait for something to start again that had stopped for a long time. How did people feel? What happened during the wait?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:17–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Ezra 4:17–24

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: King Artaxerxes answers the letter of the Jewish enemies from the previous passage. King Artaxerxes takes the writers' accusation seriously. The king reports that the records confirm that the people of Jerusalem rebel against kings a lot. The king gives an order to stop the Jews from rebuilding the city until King Artaxerxes says that the Jews can restart.

In the second scene: When someone read the letter from King Artaxerxes to Rehum the commander, and Shimshai the scribe, and their fellow workers, the ones who heard the letter went to the Jews who returned from exile and forced them to stop rebuilding the city of Jerusalem.

In the third scene: In the time of King Darius, the exiles of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin stopped the work on the house of God in Jerusalem until the second year of the reign of King Darius of Persia.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Artaxerxes
- Rehum
- Shimshai
- Fellow workers of Rehum and Shimshai
- Other previous and powerful kings of Jerusalem
- The Jewish exiles rebuilding Jerusalem
- And King Darius

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting: The king of Persia sends an answer in the form of a letter, and we hear the letter in this passage. The letter is in the traditional letter-writing form of that culture. The author names the people to whom the king writes and gives an opening greeting. The king names the same two people and their fellow workers who wrote the first letter. These people live in Samaria and elsewhere in the province of the Trans-Euphrates. You will remember that Samaria is the former Northern Kingdom of Israel.

In the first scene, the opening of the king's letter includes a normal greeting, "peace." The king hopes the people are doing well and are at peace with the people around them. This is an unusual greeting from a king to his people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what a typical greeting is that you would expect to receive from a leader in your culture. How will you translate the king's greeting of "peace" in this letter? Pause this audio here.

The king states that he received the letter, and someone translated the letter and read it to the king. The king talks about "us" receiving the letter. The king may be referring to himself and his government officials as the people who received the letter. Sometimes, kings in that time referred to themselves as "us" or "we" as a sign that they were royal and of high status.

Stop here and discuss as a group how your kings or leaders talk about themselves. How will you talk about who the king says received the letter? Pause this audio here.

The king ordered someone to search the records to find information about Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your culture talk about looking into old writings or past decisions? Do you have a natural way to say "official records" or "written history"? Think about how you translated the idea of historical records from the previous passage. Pause this audio here.

We do not know exactly what the king ordered, but the king probably ordered his people to search the records. You will remember that in the Persian kingdom, people could not change the order a king made.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you refer to a command that people cannot change? How is a ruler's command different from an ordinary request? Pause this audio here.

The king uses the same words for search and found that were used in Rehum and Shimshai's letter to the king.

Therefore, the enemies of the Jews are to issue an order to stop the rebuilding of the city until King Artaxerxes makes an order that they can rebuild again. King Artaxerxes tells the enemies of Israel not to waste any time in getting the Israelites to stop. The king asks a question that he does not expect anyone to answer. The king asks, "Why should you let the Jewish people be a threat to our kingdom?" The king means that he wants the enemies of the Jews to stop the work.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you show urgency and force in your language? Pause this audio here.

[At the end of this passage, the storyteller takes us back in time and returns to his original story during the reign of King Darius, when the Jews were able to start building the temple again.]{.mark} Remember that the exiles returned to Jerusalem and began rebuilding the temple under King Cyrus. Enemies of the Jews stopped the Jews from rebuilding the temple for a long time, until the time of King Darius, when the Jews were able to finish rebuilding the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your language show long periods of activity in a story? How can you help listeners feel the weight of waiting many years? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show that the storyteller has returned to his previous story that he had paused at chapter 4 verse 5? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:17–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Artaxerxes
- Rehum
- Shimshai
- Fellow workers of Rehum and Shimshai
- Other previous and powerful kings of Jerusalem
- The Jewish exiles rebuilding Jerusalem
- And King Darius

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

King Artaxerxes answers the letter of the Jewish enemies. King Artaxerxes takes the writers' accusation seriously. The king reports that he has confirmed from the historical records the information that the enemies of the Jews sent to the king about the rebellion and sedition of Jerusalem. Therefore, the enemies of Israel are to issue an order to stop the rebuilding of the city until King Artaxerxes makes an order that people can start again.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Artaxerxes, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so thankful that the people wrote to me about the rebuilding of Jerusalem; or
- I am serious about my order to make the Israelites stop rebuilding! or
- I am glad I have good people to tell me important information about my kingdom.

Continue the drama.

Someone read the letter from King Artaxerxes to Rehum the commander, and Shimshai the scribe, and their associates. The ones who heard the letter went to the Jews who returned from exile and forced them to stop rebuilding the city of Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehum and Shimshai, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Yes! I knew our letter would work! We are vindicated! or
- Now we get to go tell those Israelites to stop their work! The Israelites will be sorry they came here. I feel so justified; or
- Finally, we have a king who listens to us!

Continue the drama.

Rehum, Shimshai, and their men arrive in Jerusalem and force the Jews to stop rebuilding the city.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehum or Shimshai, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- It feels good to be in control at last; or
- Now the people must obey us. I feel strong and satisfied; or
- I want to make sure the work stops completely. I feel strict and determined.

Continue the drama.

The people of Judah and Benjamin stop working on the city of Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, “What are you feeling or thinking?”

The person might answer things like:

- My heart feels heavy. We were obeying God, and now we must stop; or
- I feel disappointed and tired after all our hard work; or
- I do not understand God’s plan, but I still want to trust God; or
- This feels like a great loss. Everything we built is now silent.

Continue the drama.

Going back to the time of King Darius, the exiles of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin stopped the work on the house of God in Jerusalem until the second year of the reign of King Darius of Persia.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We just want to do what God asked us to. Why did God allow this to happen? I am confused; or
- I trust that God will have his way with God’s enemies. This is not the end of the temple! or
- I am so defeated. We were making such good progress.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 4:17–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Ezra 4:17–24

King Artaxerxes answers the letter from the enemies of the exiles in Jerusalem: Rehum the **commander**, and Shimshai the **scribe**, and their fellow workers. King Artaxerxes begins the letter with the greeting of peace. Use the same words for king, commander, and scribe as you have used in previous passages. King and scribe are in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the king's greeting of "**peace**." For more information about peace, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The king tells the enemies of the exiles that his people translated the **letter** that the people had written in Aramaic and read it to the king. Because of the letter, King Artaxerxes made an order, which is a law that no one can change**.** Because of that order, someone searched the records for information about the kings of Jerusalem. The records showed that the city of Jerusalem had risen against other kings in **rebellion** and **revolt**. Use the same words for letter, rebellion, and revolt that you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **order**. Pause this audio here.

Many strong kings had ruled Jerusalem in the **Trans-Euphrates** or "province beyond the River." Those kings of Jerusalem received **taxes**, **tributes**, and **duties**. These are all types of taxes that people paid to kings. Be sure to use the same words for Trans-Euphrates, taxes, tributes, and duties as you did in previous passages.

Therefore, the enemies of Israel are to issue an order to stop people from rebuilding the city until King Artaxerxes makes a decree. King Artaxerxes tells the enemies of the **Jews** not to waste any time but to make the Jews stop immediately. King Artaxerxes asks why the king should let things get worse and damage the king's interests. Most people use the word "Jew" to refer to those Israelites who mostly came from the tribes of Benjamin and Judah. These were the Israelites who lived in the southern kingdom of Israel called Judah. These Israelites came back to Judah, the southern kingdom of Israel, when King Cyrus said they could come back. Use the same word or phrase for Jew as you used in the previous passage. For more information about Jews, refer to the Master Glossary.

When people read the letter from King Artaxerxes to Rehum the commander, and Shimshai the scribe, and their associates, the ones who heard the letter went to the Jews who returned from exile and forced them to stop rebuilding Jerusalem.

The exiles of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin stopped the work on the **temple** or "**house of God**" in Jerusalem until the second year of the reign of King Darius of Persia. The temple of God is the place where the Israelites went to worship the one true God. "Temple," or "house of God," is in the Master Glossary. Be sure to use the same word you have used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 4:17–24

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (495 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (696 KB)

Ezra 5:1–5

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 5:1–5 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:1–5 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:1–5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Remember that in the previous passage, the storyteller told us about times after the Jews finished building God's temple when enemies tried to stop the Jews from rebuilding Jerusalem. Now the story goes back to what the storyteller was talking about at the beginning of chapter 4. The storyteller takes us back to the time of King Darius, when the Jews started rebuilding the temple in the second year of King Darius' reign as king of Persia. This story is about the Jews obeying God. The story is also about God keeping his promises to the Jews.

This story starts with two men named Haggai and Zechariah. Haggai and Zachariah, two of God's prophets, gave the Jews a message from God. A prophet is someone who listens to God and gives God's messages to other people. The storyteller mentions that Zechariah is from the family of Iddo, an important family of priests. We know from the book of Zechariah that Zechariah is the grandson of Iddo. In this story, the storyteller does not tell us what message Haggai and Zechariah gave the Jews, but someone wrote God's message in the books people called "Haggai" and "Zechariah."

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people from your culture hear from God? How is that different or the same from the way that prophets in Judah heard from God? Pause this audio here.

We hear earlier in the book of Ezra that the enemies of the Jews frustrated the Jews so much that the Jews stopped building the temple during King Cyrus' reign as king of Persia. We know from the book of Haggai that instead of building the temple, the people started building their own houses and making their own houses look

Ezra 5:1–5

pretty. This made God sad because God's temple was unfinished for many years while the Jews made their own houses look pretty instead.

Stop here and tell the group a story of a time in your life when you started a project but never finished it. Explain what happened to keep you from finishing. Pause this audio here.

At the beginning of this story, Haggai and Zechariah gave a message to the Jews who lived in Jerusalem and Judah during the reign of King Darius. The storyteller in Ezra does not say what Haggai and Zechariah told the Jews, but the storyteller is very clear that Haggai and Zechariah spoke for God. This means that Haggai and Zechariah's message from God was just as true as if God said it to the Jews himself. It seems that Haggai and Zechariah told the Jews that God wanted the Jews to rebuild the temple, so Zerubbabel and Jeshua decided to start building the temple again because of what Haggai and Zechariah said.

Zerubbabel and Jeshua decided to restart building the temple even though Darius, the king of Persia at that time, had not given people permission to start. God's prophets helped and supported the Jews to rebuild the temple.

Stop here and tell a story to the group of a time in your life when you decided to do something because you knew it was right, even if the people around you did not approve of what you were doing. Pause this audio here.

While the Jews were building the temple again, two Persian officials came to visit Jerusalem. One of the men, named Tattenai, was an important leader in the Persian kingdom. Tattenai's job was to govern a place the storyteller calls the Trans-Euphrates, or "beyond the River," which was a large area of land south of the Euphrates River that included Judah and Jerusalem. Because the Persian kingdom was so big, Tattenai's job was to manage the area of land south of the Euphrates River so that the king of Persia could focus on ruling the whole kingdom.

Stop here and look at a map of the Trans-Euphrates area. Notice where this area is in relation to Judah and Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Shethar-Bozenai was the other man who came from Persia. Shethar-Bozenai was another special person in Persia, but was not as important as Tattenai. Shethar-Bozenai may have been Tattenai's helper. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai arrived in Judah with other Persian government officials. We do not know what these officials did, but they likely came to help Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this story, the rulers of Persia had many kinds of people help them rule the land and make sure the people in the kingdom followed the rules. How do leaders in your culture organize their officials to make sure that people are following the rules? Pause the audio here.

When Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai arrived in Judah, they talked to the Jews who were building the temple. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai asked the Jews who gave the Jews permission to start building the temple again. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai also asked to know the names of the men who were building the temple. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai probably asked these questions so that they could tell King Darius what was happening in Judah. During the first two years of his rule, King Darius had to deal with many people throughout his kingdom who were trying to challenge his power as king. So, Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai could be worried that the Jews will become troublemakers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people in authority do to find out if a group might cause trouble for the government or community? Pause this audio here.

But God was protecting the Jews. Tattenai and Shethar-Bosenai's visit could have kept the Jews from finishing the temple, but God protected the Jews from having to stop building again. The storyteller mentions that the eye of God was on the Jews during this time. This is important to notice because the kings of Persia would often use spies called the "king's eyes" who would spy on people to help the king know what was happening. When the storyteller mentions that the eye of God was on the Jews, the storyteller is saying that God's knowledge and understanding were better and stronger than any of the Persian kings' knowledge and understanding. Tattenai and Shethar-Bosenai did not stop the Jews from working until Tattenai and Shethar-Bosenai asked King Darius what they should do.

Stop here and tell a story where it seemed like something bad was going to happen, but something good happened instead. How did you feel during that time?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:1–5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Haggai and Zechariah give the Jews a message from God. Jeshua and Zerubbabel help the Jews start building the temple again.

In the second scene: Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai ask the Jews who gave the Jews permission to build the temple again. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai also ask the Jews for the names of the people who are building the temple.

In the third scene: God protects the Jews from having to stop building the temple. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai decide not to stop the Jews from working on the temple until Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai can talk to King Darius of Persia.

The characters in this passage are:

- Haggai
- Zechariah
- The Jews
- God
- Zerubbabel
- Jeshua
- Tattenai
- Shethar-Bozenai
- And Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai's fellow workers

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the story starts during the reign of King Darius. In the previous passage, the Jews stopped building the temple because their enemies frustrated the Jews so much. Now, in the second year of King Darius' reign as king of Persia, Haggai and Zechariah bring a message to the Jews from God.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will start this passage. What word or phrase will you use to show that this passage continues the story from the end of the previous passage? Pause this audio here.

In scene one, Haggai and Zechariah, the son of Iddo, give the Jews a message from God. It is important to know that when the storyteller says Zechariah is the son of Iddo, the storyteller means that Zechariah is from Iddo's family. Zechariah is actually Iddo's grandson. It is also important to know that the storyteller says Haggai and Zechariah spoke in the name of God. This means that Haggai and Zechariah were acting with God's power and were representing God. This is important because it means that what Haggai and Zechariah said was as important as if God had told the Jews the message himself.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about how Haggai and Zechariah speak in the name of God. Pause this audio here.

After the Jews hear God's message from Haggai and Zechariah, Jeshua and Zerubbabel start rebuilding the house of God again. The house of God is another way to say God's temple. The "prophets," or God's messengers, helped Jeshua and Zerubbabel and all the people who were working on the temple.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when you did something because someone else told you it would be a good idea. Notice the words you use to describe the order of events in your story. Pause this audio here.

In scene two, Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their fellow workers come to visit the Jews after the Jews have started building the temple again. Tattenai is the governor of the Persian province of the Trans-Euphrates, or the

"province beyond the River." Jerusalem is in this province. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai likely met the Jews in Jerusalem, where the Jews were building the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words you use for government officials who rule over a large province in your country. What do you call a government official's helpers or fellow workers? What could you call Tattenai and his fellow workers in this story? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a map of the Trans-Euphrates area again. Remind each other what you called this area in previous passages. Pause this audio here.

After Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai arrive in Jerusalem, they ask the Jews who gave them permission to start building the temple again. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai also ask for the names of the people who are working to build the temple. The storyteller records Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai's exact words to describe what Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai asked the Jews. It is important to know that Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai were probably not angry at the Jews when they asked these questions. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai were just doing their job and trying to understand what the Jews were doing in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this story, the storyteller tells the exact words Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai used when they talked with the Jews to show that they were officials who were doing an official job. The government required the men to ask these questions. How do you show in your language that the questions people ask or the things that they say are official or very important? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the storyteller states that the eye of God was on the Jews. Remember that this means that God's power and understanding were better than the Persian king's power and understanding. It also means that even though Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai could have stopped the Jews from working on the temple, God protected the Jews. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai decided to let the Jews continue to work on the temple while they asked King Darius what he wanted Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai to do.

Stop here and describe what the "eye of God" means in your own words. Notice what words you choose! What word or phrase will you use to describe the eye of God in this story? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:1–5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Haggai
- Zechariah
- The Jews
- God
- Zerubbabel
- Jeshua
- Tattenai
- Shethar-Bozenai
- And Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai's fellow workers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Haggai and Zechariah take a message from God to the Jews in Jerusalem. Jeshua and Zerubbabel hear God's message and begin to build the temple again. God's prophets, God's messengers, help the people who build God's temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My people were so excited to build my temple and worship me, but now they have stopped. I was so excited to get to be with my people again. It makes me sad that my people have not finished my temple yet; or
- I am frustrated that my people gave up building my temple. It makes me feel like other things are more important to my people than I am. That makes me sad.

Ask the people playing Haggai and Zechariah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- This message is very important because it is from God. But I am scared that the Jews are not going to like the message. What is going to happen? or
- I am excited that God is speaking to his people again! It is such a privilege to be able to serve God like this.

Ask the people playing Jeshua and Zerubbabel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I am so sorry that we did not put God first and work to finish his temple. Let's fix our mistake! or
- It is scary to start building the temple again because we do not know if King Darius will allow us to. But it is the right thing to do because we need to put God first. I pray that God protects us as we start the work.

Continue the drama.

Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers meet the Jews in Jerusalem. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai ask the Jews, "Who allowed you to build this house and to finish this structure?" and "What are the names of the men who are building this building?"

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- If the Jews finish the temple, they could want to fight the king and cause lots of trouble. Then the king might get angry at us for letting the Jews cause trouble! We need to make sure that it will not happen; or
- Oh, this is such a long way to travel just to talk to these people! I hope the trip is worth it.

Ask the people playing the Jews, Jeshua, and Zerubbabel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- It is so scary to have important people from the Persian government come to ask us questions! We know we are going against the king's orders. What if people punish us for disobeying the king's orders? What if people make us stop working on the temple? What will God do then? or
- It does not matter what the important people from Persia say or do. We must finish God's temple no matter what because God is more important.

Continue the drama.

God protects the Jews from having to stop work on the temple. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai decide not to do anything until King Darius gets their report and sends them a reply letter.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- If we make a mistake and order the Jews to do the wrong thing, the king could blame us for whatever happens. We should ask King Darius what he thinks we should do so that we do not get in trouble; or
- It does not seem like the Jews are doing anything dangerous, so we can let them continue to work. Let's just make sure that King Darius agrees with us.

Ask the people playing the Jews, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Praise God! God has protected us from getting in trouble for now, so we can keep building the temple; or
- What if King Darius does not like what we are doing? What will happen then?

Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy that my people have put me first, even if that means they have to disobey the king; or
- My people are trying so hard to obey me. I want to protect my people so that they can continue to obey my commands.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:1–5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this story, the prophets Haggai and Zechariah prophesied to the Jews in Jerusalem and Judah. A prophet is someone who gives messages from God to the people. The message could be anything that God wanted to tell his people! The message could be a warning about what will happen in the future. People did not always treat prophets well, and sometimes even tried to kill prophets!

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **prophet** and **prophesy**. Look up prophet and prophesy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Haggai and Zechariah, the **son** of Iddo, prophesied to the Jews in Jerusalem and Judah. "Son of Iddo" is another way to say **descendant** of Iddo. A person's descendants are their children, grandchildren, and all the generations of people after them from the same family line. For more information on descendant, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for descendant as you used in previous passages.

Haggai and Zechariah gave God's message to the **Jews** who were in Jerusalem. Jew is another word that refers to the Israelites, or God's people. Most people use the word Jew to refer to the Israelites who are from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin. These Israelites came back to Judah, the southern kingdom of Israel, when King Cyrus said they could come back. After these Israelites came back to Judah, most people began calling all of God's special people Jews. Use the same word or phrase for Jews as you used in previous passages. For more information on Jew, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Jews lived in **Jerusalem**, which is in the area of **Judah**. The area of land called Judah is the area of land God gave the Israelite tribe of Judah hundreds of years before King Cyrus told the Jews they could return to their homeland. For more information on Jerusalem and Judah, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for Jerusalem and Judah as you used in previous passages.

Haggai and Zechariah gave God's message to the Israelites in Jerusalem "in the name of the **God** of **Israel**." This means that Haggai and Zechariah spoke for God. The message that Haggai and Zechariah gave the Israelites had the same power and importance as if God had spoken it directly to the Israelites himself. In other words, when Haggai and Zechariah spoke "in the name of the God of Israel," it meant that Haggai and Zechariah represented God and spoke with the same authority as God when they gave the Israelites God's message. [God is the general term for God who created the world. Israel refers to the descendants of Jacob. Use the same words for God and Israel when referring to the phrase "God of Israel." For more information on God and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.]{.mark}

[Stop here and discuss how you will translate the phrase **in the name of the God of Israel**. If you have translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.]{.mark}

Ezra 5:1–5

After hearing God's message, Zerubbabel and Jeshua start building the **house of God**. The house of God is another term for God's **temple**. It is the place on earth where God meets his people. The house of God is where God lived on earth with his people in the Old Testament. Use the same word or phrase for "house of God" or temple that you used in previous passages. For more information on the house of God and temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Tattenai was an important Persian who came to Israel to talk with the Israelites. Tattenai was a **governor** of a part of eastern Persia. A governor is someone who represents the king in a small area of the kingdom. When a king rules a very large area of land, the king cannot rule all the people himself because it would be too much for one person to handle. A governor rules a small part of the kingdom but is still under the rule of the king. A governor will take care of small problems himself and bring bigger problems to the king. This way, the king can focus only on the big problems of the kingdom. Use the same word or phrase for governor as you used in Ezra 2:63.

Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai arrived in Israel with **their fellow workers**. These are men who work a similar job to Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai. It probably means that Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai arrived in Jerusalem along with other people who helped rule Persia but who were not as important as Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai.

Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai asked the Israelites who gave them an **order** to build the temple. An order is a command that often comes from kings or rulers and that tells the people what to do or what not to do. In this case, Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai are asking the Israelites who gave them the order to start work on the temple again. Use the same word or phrase for order as you used in previous passages.

The storyteller describes that the eye of their God was on the elders of the Jews. This phrase means that God was watching over his people and protecting them. It is supposed to be a good thing because God is taking care of his people.

Stop here and remind each other how you chose to say "**the eye of their God**" in step three. Pause this audio here.

The elders were important people in the Israelite community because the elders led the community. An elder was often the head of an important family or group of families.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **elders**. Look up elders in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Persian men did not stop the Israelites from working on the temple until their report reached King Darius. A report is a description of someone's experience at an event. Normally, reports are very official and formal.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "**report**." If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

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Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 5:1–5

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (605 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

Ezra 5:6–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 5:6–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:6–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:6–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, Jeshua and Zerubbabel led the Jews as they started to build God's temple again. Two Persian government officials and their fellow workers, named Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai, questioned the Jews. The men sent a letter to King Darius, the king of Persia, to ask Darius what to do. In this story, the storyteller describes the letter that Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai sent to King Darius.

Remember, Tattenai was the governor of the province of Trans-Euphrates, or the "province beyond the River," and the men who came with Tattenai worked in the same province. Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the group of leaders with them all sent a message to King Darius in Persia. The men wrote the message to King Darius to explain what the Jews were doing and to ask the king's advice.

Stop here and look at a map of the Trans-Euphrates area as a group. Pause this audio here.

Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai start their message to King Darius with a formal and respectful greeting.

Stop here and divide yourselves into a few groups. Greet each other and pretend to be different people in different situations. For example, pretend to be friends who are seeing each other for the first time in a long time. What

Ezra 5:6–17

would you say or do? You could also be people meeting each other to discuss business plans. What would you say or do then? Pause this audio here.

After they greet the king, Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their co-workers explain to the king what they saw in Jerusalem. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai send their message to the king very properly. In their report, Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai do not explain what they think about what the Jews are doing. Instead, the men only tell the king the facts about what happened.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how does a government leader write or speak to another leader who is more important than he is? Pretend that you are describing something that happened in your area to a high government official. Practice sharing that description with each other. Pause the audio here.

In their letter, Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men explain to King Darius that they traveled to Jerusalem to see the house of the great God. The men describe that the Jews are using big, polished stones and wood beams to build the temple's walls. Tattenai and his co-workers tell King Darius that the Jews are very careful as they work on the temple and that the Jews are making a lot of progress!

Stop here and have one person in the group describe a time when they saw people build an important building. Have everyone else in the group listen closely and notice how that person describes the building they saw. Pause this audio here.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men also report to King Darius about how they talked to the Jews. Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men explain that they asked the Jewish leaders who gave the Jews permission to work on the temple. Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the men also asked the Jewish elders for the names of the people who were working on the temple.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials also tell King Darius how the Jews answered the questions that Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men asked the Jewish elders. The Jews explained that they are the "God of heaven and earth's servants," which is a way to say that the Jews work for their God, the one who created heaven and earth. The Jews tell Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other leaders that the Jews are rebuilding the temple that a great Israelite king built many centuries before this story. The great king the Jews mention is King Solomon. The Jews do not say King Solomon's name because the Persians would not know who King Solomon was.

The Jews also explain to Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other leaders that the Jews made the God of heaven angry. Because the God of heaven was angry with the Jews, the God of heaven allowed King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon to capture the Jews and destroy King Solomon's temple. In their letter, Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai point out that King Nebuchadnezzar was a Chaldean. The Chaldeans were a family of people who lived in the southern part of the Babylonian kingdom.

And yet, even though many terrible events happened to the Jews a few years before this story, King Cyrus of Babylon decided to let the Jews return to Jerusalem in the first year of his time ruling Babylon.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when someone gave you something you did not feel like you deserved or that you had wanted for a long time. How did that make you feel? Pause this audio here.

The Jews also point out that King Cyrus gave the Jews permission to rebuild the house of God. King Cyrus also gave all the gold and silver items that King Nebuchadnezzar had taken from God's first temple to a Jew named Sheshbazzar. Sheshbazzar worked as a governor like Tattenai. Sheshbazzar helped the Jews build God's new temple. It is also important to know that the temple in Babylon that Sheshbazzar took the special items from is not a temple for God. When King Nebuchadnezzar took the items from the house of God, Nebuchadnezzar put the items in a temple to one of the Babylonian gods. When Sheshbazzar took the items back to Israel, he had to take them out of the temple for the Babylonian gods.

To finish their message to King Darius, Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials ask King Darius to have his servants look for a record of King Cyrus' orders. The servants look for the record in a royal archive. A royal archive was a special place where a king would store important documents and histories of the kingdom so that the kings could remember the events that happened even before the king started ruling. King Darius wanted to

find King Cyrus' orders so that he could make sure that the Jews were telling the truth. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai ask King Darius to tell them what the king thinks they should do.

Stop here and discuss these questions as a group: In your culture, where do people go to understand information from the past? What people in your community are responsible for preserving the history of your culture? How do you keep this information safe?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:6–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their fellow workers sent a letter to report back to King Darius.

In the second scene: Tattenai and his fellow workers explain how the Jews are building God's temple. The men also tell King Darius that they have talked to the Jews to gather information from them as well.

In the third scene: Tattenai and his fellow workers tell King Darius what the Jews told Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai. The Jews explain how King Nebuchadnezzar destroyed God's first temple and how the Jews began to rebuild the new temple.

In the fourth scene: Tattenai and his fellow workers ask King Darius to make sure the Jews are telling the truth. The men also ask the king to tell the men what to do.

The characters in this passage are:

- Tattenai
- Shethar-Bozenai
- The other officials
- The Jewish leaders
- King Darius
- King Nebuchadnezzar
- And King Cyrus

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the storyteller starts by explaining that Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other Persian officials are Persian leaders who governed "Trans-Euphrates," or the province beyond the River. Trans-Euphrates included Judah and Jerusalem. The rest of the story is a copy of the message that Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials sent to King Darius of Persia. It is important to know that Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the others wrote the letter in a traditional, official way. This means that the men only told King Darius facts. Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the others do not give King Darius their feelings or opinions about the events they are talking about.

In scene two, the storyteller begins Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials' message to the king. The men start their message by greeting King Darius with the word "Peace." This is a very polite and formal phrase to say hello to King Darius because King Darius is an important person. Some people think that the phrase the men use could be a short version of a longer greeting people used to say hello during the time of this story. This greeting was a traditional way to greet someone officially and respectfully. When Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai use this greeting, they tell the king that they hope the king is doing well and has a peaceful rule.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you translate the greeting in this letter so that people will understand that the letter was written to an important person? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials very carefully explain everything that the Jews have done in Jerusalem so far. The men first explain that they traveled to visit the place where the Jews are building the house of the great God, which is the temple. It is important to know that the Persian people did

Ezra 5:6–17

not believe that Yahweh, the God of the Jews, was the only God or that Yahweh was the most powerful God. The Persians probably called God's temple the "house of the great God" because they were trying to show that they respected God, the Jewish God, even if the Persians did not obey God the same way the Jews did.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when you did something you did not have to do to show respect to someone. How did that person respond? How will you translate the "house of the Great God" in a way that shows that the officials try to show respect to the Jewish God? Pause this audio here.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials explain how the Jews are building the temple. The men tell King Darius that the Jews are using large cut stones and logs of wood to build the temple walls. Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials notice that the Jews are working carefully and well and are making a lot of progress. After the Persian officials notice the Jews' progress on God's temple, they ask the Jews who gave the Jews permission to work on the temple, and they ask for the names of the people who are working on the project.

Stop here and tell a story about someone in your community who does their work very well and is very productive. Notice the words you use to describe this person and their work. Pause this audio here.

In scene four, Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men tell King Darius the exact words the Jews used to answer the officials' questions. First, the Jews explained who they are. The Jews told Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men that they are the servants of the God of heaven and earth. When the Jews called God the "God of heaven and earth," the Jews were saying that their God created the heavens and earth and that God rules over the heavens and earth. It is important to know that the Persians believed that their important god, Ahuramazda, created the heavens and earth.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the phrase "God of heaven and earth." Pause this audio here.

Next, the Jews explained that they are trying to rebuild God's temple, which a great Israelite king had built many years before this story. Then, the Jews explained that many years before this story, their families had made God angry. Because God was angry, God gave the Jews into the hands of King Nebuchadnezzar. In other words, God allowed King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon to capture the Jews and destroy the temple.

Stop here and tell a story to the group. In this section of the story, there are many events that happen one after another. Tell a story about a time in your life when many things happened to you suddenly. Notice the words you use to explain the order of events. Pause this audio here.

Next, the Jews explained that in the first year of King Cyrus of Babylon's reign, King Cyrus commanded the Jews to rebuild God's temple. The Jews also pointed out that King Cyrus had commanded the governor Sheshbazzar to take all the important gold and silver "vessels" or articles that were in the first Jewish temple and bring them to Judah again. Many of the events Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai discuss in their letter to King Darius happen at the beginning of Ezra. You may want to refer back to the first stories in Ezra to remember everything that happened. When the Persian officials tell King Darius about what King Cyrus said, they use words that mean that King Cyrus commanded the Jews to rebuild the temple and take the important silver and gold items from the first temple back with them. This is important because when a king orders someone to do something, the king's words have more power than if the king just gave the person permission. The Jews were probably trying to make the Persian officials understand that the Persians should not stop the Jews from building God's temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what words do you use to tell someone you are ordering them to do something? How do you know when someone is telling you that you must do something and not asking you to do it? Pause this audio here.

Finally, the Jews who talked to Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials explained that the governor Sheshbazzar came to Jerusalem to build the temple as King Cyrus had commanded him to. In Jerusalem, Sheshbazzar helped to build the foundation of the temple on the same spot as the foundation for the first temple, just as King Cyrus had commanded him to. Remember, a foundation is the base of a building that keeps the building strong. The Jews told Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men that the Jews had been working on the temple ever since then.

In scene five, Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials finish their message by giving recommendations to King Darius. The men ask the king respectfully when they say, “If it seems good to the king.”

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the phrase, “If it seems good to the king.” In your culture, how would you respectfully ask a leader to do something? Pause this audio here.

Now that the Persian officials have told King Darius everything that has happened in Judah with the Jews, the men ask the king to make sure that the Jews are telling the truth. It is important to know that Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men are not ordering King Darius to make sure that the Jews are telling the truth. Instead, the Persian officials are asking the king to look through the kingdom’s important documents in the royal archive to make sure that King Cyrus’ order exists. Remember, a royal archive is a place that a ruler would use to save important records of the history of the kingdom. Finally, Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men finish the letter by asking King Darius to tell the men what to do.

Stop here and remember as a group how you talked about royal archives in previous passages. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:6–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Tattenai
- Shethar-Bozenai
- The other leaders
- The Jewish leaders
- King Darius
- King Nebachadnezzar
- And King Cyrus

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In scene one, the people playing Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their fellow workers begin writing a letter to King Darius. The men greet King Darius in their letter.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We do not want to make the king angry if we do the wrong thing. Let’s message the king so he can tell us what to do; or

- I am happy to be doing my job. I want to make sure that the king has all the information he needs to run his kingdom smoothly.

Continue the drama.

In scene two, the people playing Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men tell King Darius about their visit to Judah. Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the men explain that they visited the house of the great God and watched the Jews use big stones and wood logs to build the temple walls. Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men also ask the Jewish leaders who gave the Jews permission to build the temple and ask for the names of the people working on the project.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I want to make sure the king has all the true facts about what happened here. I am proud that my job is to tell the king important information. I want to do my job well for the king; or
- If the Jews are going to be troublemakers when they finish the temple, we must stop the work now! The king needs to know all the facts to make a wise decision.

Continue the drama.

In scene three, the people playing Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials tell King Darius how the Jews responded to the men's questions. The men explain that the Jews talked about their first temple, how King Nebuchadnezzar captured the Jews because the Jews' God was angry with the Jews, and King Cyrus' order to rebuild God's temple. The Jews also tell how King Cyrus ordered Sheshbazzar to take the special gold and silver articles from Babylon back to God's temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I had no idea the Jews experienced so many things! or
- It is good that I am telling the king about what the Jews are doing in Israel because they have experienced a lot of crazy events. I have no idea what the Jews will do when the temple is finished!

Ask the people playing the Jewish leaders, "What are you feeling or thinking? The people might answer things like:

- We cannot stop building God's temple. These Persian men must understand that they cannot stop us! King Cyrus himself has ordered us to finish this project; or
- I am so grateful that we have King Cyrus' protection for this project. King Cyrus made sure we could do so many important things.

Continue the drama.

In scene four, the people playing Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials ask King Darius to make sure that the Jews are telling the truth. The men suggest that King Darius have some of his servants search the royal archives to make sure that King Cyrus really did order the Jews to build the temple. Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men also ask King Darius to tell them what to do with the Jews.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We have given the king all the information we can. We trust the king to make the best choice about how to treat the Jews; or
- The Jews could be lying so that they can build their temple and cause lots of trouble later. We must make sure that does not happen.

Ask the person playing King Darius, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai have done their job well. These men have given me all the information I need to make a good decision; or
- Hmmm, this is a hard situation, and I do not want to handle it wrong. It could cause lots of problems for me and my kingdom if I do!

Ezra 5:6–17

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 5:6–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials wrote King Darius a **letter**. Remember, a letter is a way some people send a message to others. One person will write words on paper or animal skin, and another person can read that message. Use the same word or phrase for letter as you used in previous passages.

Tattenai was a Persian **governor**. Remember, a governor is a special person who helps to run a kingdom. A governor is not as important as a king, but a governor will help the king rule small parts of the kingdom. Use the same word or phrase for governor as you used in previous passages.

Tattenai was a governor of a **province** that was west of the Euphrates River. A province is an area in a big kingdom. In the story, the storyteller is saying that Tattenai was a governor of an area called the **Trans-Euphrates**, or the "province beyond the River." This province includes Jerusalem and all of Judah. Use the same word or phrase for Trans-Euphrates as you used in previous passages.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their **fellow workers** wrote a message to King Darius to tell the king about the Jews. Remember, when someone is a fellow worker, it means that they do a similar job to someone else. This means that Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials' fellow workers were people who also worked for King Darius but were likely less important. Use the same word or phrase for fellow workers as you did in previous passages.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men wrote a message to Darius the **king** of Persia. A king is someone who rules over a group of people. Kings can rule over a lot of people or just a few people. Some kings, like King Darius, ruled over a lot of people over a very big area of land. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials wrote a message to King Darius to give him a **report** about what the Jews were doing in the province of **Judah**. A report is a description of someone's experience at an event. Normally, reports are very official and formal. Use the same word or phrase for report and for Judah as you used in previous passages. For more information about Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other men tell King Darius that they traveled to Judah to visit the house of the great God. This **house of God** is another phrase for the temple. It is the place where God can meet his people on earth. For more information on "house of God," refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for "house of God" as you used in previous passages.

The Persian officials tell King Darius that they visited the house of the great **God**. In the Bible, God refers to God who is powerful and created the whole world. It is the same God who made promises to Abraham. God is also the same God that the Jews have worshipped for many centuries. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials say that the Jews used timber to build God's temple walls. Timber is wood that someone has cut and prepared to use to build something.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **timber**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials explain that they talked with the Israelite **elders** about the Jews building God's temple. An elder is an important member of the community. Normally, elders are leaders in the community and are often the heads of important families. For more information on elders, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for elder as you used in previous passages.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials asked the Israelite elders who gave them an **order** to build God's temple. An order is a command from an important leader, like a king. An order can be a way for a leader to give another person permission to do something. Use the same word or phrase for order as you used in previous passages.

Ezra 5:6–17

The Jews tell Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials that they are **servants** of the God of heaven and earth. A servant is a person who does work for someone else. Servants may work in the house or in the fields of their master. Servants usually have a low position in the community. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages.

The Jews explain to Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials that the Jews are servants of the "God of heaven and earth." The God of heaven and earth is the same God who made promises to Abraham and whom the Jews have worshiped for many centuries. By saying the God of heaven and earth in this story, the Jews are emphasizing that God created everything and rules over everything with power. Remember, heaven is the place where God lives and is also another word for the skies! For more information on heaven, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **God of heaven and earth**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Jews also tell Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials that a great king of **Israel** built God's first temple. In this story, Israel refers to the land that God had given to his special people, the descendants of Jacob, who were also called Israel. This great king built this temple when the people of Israel were united in one kingdom. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Israel that you used in previous passages.

The Jews explain that King Cyrus commanded Sheshbazzar to take the gold and silver **vessels**, or **articles**, back to God's temple that King Nebuchadnezzar took from Israel several years before this story. Vessels are cups, pots, and other kinds of containers. People often use vessels to hold things like water or other kinds of liquids. Use the same word or phrase for vessels, or articles, as you used in previous passages.

King Cyrus commanded the Jews to take God's special cups or articles from the **temple** in Babylon and put them in God's new temple in Jerusalem. A temple is a place people go to worship God. The temple in Babylon was a place to worship the false Babylonian gods. God's temple in Jerusalem was a temple to worship God, the one, true God. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for temple as you used in previous passages.

Sheshbazzar laid the **foundations** of the new temple. Remember, foundation refers to the base of a building. Use the same word or phrase for foundation as you used in previous passages.

Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and the other officials ask King Darius to search the **royal archives** for King Cyrus' order to let the Jews build their temple. Archives are often real places or buildings where people keep important information. The important information can often be stories about what has happened to the kingdom in the past. Some people will also keep valuable treasure or money in archives. A royal archive is an archive that belongs to a king or a kingdom.

Use the same word or phrase for archives as you used in Ezra 4:15. Here, the storyteller used the word for "royal archives." The storyteller makes it clear that these are special archives that the king keeps his records of the history of his kingdom.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 5:6–17

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (642 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (994 KB)

Ezra 6:1–12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 6:1–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:1–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Remember, in the last story, Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their co-workers sent a message to King Darius to tell the king all about the Jews building the house of the great God in Jerusalem. The men asked King Darius to look in the royal records to see if King Cyrus really did command the Jews to build the temple again. In this story, the storyteller explains how King Darius answered Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their co-workers.

At the beginning of the story, King Darius commanded his people to look in the royal archives or records to find King Cyrus' order after Darius heard Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai's message. The king's servants completed this search throughout the whole kingdom. The king often put the royal archives in the same place as the royal treasury. In Babylon, many kings wrote important information on clay tablets or scrolls that people made from soft materials like animal skins and put in special rooms across their kingdom until people needed to look at them. King Darius ordered his people to look through these special rooms to see if people had made a "record," or written down, that King Cyrus commanded the Jews to build the new temple for God.

Ezra 6:1–12

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture store the records of important historical events? Pause this audio here.

In a city called Ecbatana, King Darius' people find the scroll that contains King Cyrus' command to build God's temple! Ecbatana is an important city because the Persian kings lived in a palace there during the summer every year. Throughout the year, the Persian king would live in different palaces throughout his kingdom. Ecbatana is a city in an area with lots of mountains. The Persian kings probably lived in Ecbatana in the summer because the weather was cooler near the mountains. Ecbatana was the capital city of Media, another province of the Persian kingdom. A capital city is an important city from which a ruler often lives and rules the kingdom. Capital cities are often very strong and secure to protect the ruler and other important leaders from attack.

Stop here and look at a map of Media with Ecbatana. Also, tell a story to the group about the strongest leader in your community. Where did that leader live? What was that place like? Pause this audio here.

During the time of this story, kings would not actually write their orders themselves. Instead, the kings would have servants called scribes write the king's orders. The scribe who wrote King Cyrus' command explains that King Cyrus made the order in the first year that Cyrus was king. King Cyrus commanded that the Jews rebuild the house of God in Jerusalem. King Cyrus orders that the house of God should be 60 cubits tall and 60 cubits wide. People used cubits to measure distance. A cubit was about the distance from a person's wrist to their elbow. The measurements King Cyrus gives the Jews make the house of God about 27 meters tall and 27 meters wide. However, the first temple the Jews built for God was 27 meters long, 9 meters wide, and 13 meters tall. Some people think King Cyrus tells the Jews how big to make the temple so that the Jews know how many building materials King Cyrus will pay for.

Stop here and gather a group of objects together. Measure the objects using your arms as the measuring device, just like the Jews did. Pause this audio here.

According to his decree, King Cyrus also commanded the Jews to build the house of God with stones and wood layered on top of each other. King Cyrus promises that he will use the kingdom's money to pay the workers and buy the materials for the house of God. Finally, King Cyrus commands the Jews to take all the articles of gold and silver that Nebuchadnezzar had removed from the temple back home with them to Judah. The king commands the Jews to put the special articles back into the house of God.

Stop here and tell a story to the group of a time you really wanted to do something, and you had to wait a long time. How did you feel when you were finally able to do it? Pause this audio here.

Next in his message, King Darius tells Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai to stay away from the Jews and not stop the governor of the Jews and the Jewish elders from working on the house of God. King Darius also commands that the Israelite leader and elders build the house of God on the same spot that the Jews built the first house of God many years before this story. The Jewish governor is probably Zerubbabel since Cyrus appointed Zerubbabel as governor, and Darius later confirmed that appointment.

King Darius also gives Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai instructions on how to help the Jews build the house of God. King Darius commands Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai to pay for the building expenses from money in the royal treasury, from tribute or taxes that the king's servants collected in the provinces. Tribute is money that people who live in King Darius' kingdom give to King Darius as a way to show the king that they are loyal to him and his rule as king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this story, people would pay the king money to live in the king's kingdom. What responsibilities do you have to your leaders in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Not only does King Darius promise to pay for the Jews' expenses, but Darius also commands Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai to give the Jewish priests everything that they need to make daily burnt offerings to God: the bulls, rams, sheep, wheat, salt, wine, and oil. All these supplies were common animals and foods to the Jews. A bull was a male cow that was often three years old. Rams were adult male sheep. When King Darius mentions sheep, he probably meant baby sheep, or lambs. Wheat is the common grain that the Jews used to make bread and other foods. Wine is a common drink that the Jews made from grapes. People probably made the oil from olives, which was a very common oil for the Jews.

Stop here and look at pictures of rams, sheep, bulls, grain, wine, and oil—what the Jews received from King Darius for God's sacrifices. Discuss this question as a group: What animals and foods do you depend on? What makes these things special? Pause this audio here.

King Darius tells Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their co-workers that they must make sure the Jews have all the animals and things that the Jews need for their burnt offerings every day. King Darius also mentions that he will help the Jews to build the temple and to sacrifice to God because Darius hopes the Jews will ask their God of heaven to give King Darius and his sons a long, happy life. During his rule, King Darius helped people in other parts of his kingdom also rebuild the temples to their false gods. Many people believe King Darius helped build temples to other gods because he wanted to make sure that those gods were happy with Darius. Those gods were not real, but King Darius did not know that. Some people believe that King Darius helped the Jews to build the house of God so that God would be happy with Darius.

Stop here and tell a story to the group of a time when you did something for someone else just so they would be happy with you. Pause this audio here.

Finally, King Darius finishes his message to Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their co-workers by telling them that Darius would punish them and curse anyone who does not obey King Darius' commands. It was very normal for kings to end their commands with a curse and a punishment for anyone who tried to disobey the king's orders. King Darius orders that the king's servants will take anyone who tries to change or disobey King Darius' commands and will impale that person with a large piece of wood from the person's house. Kings in the time of this story regularly impaled the people that they punished, so many people would know what King Darius was threatening to do to the people who disobey his orders. When a king impaled someone, a king's servant would sharpen one end of a piece of wood and stick the other end firmly into the ground. Then, the king's servant would stab the middle part of the person who disobeyed with the sharp end of the wood. The king's servants would then leave that person to hang from the piece of wood until that person died.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do leaders in your community do to punish people who dishonor or disobey the leader? Pause the audio here.

King Darius also commands that the king's servants will make the disobedient person's house into a pile of trash. During the time of this story, it was a very bad thing if someone turned something you owned into a trash pile. This made the thing worthless and took away its importance or status.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your culture punish people who have disobeyed the community's important people? Pause this audio here.

King Darius finally says that he wishes God would curse or cause bad things to happen to anyone who tries to change King Darius' order. This was a common thing to say in King Darius' time. People would use the name of a god or someone who was much more powerful than themselves to wish bad things on anyone who tried to hurt them. King Darius finishes by ordering that Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their co-workers obey Darius' commands quickly and thoroughly.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: King Darius' servants search the royal records to find King Cyrus' command to rebuild the house of God. King Darius' servants find King Cyrus' command in one of the king's record rooms in Ecbatana.

In the second scene: The storyteller explains what King Cyrus' order said. King Cyrus ordered the Jews to rebuild the house of God, explained how big to make the temple, promised to pay all of the Jews' expenses, and commanded that the Jews take all of God's special vessels of gold and silver back to the house of God in Jerusalem.

In the third scene: King Darius commands Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai to let the Jews continue to build the house of God. King Darius promises to pay for the Jews' expenses and to provide the Jews with all they need to make daily sacrifices to God.

In the fourth scene: King Darius threatens to punish anyone who disobeys Darius' orders and tries to stop the Jews.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Darius
- King Darius' servants
- The Jews
- Tattenai
- Shethar-Bozenai
- Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai's co-workers
- And King Cyrus

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, once King Darius receives Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their co-workers' message, King Darius orders his servants to look in all the archive rooms where they kept the kingdom's scrolls and records. The king used these rooms to put records until the king needed the records again.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Remember your discussion in the last step about how your culture stores important records. Discuss as a group how you will translate the idea of royal archives. Pause this audio here.

The king's servants find King Cyrus' order in King Darius' record room in Ecbatana. The record room is in a stronghold building that the Persian kings would live in during the summer. Remember that King Cyrus' scribes wrote King Cyrus' order on a scroll. In this case, a stronghold is a big, strong building or group of buildings. Strongholds often had big, strong walls that surrounded them and kept enemies out.

Stop here and look at the map of Media with Ecbatana on it again if needed. Discuss as a group how you will translate the idea of a stronghold, or a strong place for a king to live. Pause this audio here.

Next, in scene two, the storyteller describes what King Cyrus' order says. In his letter to the governors, King Darius repeats some of the exact words from King Cyrus' order.

Stop here and tell a story to the group about a conversation you had with a friend. Discuss how you would talk about summarizing or only describing the part of the story that relates to your friend. Pause this audio here.

King Cyrus begins his order by stating that he made the order in his first year of being king. Then, King Cyrus commands that the Jews must rebuild the house of God, the place where the Jews made sacrifices to God, on the foundation of the first house of God that the Israelites built many years before this story. The king also commands the Jews to build the temple to be 60 cubits high and 60 cubits wide. Remember that 60 cubits is about 27 meters.

Stop here and discuss as a group what measurements you will use for a cubit. Pause this audio here.

King Cyrus also orders the Jews to use three layers of stones and one layer of wood over the stones to make the temple's walls. Then King Cyrus promises that he will use money from the royal treasury to cover the cost of the building project. This means that the Jews do not have to pay for the project all on their own. In the original language, the royal treasury means "from the house of the king." It is important to know that this does not mean the place where the king lives. Instead, it is the place where a king keeps the kingdom's money. Lastly, King Cyrus orders that the Jews take all the special gold and silver cups and dishes that King Nebuchadnezzar took from God's first temple. King Cyrus orders that the Jews take these things back to Jerusalem and put them back in the house of God.

Stop here and tell a story to the group about a time when someone made a lot of promises to you. Notice the words and phrases you use to describe what happened. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the storyteller uses a phrase to tell the listeners that he has finished quoting from King Cyrus' order and that King Darius is now commanding his people.

Stop here and tell a story to the group where you quote one set of instructions and then continue with instructions from someone else. Notice how the storyteller shows the audience that someone new is talking. Pause this audio here.

King Darius orders Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their co-workers to keep away from the work and not to stop the Jewish leaders and elders from finishing building the house of God. Next, King Darius also promises that he will continue to pay for the Jews to finish building the house of God, as King Cyrus did before him. King Darius will pay the Jews using the "tribute," or revenues, of the kingdom. Remember, the tribute, or revenues, is the money the people in King Darius' kingdom would pay King Darius to live in his kingdom and to promise to be loyal to him as king.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the idea of tribute and revenues. Pause this audio here.

Finally, King Darius promises to give the Jews all the animals, grains, oils, and supplies that they need to make daily burnt offerings to God because Darius hopes that the Jews will pray that King Darius and his sons have a long, happy life.

Lastly, in scene four, King Darius commands that one of his servants will "impale" anyone who tries to stop the Jews from building God's temple or who changes King Darius' commands. To impale a person means to stab that person in the middle part of their body with a large wooden beam from their own house.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the idea of impalement. Pause this audio here.

After the disobedient person died, the king's servants would also turn the disobedient person's house into a pile of trash. Next, King Darius curses anyone who disobeys his commands or destroys the house of God by saying that God, who "causes his Name to live there," will defeat anyone who disobeys King Darius. When King Darius says that God causes his Name to live in the temple, it means that King Darius is recognizing that the Jewish temple belongs to God. It shows that King Darius recognizes that God chose Jerusalem as the place where the Jews must worship God.

Also, King Darius threatens to punish anyone who "lifts his hand" to change King Darius' commands. To lift your hand to do something is a symbolic way to say that you are starting a task or project. King Darius is saying that he will punish anyone who dares to change his commands.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about King Darius punishing anyone who lifts his hand to change King Darius' commands. Pause this audio here.

After King Darius has explained the punishments for a person's disobedience, King Darius orders all his servants to carry out his orders thoroughly and completely.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Darius
- King Darius' servants
- The Jews
- Tattenai
- Shethar-Bozenai
- Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai's co-workers
- And King Cyrus

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

Ezra 6:1–12

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

King Darius orders the king's servants to look in the royal archives in Babylonia for King Cyrus' command to rebuild the house of God in Jerusalem. The servants find King Cyrus' order in the fortress in Ecbatana!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Darius, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The Israelites were not lying! I want to make sure that the Israelites do not get mad at me and rebel against my rule; or
- I hope King Cyrus did not promise the Israelites too much! I do not want to have to give the Israelites a lot of my stuff.

Continue the drama.

Next, King Darius and his servants read the scroll, on which someone had written a record of King Cyrus' decree to rebuild the house of God on the same spot the Israelites had built the first house of God. King Cyrus ordered the Jews to build God's temple and promised them all the money they needed to finish the project. King Cyrus also promised to return God's special vessels for the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Darius, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- King Cyrus promised a lot! If I do not keep King Cyrus' promises, though, the Israelites might get angry and try to rebel against me. I cannot let that happen! or
- King Cyrus did the right thing. All my people should be able to worship their gods. That way, people will not get angry with me and cause too many problems!

Continue the drama.

Then, King Darius orders that Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai must stay away from the Jews and let the Jews build the house of God. King Darius also promises to give the Jews all the money they need for the project and all the animals, oil, grain, and supplies that the Jews need to make burnt offerings to their God.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Darius, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- If I help the Jews to build their temple, maybe their God will be happy with me and make me wealthier and give me more good things; or
- I want to make sure that the Jews have more than they need so that they do not get mad at me and my servants for almost stopping their work.

Ask the people playing Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so glad we asked King Darius what we should do about the Jews! I had no idea he was going to tell us to do all this; or
- I think King Darius is making a mistake. I think the Jews are going to become troublemakers when they finish the temple. We cannot help them do that! or
- King Darius knows the best thing to do. We just must trust Darius' plans.

Ask the people playing the Jews, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- God is so good! We thought for sure that we were going to have to stop building God’s temple when Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai arrived here. God has provided so that we can keep building! or
- King Darius is so generous. We are so thankful that King Darius promised to pay for our building costs. It is so helpful! or
- I am glad King Darius promised to help us again. King Darius needs to do it! It is right for King Darius to help us since King Cyrus promised to help us.

Continue the drama.

Finally, King Darius commands that his servants will impale anyone who disobeys King Darius’ orders. People will make that person’s house a pile of trash. Then, King Darius says, “May God, who has caused his Name to live there, conquer any king or people who try to change this decree I have made, or who tries to destroy the temple in Jerusalem.”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Darius, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I must make sure that people understand that they cannot disobey me! I am too powerful; or
- The Israelites are building a temple to God. If someone disobeys my commands and stops the Israelites from building the temple, their God might get mad at me. I must make sure that everyone is scared to disobey me so that God never gets mad!

Ask the people playing the Jews, Tattenai, and Shethar-Bozenai, “What are you thinking or feeling?” The people might answer things like:

- Oh no! King Darius has given a terrible punishment for disobeying him. I never want to disobey him so that I never have to experience King Darius’ punishment! or
- I am glad that King Darius gives a terrible punishment for anyone who tries to stop us from building God’s temple. Maybe that means we can build God’s temple in peace!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Darius, the **king** of Persia, made an **order** for his servants to search the **archives** to find King Cyrus’ orders. A king is someone who rules over a group of people. An order is a command from an important leader, like a king. An order can also be a way for a leader to give another person permission to do something. Also, remember that archives are real places where people keep important information. The important information can often be stories about what has happened to the kingdom in the past. Some people will also keep valuable treasures or money in archives. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for king, order, and archives as you used in previous passages.

King Darius found King Cyrus’ order in Ecbatana, which is a **stronghold** or fortress in Media. A stronghold can be the capital of the kingdom when the king is living and ruling from that stronghold. A stronghold, in this case, is a very strong building that kings often build to protect the people of the kingdom when an enemy attacks. Kings and their servants often build strongholds in a special way to protect them. Often, a stronghold will have big, thick stone walls or lots of soldiers to protect the area. A stronghold can also be a place where a king will live while he rules the people in the kingdom. For more information on stronghold, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for stronghold. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Darius’ servants found King Cyrus’ order on a scroll in Ecbatana. A scroll is a piece of paper or animal skin that people have made writing marks all over. Once people have written on the scroll, they roll it up to protect and store it. People in this story used scrolls to record important events and write messages to other people.

Ezra 6:1–12

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **scroll**. For more information about scroll, refer to the Master Glossary. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Cyrus wrote his order about the **house of God** in Jerusalem. "House of God" is another phrase for **temple**. It is the place where God can meet his people on earth. For more information on God, house of God, and temple, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God and "house of God" as you used in previous passages.

King Cyrus refers to the house of God as the place where the Jews made **sacrifices** to God. A sacrifice is a gift to God. The purpose of a sacrifice could be that people wanted to thank God for something, worship God, confirm their relationship with God, or ask forgiveness for something they had done wrong. When a person made a sacrifice, it might mean that people killed an animal and then burned the animal on an altar. But the gift could also be food items, oil, or sweet-smelling spices. For more information on sacrifices, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sacrifices as you used in previous passages.

In his order, King Cyrus commanded the Jews to build on the **foundations** of the old house of God. A foundation is the base of a building. People build a foundation first, before people build the rest of the building, to make the building stable and strong for a long time. The Jews often used large stones to make a building's foundation strong. Use the same word or phrase for foundations as you used in previous passages.

King Cyrus gives the measurements for the new temple in **cubits**. People often used cubits to measure distance in the time of this story. For more information on cubits, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and decide as a group if you will use cubits or meters in this story. Pause this audio here.

King Cyrus ordered the Jews to build God's temple using big stones and **timber**. Timber is a large log of wood that people often use to build buildings. Use the same word or phrase for timber as you used in previous passages.

King Cyrus promised the Jews that he would pay for the expenses to rebuild God's temple from the royal treasury. Remember, the royal treasury is a place where a king keeps the kingdom's money.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **royal treasury**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Cyrus ordered the Jews to take all the gold and silver **articles**, or **vessels** that were originally from the house of God in Jerusalem, back to the new temple in Jerusalem. Vessels are cups, pots, and other kinds of containers. People often use vessels to hold things like water or other kinds of liquids. The vessels that the Jews took back to Jerusalem were special because they were vessels that the priests used in the house of God. Use the same word or phrase for vessels or articles as you used in previous passages.

King Darius refers to Tattenai as a **governor** of the **Trans-Euphrates**, or the "**province beyond the River**." Remember, a governor is a special person who helps to run a province, or a small portion of a kingdom. A governor is not as important as a king, but a governor will help the king rule small parts of the kingdom. In the story, the storyteller is saying that Tattenai was a governor of an area of the kingdom that was west of the Euphrates River. Use the same word or phrase for governor and province as you used in previous passages. Also, use the same name for the "province beyond the River," or "Trans-Euphrates," as you used in previous passages.

When King Darius gives Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai orders, King Darius mentions the governor of the **Jews**. Most people use the word "Jew" to refer to the Jews and their children who came back to Judah with King Cyrus' order. The Jews are still the descendants of Jacob. Use the same word or phrase for Jews as you used in previous passages. For more information on Jews, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Darius mentions the governor of the Jews and the **elders** of the Jews who helped to rebuild God's temple. Remember, the elders were important people in the Jewish community because they led the community. Elders were often the head of a family or group of families. Use the same word or phrase for elders as you used in previous passages. For more information on elders, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Darius promises that he will pay the Jews' building expenses from the tribute or revenues of the people who lived in the province of the Trans-Euphrates. Tribute is the money that the people would pay King Darius to live in the kingdom.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **tribute** or **revenues**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Darius promised to give the Jews animals to make **burnt offerings** to God. Remember, a burnt offering is a specific form of sacrifice. A priest burned the plants or animals that people meant to give to God. God commanded the Jews to give burnt offerings in special ways in the Old Testament. Use the same word or phrase for burnt offerings as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offerings, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Darius promised the Jews that he would give the people wine to use in sacrifices to God. Wine is a drink that people make from fermented grape juice. Grapes are small, soft, and juicy berries that grow in several different colors.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wine**. Use the same word or phrase for wine as you used in previous passages. For more information on wine, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

King Darius promises to give the Jews all that they need to make sacrifices to the **God of heaven**. The "God of heaven" is the same God who made promises to Abraham and whom the Jews have worshiped for many centuries. He is also the same God who created the earth and everything in it. Use the same word or phrase for "God of heaven" as you used in previous passages. For more information on heaven, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Darius hopes the Jews will **pray** for him. Prayer is the way people talk to God. When someone prays to God, that person can be praising God, asking God for help, or thanking God for something. For more information on prayer, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for prayer. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 6:1–12

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (613 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (6.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (928 KB)

Ezra 6:13–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 6:13–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:13–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:13–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, King Darius' servants found the record of when King Cyrus ordered the Jews to rebuild the house of the great God. King Darius then made a new order that the king's servants would give terrible punishments to anyone who tried to stop the Jews from building the house of the great God. In this story, the storyteller describes what happened in Jerusalem after Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers received King Darius' order that allowed the Jews to keep building the house of the great God. This story also shows how God provides for the people of Judah.

After King Darius orders the Jews to continue building the house of God in the last story, the king's servants take the king's orders to Jerusalem. When Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers hear King Darius' order, the men obey the king's decision exactly. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers allow the Jews to continue building the house of God, and the people working on the temple make progress on the building! It is important to note the importance of King Darius' decision to let the Jews build the house of God and to provide everything the Jews needed to finish the temple. King Darius' order, and Tattenai, Shethar-Bozenai, and their fellow workers' obedience to King Darius, show how God provided for the Jews. God is using the Jews as well as people who are not Jews to help make God's plans happen!

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when you needed help and someone you did not expect helped you. Pause this audio here.

The Jewish elders continued working to build the house of God. Haggai, one of God's prophets, and Zechariah, who is a descendant of a man named Iddo, gave the Jews messages from God. Haggai and Zechariah's messages from God encouraged the Jews as they successfully built the house of God. You will remember that Haggai and Zechariah are the same men who gave the Jews a message from God that encouraged the Jews to start building the house of God again.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when someone encouraged you when you were trying to do something difficult. Pause this audio here.

The Jews finally finished building the house of God! The Jews finished the temple because God commanded them to and because of the orders of the kings of Persia: Cyrus, Darius, and Artaxerxes. We do not know why the storyteller included Artaxerxes in this list of kings because Artaxerxes did not become king until several years after the Jews finished the house of God. Some people think that the storyteller mentions King Artaxerxes because King Artaxerxes helped when the Jews built the walls of Jerusalem. Other people think the Jews may not have thought the temple was officially finished until the Jews put all of God's special vessels back in the house of God. This happened during King Artaxerxes' reign, many years after this story. It is important to know that King Artaxerxes was not king of Persia until many years after the Jews finished the house of God, yet the storyteller thanks King Artaxerxes for helping to finish God's temple.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when a project you were part of took a long time to finish. Explain and describe all the people who helped to finish the project. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites finished God's temple on the third day of the month of Adar. The Hebrew month of Adar was in the early spring and corresponds to the month of February or March today. The Israelites finished building the house of God in the sixth year of King Darius' rule as king of Persia. The Israelites finished the house of God 4.5 years after Haggai and Zechariah gave the Israelites their messages from God. It has also been 72 years since King Nebuchadnezzar destroyed God's first temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In this story, the storyteller tells the year of a king's reign to say when an event happened. How do people in your culture describe what year an event happened? Pause this audio here.

All the Jews who came back to Judah from exile, including the priests and the Levites, held a big event to celebrate finishing the house of God. Now the storyteller calls the Jews "the Israelites." The Israelites used the celebration to dedicate the house of God. This means that the Israelites officially gave the house of God to God in order to honor him. The Israelites felt very joyful during this celebration because they had been working to rebuild the house of God for a long time! The Israelites also probably felt joyful because they were finally able to serve God the way God commanded in the Law of Moses. It is also very important to know that this celebration was very important to the Jews because it was proof that God had forgiven the Jews for their disobedience and that the Jews' exile was officially over.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What things do the people in your culture do to celebrate a big, important event? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when you gave a really important gift to someone else. What things did you do to prepare the gift? Pause this audio here.

At the big celebration, the priests and Levites sacrificed 100 bulls, 200 rams, and 400 lambs to officially dedicate the temple to God. This was a lot of animals! The Jews probably also celebrated giving the temple to God by organizing many feasts and gatherings. The Jews also sacrificed 12 male goats as a sin or purification offering to God to make themselves ritually clean to God again. The sacrifice of the goats also meant that the Jews could use the temple to serve God. The Jews chose 12 goats to represent each of the original 12 tribes of Israel, even though the Israelites who returned to Judah were mainly from three tribes: Judah, Benjamin, and Levi.

Stop here and look at a picture of bulls, rams, lambs, and goats as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and gather several groups of objects like rocks, leaves, or sticks to represent the bulls, rams, lambs, and goats that the Israelites sacrificed to God. You can have each object represent 10 animals. Notice how many animals the Israelites gave to God! Pause this audio here.

The priests and Levites then divided into groups. Each group had specific jobs to do to serve God in God's temple in Jerusalem, the way God commanded. Many centuries before this story, God gave his instructions to Moses, the leader of the Israelites, who led the people out of Egypt and to the land of Israel. Moses wrote God's commands down in the Book of Moses. This book was very important to the Israelites because it gave the people God's instructions. When the Jews finished God's temple, the groups of priests and Levites began to serve God again as God commanded in the Book of Moses. It is important that the Israelites are obeying God again!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of laws, objects, or people have a lot of power and authority in your culture? How do people in your culture treat those important things to show respect or honor?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:13–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers receive King Darius' order and decide to obey King Darius' exact words. Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai let the Jews continue to build God's temple.

In the second scene: The Jewish elders work to build the house of God, and they make good progress. Haggai and Zechariah give the Jews messages from God. These messages encourage the Jews as they build the house of God. Finally, the Jews finish the house of God!

In the third scene: The Israelites, priests, and Levites who returned from exile hold a big celebration to officially dedicate the finished temple to God. The Israelites sacrifice many animals to God and make offerings to purify the temple and the Israelites. Finally, the priests and Levites divide into groups to serve God in the temple as God commanded.

The characters in this passage are:

- God
- Tattenai
- Shethar-Bozenai
- Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai's fellow workers
- Jewish elders
- Haggai
- Zechariah
- The Jews, or Israelites
- The priests
- And the Levites

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, when Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers hear King Darius' orders from the last story, they follow King Darius' commands "with all diligence." This saying means that Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers obeyed King Darius' exact words. The storyteller also uses this phrase to show that the Jews and the Persians believed it was very important for the Jews to build the house of God.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when you or someone in the community was working on a project that was very important to you. What words did you use to explain to the people listening to you how important that project was to you? Pause the audio here.

In scene two, the Jews continue to build the house of God. Because King Darius ordered Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers to let the Jews build God's temple, the Jewish elders made a lot of progress on the temple. It is important to remember that the Jewish elders were not the only people working on the temple. The elders worked with the whole Jewish community to finish the project! While the Jews are building the house of God, Haggai and Zechariah give the Jews messages from God that encourage the Jews.

The Jews finally finish the house of God! The Jews finish building the house of God because God, King Cyrus, King Darius, and King Artaxerxes gave the Jews everything they needed. The Jews finished the temple in the sixth year of King Darius' reign as the king of Persia, and on the third day of the twelfth month of the year.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you are going to translate the day, month, and year when the Jews finished working on the house of God. Pause this audio here.

Ezra 6:13–18

In scene three, after the Israelites finish building God's temple, all the Israelites who returned from exile, including the priests and Levites, hold a big celebration to officially dedicate the new house of God to God.

Stop here and describe to the group what events people celebrate when your community finishes a new building. Notice the words you use to describe what happens. Pause this audio here.

It is important to notice that the storyteller calls the Jews the people of Israel here, even though these Jews are the only Israelites who have returned to Judah from exile. These are mostly Israelites from the tribes of Judah, Benjamin, and Levi, and therefore, people call them Jews. However, these are the group of Israelites who continue to serve God, so they are the "true Israelites," the Israelites who have kept their promise to serve and follow God.

During the big celebration, the Jews offered sacrifices of 100 bulls, 200 rams, and 400 lambs to God to show God that the Jews were dedicating the house of God to God. The Jews also sacrificed 12 male goats as a sin or purification offering to God to make themselves ritually clean again. Also, during the big celebration, the priests and Levites divided themselves into groups to do specific jobs to serve God in God's new temple. The priests and Levites divided themselves into groups as God commanded in the Book of Moses. You will remember that the Book of Moses is the laws from God to his special people, the Israelites. Moses wrote these laws on a scroll. People called these writings the "Book of Moses." A scroll is a long sheet of paper or animal skin that someone has rolled up to protect and store. This means that the priests and Levites were following God's directions and were acting in a way that God agreed with.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:13–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- God
- Tattenai
- Shethar-Bozenai
- Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai's fellow workers
- Jewish elders
- Haggai
- Zechariah
- The Jews, or Israelites
- The priests
- And the Levites

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In scene one, the people playing Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai and their fellow workers hear King Darius' order and follow his commands completely.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Tattenai and Shethar-Bozenai, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- King Darius' punishments for anyone who disobeys him are really terrible! I do not want the king to do that to me, so I should make sure I follow everything the king says to do; or
- I trust King Darius to know what is best for the kingdom. If King Darius thinks that it is ok for the Jews to build their temple, then I think it is ok too.

Continue the drama.

In scene two, the Jewish elders work to build the temple and Haggai and Zechariah encourage the elders with messages from God. The Jews finish the house of God in the sixth year of King Darius' reign as king!

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Jewish elders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I cannot believe we have finally finished God's temple! I am so happy that we can again serve God as God commanded us; or
- I am so full of happiness now that we have finished God's house. I am so happy that we can please God and show God that we love him! We are ready to obey God and serve God the way God wants us to.

Ask the people playing Haggai and Zechariah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- God gave us the message a while ago for the Jews to start building the house of God again. I am so glad that the Jews were finally able to finish God's house! It makes me so happy to be able to please God; or
- The Jews are finally doing what God commanded them to do a while ago. We must encourage the Jews and let them know that God loves what they are doing.

Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My people are finally following me again! I love my people so much, and it makes me so happy that my people want to be with me.

Continue the drama.

In scene three, all the Israelites, priests, and Levites celebrate dedicating the house of God to God. Everyone offers 200 rams, 100 bulls, and 400 lambs as a sacrifice to God. The people also give 12 goats as a sin or purification offering for God. The priests and Levites organize themselves into groups to serve in the house of God, just as God had instructed them through the Book of Moses.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Jews, priests, and Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We must tell God how sorry we are that we disobeyed God many years ago; or
- I am so happy that we can finally obey God correctly again! I feel so thankful to God that we can worship him in Jerusalem in the temple again. It has been so long since we were able to do that! or
- We must make sure we always obey God now. Now that we can worship God in the temple again, I do not want to go back into exile.

Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing God might answer things like:

- When my people obey me, it makes me so happy. I want my people to always follow my commands so that I never have to punish them again.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:13–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Darius sent his commands back to Tattenai, the **governor** of the **province** of Trans-Euphrates, or "beyond the River." For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for king, governor, and province of Trans-Euphrates as you used in previous passages.

The **elders** of the **Jews** helped to rebuild the **house of God**. For more information on elders, Jews, and the "house of God" or **temple,** refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for elders, Jews, and the house of God as you used in previous passages.

The **prophets** Haggai and Zechariah **prophesied** to the Jews to encourage the Jews as they built the house of God. A prophecy is a message God gives to people through another person. When a person is giving a prophecy from God, that person is prophesying. For more information on prophecy or prophesying, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for prophecy or prophesying as you used in previous passages.

The Jews finished building the temple because of the **orders** of God, King Cyrus, King Darius, and King Artaxerxes. An order is from an important leader, like a king. An order can also be a way for a leader to give another person permission to do something. Use the same word or phrase for order as you used in previous passages.

The Jews thank the **God of Israel** for helping the Jews finish the house of God. The God of Israel is another name for Yahweh. He is the same God who made promises to Abraham and whom the Jews have worshiped for many centuries. The God of Israel is also the same God who created the earth and everything in it. Use the same word or phrase for God of Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on God and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

The **people of Israel** celebrated when they dedicated the **house of God** to God with the **priests** and **Levites** and **exiles**. Use the same words or phrases for the people of Israel, the priests, the Levites, and the exiles as you used in previous passages. For more information on the Israelites, the priests, and the Levites, refer to the Master Glossary.

When the Jews dedicated the house of God to God, they made **sacrifices** to God. A sacrifice is a gift to God. The purpose of a sacrifice could be that people wanted to thank God for something, worship God, confirm their relationship with God, or ask forgiveness for something the people had done wrong. When a person made a sacrifice, it might mean that people killed an animal and then burned the animal on an altar. But the gift could also be food items, oil, animals, or sweet-smelling spices. For more information on sacrifices, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for sacrifices as you used in previous passages.

The Jews sacrificed 12 goats to God as a sin offering or purification offering. A sin offering or purification offering is an offering that will purify someone after they have become unclean or unfit to serve God. When someone had sinned or was ritually unclean, that person could offer a sin offering or purification offering to God to become clean again in God's eyes.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sin offering** or **purification offering**. Look up sin offering or purification offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The people dedicated the priests and Levites for service to God in the temple. The priests and Levites worked in the temple to make the sacrifices for the people and help the people worship God.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the idea of service to God. Pause this audio here.

The priests and Levites divided themselves into groups, as the **Book of Moses** or **Scroll of Moses** says to do. The Book of Moses is the book that Moses wrote that explains the Law that God gave Moses. The Law of Moses is the commandments Yahweh gave the Israelites many centuries before this story. For more information on scroll, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "Book of Moses" or "Scroll of Moses." If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 6:13–18

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (606 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (953 KB)

Ezra 6:19–22

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 6:19–22 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:19–22 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:19–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Ezra 6:19–22

In the previous story, the Jews finished building the temple! The Israelites sacrificed many animals to God to officially give God the new temple. The Jewish priests and Levites also divided themselves into groups so that they could serve God in the temple. All these events are important because they show that the Jews are once again trying to serve God correctly. In this story, the Jews continue to try to obey God's commands. The Jews begin to celebrate other important celebrations and events that God commanded them to celebrate many years before this story.

This story takes place on the fourteenth day of the first month of the year. For the Israelites, the first month of the year took place in the month of March or April. It is important to know that this story is taking place only a few months after the Israelites finished building God's temple. It is also important to know when this story takes place because it shows that the Jews are following God's commands again. When God gave the Israelites the law of Moses, many centuries before this story, God commanded the Israelites to celebrate the special ceremony of Passover at the time of year that this story takes place.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What things do people in your community do to celebrate special holidays? Why do you celebrate these holidays at specific times of the year? Pause this audio here.

On the fourteenth day of the first month of the year, the Israelites who returned to Judah from exile celebrated Passover. Passover is a very important festival for the Israelites. During Passover, the Israelites remember the time when Yahweh rescued them from slavery in Egypt many centuries before this story. It is a happy time! During Passover, all the male Israelites and their families would come to the temple to present themselves to Yahweh, their God. Normally, these Israelites would also bring many important sacrifices to give to Yahweh, although the Israelites did not do this as much after exile. Finally, the Israelites also celebrate Passover by eating a big, special meal with special foods. These special foods represent different parts of the Passover story.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when you celebrated an important holiday as a community. What kinds of traditions or ceremonies do you observe at these events? What do those traditions or ceremonies mean and represent in your culture? Pause this audio here.

All the priests and Levites made themselves ritually clean so that the Israelites could celebrate Passover. Remember, the Levites are Israelites from the tribe of Levi who help all the Israelites worship Yahweh. The priests are part of the tribe of Levi as well. To make themselves ritually clean, the priests and Levites would wash themselves and their clothes in water to symbolize washing away all their sins. This act of washing themselves allowed the priests and Levites to serve Yahweh. Also, when the priests and Levites made themselves ritually clean, it meant that the Israelites confirmed that they were a group of people set apart from the rest of the world to serve Yahweh, their God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of things do religious leaders do in your culture to make themselves fit to do their job? Pause this audio here.

The Levites sacrificed a lamb for the priests and for themselves. The Passover lamb was an important part of the Passover celebration. Many years before, Yahweh had commanded the Israelites to sacrifice a perfect lamb and put the lamb's blood over the doors of their houses. That blood was a sign for the angel of death to pass over the Israelites' houses when the angel killed all the firstborn sons of the Egyptians. Yahweh saved the Israelite sons from death because of the blood of the Passover lamb. For all the Passover celebrations after that, Yahweh commanded the Israelites to sacrifice a perfect young lamb without any injuries or marks. In this story, the storyteller describes that the Jewish Levites made this sacrifice of a perfect lamb for Passover on behalf of the priests and the exiles. The Levites probably sacrificed more than one Passover lamb on this day.

Stop here and look at a picture of a lamb as a group. Pause this audio here.

After the Levites sacrificed the Passover lambs, the Israelites who returned from exile had a big feast. During the feast, the Israelites ate the sacrificed lambs in a big, special meal that the Israelites prepared in a special way. The Israelites would roast the sacrificed lambs whole with bitter herbs, and the Israelites would eat the lamb meat with bread that had no yeast in it.

Stop here and look at a picture of bread without yeast in it. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and talk about special feasts that you celebrate to remember a story about your people. Why do you eat that kind of food for the celebration, and what does each kind of food mean? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that all the Israelites who returned from exile ate the Passover meal, but he also mentions another group of people who ate the Passover meal. The storyteller describes this group of people as people who joined the Israelites and separated themselves from the uncleanliness of the people who lived around the Israelites. This means that the group of people stopped following the foreign gods of the people around Israel and started to worship Yahweh and follow Yahweh's laws for how to live. We do not know for sure who these people were. Some people think this group of people were Israelites from the northern tribes of Israel. Other people think this group of people were Israelites who did not leave for exile but stayed in Israel the whole time. Some other people think this group of people is not Israelites at all, but people from nearby kingdoms who made themselves ritually clean to Yahweh so that they could participate in the Passover celebrations and worship Yahweh. It is just important to know that other people celebrated Passover with the Israelites who came to Israel from exile.

Stop here and tell the group a story of a time you invited an outsider to a celebration feast. Why did you invite this person? Pause this audio here.

The Israelites also celebrated the Feast of Unleavened Bread. The Feast of Unleavened Bread was not the same celebration as Passover. But, because the Feast of Unleavened Bread starts the day after Passover finishes, many people think of them as the same celebration. The Feast of Unleavened Bread lasted for seven days. During this feast, the Israelites would eat flat bread that did not have yeast in it and would continue to stay ritually clean before Yahweh. When Yahweh freed the Israelites from Egypt, Yahweh commanded the Israelites to eat unleavened bread because the Israelites did not have time to make normal bread before the Israelites left Egypt. The Israelites celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread as a way to remember this time in their past.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time you or your family remembered a special event that happened in the past. Describe to the group the things that you or your family did to remember that event in your life. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites were very happy as they celebrated the Feast of Unleavened Bread because of all that Yahweh, their God, had done for the Israelites. The storyteller also mentions that Yahweh made the king of Assyria favor the Israelites, or treat the Israelites with special kindness, so that the Israelites could finish Yahweh's temple. We do not know for sure who the king of Assyria is in this passage. The storyteller is probably talking about King Darius or King Cyrus, even though both men were kings of Persia. The storyteller could be calling King Darius or King Cyrus the king of Assyria because the people of Persia took over the Assyrian kingdom several years before this story.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:19–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The Israelites begin to celebrate Passover again. The priests and Levites purify themselves before Yahweh so that the Israelites can celebrate Passover.

In the second scene: The Levites sacrifice a Passover Lamb for the Israelites and everyone who lived with the Israelites. The Israelites eat the Passover Lamb.

In the third scene: The Israelites are very happy as they celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days. The Israelites are happy because Yahweh allowed important people to help the Israelites build Yahweh's temple.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelites who returned from exile
- The priests

Ezra 6:19–22

- The Levites
- The people with the Israelites who had chosen to worship Yahweh
- Yahweh, the God of Israel
- And the King of Assyria

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the Israelites who returned from exile celebrate Passover on the fourteenth day of the first month of the year. At that time, all the Israelite priests and Levites made themselves ritually clean before Yahweh so that the Israelites could celebrate Passover. When someone is ritually clean before Yahweh, it means that person has purified themselves and has performed all the ceremonies Yahweh commanded in order to make up for any sin they committed intentionally or accidentally. It was important for the priests to make themselves ritually clean because people who were ritually clean were able to worship Yahweh and celebrate his feasts. The storyteller is also very clear that all of the priests and Levites became ritually clean before Yahweh—every person!

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when you were able to participate in an event because you completed a task that was necessary in order to participate. Notice what words you choose to explain this idea to the group. Pause this audio here.

In scene two, after the priests and Levites became ritually clean before Yahweh, the Levites kill and sacrifice the Passover lamb to Yahweh. It is important to know that the Levites probably sacrificed many lambs for Yahweh and not just one. The Levites sacrificed the Passover lambs for the benefit of all the priests and Levites and all the exiles. After the Levites sacrificed the Passover lambs, the Israelites drained the lambs' blood and cooked the meat before people ate the lambs in a big feast. There was a group of people who lived with the Israelites and had chosen to separate themselves from the sin of the people who lived in the lands nearby Judah. This group of people also ate the lambs and participated in the Passover feast. Remember, we do not know for sure who these people were, but we do know that these people chose to obey Yahweh's laws and become ritually clean in order to worship Yahweh, the Israelites' God.

In scene three, the Israelites celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread the day after the Passover celebrations. Unleavened bread is bread that does not use yeast, an ingredient that makes bread puff up and rise. The Israelites celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days and are very happy during that time. The Israelites are very happy because Yahweh has given the Israelites many reasons to be happy. One of these reasons is that Yahweh changed the king of Assyria's thoughts to be good towards the Israelites. This meant that the king of Assyria was willing to help the Israelites build Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and tell the group a story about a time when you felt very happy because you had so many things to be thankful for. Notice the words you use to describe how you felt. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:19–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Israelites who returned from exile
- The priests
- The Levites
- The people with the Israelites who had chosen to worship Yahweh
- Yahweh, the God of Israel
- And the King of Assyria

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In scene one, the Israelites begin to celebrate Passover. The priests and Levites make themselves ritually clean before Yahweh until every priest and Levite is clean.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests and Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- This is the first time we have celebrated Passover like this in a long, long time. We must make sure we do it right because we want to respect the law that Yahweh gave us; or
- Yahweh commanded that we become ritually clean before him before we celebrate Passover. We love Yahweh so much and have worked so hard to follow Yahweh's commands correctly again. We must become ritually clean so that we can continue to honor Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

In scene two, the Levites sacrifice the Passover lambs. The Israelites who returned from exile, the priests, the Levites, and the people with the Israelites who had chosen to worship Yahweh all eat the Passover lambs in a big feast.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests and Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- It feels so good to me that I can honor Yahweh with the Passover lamb again; or
- So many of our family members before us celebrated this same celebration. It is so amazing that we get to be a part of it again, too!

Ask the people playing the Israelites who returned from exile, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I love spending so much time with my family and friends while I honor Yahweh. I wish I could celebrate like this more often; or
- Yahweh is so good! Yahweh helped to free our people from slavery so many years ago, and now Yahweh has provided everything we needed to finish Yahweh's temple; or
- Hmmm…this lamb tastes so good! or
- I feel bad for the lamb that has to die; or
- Sacrifices remind me that I have done wrong things, and I feel sorry.

Ask the people playing the people who had chosen to worship Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I am so thankful that I know who Yahweh is. Worshipping Yahweh is so much better than the gods that the people around me worship; or
- It is so amazing that I can celebrate Passover with the Israelites.

Continue the drama.

In scene three, the Israelites, priests, and Levites begin to celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days. The Israelites are very happy because of all the good things Yahweh had done for them and because the King of Assyria had helped them.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Israelites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- I love Yahweh so much! I feel so, so happy because of the amazing things Yahweh has done for me and my people; or
- There are so many things to be thankful for. How can I thank Yahweh for them all? or
- I cannot wait to see what Yahweh does next. If Yahweh can make important kings think good thoughts towards us, Yahweh can do anything; or
- I love celebrating the Feast of Unleavened Bread because it reminds me of how Yahweh helped my ancestors escape from Egypt.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 6:19–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The **exiles** begin to celebrate Passover again. Passover is a festival that the Israelites celebrated every year to remember the time when Yahweh rescued the Israelites from slavery in Egypt. The Israelites celebrated this festival for centuries before this story. To celebrate Passover, people eat a big feast and sacrifice many perfect lambs to Yahweh. Use the same word or phrase for exiles as you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Passover**. Look up Passover in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The **priests** and Levites made themselves ritually clean before Yahweh. The priests were a special group of Levites whom Yahweh chose to serve Yahweh in the temple. All the priests were descendants of Aaron, Moses’ brother. The priests made all the sacrifices to Yahweh and performed many other special duties that served Yahweh. Use the same word or phrase for priests as you used in previous passages. For more information on priests, refer to the Master Glossary.

Before the Passover celebrations, the **Levites** made themselves ritually clean before Yahweh. Remember, Levites are the group of Israelites whom Yahweh chose to serve Yahweh in the temple. Only Levites could serve Yahweh in the temple. Use the same word or phrase for Levites as you used in previous passages. For more information on Levites, refer to the Master Glossary.

The priests and Levites **purified** themselves in order to participate in the Passover celebrations. To purify something means to make that thing ritually clean and fit to be used to serve Yahweh. For more information on purify, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for purify. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The priests and Levites purified themselves until they were **clean** before Yahweh. “Clean” does not mean someone being clean or dirty on the outside. According to Yahweh’s commands, someone was unclean when that person disobeyed one of Yahweh’s laws. That person would have to perform rituals and ceremonies in order to be considered clean again and able to serve Yahweh. For more information on clean, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for clean. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Levites sacrificed the Passover lamb after they were ritually clean before Yahweh. The Passover lambs were perfect lambs that did not have any marks or injuries. The Israelites would sacrifice Passover lambs to Yahweh on the day of Passover. The Israelites would then eat the lambs as part of a big Passover feast.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for “**Passover lamb**.” If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra 6:19–22

The people of **Israel** ate the Passover lambs that the Levites had sacrificed to Yahweh. The "people of Israel" is another name for the **Israelites**. Israel is the name Yahweh gave to a man named Jacob. All the Israelites are part of Jacob's family, but these Israelite exiles are mostly the Jews from the tribes of Judah, Benjamin, and Levi. Yahweh made important promises to Jacob and his family. These promises show that the Israelites are a group of people whom Yahweh loves. For more information on Israel and the Israelites, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for Israel and Israelites that you used in previous passages.

The Israelites eat the Passover lamb with a group of people who have separated themselves from the unclean practices of the people or nations who surround Judah in order to worship **Yahweh**. Unclean is the opposite of clean. Remember, Yahweh is a name God gives himself. The name Yahweh reminds people of God's promises to the Israelites. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **nation**. The people groups who lived in lands around Judah did not follow Yahweh, and so they were unclean. Translate nation in the same way you have translated it in other books of the Bible. For more information about "nation," refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh is the **God of Israel**. The God of Israel is another name for Yahweh. He is the same God who made promises to Abraham and whom the Israelites have worshiped for many centuries. Yahweh is also the same God who created the earth and everything in it. Use the same word or phrase for "God of Israel" as you used in previous passages. God is in the Master Glossary.

The Israelites celebrated the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven days after Passover. During the Festival of Unleavened Bread, the Israelites ate flat bread with no yeast. The Israelites ate this bread to remember the time that their families had to eat flat bread before leaving Egypt.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Festival of Unleavened Bread**. Look up "Festival of Unleavened Bread" in the Master Glossary for more information, but remember that people always celebrate this feast right after Passover. The two festivals go together. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king of Assyria helped the Israelites build the **house of God**. Remember that the house of God is a way to talk about the place on earth where Yahweh lived among his people. In this story, the house of God specifically refers to Yahweh's temple. Use the same word or phrase for the "house of God" as you used in previous passages. For more information on the house of God or temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 6:19–22

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (612 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (974 KB)

Ezra 7:1–10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 7:1–10 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:1–10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This true story probably happens more than 50 years after the Israelites finished rebuilding the temple in Jerusalem. In this story, King Artaxerxes rules the kingdom of Persia. You will remember that the Israelites from Judah and Benjamin were exiles in Babylon, which was in the territory of Persia[.]{.mark} Today, we call this region Iran and Iraq. In this story, an Israelite man, Ezra, lives in Babylon but wants to go to Jerusalem.

At the time of King Artaxerxes, Babylonia was a large area, like a province, in Persia. Babylonian people built many famous temples to local gods in Babylonia. Though the storyteller does not say this directly, we know that Ezra asks the king for permission to go to Jerusalem. Ezra probably also asks for other supplies from the king that Ezra would need in Jerusalem, but the storyteller does not tell us exactly what those things are.

Ezra descends from a long line of priests, including Seraiah. Seraiah was the last high priest in Judah before the king of Babylon captured the people of Judah, about 129 years before Ezra. Seraiah is the son, or descendant, of Azariah. Azariah is the son of Hilkiah. Hilkiah is the descendant of Shallum. Shallum is the descendant of Zadok. Zadok is the descendant of Ahitub. Ahitub is the descendant of Amariah. Amariah is the descendant of Meraioth. Meraioth is the descendant of Zerahiah. Zerahiah is the descendant of Uzzi. Uzzi is the descendant of Bukki. Bukki is the descendant of Abishua. Abishua is the descendant of Phinehas. Phinehas is the descendant of Eleazar. Eleazar is the descendant of Aaron. Aaron was Moses' brother and is the man Yahweh chose as the very first high priest, who led all the other priests. In other words, even though Ezra is not a high priest, Ezra has the authority to teach Yahweh's Law because Ezra is a descendant of Aaron.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The storyteller tells about Ezra and Ezra's ancestors, all the way back to Aaron. If these were ancestors of someone in your culture, how would you tell someone about these ancestors? Pause this audio here.

How do people in your culture talk about an important ancestor like Aaron? How do people talk about the descendants of an important ancestor? How do people talk about the authority or respect that other people give to a person because of who that person's ancestor was? Pause this audio here.

Ezra teaches people about Yahweh's law. Ezra dedicates himself to carefully study the law that Yahweh, the God of Israel, had given to Yahweh's people through Moses, or the "Book of Moses."

Stop here and, as a group, talk about who in your culture can learn and teach religious rules or laws. How do people learn these rules? How do people teach these rules? How do you think this is similar to or different than what Ezra does? Pause this audio here.

King Artaxerxes lets Ezra do everything Ezra asks for permission from the king to do because Yahweh, Ezra's God, is with Ezra. In other words, Yahweh feels pleased with Ezra, so Yahweh helps Ezra.

Stop here and discuss as a group: If a man from a different country asked your country's leader to help the people of that man's nation, how do you think this leader would respond? How is this the same or different from how Artaxerxes responds to Ezra? Pause this audio here.

Other Israelites go with Ezra to Jerusalem. These people include priests, Levites, musicians, gatekeepers, and people who will serve in Yahweh's temple. These musicians are the Levites who make music for worship in the temple. The gatekeepers guard and protect the temple. The storyteller does not mention this, but probably family members, including the elderly, women, and children, likely travel with this group. Ezra and the Israelites leave Babylonia to go to Jerusalem on the first day of the first month of the seventh year when King Artaxerxes rules over Persia.

Ezra and the other Israelites travel for four months from Babylonia to Jerusalem. Ezra and the others arrive in Jerusalem on the first day of the fifth month of the seventh year, when King Artaxerxes rules over Persia. God helps Ezra during the whole trip. Ezra completely devotes himself to learning and obeying Yahweh's Law. Ezra even teaches Yahweh's statutes and ordinances to the Israelites. Ezra does this because Ezra wants to go back to Israel to continue to teach other Israelites about Yahweh. Yahweh helps Ezra because of Ezra's devotion.

In those days, people who traveled from Babylonia in Persia to Jerusalem had to go northwest along the Euphrates River and stay on routes closer to villages to avoid robbers. After many weeks, the travelers would have to turn south to travel through the wilderness and rocky hills. Finally, the travelers had to climb steep, uphill paths to reach Jerusalem. The entire journey would be almost 1,500 kilometers.

Stop here and, as a group, look at Persia, Babylonia, the Euphrates River, and Jerusalem on a map. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, tell a story about when a group of people traveled a long distance safely.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Ezra comes from a long family line of priests, all the way back to Aaron, the first high priest of Israel. This story is about Ezra's trip away from Babylon to Jerusalem. Ezra knows Yahweh's law very well and teaches Yahweh's law to other people.

In the second scene: The Persian king, Artaxerxes, gives Ezra everything Ezra asks for because Yahweh helps Ezra. Some other Israelites go with Ezra on the journey, including priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, and temple servants.

In the third scene: Yahweh helps Ezra and the other Israelites arrive safely in Jerusalem because Ezra works hard to learn, follow, and teach Yahweh's statutes and ordinances.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- Ezra's ancestors
- Yahweh
- King Artaxerxes
- And the Israelites who travel with Ezra: priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, and temple servants

The names in this story are similar to part of another story in 1 Chronicles. You should translate parts of this story the same way as you did in 1 Chronicles 6:3–15, except in places where there are differences.

Stop here and listen to your translation of 1 Chronicles 6:3–15 now, if your team has already translated this similar passage. Pause this audio here.

Scene one happens while King Artaxerxes rules Persia. Ezra comes from a long family line of priests. Ezra is the "son of," meaning "descendant of," Seraiah. The storyteller does not mention every priest in the family line and may skip some generations. So, "son of" means "descendant," which may or may not be the direct son. Seraiah is the son of Azariah, who is the son of Hilkiah. Hilkiah is the son of Shallum, who is the son of Zadok. Zadok is the son of Ahitub, who is the son of Amariah. Amariah is the son of Azariah, who is the son of Meraioth. Meraioth is the son of Zerahiah, who is the son of Uzzi. Uzzi is the son of Bukki, who is the son of Abishua. Abishua is the son of Phinehas, who is the son of Eleazar. Finally, Eleazar is the son of Aaron. Aaron was the first high priest. This means that Yahweh chose Aaron as the very first high priest who led all the other priests.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe that each man is the descendant of his ancestor. Also, discuss in what order you will describe these ancestors so that someone in your culture will understand that Aaron is Ezra's first and most important ancestor. Pause this audio here.

Ezra prepares to leave Babylon to go to Jerusalem. Ezra is a scribe who "seeks" the law that Yahweh gave through Moses and teaches Yahweh's law to others. Scribes had the official responsibility among the Israelites to learn and teach Yahweh's law. Ezra probably learned Yahweh's law through writing the words down again and again until Ezra could quickly and accurately retell Yahweh's law. "Seeks" means that Ezra reads Yahweh's law to learn what Yahweh wants Ezra to do. Ezra can skillfully teach other Israelites about Yahweh's law in the Book of Moses. Here, the "Law of Moses" means that Ezra specifically studies the "Book of Moses," or the writings of Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe Yahweh's law in the Book of Moses and how Ezra studies Yahweh's law. Pause this audio here.

In scene two, Ezra asks for some things from King Artaxerxes of Persia. We do not know what Ezra asks for, but the king gives Ezra all of these things. The king does this because Yahweh's "hand is on" Ezra. This is special language that means Ezra's God, Yahweh, helps Ezra.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about Yahweh's hand being on Ezra. Pause this audio here.

Some of the other Israelites who live in Babylonia travel with Ezra. These Israelites include priests, Levites, musicians, gatekeepers, and temple servants. Ezra and the other Israelites travel to Jerusalem during the seventh year when King Artaxerxes rules Persia. Priests are responsible to serve God at the temple by offering sacrifices, teaching God's Law, and leading worship. Levites are descendants of Levi, the son of Jacob. The Levites are responsible for helping the priests in the temple. The singers are specific members of the tribe of Levi who have the responsibility to sing and play musical instruments in the temple. Gatekeepers are another specific group of Levites who are responsible to guard the gates of the temple. Temple servants are a group of men responsible to serve the Levites by doing chores in the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the people who travel with Ezra. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, Ezra leaves Babylonia on the first day of the first month of the seventh year when King Artaxerxes rules Persia. Ezra arrives safely in Jerusalem on the first day of the fifth month of the same year. This happens because Ezra's God's "good hand" is on Ezra because Ezra sets his heart to study Yahweh's law. In other words,

Ezra devotes himself to study and follow Yahweh's law as well as to teach these statutes and ordinances to the Israelites. God's "good hand" means that God actively makes sure that Ezra and the others safely arrive in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe the time when Ezra starts the journey from Babylon to when Ezra arrives in Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about how Ezra "sets his heart," or decides to fully study Yahweh's law. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- Ezra's ancestors
- Yahweh
- King Artaxerxes
- And the Israelites who travel with Ezra: priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, and temple servants

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Scene one happens while King Artaxerxes rules Persia. Ezra descends from a long line of priests, including Seraiah. Seraiah is the son of Azariah, who is the son of Hilkiah. Hilkiah is the son of Shallum, who is the son of Zadok. Zadok is the son of Ahitub, who is the son of Amariah. Amariah is the son of Azariah, who is the son of Meraioth. Meraioth is the son of Zerahiah, who is the son of Uzzi. Uzzi is the son of Bukki, who is the son of Abishua. Abishua is the son of Phinehas, who is the son of Eleazar. Finally, Eleazar is the son of Aaron. Aaron was the chief priest.

Ezra prepares to leave Babylon to go to Jerusalem. Ezra knows Yahweh's law in the Book of Moses very well and teaches this to the other Israelites.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- God has trusted my family with God's law for a long time. I feel humbled because this role comes from Yahweh and not from my own power; or
- Yahweh does not forget Yahweh's people. Yahweh is faithful to keep his promises for every generation; or
- I want to know Yahweh through his word and teach Yahweh's law to other Israelites so we can obey Yahweh; or

- We have lived in captivity for generations. I want to return to Jerusalem and worship Yahweh in Yahweh's temple. I trust that Yahweh is good and will help me to go to Jerusalem.

Continue the drama.

In scene two, King Artaxerxes of Persia gives Ezra all of the things Ezra asks for. The king does this because Ezra's God, Yahweh, helps Ezra. Some of the other Israelites who live in Babylonia travel with Ezra. These Israelites include priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, and temple servants. Ezra and the other Israelites travel to Jerusalem during the seventh year when King Artaxerxes rules Persia.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Artaxerxes, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Ezra's God seems powerful and worthy of my honor; or
- Even though I am not an Israelite, I respect Ezra's God. To help Ezra is the right thing for me to do. I do not want to go against Ezra's powerful God; or
- I will give Ezra authority to lead a group of Israelites to go to Jerusalem.

Continue the drama.

In scene three, Ezra leaves Babylonia on the first day of the first month of the seventh year when King Artaxerxes rules Persia. Ezra arrives in Jerusalem on the first day of the fifth month of the same year. This happens because Ezra's God helps Ezra. God helps because Ezra devotes himself to study and follow Yahweh's law as well as to teach these statutes and ordinances to the Israelites.

Pause the drama. Ask the person or group playing the Israelites who travel with Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel so thankful to Yahweh that Yahweh has safely brought us to Jerusalem. Yahweh guided us during the whole long and difficult journey; or
- Yahweh has honored Ezra's faithfulness to study, obey, and teach Yahweh's law; or
- We feel hopeful about the future because God helped us and cared for us to return to Jerusalem; or
- Now we can worship Yahweh in his temple again!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

This story is about Ezra, who comes from a long family line of priests, including Aaron, whom Yahweh chose as the first high priest.

Stop here and decide how you will translate **high priest**. If you have already translated this in other books of the Bible, then use the same word or phrase here. For more information about high priests, refer to "high priest" in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller describes Ezra as the "**son**," or **descendant** of Seraiah. The storyteller also describes the other **priests** as the sons of other priests. Here, son usually means descendant. In the story, Ezra travels with some other Israelites: priests, **Levites**, singers, gatekeepers, and **temple** servants. For more information on priest, descendant, Levites, and temple, refer to the Master Glossary. Translate priest and temple as you have in previous passages. Translate son or descendant in the same way you have translated the idea of descendant before in Ezra.

Ezra was a **scribe**, or teacher of Yahweh's law. For more information on scribe, refer to the Master Glossary

King Artaxerxes rules Persia. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

The storyteller in this passage uses the personal name for **God**, "**Yahweh**," to refer to Ezra's God, who gave Yahweh's law to the Israelites in the **Law of Moses**. Ezra talks about Yahweh, the God of **Israel**. Use the same

words for God, Yahweh, and the Law of Moses that you have used before. For more information on God, Yahweh, Israel, and the Law of Moses, refer to the Master Glossary.

The name Ezra means “help” and might come from a longer name that means “Yahweh helps.”

Stop here and decide how you will translate the name “**Ezra**.” Will you translate it according to the meaning, or will you translate it according to how it sounds?

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 7:1–10

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (900 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Ezra 7:11–28

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 7:11–28 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:11–28 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:11–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, we heard that Ezra had asked the king to allow Ezra to go back to Judah. In this passage, we will hear the letter that King Artaxerxes wrote as an official response to what Ezra asked the king to do. In those days, a king wrote letters to the people who lived in the king's nation as a way to tell the people the king's orders or rules for a specific situation. By writing this letter, the king gave Ezra authority to go to Jerusalem with other Israelites.

The storyteller introduces the letter in Hebrew, the language of the Israelites. The introduction says that Ezra is a priest and scribe. Ezra is an educated man who knows Yahweh's commands and statutes for Israel very well.

The Hebrew introduction ends with, "This is a copy of what King Artaxerxes wrote in the letter the king had given to Ezra."

The next part of the story is what the king wrote in another language. This language is the one which Persians used in those days to write official government letters. In the beginning of the letter, King Artaxerxes writes in the Persian style to show that the king is the one who writes the letter and that he writes the letter to Ezra. The king also gives a polite greeting, so we know the king is writing both an official and a positive message.

Stop here and discuss as a group how someone in your culture can show how this is a message one person sends to another person. Also, how can you show that this letter is a positive message? Pause this audio here.

In this beginning part of the letter, King Artaxerxes refers to himself with the official title that Persian kings used at that time. This title shows that King Artaxerxes is the most important king. King Artaxerxes also calls Ezra by an official title to show that the king officially recognizes Ezra's authority as a priest and scribe of the Law of the God of heavens. In other words, the king gives Ezra permission to teach the Law of Ezra's God to the Israelites in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss as a group how people in your culture refer to people who have official roles. Pause this audio here.

King Artaxerxes tells Ezra that King Artaxerxes gives an order to allow any of the Israelites in King Artaxerxes' kingdom who want to go with Ezra to go to Jerusalem. This includes priests and Levites. Artaxerxes and his seven advisers tell Ezra that they want to send Ezra to see whether the Israelites who live in Judah and Jerusalem obey the Law of Ezra's God. Artaxerxes also says that Ezra knows this Law well.

Artaxerxes and his advisors tell Ezra to take the silver and gold Artaxerxes is giving to God. Artaxerxes tells Ezra to take any other silver and gold that Ezra can get from the land of Babylon. Also, Ezra must take the offerings that the people and priests choose to give for the temple of their God in Jerusalem. Artaxerxes says to use the money to buy bulls, rams, male lambs, grain offerings, and drink offerings to use as sacrifices on the altar of the temple of Ezra's God in Jerusalem. Bulls are male cattle, rams are male adult sheep, and lambs are young sheep. Grain offerings are the best quality flour, which a priest mixes with olive oil. A drink offering is wine that a priest pours on the altar.

Stop here and, if needed, look at images of bulls, rams, and male lambs as a group. Pause this audio here.

Artaxerxes gives Ezra and the other Jews permission to use the rest of the silver and gold in a way that pleases their God. Artaxerxes tells Ezra and the other Israelites to use the articles Artaxerxes gives them to worship God in God's temple. In addition to that, Artaxerxes tells Ezra and the Israelites to take any other items they need for God's temple from Artaxerxes' royal treasury.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do people give money or gifts for important purposes like worship, helping others, or community needs, and who do you trust to take care of those gifts? Why do you need to trust those people? Pause this audio here.

King Artaxerxes gives a strong order to the officials who control the treasure in the area west of the Euphrates River. The officials must obey right away because, in those days, everyone had to do everything the king said. The king tells the officials to give Ezra the priest anything Ezra asks for because the king recognizes Ezra as a trusted teacher of the Law of the God of heaven.

The king lists exact amounts of silver, wheat, wine, oil, and salt that the officials may give Ezra. The officials must give up to 3,400 kilograms of silver. The officials must give 10,000 kilograms of wheat. The officials must give 2,000 liters of wine. The officials must give 2,000 liters of olive oil. The officials must give as much salt as Ezra needs.

Stop here and look at an image of silver metal as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at an image of wheat as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at an image of wine as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at an image of olive oil as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at an image of salt as a group. Pause this audio here.

Artaxerxes also commands everyone to work hard to do whatever God wants for the temple of the God of heaven. Artaxerxes explains that he does not want this God to feel angry at Artaxerxes' kingdom or the kingdom of Artaxerxes' descendants. The king forbids his officials in the province of Trans-Euphrates to collect taxes, tributes, or duty from the priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, temple servants, or anyone else who works at God's temple in Jerusalem.

King Artaxerxes commands Ezra to ask God for wisdom to choose judges and officials who will use justice to lead the Israelite people who live west of the Euphrates River who know Ezra's God's laws. Artaxerxes also tells Ezra to teach the people who do not know God's laws. King Artaxerxes orders punishment for anyone who disobeys God's Law or the king's law, and the punishment should match the wrong thing that person has done. For some people who disobey, their punishment is death. Other people who disobey must leave where they live and not come back. Officials must take the property away from others who disobey. Other people who disobey must go to prison.

After reading Artaxerxes's letter, Ezra speaks to the people of Israel in Hebrew. Ezra tells the people of Israel to thank Yahweh who has been the God of their people since long ago. Ezra explains that Yahweh is the One Who caused King Artaxerxes to honor Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem, as the king shows in his letter. Ezra says that Yahweh shows kindness to Ezra by causing the king and the king's advisers, and all of the king's powerful officials to show kindness to Ezra. Ezra says that Yahweh, Ezra's God, gave Ezra the courage to gather Israelite leaders to go to Jerusalem with Ezra.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:11–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Ezra serves as a priest and scribe. King Artaxerxes writes a letter to Ezra.

In the second scene: The king allows any Israelites who want to go with Ezra, including priests and Levites, to return to Jerusalem. The king also gives gifts for the Israelites to use for worshipping God.

In the third scene: The king commands Persian officials in Trans-Euphrates to support Ezra generously. The king gives Ezra authority to appoint judges and officials and to teach and judge by God's Law.

In the fourth scene: Ezra praises God and gathers leaders to return to Jerusalem.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- King Artaxerxes
- Yahweh, the God of heaven
- King Artaxerxes' advisers
- Persian treasury officials west of the Euphrates
- The Israelites, which includes:
- Priests
- Levites
- Judges and court officials
- And temple workers: musicians, gatekeepers, and servants

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the storyteller says that this is a copy of what King Artaxerxes wrote in the letter the king had given to Ezra. Ezra is a priest of Yahweh and a scribe. Ezra is an educated man who knows Yahweh's commands and decrees for the Israelites very well. When the storyteller calls Ezra a scribe, he is showing that Ezra is a leader and teacher of Yahweh's law.

Artaxerxes, king of kings, writes to Ezra the priest and scribe of the Law of the God of heaven. Artaxerxes probably did not write the letter directly. More than likely, the king said the words and a scribe wrote these words in the letter.

Stop here and discuss how you will say how Artaxerxes writes this letter to Ezra. Pause this audio here.

When Artaxerxes calls himself "king of kings," Artaxerxes means that he is the highest authority in Persia.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that Artaxerxes calls himself the "king of kings." Pause this audio here.

Artaxerxes uses the title "scribe" for Ezra to show that Artaxerxes recognizes Ezra's official authority as a scribe for the Israelites. Artaxerxes refers to Ezra's God as the "God of heaven." In those days, Israelites often talked to non-Israelites about the Israelite "God of heaven." Heaven refers to where God lives. When Artaxerxes refers to God's commands and decrees, Artaxerxes means Yahweh's law in the first five books of the Bible: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy.

In scene two, King Artaxerxes allows any of the Israelites in the kingdom of Persia who want to go with Ezra to go to Jerusalem. This includes priests and Levites. Artaxerxes and his seven advisors send Ezra to see whether the Israelites living in Judah and Jerusalem obey the Law of Ezra's God. Other Persian kings also had advisors, or important men who helped the Persian kings make decisions. Artaxerxes also says that Ezra has this law "in hand." Here, "hand" means "control." This either means that Ezra carries an actual physical copy of the law or that Ezra knows and understands the law well.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Ezra has the Law. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, Artaxerxes and his advisors give Ezra silver and gold to worship the Israelite God. Artaxerxes is probably giving the silver and gold so that the Israelites will worship God in the temple in Jerusalem. Artaxerxes also allows Ezra to take any other silver and gold that Ezra can get from Babylon. Ezra must take the offerings that the Israelite people and priests choose to give to God for God's house, meaning God's temple, in Jerusalem. Artaxerxes says to use the money to buy bulls, rams, male lambs, grain offerings, and drink offerings to use as sacrifices on the altar of the house of Ezra's God in Jerusalem. Artaxerxes gives Ezra and the other Jews permission to use the rest of the silver and gold in a way that pleases their God. Artaxerxes tells Ezra and the other Israelites to use the articles Artaxerxes gives them to worship God in God's house. In addition to that, Artaxerxes tells Ezra and the Israelites to take any other items they need for God's house from Artaxerxes' royal treasury.

King Artaxerxes now talks directly to the Persian officials who rule people in the area west of the River. Remember that this area is the Province of Trans-Euphrates, or the "province beyond the River." The king orders these

officials to give Ezra the priest anything Ezra asks for because the king recognizes Ezra as a trusted scribe of the Law of the God of heaven. In those days, people said "the River" to refer to the Euphrates River.

Stop here and, if necessary, look at the Euphrates River on a map. Pause this audio here.

The king says the exact amounts of silver, wheat, wine, oil, and salt that the officials must give to Ezra. The officials must give up to 3,400 kilograms of silver. The officials must give 10,000 kilograms of wheat. The officials must give 2,000 liters of wine. The officials must give 2,000 liters of olive oil. The officials must give as much salt as Ezra needs.

Stop here and, as a group, describe the amounts for the silver, wheat, wine, and olive oil in your language. Pause this audio here.

Artaxerxes also commands all of these Persian officials to work hard to do whatever God wants for the house of the God of heavens. Artaxerxes explains that he does not want this God to feel angry at Artaxerxes' kingdom or the kingdom of Artaxerxes' descendants. The king forbids his officials from collecting taxes, tribute, or duty from the priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, house servants, or anyone else who works at God's house in Jerusalem.

Then King Artaxerxes speaks to Ezra. The king says that Ezra has wisdom from God in Ezra's hand. Here, "hand" again means "control." In other words, the king means that Ezra knows God and God's law so well that Ezra can use this skill and knowledge to make decisions.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe how Ezra has wisdom from God in his hand. Pause this audio here.

King Artaxerxes tells Ezra to use this wisdom from God to choose Israelite judges and officials who will justly lead the people west of the Euphrates River who know Ezra's God's laws. Ezra must teach the people who do not know God's laws and punish anyone who disobeys God's law or King Artaxerxes' law. The punishment should match the crime that each person has done. These punishments could be that the rulers put the people to death. Or the punishment could be that they exile the person, or force the people to live somewhere else. The rulers could take away a person's property, or the rulers could put a person in prison.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe these punishments. Also, discuss in what order you will say these punishments. Pause this audio here.

In scene four, Ezra tells the people of Israel to praise Yahweh, the God of their "forefathers," or their ancestors. Ezra explains that Yahweh is the one who gave King Artaxerxes the heart to honor Yahweh's house in Jerusalem. By "heart," Ezra means that Yahweh is the one who caused Artaxerxes to think or feel the desire inside himself to honor Yahweh in this way. Ezra tells the Israelites that Yahweh shows kindness to Ezra by causing the king and the king's advisers, and all of the king's powerful officials, to show kindness to Ezra. Ezra says that the "hand of Yahweh my God was on me." Remember that "hand" means control or authority. Here, this means that Yahweh helps Ezra to go to Jerusalem. In other words, Yahweh, Ezra's God, gave Ezra the courage to gather Israelite leaders to go to Jerusalem with Ezra.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe how Yahweh helps Ezra. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:11–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- King Artaxerxes
- Yahweh, the God of Heaven

- King Artaxerxes' advisers
- Persian treasury officials west of the Euphrates
- The Israelites, which includes:
- Priests
- Levites
- Judges and court officials
- And temple workers: musicians, gatekeepers, and servants

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Scene one introduces the letter King Artaxerxes gave to Ezra. Ezra is a priest and scribe, educated in Yahweh's laws. The king refers to himself as the highest authority in Persia, acknowledges Ezra's authority over the Israelites, and recognizes Ezra's God as the God of heaven.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Artaxerxes, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am the highest authority in Persia. I respect Ezra and Ezra's God; or
- I believe Ezra's God has real power. I want peace and safety for my kingdom and my descendants, so I order my servants to fully obey me. When I honor Ezra's God, I protect my kingdom and show wisdom; or
- I will use my authority to protect the priests, Levites, musicians, gatekeepers, and servants. When I give this protection, no official may argue. I honor God's temple and expect my servants to respect it too.

Continue the drama.

In scene two, Artaxerxes allows any Israelites in Persia to go with Ezra to Jerusalem, including priests and Levites. Ezra keeps the Law of God with Ezra.

Pause the drama. Ask the group playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The group might answer things like:

- We feel hopeful to go to Jerusalem. We will trust Yahweh, who has faithfully taken care of our people for generations and is now allowing us to return to Jerusalem! or
- Yahweh can even work through rulers of other nations! or
- God's favor on Ezra helps Ezra to teach and lead. We will follow Ezra; or
- Ezra trusts Yahweh's ways. We must also trust Yahweh to protect and guide us; or
- Yahweh blesses and provides for his work when Yahweh's servants are faithful to Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

In scene three, Artaxerxes and his advisors generously give Ezra silver and gold for the Israelite God. The Israelites who live in Jerusalem will use this to worship God in the temple in Jerusalem. Artaxerxes tells Ezra to use the money to buy bulls, rams, male lambs, grain offerings, and drink offerings to use as sacrifices on the altar of the temple of Ezra's God in Jerusalem. In addition to that, Artaxerxes tells Ezra and the Israelites to take any other items they need for God's temple from Artaxerxes' royal treasury.

King Artaxerxes tells the officials west of the Euphrates River to give Ezra the priest anything Ezra asks for because the king recognizes Ezra as a trusted teacher of the Law of the God of heaven. The king tells the officials

to give Ezra silver, wheat, wine, oil, and salt. Artaxerxes does not want Ezra's God to feel angry at Artaxerxes or Artaxerxes' descendants. The king forbids his officials from collecting taxes, duties, or tributes from the priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, temple servants, or anyone else who works at God's temple in Jerusalem.

King Artaxerxes tells Ezra to ask God for wisdom to choose fair leaders. Ezra must teach God's laws to the people. The king will punish anyone who disobeys God's law or the king's law, and the punishment will match the wrong thing that the person did.

Pause the drama. Ask the group playing the officials in Persia, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The group might answer things like:

- Because King Artaxerxes honors Ezra's God, the king is protecting our people and kingdom; or
- Ezra's God must truly be a powerful God for King Artaxerxes to freely give so generously to this God's temple; or
- We respect the king and will obey the king.

Continue the drama.

In scene four, Ezra tells the Israelites to praise Yahweh. Ezra explains that God gave King Artaxerxes the heart to honor the temple. Ezra emphasizes how God's kindness gives Ezra courage.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- God causes even foreign kings' decisions to fulfill God's purposes. God made the king and all his officials show kindness to me; or
- I feel deeply thankful to God; or
- God is faithful and kind to our people, from the time of our ancestors and even now in our time; or
- I feel confident to go to Jerusalem. God shows us God's power and kindness. God is guiding us to obey God; or
- God gives me the courage to bring Israel's leaders and travel safely to Jerusalem. I will teach God's law, help the people follow the law, and choose leaders who are fair. I will correct anyone who does wrong and ask God for wisdom in every decision; or
- Yahweh is strong and kind. Yahweh blesses those who trust him. I will serve Yahweh and honor Yahweh completely.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 7:11–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

This story is **King** Artaxerxes' letter to Ezra. This is a copy of Artaxerxes' letter or **order**. Translate king and order in the same way as you did previously. King is in the Master Glossary.

Ezra is the **priest** and **scribe** of the "**Law** of the **God** of **heaven**." Ezra knows **Yahweh's commands** and **statutes** for **Israel**. The "Law of the God of heaven" refers to Yahweh's law in the Book of Moses. For more information on priest, scribe, law, heaven, God, Yahweh, commands and statutes, and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary. Translate these words as you have previously in the book of Ezra.

Stop here and discuss how you will say, "God of heaven." Translate this title in the same way you did in Ezra 1:2. Pause this audio here.

The king orders that the **Israelites** in his **kingdom**, including the **Levites** and priests, can go to Jerusalem if they want to. Translate Israelites, kingdom, and Levites in the same way that you have previously, and refer to Israelites, kingdom, and Levites in the Master Glossary for more information.

The king gives Ezra many gifts to worship the God of heavens in **God's house**. Here, house refers to Yahweh's **temple**. For more information on "house of God" and temple, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for "house of God," or temple, that you have used before.

The king tells Ezra to use the money for three kinds of offerings: **freewill offerings**, **grain offerings**, and **drink offerings**. People use the finest and best quality flour to give a "grain offering." This means that when a person grinds grain, this is the grain that takes the longest time to grind. To make the grain or food offering, the person mixes this flour with olive oil. Then a priest takes a handful of the grain offering and burns it on the altar, so the smoke has a nice smell when the priest burns the flour on the altar. A drink offering is wine that a priest pours on the **altar**. For more information on freewill offerings, grain offerings, drink offerings, **sacrifice**, and altar, refer to the Master Glossary. Translate freewill offerings, sacrifice, and altar in the same way you have previously.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the grain offering and drink offering. Pause this audio here.

King Artaxerxes tells his officials that they should give up to 100 **talents** of silver, 100 **cors** of wheat, and 100 **baths** of **wine** and olive oil to the Israelites. Talents, cors, and baths were units of measurement. A talent was around 34 kilograms, a cor was around 100 kilograms, and a bath was around 20 liters. The officials must give up to 3,400 kilograms of silver. The officials must give 10,000 kilograms of wheat. The officials must give 2,000 liters of wine. The officials must give 2,000 liters of olive oil. Translate wine in the same way you have previously. Wine is in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about these measurements. For more information about **talent**, refer to the Master Glossary. Will you use metric units of weight? Pause this audio here.

In the story, Ezra travels with some other Israelites: priests, **Levites**, **musicians**, **gatekeepers**, and temple **servants**. For more information on servants, refer to the Master Glossary. Translate Levites, musicians, gatekeepers, and temple servants in the same way you did in previous passages.

King Artaxerxes does not want God to feel **wrath**, or strong anger, towards Artaxerxes or his "sons," meaning **descendants**. Translate descendants in the same way as you have in previous passages. For more information on wrath and descendants, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about "wrath." Pause this audio here.

King Artaxerxes tells the treasurers of the **royal treasury** in the **Trans-Euphrates** not to force the priests, Levites, musicians, gatekeepers, temple servants, or other workers at the house of God to pay **tax**, **tribute**, or **duty**. Taxes are regular payments to the ruler. Tributes are gifts or payments to show respect to a powerful king. Duties are fees that people pay at city gates or trading places. Translate royal treasury, "province of Trans-Euphrates," taxes, tribute, and duty in the same way as you did previously.

Ezra has wisdom from God. When someone has wisdom, they can make good decisions that lead to good results.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wisdom**. For more information on wisdom, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

King Artaxerxes tells Ezra to appoint magistrates and **judges** who know Yahweh's law to judge, or rule, the Israelites in the Trans-Euphrates region. In those days, magistrates and judges meant almost the same thing. In Persia, these words may refer to two different types of judges. The magistrates are the type of judges who handle everyday problems. The other type of judge handles problems that involve the king and the government. For more information on judges, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the **magistrates** and judges. Pause this audio here.

Ezra **blesses** or praises Yahweh for causing the **heart** of the king to "glorify," meaning honor, Yahweh's temple. The heart refers to the person's thoughts, feelings, and will. Use the same word for heart and bless or praise as you used in previous passages. For more information on heart and bless, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra also thanks Yahweh for Yahweh's **steadfast love** or loving-kindness. When Yahweh loves someone steadfastly, Yahweh always shows that person kindness and mercy. Look up steadfast love in the Master Glossary for more information. Translate steadfast love in the same way as you have in previous passages.

Ezra says he has courage because Yahweh, Ezra's God, had Yahweh's hand on Ezra. Here, hand refers to Yahweh's power.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 7:11–28

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (868 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Ezra 8:1–14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 8:1–14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:1–14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Ezra 8:1–14

Pause this audio here.

The family names in this story are the same as the names in Ezra 2, but in a different order. Translate the names the same as you did in the previous story, but follow the order of the names in this story.

Stop here and listen to the names in your translation of Ezra 2:3–20. Pause this audio here.

In this story, Ezra describes the people who traveled with Ezra from Babylon to Jerusalem. Ezra describes these people according to the name of each common ancestor, whose name is also the name of the large family group or clan that descends from that ancestor. For each clan, Ezra says the names of the family leader. For most of these family leaders, Ezra also mentions the family leader's father's name. Then Ezra says who travels with that family leader from Babylon to Jerusalem during the time when King Artaxerxes rules.

Stop here and discuss the ways people in your culture talk about and name large family groups. Pause this audio here.

The first two people whom Ezra says travel with Ezra are Gershom and Daniel. Gershom and Daniel are both descendants of Aaron, the first priest of the Israelites. Gershom descends from Phinehas, the son of Aaron's third son Eleazar, and Daniel descends from Ithamar, Aaron's fourth son. The family group, or clan, that descends from Phinehas uses the name "Phinehas" for their clan. The clan that descends from Ithamar uses the name "Ithamar" for their clan. Both Gershom and Daniel come from family lines of priests, and so these men are also priests.

The next person whom Ezra says travels with Ezra is Hattush. Hattush is a descendant of Shecaniah, who is a descendant of King David. Even though Hattush is a descendant of King David, Hattush does not have any power or authority in the Israelite community because the Persians still have power over the Israelites.

Then Ezra tells about 12 other clans who travel with Ezra to Jerusalem. For each of these clans, Ezra first mentions their ancestor's name and the name of their family leader and the number of men who came with the family leader to Jerusalem. For most of these family leaders, Ezra also says the name of the family leader's father. In those days, the Israelites often said a man's name and his father's name to call him the son of his father. The Israelites probably did this to tell the difference between men who had the same name, but whose fathers probably had different names. The Israelites also did this to show which family and tribe a man came from.

These fathers or clan leaders may or may not still be alive. Women and children probably also travel with this group of Israelites to Jerusalem. Ezra mentions only the men to show the family ancestry and the people responsible to lead their clan during the journey to Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss the ways people keep records of family groups in your culture. Whose names do you include or not include? For what reasons would you include or not include a name? How is this the same or different than how Ezra lists the Israelites here? Pause this audio here.

The first of these clan ancestors is Parosh. From Parosh's clan, Zechariah leads 150 men who officially recorded their names as part of the Parosh clan.

The next clan ancestor is Pahath-Moab. From Pahath-Moab's clan, Eliehoenai, the son of Zerahiah, leads 200 men.

From Zattu's clan, Shecaniah, the son of Jahaziel, leads 300 men.

From Adin's clan, Ebed, the son of Jonathan, leads 50 men.

From Elam's clan, Jeshaiah, the son of Athaliah, leads 70 men.

From Shephatiah's clan, Zebadiah, the son of Michael, leads 80 men.

From Joab's clan, Obadiah, the son of Jehiel, leads 218 men.

From Bani's clan, Shelomith, the son of Josiphiah, leads 160 men.

From Bebai's clan, Zechariah, the son of Bebai, leads 28 men.

From Azgad's clan, Johanan, the son of Hakkatan, leads 110 men.

From Adonikam's clan, Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah lead 60 men. Ezra describes Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah as "last." This might mean that these men were the last men to arrive to go to Jerusalem. Or, more likely, this might mean that these men are the last men from Adonikam's clan to return to Jerusalem.

From Bigvai's clan, Uthai and Zaccur lead 70 men.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one scene.

In the first scene: Ezra lists the leaders of the families who are going to Jerusalem from Babylon during King Artaxerxes' reign. Ezra mentions each family according to the name of their ancestor. Each family leader represents a larger group of people who travel together.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- Gershom, who is a descendant of Phinehas
- Daniel, who is a descendant of Ithamar
- Hattush, who is a descendant of David and Shecaniah
- Zechariah, who is a descendant of Parosh, with 150 men from the clan of Parosh
- Eliehoenai, son of Zerahiah, who is a descendant of Pahath-Moab, with 200 men from the clan of Pahath-Moab
- Shecaniah, son of Jahaziel, who is a descendant of Zattu, with 300 men from the clan of Zattu
- Ebed, son of Jonathan, who is a descendant of Adin, with 50 men from the clan of Adin
- Jeshaiah, son of Athaliah, who is a descendant of Elam, with 70 men from the clan of Elam
- Zebadiah, son of Michael, who is a descendant of Shephatiah, with 80 men from the clan of Shephatiah
- Obadiah, son of Jehiel, who is a descendant of Joab, with 218 men from the clan of Joab
- Shelomith, son of Josiphiah, who is a descendant of Bani, with 160 men from the clan of Bani
- Zechariah, son of Bebai, who is a descendant of Bebai, with 28 men from the clan of Bebai
- Johanan, son of Hakkatan, who is a descendant of Azgad, with 110 men from the clan of Azgad
- Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah, who are descendants of Adonikam, with 60 men from the clan of Adonikam
- And Uthai and Zakkur, who are descendants of Bigvai, with 70 men from the clan of Bigvai

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Ezra tells this story directly in his own words after he arrives in Jerusalem. Ezra lists the leaders of the families who returned from Babylon during King Artaxerxes' reign. Ezra mentions each family according to the name of their ancestor. Each family "head" or leader represents a larger group of people traveling together.

The first ancestor Ezra mentions is Phinehas. The "son of" Phinehas is Gershom. Here, "son of" means descendant. Gershom travels with Ezra. Ithamar's descendant who travels with Ezra is Daniel. David's descendant is Hattush, the son of Shecaniah. This means that Hattush descends from David through Shecaniah.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe in your language how Hattush descends from David through Shecaniah. Pause this audio here.

Then Ezra tells about 12 other clans who travel with Ezra to Jerusalem. The men from these clans do not have responsibilities as priests and do not descend from David; these men are just ordinary Israelites. The first clan ancestor Ezra mentions is Parosh. From Parosh's clan, Zechariah leads 150 men who officially recorded their names as part of the Parosh clan.

The next clan ancestor is Pahath-Moab. From Pahath-Moab's clan, Eliehoenai, the son of Zerahiah, leads 200 men. Pahath-Moab means the "governor of Moab."

From Zattu's clan, Shecaniah, the son of Jahaziel, leads 300 men. We know from other stories that Zattu is Shecaniah's ancestor. However, Ezra does not actually mention Zattu's name here, but some Bible translations include Zattu's name.

Stop here and discuss whether or not you will include Zattu's name here. Pause this audio here.

From Adin's clan, Ebed, the son of Jonathan, leads 50 men.

From Elam's clan, Jeshaiah, the son of Athaliah, leads 70 men.

From Shephatiah's clan, Zebadiah, the son of Michael, leads 80 men.

From Joab's clan, Obadiah, the son of Jehiel, leads 218 men.

From Bani's clan, Shelomith, the son of Josiphiah, leads 160 men. We know from other stories that Bani is Shelomith's ancestor. However, Ezra does not actually mention Bani's name here. But some Bible translations include Bani's name.

Stop here and discuss whether or not you will include Bani's name here. Pause this audio here.

From Bebai's clan, Zechariah, the son of Bebai, leads 28 men.

From Azgad's clan, Johanan, the son of Hakkatan, leads 110 men.

From Adonikam's clan, Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah lead 60 men. Ezra describes Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah as "last." This might mean that these men were the last men to arrive to go to Jerusalem. Or, more likely, this might mean that these men are the last men from Adonikam's clan to return to Jerusalem.

From Bigvai's clan, Uthai and Zakkur lead 70 men.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one scene.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- Gershom, who is a descendant of Phinehas
- Daniel, who is a descendant of Ithamar
- Hattush, who is a descendant of David and Shecaniah
- Zechariah, who is a descendant of Parosh, with 150 men from the clan of Parosh
- Eliehoenai, son of Zerahiah, who is a descendant of Pahath-Moab, with 200 men from the clan of Pahath-Moab
- Shecaniah, son of Jahaziel, who is a descendant of Zattu, with 300 men from the clan of Zattu
- Ebed, son of Jonathan, who is a descendant of Adin, with 50 men from the clan of Adin
- Jeshaiah, son of Athaliah, who is a descendant of Elam, with 70 men from the clan of Elam
- Zebadiah, son of Michael, who is a descendant of Shephatiah, with 80 men from the clan of Shephatiah
- Obadiah, son of Jehiel, who is a descendant of Joab, with 218 men from the clan of Joab
- Shelomith, son of Josiphiah, who is a descendant of Bani, with 160 men from the clan of Bani
- Zechariah, son of Bebai, who is a descendant of Bebai, with 28 men from the clan of Bebai
- Johanan, son of Hakkatan, who is a descendant of Azgad, with 110 men from the clan of Azgad
- Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah, who are descendants of Adonikam, with 60 men from the clan of Adonikam
- And Uthai and Zakkur, who are descendants of Bigvai, with 70 men from the clan of Bigvai

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

During King Artaxerxes' time as king, Ezra gathers Israelite clan leaders to go with Ezra to Jerusalem. Each of the clan leaders leads other members of their clan on the journey. Ezra lists the clan leaders who went with him to Jerusalem. Pause the drama. Ask the group playing the clan leaders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel grateful to Yahweh to see so many families ready to go back to Jerusalem; or
- I feel excited. I think we will see Jerusalem soon; or
- I must help my clan stay safe; or
- God will guide us and keep us safe on the journey to Jerusalem; or
- We respect Ezra because Ezra follows Yahweh. We will follow Ezra.

Ask the group playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am grateful to have people help me lead all these people; or
- I need help to remember all the details as we prepare and pack to leave.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

This story happens while **King** Artaxerxes rules Persia. For more information on king, see the Master Glossary.

Ezra gathers Israelites to travel with Ezra to Jerusalem. The following names include the names of priests, a "son" or **descendant** of King David, the ancestor from whom each clan receives its name, the names of the current leaders, and the names of most of these leaders' fathers. These leaders are the heads of fathers' **households**. Translate "heads of fathers' households" in the same way as the same title in Ezra 1:5. Also, translate son when it means "descendants" in the same way as you did previously. For more information, refer to descendants and "household" in the Master Glossary.

Ezra gives the names of the fathers of Eliehoenai, Shecanaiah, Ebed, Jeshaiah, Zebadiah, Obadiah, Shelomith, Zechariah, and Johanan. Ezra calls these men the **sons** of their fathers. In these cases, sons means the male child of their father. Use the same word for son when it means male child as you have used previously, and refer to son in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 8:1–14

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (902 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Ezra 8:15–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 8:15–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:15–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:15–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this story, the storyteller continues the previous story about the Israelite people whom Ezra gathered to go to Jerusalem.

In this story, Ezra says that he assembles these Israelites at the river that flows in the direction toward Ahava. This might be a canal. A canal is a long, narrow waterway that people dig to carry boats from one place to another or to carry water to farmers' fields.

Stop here to look at an image of a canal. Pause this audio here.

Ezra and the other Israelites make a camp by that canal for three days. This means that the people set up tents in that area. Tents are temporary places to live. The Israelites stay here before they move to the next location on their journey to Jerusalem.

Stop here to look at an image of a tent. Pause this audio here.

Ezra checks the people and priests whom Ezra gathered and realizes that none of these people are Levites. So, Ezra calls for Eliezer, Ariel, Shemaiah, Elnathan, Jarib, another Elnathan, Nathan, Zechariah, and Meshullam, who are all leaders. Ezra also calls for Joiarib and another Elnathan, who have a lot of knowledge. Ezra tells this group of men to go meet Iddo, who is the leader in Casiphia, along with the other Levites who are temple servants there. Ezra's messengers ask the Levites in Casiphia to send servants for God's temple. Casiphia is near Babylon.

Ezra says that, because God is good to Ezra and the others, the messengers bring Sherebiah back with them. Ezra describes Sherebiah as a capable man, a descendant of Mahli, the son of Levi, the son of Israel. Here, "Israel" refers to Jacob. Eighteen of Sherebiah's sons and brothers also come with Sherebiah.

Other Levites, Hashabiah and Jeshaiah, both descendants of Merari, also come with 20 of their brothers and sons to help Ezra.

The messengers also bring back 220 temple servants. These are the descendants of the group of temple servants whom David and David's officials assigned to help the Levites. People officially record the names of all of these 220 temple servants.

At the Ahava River, Ezra tells everyone to fast. To fast means not to eat food for a short time and to instead use that time to pray for a specific thing. Ezra starts this fast so that the Israelites will act humbly toward God and ask God for a safe journey for all the adults, their children, and their possessions. Ezra does not want to ask the king to provide his army and horsemen to protect Ezra and the Israelites from thieves on the road. In other words, Ezra would have felt shame if Ezra asked for help from the king because the king might think that Ezra did not really trust Ezra's God to protect Ezra. Horsemen are both the soldier who rides a horse and the horse that the soldier rides on.

Stop here to look at an image of a horse. Pause this audio here.

Then Ezra quotes the words that he had told the king before the events of this story. Ezra had told the king that God is good to everyone who follows God and that God is very angry at anyone who leaves God. Ezra means that God acts kindly toward the people who trust God. God also acts harshly toward the people who choose to turn away from God. So, Ezra and the other Israelites fast and ask God for protection. Ezra tells us that God answered the Israelites' prayer. You will remember that the storyteller is telling the story after Ezra and the people went back to Judah and Jerusalem, so here, Ezra is telling this part of the story after the Israelites returned to Jerusalem and Judah. God has protected the Israelites on their journey!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:15–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Ezra gathers the Israelites to camp for three days near the river that flows towards Ahava. Ezra carefully looks at all the people and priests and sees that none of them are Levites.

In the second scene: Ezra sends a group of messengers to ask Iddo, the leader in Casiphia, to send Levites to come help with God's temple in Jerusalem.

In the third scene: God helps Ezra and the other Israelites and causes Levites and temple servants to come to help.

Ezra 8:15–23

In the fourth scene: Ezra tells everyone at the Ahava River to fast and act humbly towards God. Ezra and the other people ask God to keep them, their children, and their possessions safe during the journey. Ezra reminds the people that Ezra did not ask the king for help because Ezra had told the king that God helps those who obey God and punishes those who turn away from God. God answers Ezra and the Israelite's prayers.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- Ezra's messengers: Eliezer, Ariel, Shemaiah, Elnathan, Jarib, another Elnathan, Nathan, Zechariah, Meshullam, Joiarib, and Elnathan
- Iddo and the other Levites in Casiphia
- The Levites: Sherebiah, Hashabiah, and Jeshaiah, and the other Levite men in their families
- 220 temple servants
- King Artaxerxes, the king's soldiers, and the king's horsemen
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Ezra tells this story in his own words. Ezra tells this story to other Israelites sometime after these events happened. Ezra talks about himself and about the other Israelites who go with Ezra.

Stop here and discuss how you will tell this story so that people will understand that Ezra himself tells this story to other Israelites sometime after the events of the story happened. Pause this audio here.

In scene one, Ezra assembles the Israelites at the river or canal that flows in the direction toward Ahava. Ezra and the other Israelites camp there in tents for three days. A tent is a temporary, movable shelter, and in those days, people made tents out of dried animal skins. Ezra checks the people and priests at the camp. Here, "people and priests" shows a difference between ordinary people and the priests who are Levites. The other Levites who are not priests help the Levite priests to take care of God's holy place. Ezra organizes the group and checks to see if any of these other Levites are among the group of people. Ezra does not find any of these Levites.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the difference between the ordinary people and the priests. Pause this audio here.

In scene two, Ezra sends for 11 men. In other words, Ezra asks someone to go find these men from among the group who camp there at the river. Ezra wants these men to all come to meet Ezra so Ezra can talk to these men all together. Ezra describes Eliezer, Ariel, Shemaiah, Elnathan, Jarib, another Elnathan, Nathan, Zechariah, and Meshullam as "heads" or leaders. Ezra describes Joiarib and another Elnathan as men who have understanding. Joiarib and Elnathan probably have general wisdom or, perhaps, an understanding of God's laws. Ezra says the name Elnathan three times. These are three different men.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the three different Elnathans so that people know these are two different men. Pause this audio here.

Ezra chooses these 11 men as his representatives or messengers. Ezra says that he "places in the messengers' mouths what to say." This means that Ezra tells the messengers what words to say. Ezra tells the 11 men to give Ezra's message to Iddo, the "head" or leader, Iddo's "brothers," and the temple servants. When Ezra says Iddo's "brothers," this refers to Iddo's fellow Levites. Ezra calls the temple servants by the title of their role. These temple servants did the lower-level daily tasks in the temple. These men all live in a place called Casiphia. So, Ezra sends the messengers to Casiphia to tell Ezra's message to Iddo, the other Levites, and the Levites' temple servants.

Ezra specifically calls Casiphia, "the place." In those days, the Israelites in Babylon may have called the location of a place of worship, "the place." This probably means that Iddo leads a large community of Levites and the temple servants who assist the Levites to worship God in Casiphia.

Ezra asks Iddo and the other Levites to send servants who will serve God in the "house of our God," or God's temple.

In scene three, Ezra tells the Israelites that "God's good hand is on us," so messengers bring back Levites to help. In those days, "hand" often referred to someone's power. So, Ezra means that God helps Ezra and the other

Israelites. The messengers bring Sherebiah, a man who has understanding. Here, "understanding" probably refers to practical wisdom, like the ability to act wisely with common sense and avoid foolish and harmful behavior. Or, "understanding" might mean the spiritual insight of someone who knows and obeys God. Either way, this means that Sherebiah was a person with good ability and intelligence to do religious duties as a Levite well. Sherebiah is one of the sons of Mahli. Mahli is a descendant of Levi. Levi is one of Israel's sons. You will remember that God gave the name "Israel" to Jacob, so Levi is one of the 12 sons of Jacob. The messengers also bring Sherebiah's sons and brothers, meaning Sherebiah's sons and other male relatives. Eighteen of Sherebiah's sons and male relatives come with the messengers to meet Ezra.

The messengers also bring Hashabiah and Jeshaiah, both of whom are descendants of Merari. Along with Hashabiah and Jeshaiah, 20 of their sons and "brothers" come. This means that the combination of Hashabiah's sons, Jeshaiah's sons, and their other male relatives totals 20 men.

The messengers also bring 220 of the temple servants. Ezra says that King David and King David's officials were the ones who first set up this type of group of temple servants as specific servants to help the Levites during the time when David ruled as king. This means that this type of group of temple servants continued to help the Levites for many generations. At this time, someone wrote the names of the 220 temple servants in books.

In scene four, Ezra "calls" out or tells the Israelites at the camp near the river by Ahava to do a fast. A fast is a specific amount of time when people do not eat food so that they can focus on a spiritual need. Ezra does this so that the Israelites at the camp will humble themselves before God. In other words, Ezra wants the people to recognize that God has authority over the people. So, Ezra wants the people to ask for God's help and to rely on God. Ezra also wants the Israelites to "seek" from God to make a straight way for them, their children, and their possessions. Here, "seek" means for the Israelites to ask or plead with God for help. By "straight way," the Israelites are asking God to protect them from dangers such as people who might try to rob them on the journey from the camp to Jerusalem. The possessions include the expensive gifts King Artaxerxes gave to Ezra in the previous story.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe what Ezra and the Israelites do as they humble themselves and seek God to make a straight way for them. Pause this audio here.

Ezra says that Ezra feels "ashamed" to ask the king for soldiers and horsemen to help protect the Israelites on the journey. Here, Ezra means that Ezra did not ask the king for help and will not ask the king for help. Ezra then says the words that Ezra previously told the king. Ezra had said that God's good hand helps everyone who seeks God. God acts with strong anger against everyone who chooses not to follow God.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe how God acts towards the people who follow God and towards the people who do not follow God. Pause this audio here.

Ezra finally says that the Israelites fast and seek "our God" and ask God to protect the Israelites. God listens to the Israelites' prayer. Ezra knows that God has answered the Israelites' prayer because Ezra tells this story after Ezra and the Israelites have already arrived safely.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:15–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- Ezra's messengers: Eliezer, Ariel, Shemaiah, Elnathan, Jarib, another Elnathan, Nathan, Zechariah, Meshullam, Joiarib, and Elnathan
- Iddo and the other Levites in Casiphia
- The Levites: Sherebiah, Hashabiah, and Jeshaiah, and the other Levite men in their families

- 220 temple servants
- King Artaxerxes, the king's soldiers, and the king's horsemen
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In scene one, Ezra gathers the Israelites by the Ahava River. After carefully observing the priests and other people there, Ezra realizes no Levites are there.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- God helped me check the people and find out that there are no Levites. I am thankful to God for his help; or
- We need Levites to serve in God's temple. I must fix this before we can start our journey; or
- I am responsible to make sure Levites come on our journey.

Continue the drama.

In scene two, Ezra calls leaders and knowledgeable men to go to Casiphia to ask Iddo to send Levites to help.

Pause the drama. Ask the group playing Ezra's messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Ezra trusts us to tell his message to Iddo. We have a big responsibility. We must have Levites to serve in the temple in Jerusalem; or
- We need wisdom from God to explain Ezra's message clearly.

Continue the drama.

In scene three, some Levites and 220 temple servants come to join the journey with Ezra and the other Israelites.

Pause the drama. Ask the group playing the Levites and temple servants, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel honored and ready to serve Yahweh. God chose us to help in his temple! or
- We feel thankful to Yahweh for allowing us to be a part of Yahweh's good plan for our people; or
- We need Yahweh to continue to guide us on the upcoming journey, and when we serve Yahweh in his temple in Jerusalem.

Continue the drama.

In scene four, Ezra and the other Israelites fast and pray to ask God to protect and help them.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- God answered our desire for Levites to serve in his temple. We can trust God to answer our other prayers because we are following God. God is faithful to answer our prayers. God has done this for our people again and again for many generations! or
- I must humbly depend on God; or
- I trust God and will rely only on God; or
- I do not need to ask for help or protection from the king's soldiers. God will help and protect us; or
- I do not want the king to misunderstand if I ask for soldiers to help us travel safely. I want the king to see that Yahweh has the power to protect us; or
- I told the king that God helps the people who follow God, and God acts in anger towards the people who choose to turn away from God. I must follow God. I want God's help, and I want the king to see God's power to help; or
- We cannot rely on our own strength; we need to ask God for help; or
- Thank you, God, for responding with protection and guidance!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:15–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Ezra gathers the Israelites, both **priests** and other people. Ezra does not find any **Levites** in this group. For more information on priests and Levites, refer to the Master Glossary, and translate priests and Levites in the same way as you did previously.

Ezra sends messengers to ask the Levites and temple **servants** to come with Ezra so they can serve in the **temple** in Jerusalem. Usually, a servant is a man or woman who works for another person, the master. These temple servants specifically work as servants in the temple to help the Levites with ordinary tasks so that the Levites can do their religious duties. Ezra calls the temple servants by the title of their role, the specific name that King David gave to these servants: "Nethinim." In Ezra's language, Nethinim are the specific group of temple servants whom King David and his officials set up to help the Levites. The Nethinim in this story are the descendants of the group King David set up. Look up servant and temple in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the temple servants who help the Levites in your language. Pause this audio here.

Ezra talks about the **house of our God**. Ezra is referring to the temple. For more information on "house of God," see the Master Glossary, and translate house of God and **God** in the same way as you did previously.

Ezra tells the Israelites to start fasting, or not to eat food for a short time, so that they can pray to God. Ezra also says that he does not ask the **king** for help because the king might think Ezra does not trust God. Ezra says that God helps people who follow God, but feels great anger towards people who do not follow God. For more information on king, see the Master Glossary.

Stop here and, as a group, discuss what word or phrase you will use for **fasting**. For more information about fasting, refer to the Master Glossary. Translate fasting in the same way as you have in other books of the Bible.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 8:15–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (987 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Ezra 8:24–30

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 8:24–30 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:24–30 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.

What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.

What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.

How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.

Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:24–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Ezra gathered the people by the Ahava River in the region of Babylon. This group of Israelite men, women, and children had chosen to leave Babylon to travel with Ezra to Jerusalem. As the people prepared for the long journey, Ezra sent a message and asked for some Levites to join them. Then the people all prayed and fasted together. The people asked Yahweh to protect the people during the journey. Ezra decided not to ask King Artaxerxes for soldiers to protect the people. Instead, Ezra trusted that Yahweh would look after the people.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that shows Babylon and Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

In this story, Ezra prepares to take the holy items and offerings with Ezra and the people. These are gifts that people have set apart, or given, especially for Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem. These temple gifts came from three

groups: King Artaxerxes of Persia and his officials, the leaders of the region around Judah and Jerusalem, and the Israelites who were traveling with Ezra. You may remember that Artaxerxes was the king who had previously allowed Ezra to lead a group of Israelites from Babylon back to Jerusalem. Ezra knows that the temple gifts all belong to Yahweh. Ezra understands that it is important for the people to treat these items with care and respect until the group reaches Jerusalem.

Before they set out on the journey, Ezra chooses several leaders from the priests and several leaders from the Levites to look after and carry the temple gifts. Scholars do not completely agree about the number of leaders Ezra chose, but most people think that there were probably 12 leading priests and also 12 Levites. The 12 Levites include Sherebiah, Hashabiah, and 10 of their brothers or relatives.

Ezra carefully counts and weighs out the temple gifts. The gifts include silver, gold, and other treasures. Ezra does not weigh these items straight into the hands of the priests and Levites. Ezra weighs the gifts first on a weighing scale or balance of some kind, and then Ezra gives the items to the priests and Levites to look after. Ezra counts and weighs the treasures to make sure the group does not lose anything on the journey.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a weighing scale that people may have used at that time to weigh items. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller talks about silver, gold, and bronze articles and vessels for the temple. Vessels are containers such as cups, bowls, or other items people use to hold things during worship. Bowls are round containers that people use to hold liquids or offerings in the temple.

The people of those lands sometimes measured large amounts of silver and gold in talents. A talent is a unit of weight used to measure precious metals. One talent is about 34 kilograms. The storyteller also uses the word “darics” when listing the temple treasures to describe how much they are worth. Darics are a type of money or coin that people made out of gold.

Here is a list of the items that Ezra weighs out, along with how much each item weighs:

- About 22,100 kilograms of silver.
- About 3,400 kilograms of silver articles.
- About 3,400 kilograms of gold.
- 20 gold bowls that weigh about 8.4 kilograms in total.
- 2 polished articles that look very valuable, like gold. We do not know the weight of these.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of some valuable temple items like bowls or cups so that you imagine the kind of items that Ezra seeks to protect. Pause this audio here.

Scholars do not know what people made the final two temple gifts from. Some scholars think that people made these two vessels from metal, either copper or bronze, but then polished them to look like gold.

In total, the weight of these temple gifts is the same as the weight of about 415 adults.

Ezra reminds the priests and Levites that the priests and Levites are “holy,” set apart for Yahweh. Ezra also says that the temple items are “holy,” set apart for Yahweh. This shows that only the holy people who serve in the temple should carry the holy items for the temple.

Ezra tells the priests and the Levites that the silver and gold are a freewill offering to Yahweh. This means that the people gave the silver and gold as gifts to show their devotion to Yahweh because they wanted to, not because Yahweh told the people to.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when do people give gifts freely? When do people give gifts because leaders ask the people to? What is the difference between the two? Pause this audio here.

Ezra tells the priests and the Levites that they must guard the temple gifts very carefully. Ezra explains what will happen once the group arrives in Jerusalem. The priests and the Levites will give the temple gifts to the leading priests, the Levites, and the heads of the families of Israel in Jerusalem. The priests and Levites will then weigh the items again in the storerooms of the house of Yahweh. These storerooms were probably the outer rooms of the temple in Jerusalem, which the people used to store things.

The priests and Levites accept this responsibility. The priests and Levites take charge of the silver, gold, and sacred items, and prepare to carry them on the journey.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people keep valuable things safe on a long trip? Pause this audio here.

We see in this story that Ezra takes responsibility for the gifts for Yahweh's temple and makes sure that the priests and Levites look after these things well. Next, the group will start on the journey to Jerusalem. The priests and Levites will carry all the temple gifts carefully.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:24–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Ezra chooses 12 leading priests and 12 Levites. Ezra gives the priests and Levites responsibility for the valuable items for God's temple. Ezra weighs out and lists the items carefully.

In the second scene: Ezra tells the priests and Levites that they and the holy items belong to Yahweh. Ezra says the priests and Levites must guard the items carefully until they have given the valuable items to the priests and Levites at the temple in Jerusalem.

In the third scene: The priests and Levites accept this responsibility and take the items, ready for the journey.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- 12 leading priests
- 12 Levites, including Sherebiah and Hashabiah
- Heads of families
- King and his officials
- The exiles
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the Israelite men, women, and children gather along with Ezra at the Ahava River in Babylon. Ezra chooses 12 leaders from the priests and 12 leaders from the Levites to look after and carry the temple gifts from Babylon to Jerusalem. The 12 Levites include Sherebiah, Hashabiah, and 10 brothers or relatives.

Remember, the priests and the Levites have a special responsibility for the temple and for serving in the temple. So, Ezra chooses these people specially to handle and deliver the temple gifts. Ezra chooses 12 priests and 12 Levites. Ezra may consider the number 12 important because it might remind people of the 12 tribes of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what kinds of people do you choose for special tasks, like caring for important places or valuable things? How do people choose these people, and how do people treat these people? Pause this audio here.

After Ezra has chosen the priests and Levites who will help him, Ezra then carefully counts and weighs out the silver, the gold, and the articles. People have given these items as special gifts to Yahweh.

It is important to note that Ezra does not weigh these items straight into the hands of the priests and Levites. Ezra weighs the items first on a weighing scale or balance of some kind. Then Ezra gives the treasures to the priests and Levites. To "weigh out" means to measure by weight so that people get the right amount. When Ezra weighs out the items into their hands, each person receives the correct amount.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "weighed out into their hands." Pause this audio here.

The reason Ezra counts and weighs the treasures is to make sure that the people do not lose anything on the journey when they travel from Babylon to Jerusalem.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that shows Babylon and Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when do people count, measure, or weigh things carefully? What items might people weigh? Why is this important? What word or phrase will you use for "measuring by weight"? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, Ezra reminds the priests and Levites that the priests and Levites are holy, set apart for Yahweh. Ezra also says that the temple items are holy, set apart for Yahweh. Ezra makes a comparison between the people and the temple items. Ezra repeats the word "holy" often. This shows that only the holy people who serve in the temple should carry the holy items for the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Can you think of things in your culture that people consider special or holy? How do people treat these things differently from ordinary things? Pause this audio here.

Ezra tells the priests and the Levites that the silver and gold are a freewill offering to Yahweh. This means that the people wanted to give the silver and gold as gifts to show their devotion, love, and loyalty to Yahweh. A gift of this kind shows that Yahweh's people want to be close to Yahweh, not just obey rules.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why do you think Ezra reminds the priests and Levites that the silver and gold are a freewill offering to Yahweh? What difference might it make that the people gave these treasures gladly? Pause this audio here.

Ezra tells the priests and the Levites to guard all the temple items very carefully. Ezra then explains to the priests and the Levites what will happen once they arrive in Jerusalem. Ezra tells the priests and Levites that they will give the treasures to the leading priests, the Levites, and the heads of the families of Israel. The priests and Levites will weigh the items again in the storerooms of the house of Yahweh. These storerooms were probably the outer rooms of the temple in Jerusalem, where the people kept things.

In the final part of scene two, the priests and Levites agree to protect the treasures. The priests and Levites take charge of the silver, gold, and sacred articles, and prepare to carry these things on the journey from Babylon to Jerusalem.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:24–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- 12 leading priests
- 12 Levites, including Sherebiah and Hashabiah
- Heads of families
- King and his officials
- The exiles
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out Ezra choosing 12 priests and 12 Levites to take care of the temple treasures.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I know these treasures belong to Yahweh, so I must choose the right people to take care of these treasures; or
- I hope the people I have chosen understand how important their task is; or
- I pray that Yahweh protects us as we start on our long journey to Jerusalem with these treasures.

Continue the drama.

Act out Ezra weighing out the treasures carefully.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- These items belong to Yahweh. I must be careful to count and weigh everything correctly; or
- Every piece of silver and gold is sacred. I want to treat these items with respect; or
- I am grateful that the people have given these offerings willingly for the temple, and I want to honor the people’s devotion.

Continue the drama.

Act out the priests and Levites watching as Ezra weighs out the treasures.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests and Levites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- These treasures look heavy and valuable! We must be very careful as we handle these treasures; or
- Ezra is taking this task very seriously! Ezra is counting and weighing everything very carefully.

Continue the drama.

Act out Ezra telling the priests and Levites that they are holy and the treasures are holy. Ezra tells the priests and Levites to look after the treasures carefully until they reach the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests and Levites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- I feel a little nervous because this is such an important task; or
- I feel proud to be chosen for this important work; or
- I want to honor Yahweh by guarding these treasures carefully.

Continue the drama.

Act out the priests and Levites as they take charge of the items ready for the journey.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests and Levites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We must protect these offerings. These offerings belong to Yahweh and are very important for the temple; or
- I feel a little worried about thieves on the road during our journey. I trust Yahweh will help us.

Continue the drama.

Act out Yahweh as he sees how Ezra, the priests, and the Levites take care of the treasures.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am pleased that Ezra and the people respect the holy treasures; or
- I am watching to see if the priests and Levites are careful and faithful; or
- I care about my people and want them to reach Jerusalem safely with the holy treasures.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:24–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Ezra chooses 12 "leading **priests**" to help carry and guard the treasures for God's temple. Priests are Levite men who serve God and help the Israelites make sacrifices to God. These leaders direct the other priests and make sure the treasures are safe. A leading priest is a priest with authority over other priests. For more information on "priest," refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "**leaders of the priests**." Pause this audio here.

In the next story, the people will travel to **God's house** or **temple** in Jerusalem. The temple is the special place in Jerusalem where God's people worship God and bring offerings. In this story, Ezra's priests and Levites prepare to carry the holy items and treasures to the temple. Use the same word or phrase for God, and "house of God" or temple, that you used in previous passages. For more information on God, "**house of God**," or temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra also chooses 12 **Levites** who are not priests to help carry and guard the treasures alongside the priests. Levites are members of the tribe of Levi who are set apart and have special duties in the temple to help the priests. In this story, the Levites work closely with the priests to handle the treasure well. Use the same word or phrase for Levites as you used in previous passages. For more information on Levites, refer to the Master Glossary.

Among the Levites, the storyteller describes some as **relatives** or **brothers** of Sherebiah and Hashabiah. This shows that family connections were important when Ezra chose the right people for the task. A relative or brother is a male relative from the same family or extended family. Use the same word or phrase for relative or brother as you used in previous passages.

Ezra counts and weighs large amounts of **silver** to give to the priests and Levites. Silver is a valuable, shiny, grey metal that people used in temple offerings. In this story, silver is a treasure that people gave to Yahweh for the temple. People often use silver for money, gifts, or valuable objects. Use the same word or phrase for silver as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a piece of silver as a group. Pause this audio here.

Along with silver, Ezra counts and weighs **gold** as part of the temple treasures. Gold is a valuable, shiny, yellow metal. In this passage, gold is a treasure that the people gave to Yahweh's temple because they wanted to show their devotion. Use the same word or phrase for gold as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a piece of gold as a group. Pause this audio here.

Two polished **bronze** items are part of the temple treasures that Ezra counts. Bronze is a strong metal that people made from copper and tin. Scholars think these items were valuable and shiny, like gold. Bronze is a metal that people use to make strong, useful, or valuable objects. Use the same word or phrase for bronze as you used in previous passages. For more information on bronze, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and look at a picture of a piece of bronze as a group. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller describes some of the silver, gold, and bronze **articles** that people offered for the temple. Some of these silver, gold, and bronze articles are containers or objects that people used to hold things during temple worship. A vessel is a container, cup, bowl, or other item that can hold something. Some of these items are

articles that priests use in the temple to help them with their work. Use the same word or phrase for the silver, gold, and bronze articles as you used in previous passages.

The gold includes **bowls** that are part of the temple treasures. Bowls are open, round containers that people often used in the temple for offerings or rituals. A bowl is a round container that people used to hold liquids or objects. Use the same word or phrase for bowl as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of the kinds of silver, gold, and bronze items that Ezra described in this story. These could be articles, vessels, or bowls. Think about what words you will use to describe those items. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller sometimes mentions **darics** when listing the temple treasures to describe how much they are worth. Darics are a type of money or coin that people made of gold. Darics were valuable coins that people used in trade or gave as gifts in ancient times. If you use the word for darics, use the same word or phrase for daric as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a daric as a group. Pause this audio here.

People sometimes measure large amounts of silver and gold in **talents**. A talent is a unit of weight that people used to measure precious metals. One talent is about 34 kilograms. If you use the word for talent, use the same word or phrase for talent as you used in previous passages. For more information on talent, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra reminds the priests and Levites that they are **holy**, and the temple items are holy. Things that are holy are things that Yahweh has set apart as special for Yahweh. Things that are holy belong to Yahweh, and people should treat those things with respect. Use the same word or phrase for holy as you used in previous passages. For more information on holy, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra calls the silver and gold for the temple "**freewill offerings**." This means the people voluntarily give these treasures to Yahweh out of love and devotion. A freewill offering is something that people give freely, not through force or duty. Use the same word or phrase for freewill offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on freewill offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra plans that after arriving in Jerusalem, the leading priests, Levites, and **heads of Israelite families** or **heads of father's houses** will receive the treasures. A head of a father's house is a leader responsible for a family group among the Israelites. Use the same word or phrase for "heads of Israelite families" or "heads of fathers' houses," and for **household,** as you used in previous passages.

In Jerusalem, the priests will keep the treasures in the chambers or storerooms of the temple. Storerooms or chambers are often outer, enclosed rooms in the temple that people used to store valuable items.

Stop here and discuss: What word or phrase will you use for **storerooms**? Pause this audio here.

Some of the gifts for the temple came from the **king** of Persia. A king is someone who rules over a country, region, or people. Use the same word or phrase for king, **Babylon**, and **Jerusalem** as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Advisors or counselors for the king also give gifts for the temple. Advisors help the king make decisions and manage the kingdom. An advisor is someone who gives advice or helps make important decisions. Use the same word or phrase for advisor as you used in previous passages.

Some **officials** also give gifts for the temple. An official is a person in a position of authority or responsibility. Officials are people who have authority in the government or administration. Use the same word or phrase for officials as you used in previous passages.

The silver, gold, and items are **offerings** to God's temple. An offering is something that people give to Yahweh as a gift of devotion, worship, or support. An offering is a gift that people give for a religious or sacred purpose. Use the same word or phrase for offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on "offering," refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra “sets apart” or consecrates the priests, Levites, and temple treasures for Yahweh. To set apart means to make something special for a holy purpose. When someone sets something apart, they choose or reserve that thing for people to use in a holy or important way.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **consecrate**. Use the same word or phrase for consecrate as you used in previous books of the Bible, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information about consecrate.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 8:24–30

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.1 MB)
- Setting the Stage (5.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (7.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Ezra 8:31–36

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 8:31–36 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:31–36 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Ezra and the exiles who were returning to Judah gathered beside the Ahava River to prepare for the journey from Babylon to Jerusalem. Ezra carefully weighed and recorded all the temple treasures. Ezra gave the treasures to the priests and Levites. The priests and Levites agreed to guard the treasures on the long journey.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that shows Babylon and Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that the journey starts at the Ahava River. This was likely a canal or waterway in the Babylonian region. The group leaves on the twelfth day of the first month. It would have been mid-April as the weather became warmer in that part of the world. Ezra began to travel from Babylon to the Ahava Canal to gather everyone on the first day of the first month. It took Ezra 12 days to assemble the exiles, search for Levites, and make preparations.

Ezra and the exiles travel together in a large group, probably over 5,000 people. The group carries families, animals, and the treasures for the temple. The journey covers about 1,450 kilometers, and takes the group about four months. The exiles would have arrived in Jerusalem around the beginning of the month of August.

The storyteller does not give us many details about the journey itself. The storyteller says that the hand of God is upon the group. This means Yahweh gives the group his power and protection. Yahweh saves the people from enemies and from ambushes along the way. Travelers in those days were often in danger from wild animals or robbers, who hid beside the road. We do not know if bandits actually attack the people, but Yahweh brings the group safely through the journey.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what dangers are people in when they travel long distances? How do people stay safe on a journey? Pause this audio here.

The group arrives in Jerusalem and stays for three days. The storyteller does not explain exactly why. The people probably rested after the long journey. Or, maybe the exiles arrived on a Friday and waited for the Sabbath to finish before they weighed the treasures.

Stop here and look at a picture of temple treasures of silver, gold, and bronze as a group. Pause this audio here.

On the fourth day, the group goes to the temple. Ezra weighs all the treasures and gives them to the two priests and two Levites in charge of the temple treasures. The priests are Meremoth, the son of Uriah, and Eleazar, the son of Phinehas. The Levites are Jozabad, son of Jeshua, and Noadiah, son of Binnu. We do not know for sure if these are the same people that the storyteller mentions in other parts of the Bible.

Ezra and the priests and Levites carefully record the weight of the treasure, so there is a clear record of the treasure. The people probably recorded this information to show King Artaxerxes that the group had delivered and counted all the treasures correctly. In the Persian Empire, it was normal to keep detailed records like this. The storyteller does not say this directly, but we can probably assume the people kept everything safe.

Then, the exiles, or the people who had come from Babylon, make offerings to Yahweh. At this time, people gave burnt offerings to Yahweh to show that they worshipped God and were devoted to God. People gave sin offerings or purification offerings to Yahweh to become clean after someone had become ritually unclean or had accidentally broken one of Yahweh's laws. The people make a burnt offering of 12 bulls, 96 rams, and 77 lambs for all of Israel. The large number of animals shows that the burnt offerings are not just for the exiles, but for, or on behalf of, the entire nation of Israel. The burnt offerings covered or represented everyone in the community. The people also make the sin offering or purification offering of 12 male goats.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a bull, a ram, a lamb, and a male goat. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When someone arrives safely somewhere after a long journey, what do people do to celebrate or show that they are thankful that they have arrived safely? Pause this audio here.

Ezra takes King Artaxerxes' written orders to the local governors and to the king's satraps or important leaders from the entire region, and to the local governors from the province beyond the river. This was the region west of the Euphrates River, which people sometimes called the Trans-Euphrates.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the Trans-Euphrates area. Pause this audio here.

A satrap was a governor in the Persian Empire that the king appointed to manage a large area. The satrap collected taxes, kept the region in order, and ensured that people obeyed the king's laws. You will remember that these written orders were letters that gave instructions from the king. In these letters, the king asks the local leaders to support the people and the temple. So, by delivering these letters, Ezra makes sure that the people have the help and resources they need to rebuild the temple and continue to worship.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why is it important to have official approval, like the king's letters? How do leaders or authorities in your community give permission or approval for projects? Pause this audio here.

This story shows [that the people of God were preparing to travel to Jerusalem, and they finally did it!]{.mark} The people travel safely, worship God, and follow the king's instructions. In the next story, we will hear that Ezra is concerned when he discovers that some of the people have not followed Yahweh's commands.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8 31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The group begins the long journey from Babylon to Jerusalem. God protects the people from danger, including enemies or robbers. We do not know if attacks happened, but God brought the people safely through the journey.

In the second scene: The people arrive in Jerusalem and stay there for three days. The people probably needed to rest after the long journey.

In the third scene: The people go to the temple. Here, Ezra weighs all the treasures and gives them to the priests and Levites, who will take care of the treasures. Ezra carefully records the weight of the treasures. This may be to show King Artaxerxes that the people have delivered the treasures properly.

In the fourth scene: The returned exiles offer sacrifices to Yahweh, the God of Israel: 12 bulls for all Israel, 96 rams, and 77 lambs as burnt offerings, and 12 male goats as purification offerings.

In the fifth scene: The people give the king's written orders to the local governors and the Persian satraps of the province of Trans-Euphrates, the area west of the Euphrates River. In these letters the king gives instructions to those officials to support the exiles and the temple.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- The returned exiles
- The priests, including Meremoth and Eleazar
- The Levites, including Jozabad and Noadiah
- The satraps and local governors
- And Yahweh, the God of Israel

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The people begin their journey from Babylon to Jerusalem. It is a long and dangerous journey over a distance of around 1,400 kilometres. Over 5,000 people travel as a group in a long line. The group carries animals and heavy treasures. Robbers might attack the people, so the people probably feel afraid. However, “the hand of God was on them,” which means that God protects the people all the way.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that shows Babylon and Jerusalem. Notice how far the group travels and imagine walking for four months through this land. Pause this audio here.

It is important to notice that Ezra tells this story himself. This reminds us that Ezra is central to the story. Ezra tells us that the people started on their journey on the twelfth day of the first month.

When the people arrive in Jerusalem, the people stay there for three days. The group rests after their long, dangerous journey before they do anything else. On the fourth day, after three days of resting, Ezra and the people go to the temple. We know this because the storyteller says that what happens next is “within the house of our God.” The “house of our God” is another way to say the temple.

At the temple, Ezra weighs all the treasures and gives them to the temple priests and Levites to look after. The storyteller names the men who receive them: the priests Meremoth son of Uriah and Eleazar son of Phinehas, and the Levites Jozabad son of Jeshua and Noadiah son of Binnui. The storyteller gives the fathers’ names to show exactly who these men are. The fathers’ names show that these men come from the right families, so God allows these men to serve in the temple.

Ezra weighs the treasures “into the hands” of Meremoth, Eleazar, Jozabad, and Noadiah. This is a careful process. It means that Ezra first weighs the treasures on a scale, then Ezra hands the treasures over to the men. Finally, Ezra makes a record of the weights of the treasures. [The storyteller probably says that Ezra, or someone, makes a record at that time. This means that Ezra probably writes down how much each treasure weighs in order to show that the people have not lost or stolen anything on the way.]{.mark}

At this point, the storyteller changes how he tells the story. Before, Ezra spoke as part of the story. Now, someone else tells what Ezra and the people do. Many scholars think someone different added this short section to complete the story. We do not know for sure.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you change who is telling a story in the middle of the story? In this story, how will you show that Ezra has stopped talking and someone else is telling this part of the story? Pause this audio here.

The exiles, or the people who had returned from captivity, make offerings to Yahweh, the God of Israel. People normally gave burnt offerings to Yahweh to show that they worshipped Yahweh, were devoted to Yahweh, and were thankful to Yahweh. People gave sin offerings or purification offerings to Yahweh to become clean after someone had become ritually unclean or had accidentally broken one of Yahweh’s laws. In a burnt offering, the people burned the whole animal. In a sin or purification offering, the people burned only part of the animal, and the priests kept the rest.

Notice that Ezra gives a list of animals for the offerings. This means that Ezra names each kind of animal, one after another: bulls, rams, lambs, and goats. This careful list shows that the people want to respect and honour Yahweh with the offerings they make.

Notice the numbers in this list too. Most of the numbers connect to 12. This is a way to remind us of the 12 tribes of Israel. The number 77 is different, so some experts think the number should be 72. Others think 77 means a large or complete number. No one knows for sure.

At the end of the list of offerings, the storyteller says that “all this was a burnt offering to Yahweh.” This is confusing because the male goats were sin offerings or purification offerings, but not burnt offerings. Scholars think that the storyteller is only talking about the burnt offerings—the bulls, rams, and lambs, which are the largest part of the offering.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will list these offerings—the bulls, rams, and lambs for the burnt offerings and the male goats for the sin or purification offering. Pause this audio here.

After the offerings, the group delivers the king’s letters to the Persian satraps and governors from west of the Euphrates River. Usually, a single satrap would look after this region with several governors under him. However,

the storyteller uses a word that means more than one satrap. So, scholars think that satraps from more than one region helped the returned exiles.

The king had told the leaders to give help to the Jewish people and the temple in Jerusalem. So, after they read the king's orders, these leaders probably gave practical support. The leaders likely provided money, food, animals, or protection for the temple and for the people who served there.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- The returned exiles
- The priests, including Meremoth and Eleazar
- The Levites, including Jozabad and Noadiah
- The satraps and local governors
- And Yahweh, the God of Israel

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out the exiles starting the long journey from Babylon to Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the exiles, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Nervous. It is a long journey and I feel afraid that robbers might attack us; or
- Hopeful. I hope we all reach Jerusalem safely with the treasures; or
- Grateful. I am so glad that Yahweh is watching over us all as we travel.

Continue the drama.

Act out the people arriving in Jerusalem and staying for three days.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing exiles, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Tired. I need to rest well after such a long journey; or
- Happy. I am so pleased to see Jerusalem again; or
- Thoughtful. I am thinking about the tasks we must do next at the temple.

Continue the drama.

Act out Ezra weighing the treasures and handing them over to the priests and Levites at the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Focussed. I must record everything carefully to show that we have taken care of the treasures on our journey; or
- Determined. These treasures belong to Yahweh and I want to honour him; or
- Proud. I feel glad to serve Yahweh in this important work.

Continue the drama.

Act out the exiles offering the bulls, rams, lambs, and male goats to Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the exiles, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Devoted. I want to honour God by making these offerings; or
- Thankful. I am grateful to worship Yahweh in this way after the long journey; or
- Hopeful. I hope Yahweh accepts our sacrifices and blesses Israel.

Continue the drama.

Act out Ezra and the people giving the Persian leaders of the province of Trans-Euphrates the written orders from King Artaxerxes.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Persian leaders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Respectful. I must follow the king's instructions carefully and help these people as the king commanded; or
- Responsible. I want to support the people of Israel; or
- Careful. I want to make sure the temple work continues smoothly.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 8:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The exiles travel to Jerusalem. Ezra says "the **hand of our God** was on us" during the exiles' journey. This means God gives the exiles help, power, and protection. The general word for the Creator God is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for "hand of our God" as you used in previous passages.

Ezra says that God keeps the group safe from the hand, or power of the enemy. This means Yahweh protects the exiles from people who want to harm them. Use the same word or phrase for **hand of the enemy** as you used in previous passages.

Ezra says that God protects the group from enemies and ambushes on the journey. Ambushes are surprise attacks by people who hide and wait to harm travellers.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **ambushes**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The exiles arrive in Jerusalem and stay there for three days. After three days, Ezra says that he and the exiles go to the **house of our God** in Jerusalem. The "house of our God" is Ezra's way to talk about the **temple**, and Ezra makes it clear that the temple is the people of Israel's special temple when he calls it the house of "our" God specifically. It is not the temple for any other god. Use the same word or phrase for temple or house of our God as you used in previous passages. For more information on temple or "house of God," refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra and the exiles bring **silver**, **gold**, and **articles** to the temple. The people give these valuable items for God's house. Silver and gold are precious, shiny metals. People use silver and gold to make money, gifts, and offerings.

Ezra 8:31–36

Articles are containers or objects that people use in temple worship. Use the same words or phrases for silver, gold, and articles as you used in previous passages.

Ezra measures the treasure before he gives the treasure to the **priests** and **Levites**. To weigh out means to measure by weight so that each person receives the correct amount. Use the same word or phrase for the action of **weighing out into the hands** of the priests and Levites as you used in previous passages. For more information on priests and Levites refer to the Master Glossary, and use the same words for priests and Levites as you used previously.

The **returned exiles** offer burnt offerings to the God of Israel. Returned exiles are the people of Israel who return to Jerusalem after living in Babylon. Use the same word or phrase for returned exiles or exiles as you used in previous passages.

The exiles make **burnt offerings** and **sin offerings** or **purification offerings** to God. A burnt offering means the people burn an animal completely on the altar to show worship and honour to God. People gave purification offerings to God to become clean after someone had become ritually unclean or had accidentally broken one of Yahweh's laws. Use the same word or phrase for burnt offerings and sin offerings or purification offerings as you used in previous passages. For more information about burnt offerings and sin offerings or purification offerings, refer to the Master Glossary.

The burnt offerings include 12 **bulls** for all Israel, 96 **rams**, and 77 **lambs**. The sin offering or purification offering includes 12 **male goats**. Use the same word or phrase for bulls, rams, lambs, and male goats as you used in previous passages.

The exiles gave the burnt offerings to **Yahweh**. Yahweh is the personal name for the God of Israel. You will notice that sometimes the storyteller uses the general word for the Creator God, sometimes he calls God the "God of Israel," and sometimes he uses the personal name "Yahweh" for God. In this part of the passage, use the same word for Yahweh that you have used previously, and refer to Yahweh in the Master Glossary for more information.

The group delivers the king's **orders** or instructions to the local leaders. These were special instructions that people wrote down from the king to give to the king's servants. Use the same word or phrase for orders as you used in previous passages.

The exiles deliver the **king**'s written orders to the local **governors** and Persian satraps. A king rules over a country, region, or people. A satrap rules over a region of the Persian Empire. There may be several governors within one region to help the satrap rule, but we are not sure exactly. These leaders collect taxes, keep order, and make sure people obey the king's laws. Use the same words or phrases for king and governor as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **satrap**. A satrap is probably a more important ruler than a governor, but less important than the king. Pause this audio here.

The group delivers the king's orders to the governors of the **province beyond the River**. A province is a large area of land. The province beyond the River means the Persian territory west of the Euphrates River, which includes Judah and Jerusalem. The area is sometimes called the **Trans-Euphrates** or the province beyond the River. Use the same word or phrase for Trans-Euphrates or "province beyond the River" as you have previously.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 8:31–36

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.1 MB)
- Setting the Stage (4.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.3 MB)

Ezra 9:1–4

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 9:1–4 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:1–4 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:1–4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The storyteller in this story tells us about what Ezra did in Jerusalem. You will remember from the previous story that Ezra and a group of exiles travelled from Babylon to Jerusalem. When Ezra arrived in Jerusalem, Ezra gave instructions to the king of Persia's officials. In this story, the storyteller tells us that the events in this story happen after Ezra's arrival. Later in the book, the storyteller tells us this story happens four months after Ezra arrives in Jerusalem.

In this passage, the storyteller does not tell us where Ezra is. However, later in the book, the storyteller tells us that Ezra is in front of the temple in Jerusalem. Officials or leaders of the Israelite people come to talk to Ezra. The leaders are the heads of families or clans of the Israelite people. The leaders, who are probably men, have authority over the Israelite community.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who are the leaders in your community? Who do the leaders represent and speak for? How do these leaders come to a more important leader when there is a problem? Pause this audio here.

The leaders want to tell Ezra something important. The leaders tell Ezra about a problem for the Israelites. The leaders talk to Ezra about the Israelites who came back from Babylon to Jerusalem at the time of Zerubbabel, about 60 years earlier. The leaders tell Ezra that the Israelites have not kept themselves separate or apart from people in Jerusalem and the surrounding countryside who are not Israelites.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about the people who live in the lands around your community but who are not part of your community. What special names do you have for those people? Pause this audio here.

The leaders mean that the Israelites are living with women who are not Israelites. The Israelites have taken women into the Israelite homes to live with the men as wives. A wife is a woman who is married to a man. You may remember from the book of Deuteronomy that Yahweh commanded the Israelites not to marry the people from certain tribes that lived in and around Canaan. At the time of Ezra, many different people groups lived in Jerusalem and lived next to the Israelites. The different people are the neighbours of the Israelites. The different people follow different gods than the Israelites. It is an "abomination," or a detestable thing, to Yahweh when people worship another god. An abomination is something a person does that disgusts or repels people or Yahweh. An abomination makes people feel horror.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What actions or things make you feel disgusted or horrified? Pause this audio here.

The leaders list the people groups in Canaan and the surrounding countries who follow different gods. Some of the groups of people did not exist by the time of Ezra, but the leaders want Ezra to know that the neighbouring people are like the people groups the leaders list. You will remember that the Canaanites are the people who lived in Canaan before Yahweh gave Canaan to the Israelites. There are different tribes of Canaanites, including the Hittites, Perizzites, Jebusites, and Amorites. The Ammonites, Moabites, and Egyptians are from countries next to Judah and Israel.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the lands around Jerusalem that shows the original places where the Canaanites lived, including the Hittites, Perizzites, Jebusites, and Amorites, and where the Moabites, Egyptians, and Ammonites lived. Pause this audio here.

It is likely that only the Ammonites, Moabites, and Egyptians are living in or near Jerusalem at the time of Ezra. The leaders tell Ezra that the Israelite men and their sons have taken wives from the daughters of the other people. At the time of Ezra, it was common for a father to organize the marriage of his son to a woman. The Israelites married people from the surrounding lands who worshipped other gods. The two groups of people mixed with each other. The leaders call the Israelites "the holy race" or "the holy seed." Race is a way to describe a group of people who share the same general physical features as each other and have a shared culture or traditions. The leaders are talking about the Israelites who have returned to Jerusalem from exile, the offspring or descendants from whom a new nation of people will grow. Yahweh set apart the Israelites to make the Israelites holy. The leaders tell Ezra that it is other leaders and officials who have started this! These people are leading other men to be unfaithful to God, also! The Israelites did not keep Yahweh's commands and were unfaithful to Yahweh.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about a person or people who encouraged other people to do something by being the first to do it themselves. Pause this audio here.

When the Israelite leaders tell Ezra of the sin that the people of Israel have done, Ezra is very upset. Ezra shows how he feels by doing signs of mourning. At the time of Ezra, when someone died, it was normal for a person to show their grief and sadness by doing certain actions. Ezra tears the garment or the tunic that Ezra wears close to his body.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a person who wears a tunic. Pause this audio here.

Ezra also tears his mantle or cloak, a piece of clothing that Ezra wears over the rest of his clothes.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a person who wears a mantle or cloak. Pause this audio here.

Ezra pulls hair from his head and out of his beard. At the time, it was common for a person to shave their head to show that they were mourning. However, Yahweh commanded the Israelites not to shave their heads. To be obedient to Yahweh, Ezra pulls out some hair but leaves the rest.

Ezra sits down. At the time, a person showed extreme sadness and grief by sitting down without saying anything. Ezra is horrified and overwhelmed by grief because of what the leaders told Ezra.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, how do people show that they are mourning because of something bad someone else did? Pause this audio here.

A group of people gathers around Ezra. The people are strict followers of the words of the God of Israel, or God's law for the Israelites. The people fear that the God of Israel will judge the people. People who feel strong emotions like fear may tremble and shake. The people are not trembling at the time of the story. The storyteller is using the description of the people to help us understand that the people are strict followers of the God of Israel, and the people have a strong respect and awe for God's law. The people did not gather to threaten Ezra.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a group of people who are devoted to God and are afraid of sinning against God. How do those people show how they feel about God? Pause this audio here.

The unfaithful exiles are the Israelites who returned to Jerusalem with Zerubbabel and afterward. These are a different group of exiles from the people who returned to Jerusalem with Ezra. The exiles were unfaithful because the exiles did not follow Yahweh's command to only marry other Israelites.

Ezra sits until the evening offering. Traditionally, the priests at the temple made an offering to Yahweh near the end of each day when the sun was low in the sky but before the dark of night. The evening offering to Yahweh did not require the priests to kill an animal. Ezra feels appalled and horrified. Ezra is not able to do anything because Ezra feels so much grief. Ezra is humble and behaves as someone who does not deserve respect.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about a time when you were overcome by grief and sadness. What did you do or not do to show how you felt?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:1–4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: The leaders tell Ezra that the Israelite people have married people who are not Israelites. Ezra tears his clothes and pulls out his hair to show how upset Ezra is, and Ezra sits down to mourn.

In the second scene: Israelites who follow Yahweh's commands gather around Ezra until the time of the evening offering.

The characters in this passage are:

- Israelite leaders
- Ezra
- Israelite people
- Women from surrounding people groups and countries
- And Israelites who follow Yahweh's commands

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The storyteller starts the story by telling us that this story happens after Ezra and the other Israelites made sacrifices and gave messages to the Persian officials. The story in this passage happens four months after the events in the previous passage. The Israelite leaders come to talk to Ezra. The Israelite leaders tell Ezra about three groups of people: the ordinary people of Israel, the priests who serve Yahweh in the temple, and the rest of

the people from the tribe of Levi. We do not know if the leaders want Ezra to think of the three groups of people separately or if the leaders talk about the three groups to mean everyone, including the priests and the Levites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about all the people in your community? How would you help someone to understand that you mean everybody, including the leaders or other important people? Pause this audio here.

The leaders talk to Ezra about the Israelites who came back from Babylon to Jerusalem at the time of Zerubbabel, about 60 years earlier. The leaders tell Ezra that the Israelites did not stay separate from the other people in Jerusalem. The leaders do not mean that the Israelites went near the other people, but that the Israelites married the other people. The leaders call the other people "people of the land" to tell Ezra that they are talking about people who are foreign and not Israelites. The Israelites have married women from different people groups and countries who worship different gods. When people worship different gods, it is an abomination to Yahweh.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Tell a story about something or some action that you think is horrible or disgusting. What words do you use to talk about that thing, and how will you describe it here? You may want to listen to your translation of Leviticus 18:22 to see how you translated abomination there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelite leaders list the tribes of people who lived in Canaan and people from surrounding countries as examples of people who have detestable or abominable practices. The Hittites, Perizzites, Jebusites, and Amorites lived in Canaan with other Canaanites. The Egyptians, Ammonites, and Moabites lived in countries next to Judah and Israel.

Stop here and, if needed, look as a group at a map of the lands around Jerusalem that shows the original places where the Canaanites lived, including the Hittites, Perizzites, Jebusites, and Amorites, and where the Moabites, Egyptians, and Ammonites lived. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your translation, how will you list the people or places with detestable practices that the leaders list to Ezra? Pause this audio here.

The Israelite men married some of the daughters or women of the foreign people. Also, some of the Israelite men's sons married some of the foreign women. The Israelite men and non-Israelite women have had children. The Israelites, the holy people whom Yahweh set apart for himself, are now mixed with people who are not Israelites. The leaders and officials of the Israelites were the ones who started marriage with foreigners; these men were the most unfaithful or disloyal of all the people. The Israelites were unfaithful because they did not keep their oath to Yahweh not to marry foreigners.

After Ezra listens to the leaders of the Israelites, Ezra shows everyone that he is very upset. Ezra mourns for the people of Israel who have been unfaithful to Yahweh. Ezra tears his clothes, pulls at his hair and beard, and sits down in silence.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words would you use to describe someone who sits in silence because they are very sad and who mourns? What special phrase do you use to describe the person? Pause this audio here.

Ezra sits and is silent for some time. We do not know how long Ezra sat because we do not know what time of day the leaders came to speak to Ezra. While Ezra sits, people come to be with Ezra and stay with Ezra. We do not know if all these people are different people from the leaders or if the leaders stay with Ezra and the new people join them. The storyteller uses a special phrase to describe the new people to help us to know that the people who join Ezra keep Yahweh's commands for the people of Israel. The storyteller says that these people "tremble at the words of the God of Israel." These people may not be trembling right now, but the storyteller describes the people in this way to show that these people are afraid of God. These people respect and honor God and God's laws for his people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The people who gather around Ezra are very strict followers of God. How will you translate that these people "tremble at the words of the God of Israel"? Pause this audio here.

The new people come to be with Ezra because they know the Israelites who returned to Jerusalem were unfaithful to Yahweh. Ezra stays in the same place until the evening, when it is time for the priests at the temple to make

the evening offering. You will remember that the evening offering was usually a grain offering, not an animal sacrifice. The other people stay with Ezra.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:1–4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Israelite leaders
- Ezra
- Israelite people
- Women from surrounding people groups and countries
- And Israelites who follow Yahweh's commands

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The Israelite leaders tell Ezra that the Israelite people have married people who are not Israelites. Ezra tears his clothes and pulls out his hair to show how upset Ezra is, and Ezra sits down to mourn.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Israelite leaders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are really worried. We know we have disobeyed Yahweh; or
- Ezra, we need to know what to do. Please help us; or
- Will Yahweh forgive us?

Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My people have sinned against Yahweh; or
- This is terrible. Yahweh may kill everyone who has married a foreign woman; or
- I am really sad and upset.

Ask the person playing the Israelite people, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We wanted to marry women and have a family; or
- We feel sad and frightened because we have sinned against Yahweh; or
- What should we do now?

Ask the person playing women from surrounding tribes and countries, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are married to Israelite men; or

- We want to have children and make a good home with the Israelite men; or
- We are confused because we did not know the men were doing something wrong.

Continue the drama.

Israelites who follow Yahweh's commands gather around Ezra until the time of the evening offering.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Israelites who follow Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Ezra mourns for our people; or
- We feel sad and worried; or
- What will Ezra tell us? or
- Will we survive Yahweh's judgement on us?

Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- How will we survive this? or
- I am overwhelmed by sadness for my people; or
- I need to pray to Yahweh.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:1–4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Some of the Israelite **leaders** come to Ezra. The leaders are important people in the Israelite community. Use the same word or phrase for leaders as you used in previous passages.

The people of **Israel**, the **priests**, and the **Levites** have not kept themselves separate. Use the same words or phrases for Israel, priests, and Levites as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel, priest, and Levite, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people have not kept separate from the "neighbouring people," the people from other lands who are not Israelites. The neighbouring people live next to the Israelite people in and near Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **neighbouring people**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The neighboring people do "detestable things" or "abominations." The people worship false gods.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **detestable practices**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites have mixed the "**holy** race" or "seed" with the people from surrounding lands. Use the same word for holy as you have used previously, and refer to holy in the Master Glossary for more information. The race or seed are the descendants of Israel who have returned to Jerusalem from Babylon.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **race** or **seed**. Look up seed in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

The leaders and **officials** have led the way in being unfaithful to Yahweh. We do not know the responsibilities of the two groups of people: the leaders and the officials. Officials help govern people, and the Babylonians may have appointed the officials. Leaders are a type of community leader, but the Babylonians may not have appointed them. Use the same word for official as you used in previous passages. The leaders and officials were unfaithful; they did not follow Yahweh's laws.

Ezra 9:1–4

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **unfaithfulness**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra tore the garment or tunic that Ezra wore close to his body.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a person who wears a tunic, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **tunic**. Look up tunic in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra tore his "mantle" or "cloak," which Ezra wore over his clothes.

Stop here and look at a picture of a person wearing a mantle or cloak as a group if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **cloak**. Look up cloak in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra was appalled. Ezra felt horrified.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe how Ezra felt when he was **horrified** or very, very sad. If you have already translated this feeling in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

People who trembled at the words of the **God** of Israel or God's law gathered around Ezra. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

People gathered because of the unfaithfulness of the **exiles**. Use the same word or phrase for exiles as you used in previous passages.

Ezra sat until the evening offering. The priests made an offering to Yahweh in the evening before the sun set.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **evening offering**. Look up offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 9:1–4

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (874 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Ezra 9:5–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 9:5–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:5–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:5–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage directly follows the previous passage. You will remember that the leaders of the Israelites in Jerusalem told Ezra that the Israelites in Jerusalem married people who were not Israelites and who did not obey Yahweh. Ezra was horrified and sat down to mourn for the Israelite people. Ezra sat and mourned until the evening. Some Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh came to be with Ezra. We do not know how many Israelites are with Ezra, or if they are only men or men and women. The previous story and this story take place in front of the temple in Jerusalem.

At the end of the day, at the time when the priests perform the evening offering, Ezra moves and gets up from his sitting position. Ezra's tunic and cloak are torn.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a person wearing a tunic. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a person wearing a cloak. Pause this audio here.

Ezra does not change his clothes. Ezra falls to his knees to show Yahweh that Ezra is humble. Ezra is not proud and does not feel good enough to stand in front of Yahweh. Ezra does not fall from a height or because he loses his balance. Ezra moves onto his knees quickly. It was more common for Israelites to pray to Yahweh standing or sitting. Ezra prays to Yahweh while on his knees to show that Ezra does not deserve respect. Ezra spreads out his hands to show that Ezra needs Yahweh's help.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you pray to God? How does a person's position of their body change if the person is praising God, saying sorry to God, or asking for help? Pause this audio here.

Ezra 9:5–15

Then, Ezra prays to Yahweh. Ezra prays out loud. Sometimes, Ezra talks to Yahweh personally, and at other times, Ezra uses his words in the prayer to talk to the people around him as well as to Yahweh. Ezra feels ashamed and embarrassed.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have one person pretend to have done something terrible and need to tell another person in the group what they have done wrong. Help the person who is pretending to have done something terrible to use their body to show how bad they feel. Pause this audio here.

Ezra calls on God, the almighty Creator God. Ezra does not use "Yahweh," God's personal name. Ezra addresses God directly as the God whom Ezra worships. Ezra bows his head to show how he feels. At Ezra's time, people looked up to imagine God in front of or above them. This was a usual way for people to worship and pray to God. Ezra did not feel able to look up to pray to Yahweh. Ezra uses creative language to talk about how big and how serious the Israelites' sins are. Ezra includes himself among the people who have sinned. Ezra talks about all the Israelites' guilt because the Israelites had disobeyed Yahweh for a long time.

Ezra knows all the bad things that happened to the Israelites because of the sins of the Israelite people. You may remember from the books of 2 Kings and 2 Chronicles that the Assyrians and Babylonians killed many Israelites and took many Israelites from Jerusalem to Babylon. The Babylonians stole the Israelites' belongings. The Babylonian and Assyrian kings shamed the Israelites. At the time of Ezra, the king of Persia reigned over the Israelites and the land Yahweh gave to the Israelites. You may remember that the Persians took control of Babylon and everything that the Babylonians owned.

Stop here and talk about a time when another people group ruled or controlled your land and people. What did the other people do to your people to show that they were in control of your people and your land? Pause this audio here.

Ezra continues to pray to God, and Ezra uses God's personal name, Yahweh. Ezra prays for everyone, and Ezra includes himself. Ezra talks about a short amount of time. This is about 80 years from the first return of the exiles to the present time for Ezra. Ezra knows that Yahweh was kind, generous, and showed mercy to the Israelites. Yahweh allowed a remnant, a small part of something, to remain. This remnant is the Israelites who survived the exile and came back to Jerusalem with Zerubbabel and Ezra. Yahweh gave the Israelites a small but secure hold in Yahweh's holy place, the rebuilt temple or Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about how your people arrived at the land where they now live. Pay particular attention to any part of the story that relates to how people claimed or took hold of the land. Pause this audio here.

Ezra says God gave light to Ezra and the Israelites' eyes. Yahweh gave hope and revived Ezra and the Israelites. God gave Ezra and the Israelites a better life in Jerusalem compared to life in Babylon. The Israelites are still slaves to the Persians, and there are still some Israelites in Babylon. The Persians own the Israelites, and the Israelites have to work for the Persians. However, God has not left or abandoned the Israelites as slaves in Babylon. God has shown kindness to the Israelites. We do not know if Ezra thinks the kings of Persia see God's love for the Israelites or if Ezra thinks God prompted the kings of Persia to make life better for the Israelites. Either way, God has caused the kings of Persia to make life better for the Israelites. During the brief time since Yahweh rescued the Israelites from exile in Babylon, Yahweh gave the Israelites permission to rebuild and repair the temple in Jerusalem. This happened before Ezra's time, but Ezra thanks God here. When the Persians allowed the Israelites to rebuild their temple, it was like the Israelites had a new and wonderful life! Ezra also says that Yahweh has given the Israelites a wall of protection in Judah and Jerusalem. Ezra does not mean an actual wall that people make from stone or bricks. Ezra means that the Persians are like a wall that gives protection to people and keeps the people safe. God is protecting the Israelites by causing the Persians to protect and keep the people safe.

Now Ezra asks God a question that he does not expect God to answer. Ezra uses the question to ask what the Israelites can do after everything that Ezra spoke about in the first part of Ezra's prayer. Ezra knows that the Israelites cannot do anything because the Israelites have disobeyed Yahweh's laws. Yahweh gave the laws or commands to Moses and other prophets who served Yahweh. Ezra remembers the laws in his prayer. First, Ezra quotes the law Yahweh gave to Moses that Moses wrote in Deuteronomy.

Ezra 9:5–15

Stop here and do this activity as a group: If possible, listen to your translation of Deuteronomy 7:1–3 in your own language as a group. Pause this audio here.

You will remember that Yahweh spoke to Moses about the Israelites going into and taking the promised land, Canaan. Yahweh describes the land as unclean because the Canaanite people make the land unclean with their abominations or detestable practices. The Canaanite people worship false gods. Yahweh commanded the Israelites not to marry the people who lived in Canaan. Yahweh also told Moses that the Israelites must not live peacefully with or be friends with the Canaanites. Yahweh did not want the Israelites to make a treaty of friendship with the people in Canaan. A treaty is an official agreement between two groups of people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when two groups of people met each other and made friends with each other. Pause this audio here.

Ezra quotes three blessings Moses wrote in Deuteronomy about how Yahweh will bless the Israelites if the Israelites follow Yahweh's commands. Yahweh will make the nation of Israel strong. Yahweh will give good things from the land to the Israelites. Yahweh will make it possible for the Israelites to pass the land from one generation to the next as an inheritance.

Ezra now starts the last part of his prayer to Yahweh. Ezra says to God and the people listening to Ezra that the deaths and exile of the Israelites happened because the Israelites disobeyed Yahweh. Ezra prays for himself and the Israelites but does not use "Yahweh," the personal name for God. Ezra thanks God for showing mercy and not punishing the Israelites with death. In Ezra's prayer, Ezra asks God and the Israelites a question that he does not expect God or the people to answer. Ezra asks if the Israelites should break Yahweh's laws again and marry people who are not Israelites. Ezra hopes that the Israelites will repent of the sin they did. Ezra wants the people who are listening to Ezra to answer "No" to Ezra's question.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about people in your community who have married people from outside of your community. Pause this audio here.

Ezra then asks God and the Israelites another question that Ezra does not expect God or the people to answer. Ezra asks if God would be angry enough to destroy the Israelites if the Israelites marry people who are not Israelites. Ezra knows that Yahweh's anger at sin can kill all the Israelites. Ezra wants the people who are listening to Ezra to answer "Yes" to Ezra's question.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Pretend to be parents trying to teach a child to do the right thing. What questions can a "parent" use to help teach the child? Try to ask questions of a child that the parent does not expect the child to answer. Pause this audio here.

Ezra directly talks to Yahweh, the God of Israel, to declare the truth that Yahweh is righteous. Ezra again states the fact that Yahweh has been good to leave a remnant, or small part of Israel, alive. Ezra has hope because Yahweh left a remnant before when the Israelites were disobedient. Ezra talks about the Israelites at Ezra's time. Ezra knows that Yahweh sees the Israelites as disobedient people who know that they have disobeyed Yahweh. In Ezra's time, someone who was not guilty of a crime stood before the judge so the judge could allow the person to go free. The Israelites cannot stand before God because the Israelites know they are guilty.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:5–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Ezra stands up. Then Ezra kneels and spreads out his hands and starts to pray.

In the second scene: Ezra continues to pray to his God. Ezra says he is ashamed. The Israelites are guilty of lots of sins. Foreign kings captured and killed the Israelites because of the Israelites' sins.

Ezra 9:5–15

In the third scene: In the next part of Ezra's prayer, Ezra prays to Yahweh, the God of Ezra and the Israelites. Ezra thanks Yahweh for showing the Israelites grace and mercy and for bringing some Israelites back to Jerusalem.

In the fourth scene: Ezra continues to pray to his and the Israelites' God. Ezra confesses that the Israelites have disobeyed God. Ezra quotes Yahweh's commands to Moses and the blessings for obedient Israelites.

In the fifth scene: Ezra finishes his prayer to God. Ezra thanks God for God's mercy to the Israelites. Ezra asks why the Israelites should test God again. Ezra tells Yahweh that Yahweh can judge Ezra and the Israelites.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh's commands
- Israelites who were unfaithful to Yahweh's commands
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This passage happens on the same day as the previous passage. We do not know how long Ezra sat with torn clothes. This passage starts in the evening of that day, when it was time for the evening offering. The priests make the evening offering at the end of the day when the sun is very low in the sky, close to sunset. Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh's commands are with Ezra. We do not know how many Israelites are with Ezra, or if these people are only men or men and women.

Ezra moves from sitting to standing and then to being on his knees. When Ezra moves to being on his knees, Ezra spreads out his hands in front of him. Ezra's arms and hands are probably in the air, not on the ground. Ezra bows his head down with his face toward the ground.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: If possible, sit on the ground. Then, move from sitting to standing and then move quickly onto your knees. Use your body's weight to drop down onto your knees. Reach out in front of you with your arms and hands. Now describe to each other the movements you made. Pause this audio here.

Ezra starts to pray. Ezra uses the prayer to speak to the people around Ezra as well as to pray to God. Ezra prays out loud. Ezra talks to God about how he feels. Ezra feels ashamed and embarrassed. When a person is embarrassed, a person may blush or have a red face. Ezra uses creative language to describe in a visual way something that people cannot see. Ezra says that his and the Israelites' iniquities, or sins, are higher than their heads. Ezra says that the Israelites' sins are so many that if someone were to put the sins in a pile, the pile would be taller than the people. Then Ezra says that his and the Israelites' guilt has reached to the heavens, all the way to Yahweh. In other words, the Israelites no longer have a right relationship with God because the Israelites have sinned. At the time of Ezra, it was common to think of Yahweh as being high up in the heavens away from the earth. Ezra says the Israelites' sin and guilt are very, very big. The guilt reaching the heavens is a way for Ezra to emphasize the huge amount of sins and for Ezra to say it in a strong way.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What creative or special language do you use to describe something very big in size or number? Pause this audio here.

Ezra talks about a time long ago by calling it the days of the Israelites' ancestors or fathers. Ezra means the people who were alive a long time ago. Ezra talks about a period of time from when the Babylonians captured the Israelites until Ezra's present time. Ezra talks to his God about the bad things that happened to the Israelites during their time in exile and says that the same things are happening to Ezra's people on the day of Ezra's prayer. Ezra also says that God gives the people into the hands, or power, of the kings of the lands nearby. Ezra talks about people using the sword against the Israelites to represent Babylonians, Assyrians, and Persians killing Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases do you use to talk indirectly about people killing other people? Pause this audio here.

Ezra stops praying about past events and starts to pray about the Israelites at Ezra's present time. In this part of the prayer, Ezra speaks to the Israelite people around him as well as to God. Ezra does not talk directly to God but refers to God like a person in a story. Ezra calls God by the personal name of Yahweh. Ezra knows that Yahweh has shown favor, or grace and mercy, to the Israelites by giving the Israelites good things. Ezra includes

himself in the Israelite people. Ezra describes the Israelites who are still alive as a remnant, a surviving portion of the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you describe a small group of people who were part of a larger group of people? Pause this audio here.

Ezra says that Yahweh has given the Israelites a secure hold or a firm place in Yahweh's holy place. In the original language, the Israelites used the word for a secure hold to refer to a place the people reach after a long journey. It can also mean a claim to a plot of land. Ezra uses special language to describe how God gives hope and encouragement to the Israelites. God used the good things to brighten or give light to the Israelite's eyes.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What imaginative ways do you use to talk about a person helping another person to have hope or to encourage another person? Pause this audio here.

Ezra talks about the ways God blesses the Israelites who are still alive at the time of Ezra. Ezra recognizes that the Israelites are still slaves. Ezra talks about God giving the Israelites a wall of protection. Ezra is using special language to talk about the Persian officials and government protecting the Israelites in Jerusalem and Judah. God is protecting the Israelites by causing the Persians to protect and keep the people safe.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What special language do you use to talk about something or someone giving protection to a person or people? Pause this audio here.

At this time in Ezra's prayer, Ezra talks directly to God again, but also speaks to the people around Ezra. Ezra prays to "our God" to speak for himself and the people around Ezra. Ezra does not use the personal name for God. Ezra uses a question that he does not expect anyone to answer to question what the Israelite people can say or do at the time of Ezra's prayer. Ezra says he and the Israelites are responsible for abandoning or not obeying God's laws. Ezra quotes from the law Yahweh gave to Moses before the Israelites entered Canaan. You may remember that the land of Canaan is unclean because the people who live there are unclean. This means that the people do detestable things, and that makes the people ritually unclean, or unfit to worship Yahweh. This is why Yahweh does not want the Israelites to do anything with these people or give their sons or daughters to marry these people. Yahweh did not want the Israelites to make a treaty or agreement to be friends with the other groups of people in Canaan.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about the activity in step two when you talked about two groups of people who agreed to be friends. What words did you use to describe the relationship between the two groups of people? Pause this audio here.

Then Ezra quotes the blessings Yahweh promised to the Israelites through Moses if the Israelites obeyed the law. If the Israelites avoid being friends with the people who live in the land of Canaan, the Israelites will be strong, and the land will be like an inheritance for their children.

Ezra finishes his prayer by speaking for the Israelites to God and to the Israelites around Ezra. Ezra uses his prayer to ask questions that he does not expect anyone to answer. Ezra asks what the Israelites will do next and what God will do to the Israelites. First, Ezra asks if the Israelites should break Yahweh's law on marriage again and intermarry with the people in the surrounding lands. Intermarriage describes when people from different social, racial, or religious groups marry each other. Ezra expects the answer to be no. Then, Ezra asks if their God's anger would be enough to destroy the rest of the Israelites if the Israelites continue to be unfaithful. At the end of Ezra's prayer, Ezra says what is true. Ezra calls on Yahweh, using the personal name for the God of Israel. Yahweh is just and righteous. The Israelites are a small surviving piece of the past larger nation, and the Israelites are guilty of disobeying Yahweh.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:5–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh's commands
- Israelites who were unfaithful to Yahweh's commands
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Ezra stands up. Then Ezra kneels and spreads out his hands and starts to pray.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel horrified and very sad; or
- What can we say to Yahweh? We do not deserve to live; or
- Maybe Yahweh will have mercy on us one more time?

Ask the person playing Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Look, Ezra is moving. What is Ezra going to do? or
- Should we pray too? or
- We feel very worried. We know some Israelites have disobeyed our God.

Continue the drama.

Ezra continues to pray to his God. Ezra says he is ashamed. The Israelites are guilty of lots of sins. Foreign kings captured and killed the Israelites because of the Israelites' sins.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel ashamed and embarrassed; or
- We have disobeyed God many, many times; or
- We are responsible for everything we have done wrong; or
- Our sins and disobedience caused our captivity and the death of our people.

Ask the person playing Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel guilty and ashamed; or
- Ezra is right. We are responsible for losing our land and becoming slaves.

Ask the person playing Israelites who were unfaithful to Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We were unfaithful and have not followed Yahweh's laws for us; or
- People captured and killed us because we did not keep Yahweh's laws.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad Ezra is talking to me; or
- Ezra is right. My people have sinned many times and are guilty of disobeying me; or
- I am sad and disappointed. My Israelites did not stay separate from other people, and my Israelites disobeyed me.

Continue the drama.

In the next part of Ezra's prayer, Ezra prays to Yahweh, the God of Ezra and the Israelites. Ezra thanks Yahweh for showing the Israelites grace and mercy and bringing some Israelites back to Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh, thank you for giving us hope and helping us; or
- Yahweh still cares about us; or
- Yahweh has brought some of us home.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love my people; or
- I have helped my people come home to Judah and Jerusalem; or
- The kings of Persia serve me to help my people.

Ask the person playing Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are grateful. Yahweh brought us home to Jerusalem; or
- Life is better here; or
- We are happy because we have built the temple again and can live in Jerusalem.

Ask the person playing Israelites who were unfaithful to Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It is good to live in Jerusalem; or
- We did not understand what God had done for us to keep us safe.

Continue the drama.

Ezra continues to pray to his and the Israelites' God. Ezra confesses that the Israelites have disobeyed God. Ezra quotes Yahweh's commands to Moses and the blessings for obedient Israelites.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I remember the law, and I love the law; or
- We have disobeyed Yahweh's commands to us; or
- Yahweh wants to bless us with good things for us and our children.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- You have broken my commands that I gave to Moses; or
- I want to bless my people if they obey me; or
- My people must not mix with people who do not worship me; or
- There is nothing you can do to make things right, but I will show mercy to you because I love my people.

Ask the person playing Israelites who were unfaithful to Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We forgot the laws; or
- We did not understand what we had to do to be Yahweh's people.

Ask the person playing Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What can we do? Can we make sacrifices to Yahweh to say we are sorry? or
- We disobeyed God's law; or
- Yahweh could not bless us.

Continue the drama.

Ezra finishes his prayer to God. Ezra thanks God for God's mercy to the Israelites. Ezra asks why the Israelites should test God again. Ezra gives himself and the Israelites to Yahweh's judgement.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh has shown us mercy; or
- Will my people see and understand that they must change and not marry people from other lands? or
- I give myself and my people to Yahweh. I trust Yahweh to judge us.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I did show mercy to my people; or
- My people need to learn to obey my commands; or
- My people disobeyed me again. I will decide what happens to my people.

Ask the person playing Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh saved us even though we did not deserve Yahweh to save us; or
- We are angry. Some of our people have put us all in danger because they did not follow Yahweh's laws; or
- What will happen now? Will Yahweh save us again?

Ask the person playing Israelites who were unfaithful to Yahweh's commands, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- No, we will not break Yahweh's commands again; or
- We are frightened. Will Yahweh judge us guilty? or
- We are confused. Have we made a terrible mistake when we married women who lived here?

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 9:5–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

At the time of the evening offering, Ezra got up. Use the same word or phrase for **evening offering** or sacrifice as you used in previous passages. Refer to "offering" in the Master Glossary for more information.

Ezra got up from his time of humiliation when he mourned and tore his clothes. Ezra mourned, fasted, and made himself humble before Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **humiliation**, the time when Ezra mourned for the people of Israel. Pause this audio here.

Ezra's **tunic** and **cloak** were torn. Use the same words or phrases for tunic and cloak as you used in previous passages. For more information on tunic and cloak, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra spread out his hands to **Yahweh**, Ezra's **God**. Yahweh is the personal name for God. Ezra's God created the whole world and is the God that the Israelites worship. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh and God as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up Yahweh and God in the Master Glossary.

Ezra tells God that Ezra feels ashamed. Ezra feels embarrassed and guilty on behalf of his people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **ashamed**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra 9:5–15

Ezra feels disgraced or embarrassed. Ezra feels like he has lost approval and respect from God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **disgraced**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites have many iniquities or sins. Iniquity is like sin, but it is a persistent and repeated behaviour that disobeys God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **iniquity**. Look up iniquity in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites' guilt has reached the heavens. Guilt is what a person has after they have sinned.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **guilt**. Look up guilt in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites' guilt has reached the **heavens**. Ezra imagines the guilt reaching to the place where God lives with his angels. Use the same word or phrase for heaven as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up heaven in the Master Glossary.

Foreign **kings** killed and captured Israelite kings. A king is someone who rules over a city or a group of people. Look up king in the Master Glossary for more information and translate king in the same way you have previously.

Foreign kings killed and captured Israelite **priests**. Priests were people who worked in the temple of God in Jerusalem. Use the same word or phrase for priest as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up priest in the Master Glossary.

Yahweh, the Israelites' God, has shown the Israelites grace, or favor, that they did not deserve. God shows grace when he does good things for people that those people do not deserve. In this case, God has been kind to the Israelites by leaving a small group, or "remnant" of people, who are faithful to God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **grace**. If you have already translated this idea in another part of the Bible, translate it here in a similar way. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh left a remnant of the Israelites. A remnant is a group of survivors who escape after enemies destroyed the rest of the people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **remnant**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh gave the Israelites a place in Yahweh's holy place or sanctuary. A holy place is a place that people dedicate to God. Ezra means that the temple and also Jerusalem as a whole are Yahweh's holy place.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **holy place**. Look up **sanctuary** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh has helped the Israelites in their **slavery**, or the life the Israelites live as slaves. Use the same word or phrase for slave as you used in previous passages, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information about slaves.

God has shown his steadfast love to the Israelites. Steadfast love is the loyal love of Yahweh, which does not change, become less, or end.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **steadfast love**. Look up steadfast love in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra says that Yahweh allowed the Israelites to rebuild the "**house of our God**," the temple in Jerusalem. Look up "house of God" and temple in the Master Glossary for more information, but remember that Ezra specifies that it is the house of "our" God.

Ezra 9:5–15

Yahweh has given the Israelites a wall of protection in **Judah** and Jerusalem. Use the same word or phrase for Judah as previously, and refer to Judah in the Master Glossary for more information.

The Israelites abandoned Yahweh's commands, which are Yahweh's laws and instructions.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **commands**. Look up **commandments** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh gave commands to Yahweh's **servants**, the prophets. Although this is the same word for servant or slave that the storyteller used when he said that the Israelites were slaves, these prophets did not perform small tasks for Yahweh. Here, the storyteller uses the idea of a servant to show that the prophets did the things Yahweh asked them to do. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh gave commands to his **prophets**. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Use the same word or phrase for prophets as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophets, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Israelites were entering a land that the people had made unclean by the things they did that were unclean.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **unclean** or **polluted**. Use the same word or phrase that you used for unclean in Ezra 2:62. Pause this audio here.

The people's **detestable practices** or **abominations** made the land impure. Use the same word or phrase for detestable practices or abominations as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh told the Israelites not to give their daughters in marriage to the sons of the Canaanite people. Marriage is the act in which two people marry each other. Marriage is also the relationship between two people who are married to each other.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **marriage**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh did not want the Israelites to make a treaty of friendship or to live in peace with the Canaanites.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for a **treaty of friendship**. Look up **peace** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here

Yahweh wants to bless the Israelites with an everlasting inheritance or possession. Yahweh wants the Israelites to own the land and pass the land on to their descendants.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **inheritance**. Look up **heir** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

What happened to the Israelites happened because of the Israelite's "evil deeds," actions which are bad and disobedient to God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **evil deeds**. Look up **evil** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra asks if the Israelites will intermarry with foreign people. When people from different racial or religious groups "intermarry," they marry each other.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **intermarry**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh is the God of **Israel**. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh is righteous. Everything Yahweh does is right and good.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **righteous**. Look up **righteousness** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 9:5–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (900 KB)
- Setting the Stage (7.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (6.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Ezra 10:1–8

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 10:1–8 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:1–8 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.

Ezra 10:1–8

6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage continues the story of Ezra in front of the temple in Jerusalem. The Israelite leaders told Ezra that the Israelites had disobeyed Yahweh, their God, because some of the Israelites had married women from the surrounding lands. The women are not Israelites and do not worship Yahweh. Ezra mourned and prayed for the people of Israel. The storyteller told us what Ezra prayed, and now, in this passage, the storyteller tells us how Ezra responds to the news from the leaders. Ezra prays to ask for help for the people of Israel. Ezra confesses the sins of the Israelites to God. Ezra shows signs of mourning by crying loudly and for a long time. Ezra prostrates himself. In other words, Ezra lay on the ground with his face down and forehead touching the ground. Ezra humbles himself in front of God. Ezra is in front of the house of God, the temple in Jerusalem.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the temple in Jerusalem and find the open space in front of the temple. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that many people gather around Ezra before and during Ezra's prayer and mourning. The group of people is an "assembly," a special group of people who come together for a special purpose, usually related to worship of God.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about a time when a large group of people came together to worship God. Now talk about a time when a large group of people came together for a different reason, maybe a wedding or other celebration. Notice what you call the group of people at these different times. Pause this audio here.

Men, women, and children gather around Ezra. The people are Israelites. The Israelite people also cry loudly and for a long time.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you and your people mourn or show great sadness? Pause this audio here.

Shecaniah, a man from the group of Israelites, talks to Ezra. Shecaniah's father was Jehiel. Shecaniah is part of the family group or clan of Elam. Elam was an ancestor of Shecaniah. Shecaniah speaks loudly and talks to the assembly as well as Ezra. Shecaniah says that the Israelites broke their oath to their God, and the Israelites are unfaithful. The Israelites married foreign women. The Israelite men asked the foreign women to live in the men's homes as the men's wives. The foreign women come from the land around Jerusalem, but these women are not Israelites. The foreign women worship different gods. Even though Shecaniah talks about the Israelites as if all of them were unfaithful, Shecaniah knows that only some Israelite men married foreign women.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about men and women who live together in your community. What types of formal commitments do you have in your community between men and women? Pause this audio here.

You may remember from the book of Deuteronomy that Yahweh commanded the Israelites not to marry the people from the tribes that lived in and around Canaan.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a man who married a woman from a different country or culture from his own. Was the woman from a long way away or from people who live next to the man's country? Pause this audio here.

Shecaniah tells Ezra and the Israelite assembly that there is hope. Shecaniah believes something good will happen. Shecaniah wants the Israelites to make a covenant or solemn promise to each other in the presence of their God. Shecaniah wants the Israelites to promise to send the foreign women away from the Israelite homes. Shecaniah also wants the Israelites to promise to send away the children of the foreign women. Some Israelite men and the foreign women had children together. Shecaniah suggests this action because Shecaniah listened to the advice or counsel from Ezra and those Israelites who are strict followers of Yahweh. Shecaniah wants the

Ezra 10:1–8

Israelites to follow their God's commands or law. Shecaniah tells Ezra to make a start right now to send away the foreign women and children. Shecaniah trusts Ezra to make good decisions for the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you encourage someone to quickly start to do something when the person feels scared and is frightened to start? Pause this audio here.

Ezra gets up to start to make the covenant with the assembly. Ezra makes a solemn promise with the leading priests, the Levite people, and all the Israelites at the assembly. The people promise Ezra that they will send away the foreign wives and their children. Ezra does not force the people to make the promise. Ezra walks away from the temple to a room or chamber nearby. The room was probably not part of the temple. The room may belong to Jehohanan, or the room may be named after Jehohanan. We do not know who Jehohanan is. Eliashib was the father of Jehohanan. Ezra uses the room during the night after he took the oaths of the people outside the temple. During the night after the events in the story, Ezra fasts and does not eat any food or drink any water. Ezra is very sad because the people who returned to Jerusalem from exile were not faithful to their God.

The Israelite leaders and elders make a proclamation. When someone speaks a proclamation, that person announces a message out loud to a group of people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time or times when a person spoke a proclamation to your people. How did the person speak it? Who spoke it? Pause this audio here.

The leaders' proclamation calls all the exiles, the people who have returned from Babylon, to gather as an assembly in Jerusalem. The leaders want all the men to come to Jerusalem. The men have three days to come to Jerusalem. The exiles lived close to Jerusalem, no further than three days' travel or 60 kilometers from Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map of Jerusalem and the lands of Judah and Benjamin. Look at the line around Jerusalem, which is 60 kilometers from Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Any Israelite man who does not come to Jerusalem will forfeit his property. In other words, the man will have to give up his property to the priests of the temple. The priests of the temple will own the man's property and may keep or destroy the property. The officials and elders will separate from the Israelites any man who does not come to Jerusalem. The officials and elders would not allow the man to join religious gatherings, and the Israelites would treat the man as a foreigner. You may remember that the Persian king gave authority to Ezra to make any decisions about the Israelites that Ezra needed to make. Even so, Ezra allowed the Israelite leaders to call the people and make the announcement.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, when can people in authority take away another person's property as a punishment? When might your community exclude someone from community events or a place of worship as a punishment?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: Ezra prays, confesses the Israelites' sins to God, cries, and prostrates himself in front of the temple. Israelites gather around Ezra and cry out loud.

In the second scene: Shecaniah speaks to Ezra and the Israelites. Shecaniah suggests the Israelites make a solemn promise to send away the foreign wives and their children and follow God's law. Shecaniah encourages Ezra to start the work.

In the third scene: Ezra makes the leading priests, Levites, and all the Israelites at the temple make a solemn promise to Ezra to send away the foreign wives and their children.

In the fourth scene: Ezra leaves the temple and goes to Jehohanan's room. Ezra does not eat or drink, and Ezra mourns because the exiles disobeyed God.

Ezra 10:1–8

In the fifth scene: Israelite leaders and elders send a message to all the exiles in the land of Judah and Jerusalem to come to Jerusalem within three days. Any man who does not come will have to give his property to the temple, and the rest of the Israelite community will separate itself from the man.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- A large group of Israelites
- Shecaniah, son of Jehiel
- Leading priests, Levites, and Israelites
- Israelite leaders and elders
- And the exiles in Judah and Jerusalem

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The storyteller continues the story about when Ezra hears about Israelite men who married foreign women. In the last passage, the storyteller tells us Ezra's prayer to Yahweh, the Israelites' God. Now the storyteller goes back to telling the story. The storyteller reminds us of everything Ezra did between the time the leaders told Ezra about the Israelite men and Ezra's prayer at the end of the day. The storyteller also tells us about the people who came to be with Ezra while Ezra mourned and then prayed. The large group of people cried loudly and for a long time. These people are in addition to the people who trembled at the words of God, who were around Ezra when Ezra started to pray.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases do you use to describe a group of people who are very sad and upset and cry loudly and for a long time? Pause this audio here.

Ezra and the large group of Israelite men, women, and children are in the open space in front of the house of God, the temple in Jerusalem.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the temple in Jerusalem and find the open space in front of the temple, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Shecaniah, son of Jehiel, speaks to Ezra and to the Israelite people. Shecaniah's ancestor was Elam. Shecaniah agrees with Ezra that all the Israelites were unfaithful to God. Israelite men married foreign women, and the foreign women live in the homes of the Israelite men with their children.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call people who come from a different culture or religion than you? Pause this audio here.

In the original language, Shecaniah does not use the normal words that the Israelites use to describe an Israelite marrying another Israelite. Shecaniah uses a different word, which the Israelites use to describe when an Israelite man takes a foreign woman into the Israelite man's home and lives with the woman as a wife for the Israelite man. Though these Israelite men considered and treated these foreign women as their wives, the Jewish law did not recognize these foreign women as legitimate wives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you describe the relationship between an Israelite man and a foreign woman where the Israelite man treats the foreign woman like a wife? Pause this audio here.

Shecaniah thinks that there is hope for Israel, the people who follow Yahweh. Shecaniah thinks the people can be faithful to their God and survive as a people. Shecaniah wants the Israelite people to make a covenant, a solemn promise, in the presence of the Israelites' God. Shecaniah wants the people to promise to send away all the foreign women from the Israelite men's homes. When a man sends away a foreign woman, it is like he divorces the woman. However, it is not a formal divorce according to Jewish law because the Israelite man and the foreign woman were not married according to Jewish law. Shecaniah wants the Israelite men to send away the children of the Israelite men and the foreign women. Shecaniah claims that it is Ezra and the people who tremble at the commands of God who want the people to make the covenant to follow God's law and send away their wives and children. Shecaniah thinks that Ezra is a wise man, and Shecaniah thinks that Ezra has made a good proposal. Shecaniah wants Ezra's understanding of the Jewish law to guide the Israelites' response. Shecaniah encourages Ezra. Ezra is responsible for deciding what the Israelites will do. Shecaniah tells Ezra that

Shecaniah and the other Israelites will support Ezra. Shecaniah tells Ezra to be brave and start doing something to help the Israelites.

Ezra moves from his place on the ground outside the temple. Ezra takes charge and leads the leading priests, Levites, and all the Israelite people around Ezra to make an official oath with God to send away the foreign women and their children. Everybody takes the oath.

After Ezra helps the Israelites make the oath to send away their foreign wives and children, Ezra leaves the open space in front of the temple and goes to a room. The room is near the temple in Jerusalem, in the living area for priests. In the room, Ezra continues to mourn and show great sadness that the exiles had disobeyed God. Ezra mourns through the night.

We do not know how much time passes between Ezra mourning in Jehohanan's room and the leaders and elders sending out a message to the exiles in Judah and Jerusalem. The elders and leaders want every Israelite man to come to Jerusalem within three days. The proclamation tells the people what will happen if someone does not obey the proclamation. A man who does not come to Jerusalem will have to give up all his possessions to the temple and will not be able to worship with the exiles.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call an oral message from community leaders to your people? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ezra
- A large group of Israelites
- Shecaniah, son of Jehiel
- Leading priests, Levites, and Israelites
- Israelite leaders and elders
- And the exiles in Judah and Jerusalem

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Ezra prays, confesses the Israelites' sins to God, cries, and prostrates himself in front of the temple. Israelites gather around Ezra and cry out loud.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Will Yahweh kill all of us now? or

Ezra 10:1–8

- We have been unfaithful to Yahweh and not followed Yahweh's commands to us; or
- I am so upset. Yahweh, please forgive us.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My people have been unfaithful; or
- I hear Ezra, my servant; or
- Many of my people are sad today. My people know that I will judge my people.

Ask the person playing the large group of Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh will punish us; or
- We are worried and frightened. Will we lose our land again? or
- Ezra mourns for us. Ezra must care about us.

Continue the drama.

Shecaniah speaks to Ezra and the Israelites. Shecaniah suggests the Israelites make a solemn promise to send away the foreign wives and their children and follow God's law. Shecaniah encourages Ezra to start the work.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Shecaniah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know what we can do to please Yahweh; or
- I want to help Ezra and my people. Maybe Yahweh will have mercy on us; or
- Let us do something now, Ezra. We can promise to send the foreign women and children away.

Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Shecaniah is right; or
- I feel hope for us; or
- Shecaniah will help me. I feel better now.

Ask the person playing the large group of Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Shecaniah is right; or
- We feel very sad. It will be hard to send away the foreign women and their young children from our homes; or
- We can make a promise today.

Continue the drama.

Ezra makes the leading priests, Levites, and all the Israelites outside the temple make a solemn promise to Ezra to send away the foreign wives and their children.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am relieved. We are making a good decision today; or
- Yahweh sees our promise; or
- I hope Yahweh forgives us.

Ask the person playing leading priests, Levites, and Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It feels good to make this promise to Ezra; or
- Will Yahweh forgive us? or
- We need to make sure we know which women and children to send away.

Continue the drama.

Ezra leaves the temple and goes to Jehohanan's room. Ezra does not eat or drink, and Ezra mourns because the exiles disobeyed God.

Ezra 10:1–8

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so sad; or
- I am worried about the Israelites who came back from Babylon; or
- Yahweh, please forgive us.

Continue the drama.

Israelite leaders and elders send a message to all the exiles in the land of Judah and Jerusalem to come to Jerusalem within three days. Any man who does not come will have to give his property to the temple, and the rest of the Israelite community will separate itself from the man.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Israelite leaders and elders, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We need to keep our promise to send away the foreign women and the children; or
- We hope every man comes to Jerusalem; or
- We hope this will stop Yahweh from destroying us.

Ask the person playing the exiles in Judah and Jerusalem, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- All our men must go to Jerusalem; or
- We need to be obedient to our leaders and to Yahweh; or
- We do not want the priests to take our belongings. We want to be part of the people of Israel.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Ezra **prays** and confesses to Yahweh. Ezra knows the Israelites were disobedient to God and tells God about all the wrong things the Israelites did. Use the same word or phrase for pray as you used in previous passages, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information if needed.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for “**confesses**.” If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here

Ezra **weeps**. Ezra is very sad and cries loudly and for a long time. Use the same word or phrase for weeps as you used in previous passages.

Ezra is in front of the **house of God**. Ezra is in front of the temple in Jerusalem. Use the same words or phrases for “house of God” and God as you used in previous passages. For more information on “house of God,” temple, and God, refer to the Master Glossary.

A great assembly of men, women, and children from Israel, or “**Israelites**,” gathered around Ezra. Use the same word or phrase for Israelites as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israelites, refer to the Master Glossary.

An assembly is a group of people who gather together for a particular purpose.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **assembly**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Shecaniah is a **descendant** of Elam. Use the same word or phrase for descendant as you used in previous passages. For more information on descendant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Shecaniah says the Israelites have been **unfaithful** to God. Use the same word or phrase for unfaithful as you used in previous passages.

Ezra 10:1–8

Some Israelites married foreign women. The foreign women are the wives of Israelites and live in the homes of the Israelites. The married relationship between the foreign woman and the Israelite man is not an official marriage.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **married** in this story. Pause this audio here.

Some Israelites married foreign women. The women are not Israelites and come from outside the Israelite community. The storyteller uses a word for foreign that is not very positive. These are the kinds of foreigners that do not belong in a place.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **foreign**, or a foreign person who does not belong in that place. Pause this audio here.

Shecaniah has hope for **Israel**, the people of Israel. Shecaniah feels that he can trust God that something good will happen to the people of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for Israel as you have previously, and refer to Israel in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **hope**. Look up hope in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Shecaniah wants the Israelites to make a covenant, which is a solemn promise.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **covenant**. Look up covenant in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Shecaniah wants the Israelites to follow the Law. The Law usually refers to all the commands that Yahweh gave to Moses. Although there is no law of Moses that says an Israelite must send away a foreign wife, the law does say that Israelites are not supposed to marry wives from the lands near them. And, the law states that an Israelite man can divorce a wife who does not please the man.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Law**. Look up law in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Ezra makes the **leading priests** and **Levites** take an oath. These men are leaders among the priests and the Levites. Use the same words or phrases for leading priests and Levites as you used in previous passages. For more information on priests and Levites, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people took the oath. The people made a very serious promise in the presence of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **oath**. Look up oath in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The leaders made a **proclamation** for the **exiles** to come together in Jerusalem. The leaders gave a loud, spoken, formal message to the people who returned from Babylon. Use the same words or phrases for proclamation and exiles as you used in previous passages.

A person who does not come to Jerusalem will forfeit all their property. The property will no longer belong to the person.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **forfeit**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The **officials** and **elders** will decide if anybody has to forfeit their property. Use the same words or phrases for officials and elders as you used in previous passages. For more information on elders, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 10:1–8

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (875 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Ezra 10:9–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 10:9–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:9–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:9–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Ezra 10:9–17

In this story, we hear what happens when the people assemble in Jerusalem. The story continues on from the previous story. At the end of the previous story, the Israelite leaders and elders sent out a proclamation to all the Israelites in the areas of Judah and Jerusalem. The Israelite leaders and elders told the Israelite men to come to Jerusalem. The men have three days to come to Jerusalem.

The Israelites obey Ezra's proclamation. All the Jewish men who live in the lands Yahweh gave to Judah and Benjamin arrive in Jerusalem. On the twentieth day of the ninth month in the year, the people gather and wait in the open space in front of the temple.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the temple in Jerusalem. Find the open space in front of the temple. Pause this audio here.

In Ezra's time, there were usually 12 months in a year. The ninth month was at the beginning of colder weather. In Jerusalem at this time of year, the weather was often cold with lots of rain.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does the weather change in your area through the year? What time of year is colder? What time of year do you have more rain? Pause this audio here.

The people in the open space were very unhappy. The people were trembling because of worry and fear about what Ezra might say or what their God might do to them. The people were also trembling because they were cold and wet. Ezra told the men that they had broken God's command because the men married foreign women. These men's sins increased Israel's guilt. The men's sins were in addition to the sins of Israel that made God allow the Babylonians to exile the Israelites many years ago. Ezra wants the men to give honor, thanks, and respect to Yahweh and do what pleases Yahweh. Ezra tells the Israelite men to be separate from the people who do not follow Yahweh and from their foreign wives.

All the men in front of the temple call out to answer Ezra. The men say that Ezra is right and that the Israelite men have to do what Ezra said to the men. Some Israelite men then give reasons why the Israelite men cannot do what Ezra wants on that day. We do not know which men speak to Ezra. The Israelite men say that there are too many men for the elders to make a judgement about in one day. The Israelite men also say that on that day, it is raining too much for the men to stand outside to consider each man with a foreign wife. The storyteller then tells us that the Israelites cannot take care of the problem in a day or two because the Israelites have sinned a lot by taking foreign wives. The Israelite men are probably saying that this is too important a matter to consider quickly and too complicated to make a general solution for everyone. When the men say that it is too important to deal with "in a day or two," the men are probably talking about an unknown length of time as opposed to exactly one or two days. The people in the assembly propose to Ezra a way to carry out Ezra's instructions to the Israelites. The men propose that leaders or officials in the Israelite community do the work of the assembly. The men propose that the leaders set a time in each town for a meeting between men married to foreign women and the elders and judges of the town. At the meeting, the elders and judges will consider the marriage and make a decision. The elders are respected and responsible members of the Israelite community. The judges are Israelite men who support and maintain the laws of the community and help to organise the community.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call the people in your community who help to organise and lead your community and make sure people follow the laws of your community? Pause this audio here.

The Israelite elders and judges will work until the elders and judges judge every man, and the Israelite men are separate from the foreign women and their children. When the Israelites finish the action, God will stop being very angry with the Israelites for marrying foreign wives.

The storyteller tells us that Jonathan, son of Asahel, and Jahzeiah, son of Tikvah, disagreed with the assembly's proposal. Asahel is the father of Jonathan, and Tikvah is the father of Jahzeiah. We do not know why Jonathan and Jahzeiah disagreed with the proposal. It is possible that the two men do not want to give up their foreign wives, or alternatively, the two men may not want to wait for a decision about their marriages. Meshullam and Shabbethai the Levite supported Jonathan and Jahzeiah. We do not know if these men agreed with Jonathan and Jahzeiah or if they agreed with the proposal. Meshullam may be the same Meshullam who traveled with Ezra to Jerusalem. Shabbethai may be the leader of the Levites that the storyteller of Nehemiah tells us about.

Ezra 10:9–17

The storyteller tells us that the exiles, the Israelites who returned from Babylon to Jerusalem, followed the plan the Israelite men proposed to Ezra outside the temple in Jerusalem. Ezra chose men who were leaders of the clans, the family groups. Ezra named each person whom Ezra chose to investigate each case or situation of marriage. The leaders started to investigate and find out the truth about the marriages of Israelite men on the first day of the tenth month. This day was ten days after the assembly at the temple in Jerusalem. The leaders finished their work by the first day of the first month of the next year. It took the leaders three months to decide what to do in all the situations where Israelite men married foreign wives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time someone investigated or looked for the truth in a difficult or complicated situation in your community or in your family. Who investigated the situation? How long did it take the person to find out what happened?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:9–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: For three days, the Israelite men who live in the areas of Judah and Benjamin travel from their homes to Jerusalem.

In the second scene: The Israelite men from the areas of Judah and Benjamin wait in the open space in front of the temple. The Israelite men are worried and uncomfortable because they do not know what will happen, and they are cold and wet. Ezra tells the Israelite men that they were unfaithful to God and even more guilty now than they were before. The Israelite men must live separately from the people who are not Israelites, and the Israelite men must send away the foreign wives of the Israelites. The Israelite men agree and propose a plan to judge what each man with a foreign wife should do. Some men did not agree with what the people said in the open space in front of the temple.

In the third scene: Ezra chooses leaders from the Israelite clans to consider each situation of an Israelite man married to a foreign woman.

In the fourth scene: For three months, the community leaders investigate all the Israelite men with foreign wives and make decisions for the Israelite men.

The characters in this passage are:

- All the Israelite men from Judah and Benjamin, including the men who had married foreign women
- Ezra
- Jonathan, Jahzeiah, Meshullam, and Shabbethai
- And heads of Israelite family groups

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the previous story, the leaders and elders sent out a proclamation to call the Israelite men in Judah and Jerusalem to meet in Jerusalem. This story starts three days after the end of the previous story. The Israelites hear the proclamation, and the men go to Jerusalem. All the men go to Jerusalem during the three days after the proclamation.

All the men go to the open space in front of the temple on the twentieth day of the ninth month. We do not know if this is the third day after the proclamation or the next day after the third day. The men gather and wait in the square. The square was an open area within a city or group of buildings. In this case, this is the area in front of the temple. We do not know if everyone is sitting down or if some are sitting and some are standing.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the temple in Jerusalem. Find the open space in front of the temple, if needed. Pause this audio here.

All the men trembled or shivered. The storyteller makes it clear that the men trembled for two reasons. The men trembled because they were worried, and the men trembled because they were cold and wet from the rain.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call cold rain that makes people very wet and lasts a long time? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you make it clear in your translation that the men trembled for two reasons? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller reminds us that Ezra is a priest. Ezra speaks to the men in front of the temple and tells the men what they have done wrong. Ezra uses many of the same words and phrases that Ezra used in earlier passages. The men took foreign women as wives into their homes. Ezra tells the men that they have increased Israel's guilt. The people of Israel are more deserving of God's judgement and punishment than before. Ezra wants the men to admit to Yahweh what the men have done wrong and do what Yahweh wants them to do. Ezra wants the men to be separate from the people from the surrounding lands who are not Israelites. Ezra also wants the men to send away their foreign wives.

Everyone in the assembly replies to Ezra with a loud voice. The people agree with Ezra.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have one person stand apart from the group. Have the rest of the group stand together and say together "Yes" and "We agree." Afterward, talk about how your voices sounded when you spoke together. Pause this audio here.

Some people speak to suggest a plan to Ezra. The men know it will take a long time to look at every relationship between an Israelite man and a foreign woman. There are too many relationships for Ezra to look at on his own. People cannot stay outside because it is cold and wet. The Israelite men know it is important to make everything right because the Israelite men know many people are disobeying Yahweh.

The men in the assembly suggest to Ezra a way to find all the men who have foreign women in their homes as wives. The assembly wants officials to do the work for all the Israelite men. The elders and judges of each town will set times to meet with men who have married foreign women. The elders and judges will meet with men until they are finished so that God's anger will turn away from the Israelites. The Israelite men use special language to describe God's very strong anger at the Israelites. God's anger is fierce, just like something hot or burning.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases do you use to describe a person's intense and strong anger toward a person or people? Pause this audio here.

Jonathan and Jahzeiah opposed what the people said. Meshullam and Shabbethai supported Jonathan and Jahzeiah. We do not know what Jonathan and Jahzeiah oppose. The men may not want to separate from their foreign wives, or the men may not want the elders and judges to judge each marriage so slowly.

The storyteller finishes the story by telling us that the exiles, the Israelites who came back from Babylon with Zerubbabel and afterward, followed the plan from the assembly. Ezra chooses men who are heads of families. Ezra chooses one man from each family division or clan and names the men. The storyteller tells us that the chosen men started to investigate the cases, the situations of men with foreign wives. The men started to work on the first day of the tenth month. The men finished all the cases by the first day of the first month of the following year. The men took three months to investigate all the cases.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the time the Israelites took to investigate all the cases? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:9–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

Ezra 10:9–17

The characters in this passage are:

- All the Israelite men from Judah and Benjamin, including the men who had married foreign women
- Ezra
- Jonathan, Jahzeiah, Meshullam, and Shabbethai
- And heads of Israelite family groups

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

For three days, the Israelite men who live in Judah and Benjamin travel from their homes to Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing all the Israelite men from Judah and Benjamin, including the men who had married foreign women, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is important. We must go to Jerusalem; or
- We are worried. Some of us have made Yahweh angry; or
- There are so many men in Jerusalem. Everyone listened to our leaders.

Continue the drama.

The Israelite men from Judah and Benjamin wait in the open space in front of the temple. The men are worried and uncomfortable because they do not know what will happen, and the men are cold and wet. Ezra tells the men the Israelite men were unfaithful to God and even more guilty now than they were before. The Israelite men must live separately from the people who are not Israelites, and the Israelite men must send away the foreign wives of the Israelites. The Israelite men agree and propose a plan to consider each man with a foreign wife. Some men did not agree with what the people said in the square.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing all the men of Judah and Benjamin, including the men who had married foreign women, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are cold and wet. This is a terrible time of the year to stand outside in front of the temple; or
- Ezra tells us the truth. We need to do something; or
- Yahweh is angry with us. Yahweh may kill us all or make us leave Jerusalem again; or
- We need wise people in our community to look at each marriage of an Israelite to a foreign woman.

Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want everybody to understand that Israel is in danger; or
- I am so worried and frightened for us; or
- Now every Israelite man must be faithful to Yahweh and not have a foreign wife; or
- We need a plan to stop Yahweh's anger at us.

Ask the person playing Jonathan, Jahzeiah, Meshullam, and Shabbethai, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Will we separate ourselves from the foreign wives in time to stop Yahweh from punishing us? or
- We do not know if this is the right plan to stop Yahweh's anger; or
- We are worried about the plan.

Continue the drama.

Ezra 10:9–17

Ezra chooses leaders from the Israelite clans to judge each situation of an Israelite man with a foreign wife.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ezra, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- These are wise men. The Israelite community trusts these men; or
- Now everybody will know which men will look at the cases of Israelite men married to foreign wives; or
- I feel relief. Yahweh will be pleased with us.

Ask the person playing heads of Israelite family groups, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Ezra chose us to make good decisions; or
- We need to look at all the information to make a good decision; or
- There is a lot of work for us. We are happy to do the work to stop Yahweh's anger.

Continue the drama.

For three months, the community leaders investigate all the Israelite men with foreign wives and make decisions for the Israelite men.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing heads of Israelite family groups, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We must listen to all the information to make a good decision; or
- The men in our community trust us to do a good job; or
- We must keep going until we have looked at every case.

Ask the person playing all the men of Judah and Benjamin, including the men who had married foreign women, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We trust our elders to listen to us and make the right decision for us; or
- We are sad. We made a bad decision to marry foreign women. We made Yahweh angry; or
- We will miss our wives and children.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:9–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

All the men from the areas of **Judah** and Benjamin gathered in Jerusalem. Use the same words or phrases for Judah and Jerusalem as you used in previous passages. For more information on Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people sat in the square. A square is a flat, open space where people can gather. A square is usually surrounded by buildings.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the temple in Jerusalem. Find the open space, the square, in front of the temple, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **square**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The people sat in front of the **house of God**. Use the same word or phrase for house of God as you used in previous passages. Refer to "house of God" and temple in the Master Glossary for more information.

Ezra the **priest** stood up and told the men that the men had been **unfaithful**. Use the same words or phrases for priest and unfaithful as you used in previous passages. For more information about priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Israelite men **married foreign** women. The Israelite men and foreign women had formal relationships like marriage but not an official marriage. The word here is not the usual word to use for marry because the marriages

Ezra 10:9–17

were not official marriages. Use the same words or phrases for married and foreign as you used in previous passages.

The Israelite men added to **Israel**'s **guilt**. Use the same words or phrases for Israel and guilt as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel and guilt, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ezra tells the men to make a confession to **Yahweh**. Yahweh is the personal name for God. Be sure to translate Yahweh in the same way as you have in previous passages, and remember that Yahweh is in the Master Glossary.

Yahweh is the **God** of the Israelite's **ancestors**. Use the same words or phrases for God and ancestors as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

The **assembly**, or group of Israelites, responded to Ezra. Use the same word or phrase for assembly as you used in previous passages.

The people in the assembly say that they have transgressed against Yahweh. A transgression is like a sin. When someone "transgresses" or does something wrong towards Yahweh or another person, the person causes great offense to that person.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **transgression**. For more information about transgression, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The Israelite men want Israelite **officials** to act for the whole assembly. Use the same word or phrase for officials as you used in previous passages.

The **elders** and **judges** of each town will meet with men who married foreign women. An elder is a person with authority in a community. A judge is a person in the community who makes judgements and decisions about the law. Use the same words or phrases for elders and judges as you have in previous passages, and refer to elder and judge in the Master Glossary for more information.

Use the same word for **town** as you used in previous passages. Here, town is a general word for a settlement of people of any size, from very small to a big city with walls around it.

The **exiles** did what the Israelite men proposed. Use the same word or phrase for exiles as you used in previous passages.

Ezra chose men who were "**family heads**" or leaders. Use the same word or phrase for family heads as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 10:9–17

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (879 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Ezra 10:18–24

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 10:18–24 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:18–24 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:18–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this story and the next story, the storyteller ends the story about Ezra and the Israelites with foreign wives. You will remember that some Israelite men took foreign women, women who were not Israelite, into their homes. The Israelite men lived with the women in the same way as an Israelite man married and lived with an Israelite woman. Ezra knew that some Israelite men had disobeyed Yahweh and married foreign women. Ezra and the Israelite leaders agreed to judge the Israelite men and make sure the Israelite men separated themselves from their foreign wives.

In this story, the storyteller tells us which Israelite men married foreign women. The storyteller starts with a list of Israelite men who are the sons or descendants of priests. You will remember that Yahweh set apart the Levite tribe to serve Yahweh. In the Levite tribe, Yahweh chose some people to be Yahweh's priests. The men descended from Yahweh's priests served Yahweh as priests from one generation to the next. The priests were important religious leaders.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What families or people in your community or country, if any, are important, special, or set apart for special work? How do ordinary people expect the special people to behave? How do the laws of your people apply to the special people? Pause this audio here.

In the time of Zerubbabel, a man named Jeshua, also known as Joshua, was the high priest in Jerusalem. You will remember that the storyteller identifies families of men by an important ancestor. In this story, the storyteller uses Jeshua as the important ancestor for the men descended from the high priest. Jeshua's father was Jozadak. In some translations, the storyteller calls Jozadak "Jehozadak." You may remember from Ezra 2:36

that the storyteller identifies this Jeshua as from the larger family of Jedaiah. In this part of the story in Ezra, the storyteller uses this Jeshua to identify the family because Jeshua was an important person. Jeshua led the family back to Jerusalem from Babylon.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you identify different family groups in your community? Is there a connection between the way you identify family groups and significant ancestors in the families? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that the first group of men is from Jeshua's family and Jeshua's brothers. The storyteller may not mean brothers who have the same father and mother as Jeshua. The storyteller uses the word "brothers" to mean other priests who are related by blood to Jeshua and are part of Jeshua's wider family.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about people who are part of your wider family. The wider family is the people you are related to by blood but do not have the same father and mother as you. Pay attention to how you describe your wider family. Pause this audio here.

Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah were male descendants of Jeshua. You will remember that it was common to call male descendants the sons of a significant ancestor. The storyteller tells us that these men gave their hands as a pledge or promise to separate from their wives. The storyteller does not mean that the men actually gave their hands to somebody. At the time of Ezra, a person shook or held hands with another person to show their promise to that person.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What things do you do to make a strong agreement or promise with someone? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller also tells us that Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah each gave a ram to the temple for the priests to sacrifice as a guilt offering. A ram is an adult male sheep.

Stop here and look at a picture of a ram as a group. Pause this audio here.

The ram came from the group or flock of sheep that the Israelites kept for sacrifices. The men gave the rams for sacrifice because the men had broken Yahweh's law. You may remember that an Israelite person would make this offering whether the person purposely or accidentally disobeyed a law. The Israelite men at the time of Ezra did not know Yahweh's law very well. The Israelite men probably did not mean to be unfaithful to Yahweh when the men took foreign women as wives. It is not clear from the story whether all the Israelite men who were guilty of marrying foreign women made guilt offerings. It is possible that only Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah made sacrifices. However, Yahweh's law taught the Israelites that everyone who broke Yahweh's law should make a guilt offering to Yahweh.

The storyteller continues the list of guilty men by telling us about the other priest families. In the family of Immer, Hanani and Zebadiah were guilty. In the family of Harim, Maaseiah, Elijah, Shemaiah, Jehiel, and Uzziah were guilty. In the family of Pashhur, Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, and Elasah were guilty. Immer, Harim, and Pashhur were not alive at the time of this story. Immer, Harim, and Pashhur are the significant ancestors in these three other priest families. You will notice that there are men with the same names in different families. The repeated names in the different families are different people who share a common name. We do not know anything about the men in the list.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some common names that people give to more than one person in your community? Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller tells us about the Levite men who were not priests but who are also guilty. The storyteller tells us of a group of six Levite men who are guilty, but does not tell us which family or families these men come from. However, the men are probably descendants of Jeshua and Kadmiel. The six Levite men are Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah, also known as Kelita, Pethahiah, Judah, and Eliezer. Earlier in the book of Ezra, the storyteller told us that Jozabad received the gifts for the temple from Ezra. Also, the storyteller of Nehemiah tells us that Jozabad and Kelita helped to explain the Law. We also know from Nehemiah that Jozabad was a Levite leader who supervised the people who worked on the outside of the temple. The storyteller of Nehemiah 10:10 also tells us that Kelita put his name on the written covenant.

Ezra 10:18–24

The next person comes from the group of Levites who are musicians or singers. You will remember that the musicians are the descendants of Asaph, who sing and make music in the temple. Eliashib the musician was guilty.

The last group of Levites who were guilty were from the gatekeepers. The gatekeepers were people responsible for guarding the temple and the entrances of the temple. The gatekeepers took care of the rooms and the valuable objects in the temple. The gatekeepers were not soldiers. Shallum, Telem, and Uri from the gatekeepers were guilty.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:18–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller introduces the list of guilty men and tells us the four guilty men from the family of Jeshua, son of Jozadak. The men are Levite priests.

In the second scene: The storyteller tells us that the guilty men promise to separate themselves from their wives and each give a ram as a guilt offering.

In the third scene: The storyteller tells us the two guilty men who are descendants of Immer, the five guilty men who are descendants of Harim, and the six guilty men who are descendants of Pashhur. All the men are Levite priests.

In the fourth scene: The storyteller tells us six more Levite men who are guilty.

In the fifth scene: The storyteller tells us that one man from the musician Levites is guilty and that three men from the gatekeeper Levites are guilty.

The characters in this passage are:

- Storyteller
- The guilty Levite priest descendants of Jeshua: Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah
- The guilty Levite priest descendants of Immer: Hanani and Zebadiah
- The guilty Levite priest descendants of Harim: Maaseiah, Elijah, Shemaiah, Jehiel, and Uzziah
- The guilty Levite priest descendants of Pashhur: Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, and Elasah
- The guilty Levites: Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah, Pethahiah, Judah and Eliezer
- The guilty musician, Eliashib
- And the guilty gatekeepers: Shallum, Telem, and Uri

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story continues from the previous passage when the Israelites decided which men had foreign wives. The storyteller finishes the story now by telling us a list of the men who broke Yahweh's law and were guilty. The storyteller starts the list by telling us about the men from Levite priest families, the important religious leaders of the community. The storyteller divides the list into groups of men according to the family each man belongs to. Each family group is identified as the descendants or sons of an important ancestor. The first group of men is the descendants of Jeshua and Jeshua's brothers or close family. The guilty men are Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words do you use to describe people who are related to each other by blood? Think about words that indicate a specific relationship as well as words that are more general. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller pauses the list to tell us that the guilty men gave their hands as a promise to send away their wives. You will remember that this is special language that means the men held or shook another person's hand with their own hand.

Ezra 10:18–24

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you say someone has made an agreement with, or a promise to, another person to do something? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller also tells us that each man brought a ram to the priests at the temple to make a guilt offering.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together four small objects and place them in a group in front of you. The four objects represent the four guilty men. Now find four more small objects. These objects represent the four rams that the men bring to the priests for the sacrifice. Place these objects in front of you and take away the other objects to represent how the rams take the punishment for the guilt of these men. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller returns to the list of guilty men who were Levite priests. The next group of men are descendants of Immer. The guilty men are Hanani and Zebadiah.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together two more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The next group of men are descendants of Harim. The guilty men are Maaseiah, Elijah, Shemaiah, Jehiel, and Uzziah.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together five more small objects. Like before, place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activities before this one. Pause this audio here.

The last group of Levite priests is descendants of Pashhur. The guilty men are Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, and Elasah.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together six more small objects. Like before, place these objects together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activities before this one. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller now tells us about other groups of Levite men who are guilty. The storyteller does not tell us the family or families of the men in the first group of Levites who are not priests. The guilty Levite men are Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah, who is also known as Kelita, Pethahiah, Judah, and Eliezer.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together six more small objects. Place these objects together in a group near the other groups of objects. Leave a bigger space between these objects and the groups of objects from the activities before this one to show that these men are Levites but are not priests. Pause this audio here.

The next group of men is temple musicians or singers. There is only one guilty musician. The man is called Eliashib.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect one small object. Place this object next to but separate from the group of six objects in the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The last group of Levite men in the list is the gatekeepers for the temple. The guilty men are Shallum, Telem, and Uri.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together three more small objects. Like before, place the objects together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects in the activity before this one. Notice all the different objects that represent all the guilty Levite men. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:18–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Storyteller
- The guilty Levite priest descendants of Jeshua: Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah
- The guilty Levite priest descendants of Immer: Hanani and Zebadiah
- The guilty Levite priest descendants of Harim: Maaseiah, Elijah, Shemaiah, Jehiel, and Uzziah
- The guilty Levite priest descendants of Pashhur: Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, and Elasah
- The guilty Levites: Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah, Pethahiah, Judah, and Eliezer
- The guilty musician, Eliashib
- And the guilty gatekeepers: Shallum, Telem, and Uri

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The storyteller introduces the list of guilty men and tells us the four guilty men from the family of Jeshua, son of Jozadak. The men are Levite priests.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the storyteller, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- These are the men who had foreign wives; or
- I am pleased. The elders worked hard to find the men who were unfaithful; or
- Even the priests and the other Levites were unfaithful and did not follow Yahweh’s law.

Ask the person playing the guilty Levite priest descendants of Jeshua: Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We feel ashamed. We did not know that we were unfaithful to Yahweh; or
- We did not learn Yahweh’s laws for us when we were in Babylon; or
- We will learn from Ezra and follow Yahweh’s laws from now on.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller tells us that the guilty men promise to separate themselves from their wives and each give a ram as a guilt offering.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the storyteller, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- These men made the correct offering for their guilt.

Ask the person playing the guilty Levite priest descendants of Jeshua: Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are so sorry for our mistake. We do not want Yahweh to be angry with us; or
- We want to follow Yahweh’s laws; or
- We have made the right offering to God to pay for our sin; or
- We hope Yahweh will not punish Israel anymore.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller tells us the two guilty men who are descendants of Immer, the five guilty men who are descendants of Harim, and the six guilty men who are descendants of Pashhur. All the men are Levite priests.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the guilty descendants of Immer, Harim, and Pashhur, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We made a terrible mistake; or
- We want to follow Yahweh’s laws and be faithful priests; or
- We feel ashamed.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller tells us six more Levite men who are guilty.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the guilty Levites: Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah, Pethahiah, Judah, and Eliezer, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We want to serve Yahweh and be faithful to Yahweh; or
- We will follow Yahweh’s laws from now on; or
- We hope Yahweh will not punish us anymore.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller tells us that one man from the musician Levites is guilty and that three men from the gatekeeper Levites are guilty.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the guilty musician, Eliashib, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I made a mistake because I did not know the law; or
- I will do the right thing now and send my wife away; or
- I want to serve Yahweh in the temple, as my ancestors did.

Ask the person playing the guilty gatekeepers, Shallum, Telem, and Uri, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are very sorry that we had wives who were not Israelites; or
- We will follow Yahweh’s laws; or
- We feel sad that our wives are gone, but we must obey our elders.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:18–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Some of the male **descendants** or “sons” of the **priests** had **married foreign** women. You will remember that the storyteller uses the word sons to mean male descendants. Use the same words or phrases for descendants or sons, priests, married, and foreign as you used in previous passages. For more information on descendants and priests, refer to the Master Glossary.

The descendants of Joshua “gave their hands in pledge” to put away their wives. Each man shook or clasped his hand with an elder’s hand as a sign of the man’s promise to separate from his foreign wife or wives.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for “**gave their hands in pledge**.” Pause this audio here.

The men presented a ram to Yahweh as an offering for their **guilt**. Use the same words or phrases for ram and guilt as you used in previous passages. For more information on guilt, refer to the Master Glossary. A ram is an adult male sheep.

Stop here and, if needed, look at a picture of a ram as a group. Pause this audio here.

The men took the rams from the flock, the group of rams that the Israelites kept for offerings to Yahweh. A flock can include both sheep and goats.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **flock**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The men made guilt offerings. A person makes a guilt offering to ask Yahweh to forgive their sin when the person broke one of Yahweh's laws.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **guilt offering**. Look up guilt offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us the guilty men who are **Levites**, **musicians**, and **gatekeepers**. Use the same words or phrases for Levites, musicians, and gatekeepers as you used in previous passages. For more information on Levites, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 10:18–24

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (896 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Ezra 10:25–44

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Ezra 10:25–44 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:25–44 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:25–44 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this passage, the storyteller continues to tell us the names of the men who are guilty of having wives who are not Israelites. In the last story, the storyteller told us about the Levites who were guilty. Now, the storyteller tells us about the men from family groups who are not Levites who were guilty. The men are Israelites from the other tribes of Israel. The storyteller lists several family groups with guilty men. Not all of the family groups that returned to Jerusalem with Zerubbabel included guilty men. The storyteller names four family groups that did not return to Jerusalem with Zerubbabel. The men are all descendants of an important ancestor in their family. We do not know when the important ancestor was alive, and the important ancestor is probably dead when this story happens.

The storyteller tells us that seven sons or descendants of Parosh are guilty. The guilty men are Ramiah, Izziah, Malkijah, Mijamin, Eleazar, Malkijah, and Benaiah. There are probably two descendants of Parosh called Malkijah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about people in your family or community who have the same name as each other. How do you know which person someone is talking about? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that six descendants or sons of Elam are guilty. The guilty men are Mattaniah, Zechariah, Jehiel, Abdi, Jeremoth, and Elijah.

The storyteller tells us that six descendants or sons of Zattu are guilty. The guilty men are Elioenai, Eliashib, Mattaniah, Jeremoth, Zabad, and Aziza.

The storyteller tells us that four descendants or sons of Bebai are guilty. The guilty men are Jehohanan, Hananiah, Zabbai, and Athlai. The storyteller of Nehemiah tells us that Zabbai helped to repair the wall of Jerusalem.

The storyteller tells us that six descendants or sons of Bani are guilty. The guilty men are Meshullam, Malluch, Adaiah, Jashub, Sheal, and Jeremoth. We do not know if Meshullam is the same man as the Meshullam who objected to the leaders' plan when Ezra called all the men to Jerusalem earlier in the book of Ezra.

The storyteller tells us that eight descendants or sons of Pahath-Moab are guilty. The guilty men are Adna, Kelal, Benaiah, Maaseiah, Mattaniah, Bezalel, Binnui, and Manasseh.

The storyteller tells us that eight descendants or sons of Harim are guilty. The guilty men are Eliezer, Ishijah, Malkijah, Shemaiah, Shimeon, Benjamin, Malluch, and Shemariah. This Malkijah is a different man from the two descendants of Parosh also named Malkijah.

The storyteller tells us that seven descendants or sons of Hashum are guilty. The guilty men are Mattenai, Mattattah, Zabad, Eliphelet, Jeremai, Manasseh, and Shimei. This Manasseh is a different man from the descendant of Pahath-Moab also named Manasseh.

The storyteller tells us that 12 descendants or sons of Bani are guilty. This is a different family group from the descendants of Bani that the storyteller told us about earlier in the story. It is possible that there were two different men named Bani, and so this was a different family from the one we heard about already. However, it is also possible that the storyteller recorded the name of the men's ancestor incorrectly. The guilty men are Maadai, Amram, Uel, Benaiah, Bedeiah, Keluhi, Vaniah, Meremoth, Eliashib, Mattaniah, Mattenai, and Jaasu. The men are different from the men with the same names in other family groups.

Ezra 10:25–44

The storyteller tells us that 13 descendants or sons of Binnui are guilty. The guilty men are Shimei, Shelemiah, Nathan, Adaiah, Macnadebai, Shashai, Sharai, Azarel, Shelemiah, Shemariah, Shallum, Amariah, and Joseph.

The storyteller tells us that seven descendants or sons of Nebo are guilty. The guilty men are Jeiel, Mattithiah, Zabad, Zebina, Jaddai, Joel, and Benaiah.

The storyteller finishes the story by telling us that all the men named in the list in this story and the Levites in the previous story took women who were not Israelites into their homes. The women were wives to the Israelite men in the same way that Israelite women were wives to the Israelite men. There are two possible translations of the last part of the story. In some translations, the storyteller tells us that some of the Israelite men had children with the foreign women. In other translations, the storyteller tells us that the Israelite men sent away the foreign women with the Israelite men's children. It seems that the storyteller wants us to know that the Israelite men also sent away the children that the men had with their foreign wives.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:25–44 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller tells us about the Israelites who are guilty and who are not Levites.

In the second scene: The storyteller tells us the family groups of the guilty men and the names of the guilty men in each family group. Seven descendants of Parosh are guilty. Six descendants of Elam are guilty. Six descendants of Zattu are guilty. Four descendants of Bebai are guilty. Six descendants of Bani are guilty. Eight descendants of Pahath-Moab are guilty. Eight descendants of Harim are guilty. Seven descendants of Hashum are guilty. Twelve descendants of Bani are guilty. Thirteen descendants of Binnui are guilty. Seven descendants of Nebo are guilty.

In the third scene: The storyteller ends the list and tells us that all the men in the list had foreign wives. Some of the Israelite men had children with the foreign women and sent away the children with their mothers.

The characters in this passage are:

- Storyteller
- Guilty men who are descendants of Parosh, Elam, Zattu, Bebai, Bani, Pahath-Moab, Harim, Hashum, Bani, Binnui, and Nebo
- And the children born to Israelite fathers and foreign women

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This passage continues on immediately after the previous passage. In this passage, the storyteller completes the list of Israelite men who are guilty of having foreign wives. In the previous passage, the storyteller listed all the Israelite Levite men who were guilty. Now the storyteller tells us all the other Israelite men who are guilty. The storyteller divides the list into groups of men according to the family that each man belongs to. Each family group is identified as the descendants or sons of an important ancestor. Most scholars say there are 11 family groups with guilty men in the family group. However, some scholars say there are 12 family groups. The first group of men is the descendants of Parosh. The guilty men are Ramiah, Izziah, Malkijah, Mijamin, Eleazar, Malkijah, and Benaiah.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together seven small objects and place them in a group in front of you. The seven objects represent the seven guilty men. Pause this audio here.

The second group of men is the descendants of Elam. The guilty men are Mattaniah, Zechariah, Jehiel, Abdi, Jeremoth, and Elijah.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together six more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

Ezra 10:25–44

The third group of men is the descendants of Zattu. The guilty men are Elioenai, Eliashib, Mattaniah, Jeremoth, Zabad, and Aziza.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together six more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The fourth group of men is the descendants of Bebai. The guilty men are Johanan, Hananiah, Zabbai, and Athlai.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together four more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The fifth group of men is the descendants of Bani. The guilty men are Meshullam, Malluch, Adaiah, Jashub, Sheal, and Jeremoth.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together six more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The sixth group of men is the descendants of Pahath-Moab. The guilty men are Adna, Kelal, Benaiah, Maaseiah, Mattaniah, Bezalel, Binnui, and Manasseh.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together eight more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The seventh group of men is the descendants of Harim. The guilty men are Eliezer, Ishijah, Malkijah, Shemaiah, Shimeon, Benjamin, Malluch, and Shemariah.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together eight more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The eighth group of men is the descendants of Hashum. The guilty men are Mattenai, Mattattah, Zabad, Eliphelet, Jeremai, Manasseh, and Shimei.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together seven more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The ninth group of men is the descendants of Bani. The guilty men are Maadai, Amram, Uel, Benaiah, Bedeiah, Keluhi, Vaniah, Meremoth, Eliashib, Mattaniah, Mattenai, and Jaasu.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together 12 more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The tenth group of men is the descendants of Binnui. The guilty men are Shimei, Shelemiah, Nathan, Adaiah, Macnadebai, Shashai, Sharai, Azarel, Shelemiah, Shemariah, Shallum, Amariah, and Joseph.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together 13 more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Pause this audio here.

The last group of men is the descendants of Nebo. The guilty men are Jeiel, Matthithiah, Zabad, Zebina, Jaddai, Joel, and Benaiah.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect together seven more small objects and place them together in a group next to, but separate from, your objects from the activity before this one. Notice all the different objects, which represent all the guilty Israelite men who are not Levite men. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller ends the story with a reminder to us that all the men in the list, Levites and other Israelites, married foreign women. The storyteller gives us a final piece of information that some of the Israelite men had children with their foreign wives. The Israelite men also sent away their own children with the children's mothers.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:25–44 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Storyteller
- Guilty men who are descendants of Parosh, Elam, Zattu, Bebai, Bani, Pahath-Moab, Harim, Hashum, Bani, Binnui, and Nebo
- And the children born to Israelite fathers and foreign women

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The storyteller tells us about the Israelites who are guilty and who are not Levites.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the storyteller, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Look, not all of the guilty men were Levites. There were also men from the other tribes of Israel; or
- Many men did not know Yahweh’s laws; or
- Many men sent away their foreign wives.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller tells us the family groups of the guilty men and the names of the guilty men in each family group. Seven descendants of Parosh are guilty. Six descendants of Elam are guilty. Six descendants of Zattu are guilty. Four descendants of Bebai are guilty. Six descendants of Bani are guilty. Eight descendants of Pahath-Moab are guilty. Eight descendants of Harim are guilty. Seven descendants of Hashum are guilty. Twelve descendants of Bani are guilty. Thirteen descendants of Binnui are guilty. Seven descendants of Nebo are guilty.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the guilty men who are descendants of Parosh, Elam, Zattu, Bebai, Bani, Pahath-Moab, Harim, Hashum, Bani, Binnui, and Nebo, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We feel so ashamed. We did not know Yahweh’s laws; or
- The Levites are supposed to help us obey Yahweh. But when we saw that some of the Levites took foreign wives, we decided to do it too; or
- We will miss our wives, but we promised Ezra and our elders to send our foreign wives away; or
- Will Yahweh still be angry with us? Did we do everything to stop Yahweh’s anger? or
- Now we will follow Yahweh’s laws and only have Israelite wives.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller ends the list and tells us that all the men in the list had foreign wives. Some of the Israelite men had children with the foreign women and sent away the children with those children’s mothers.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the storyteller, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- There were lots of men who married foreign women in the same way that an Israelite man marries an Israelite woman; or
- The guilty men kept their promises to Ezra and the Israelite elders; or
- It was a terrible time. The Israelite men sent away not only their foreign wives, but also the children they had with those wives.

Ask the person playing the children born to Israelite fathers and foreign women, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Why do we have to leave our homes? or
- We are sad to leave our fathers and our homes; or
- Where will we go and who will look after us and our mothers?

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Ezra 10:25–44 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The storyteller tells us the guilty men who are from the rest of the **Israelites**, the Israelites who are not Levites. Use the same word or phrase for Israelites as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israelites, refer to the Master Glossary.

The storyteller tells us the guilty men who are the **descendants** or **sons** of different significant ancestors. Use the same words or phrases for descendants or sons as you used in previous passages where sons meant descendants. For more information on descendants, refer to the Master Glossary.

All the men in the list **married foreign** women. Use the same words or phrases for married and foreign as you used in previous passages.

Some of the men had children with the foreign women or "**wives**." Use the same word or phrase for wives as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Ezra 10:25–44

Ezra 10:25–44

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (891 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (805 KB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)